



EMPIRE ENGLISH COMMUNITY

STAGE 3: CONFIDENT — FLAGSHIP GRADUATION

CEFR B2

Rank · Confident

التتويج

STUDENT'S EDITION

بلينة كل يوم. · 2026 — An empire is built brick by brick

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STAGE 3 — GLOSSARY

👑 STAGE 3 — CONFIDENT ★ (FLAGSHIP GRADUATION)

Empire English · CEFR B2 · Rank: **Confident** Built from: `curriculum/01-cefr-roadmap.md` §6 + `curriculum/stage3/00-stage3-unit-map.md`

From studying English to living in it.

WELCOME, CONFIDENT — أهلاً بالكونفيدنت

This is the stage the whole programme was engineered backwards from.

You arrive with B1. You can tell a story, state an opinion and give a reason for it, imagine an alternative, report what someone else said, and hold a discussion for eight to twelve minutes. That is genuinely a lot. What it is not yet is **comfortable** — and comfort is the entire subject of Stage 3.

By the end of Stage 3 you will be able to hold a natural twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation on everyday and professional topics, clearly and confidently, with a neutral American accent.

That sentence is the flagship promise of Empire English. It is not decoration and it is not aspirational: it is a testable claim, and in Unit 12 it gets tested, on a rubric, with a defined minimum in every dimension. Everything in the sixty lessons ahead exists to make that twenty-five minutes possible.

Notice what the promise does **not** say. It does not say error-free, and it does not say native. B2 is not the level where mistakes stop; it is the level where you become **reliable** — precise enough about who did what, which thing you meant, who claimed it and how sure you are that a listener can act on your account of it. That is a higher and much more useful standard than sounding perfect.

YOUR RANK — رُتبتك

Rank	Confident — الكونفيدنت ★
CEFR	B2 — Upper Intermediate
Entry	B1 achieved through Stage 2 or placement evidence
What it means	you can work, argue, explain and socialise in English without the language being the obstacle

The rank path: Recruit (A1) → Citizen (A2) → Legionary (B1) → **Confident (B2 — the Coronation)** → Sovereign (C1, optional).

A Legionary can hold a position in a conversation. A Confident can hold the **whole conversation** — move it from the weekend to a work process to an abstract question, change how they sound as it moves, and

stay in it for half an hour without it becoming hard work for anybody.

This is the graduation. Stage 4 exists, and it is optional. Nothing after this point is required of you.

THE ROADMAP — خريطة المرحلة

12 units · 60 lessons · roughly 150–200 guided hours, about 16–24 weeks at around 7 hours a week.

Unit	Theme	What you take from it
1	Perfect Aspect Mastery	present perfect continuous; the perfect-against-simple choice, decided
2	Past Perfect & Narrative Mastery	sequence a complex story; say what had already happened
3	Future Forms (Advanced)	future continuous and perfect; arrangements; degrees of certainty
4	Third & Mixed Conditionals	the unreal past, and the unreal past still shaping now
5	Modals of Deduction	infer about the present and the past, with your evidence attached
6	The Passive (Advanced)	every tense, modal and perfect passives, the reporting passive, the causative
7	Relative Clauses (Advanced)	non-defining, reduced, preposition + <i>which/whom</i> , <i>which</i> for a whole idea
8	Reported Speech (Advanced)	the full reporting-verb range and its patterns — stance, not just words
9	Register & Nuance	formal and informal control, diplomacy, collocation, natural phrasing
10	Professional Communication	meetings, presentations, negotiating, calls
11	Abstract Topics & Debate	structured argument, defending and conceding, small talk to deep talk
12	Putting It Together ★	retrieval, the accent clinic, the full mock, and the B2 benchmark

The grammar spine: perfect aspect → past perfect narrative → advanced futures → third and mixed conditionals → modals of deduction → advanced passive and causative → advanced relative clauses → advanced reported speech → register and nuance → all of it in professional and abstract use.

Stage 3 is built in four movements. **Units 1–3 complete and sharpen the time system**, so that every tense in English is available to you and you never have to approximate when something happened. **Units 4–5 add hypothetical and inference grammar** — the unreal past, and reasoning out loud from evidence. **Units 6–8 are the precision block:** the structures that make an educated speaker sound precise rather than merely fluent. **Units 9–11 are the naturalness layer** — register, professional communication, and thinking in English about things you have not prepared for. Unit 12 consolidates all of it and runs the benchmark.

Vocabulary target: roughly **3,500–4,000+ words cumulative** — professional and workplace language, topic-specific range, collocations and natural phrasing. All of it is collected in the generated glossary at the back of this book.

Accent Lab priorities. Stage 3 stops teaching sounds and starts refining speech:

- **thought groups and phrasing** — where you break, and where you refuse to
- **contrastive and sentence stress** — the single word that carries a sentence's meaning
- **intonation for attitude** — certainty, doubt, politeness, emphasis, concession
- **register in prosody**, not only in vocabulary: formal is slower and flatter, never louder
- **connected speech at speed** — the reductions that have to survive a long turn
- **self-monitoring and self-correction** — the one skill that keeps working after the course ends
- your own residual sounds, fine-tuned individually from your recordings

FULL IMMERSION — إنجليزي بالكامل

Arabic support in Stage 3: none. Zero, in every unit, from the first lesson to the benchmark.

Units	Arabic support	What that looks like
1–12	0%	English instruction, English examples, English feedback, English live sessions

Stage 2 finished its Arabic fade by Unit 12 and ran its own assessment in English only. Stage 3 begins where that ended and does not go back. Section labels keep their Arabic names because they are the furniture of the book and you navigate by them — but the teaching, the explanations, the corrections and the conversations are all in English.

This is not support being withdrawn. It is the recognition that you no longer need translation to understand an explanation, and that the flagship benchmark is a conversation in English, so every hour of practice should be one. A learner who has been coached in Arabic and then assessed in English has been prepared for the wrong event.

THE TWO THINGS THAT ACTUALLY DECIDE THIS STAGE — الحقيقتين المهمتين

Neither of them is grammar, and both are worth knowing on day one rather than in Unit 12.

The first is that knowing a structure and reaching for it are different skills. You will be able to build a mixed conditional correctly in Unit 4 if someone asks you to. The benchmark asks something else: whether you produce one in the middle of an argument, when your attention is on the point you are making. That gap is closed only by producing language under mild pressure, repeatedly, which is why every lesson ends with you speaking and recording rather than with an exercise you can check. If a lesson feels harder than reading about the same structure would, that is the design working.

The second is that this stage is scored as a conversation, not a performance. Five dimensions — Fluency, Accuracy, Range and Coherence, Interaction, Pronunciation — and the B2 determination needs the minimum in **all five**, not on average. Your weakest dimension is your result. In practice that reshapes how you prepare: a learner who spends four months perfecting accuracy and never learns to ask a real question, change register, or sustain twenty-five minutes will not pass, and will be surprised. Interaction and Range are not soft dimensions. They are half of what a conversation is.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK — إزاي تستخدم الكتاب

Every teaching lesson keeps the same route. Review, clinic and assessment lessons adapt the middle to the task.

Section	What you do there
 Your Conquest	name the ability you are building
 Why this matters	connect the language to a real reason to use it
 Warm-up	retrieve earlier language before adding more
 Watch & Listen	meet the language inside a complete situation
 Decode it	notice the form, the meaning, and the contrast that matters
 Your Arsenal	collect the words and functional phrases
 Accent Lab	perceive, cue, produce, record, and compare
 Train	practise accurately before the speaking load rises
 Your Turn	connect the lesson into meaningful speech
 Your Orders	carry one small action into real life
 Remember	compress the lesson into what must survive
 Self-check	verify and correct without waiting for a teacher

Five rules make Stage 3 work:

- 1. Talk through the gap, never around it.** By B2 the missing word is rarely the problem — stopping is. Describe it, approximate it, say what it is not, and keep the turn alive.
- 2. Repair the phrase; never restart the sentence.** The same slip, handled two ways, lands in two different places on the rubric. A mid-phrase repair reads as control. A restart reads as breakdown.
- 3. Attach your evidence to your inference.** *It must have been decided earlier — nobody could answer about the date.* A deduction with no clue attached is just an assertion, and B2 is the level where the difference shows.

4. **Choose the right form, not the heaviest one.** *The individual to whom I reported* is correct, impressive, and completely wrong at a family dinner. Over-formality is the mistake that catches good students.
5. **Record before you feel ready, and compare only with yourself.** Your own earlier recordings are the only fair comparison that exists, because they are the only one where everything except your work is held constant.

★ **The golden rule stands:** consistency beats intensity. Come back quickly, even if you come back for ten minutes.

WHAT GETS RECORDED — إيه اللي بيتسجل

Every unit ends in a speaking task, and Unit 12 contains two full-length recorded conversations. Those recordings do three jobs: they give your coach evidence for specific rather than general feedback, they let you compare your speech with your own earlier speech, and they complete the proof timeline that reaches five points at the end of this stage — **Day 1 → Stage 0 → A2 → B1 → B2**.

The benchmark conversation and the graduation sample in Unit 12 are two **separate** recordings, kept as separate files. The conversation determines your result. The graduation sample answers the same standard prompt you answered on your very first day, so the comparison is fair — and nothing you say in it is scored.

Recording for learning is not permission to publish. Storage, comparison and any public use follow the consent tier in the before/after protocol, that tier is yours to choose, and you may withdraw it later without giving a reason. You can complete this entire course, including graduation, without ever granting marketing use.

HOW YOU ARE ASSESSED — التقييم

- **Entry:** B1 evidence through the Stage-2 summative or the placement process.
- **End of every unit:** a short quiz plus a speaking task — formative checks that direct feedback and the review queue. They are not gates.
- **Unit 12, L01-L02:** integrated retrieval across the whole stage. Their real output is a written list of your own six residual errors, specific enough to work on.
- **Unit 12, L03:** a personalised accent and fluency clinic, built entirely from those six targets and your tracker flags — and the self-monitoring routine you keep afterwards.
- **Unit 12, L04:** a full-length mock in the exact shape of the benchmark, with no determination attached, so that nothing about the format is new a week later.
- **Stage-3 flagship summative:** a full-range quiz plus the **20–30 minute B2 benchmark conversation** — everyday, professional and abstract — scored on **Fluency · Accuracy · Range/Coherence ·**

Interaction · Pronunciation, requiring the **defined minimum in every dimension**, in English only.

- **Graduation "after" sample:** a separate standard-prompt recording, so all five points of the timeline can be compared fairly.

A green quiz is not proof of speaking ability, and a strong conversation is not proof that every structure is stable. The determination uses the required evidence together, and it always begins with the evidence rather than with the label.

AN HONEST PROMISE — وعد صادق

We promise structured practice toward a natural twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation in **clear, confident, neutral American English**. We do not promise a native accent, effortless fluency in a fixed number of days, or progress without sustained use. Pronunciation is scored for clarity, naturalness and prosody. Sounding indistinguishable from someone born in Ohio is not the standard, has never been promised to you, and is required for nothing you are trying to do.

What Stage 3 can honestly deliver: you can sustain a long, wide-ranging conversation; narrate, argue, speculate, report and hedge spontaneously; describe processes and systems precisely; change register for the room; defend a position under challenge and concede the part that is fair. You will still meet unfamiliar idiom, find fast native-to-native banter demanding, and occasionally lose a structure inside a very complex sentence. That is not a failed C1. That is a real B2 — and C1 is an optional next climb, not a standard you have missed.

NEXT → UNIT 1: PERFECT ASPECT MASTERY

Your first campaign is the tense that talks about work in progress across time — what you have been doing, for how long, and why the choice between *I've done* and *I've been doing* is a choice about meaning rather than grammar.

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STAGE 3 · UNIT 1

PERFECT ASPECT MASTERY

👑 UNIT 1 — PERFECT ASPECT MASTERY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: talk precisely about work in motion — what you've **been** doing, what you **have** done, and how long — then assemble it into a ninety-second status update you'll reuse for years.

Stage 3 is written entirely in English. Not as a test of endurance, and not to make things harder. The support is gone because you no longer need it, and the last place to discover otherwise is a professional conversation. Everything in this unit builds on B1 grammar you already own.

Nothing here is a new tense so much as a new choice. You arrive with a present perfect. This unit gives you a second one and then makes you decide between them, sentence by sentence. That is the shape of the whole stage: B2 is where the tense system stops growing and starts getting accurate.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Present perfect continuous	<i>have/has been + -ing</i> — activity that's still running
L02	Continuous vs simple perfect	choose: activity and duration or result and quantity
L03	<i>How long have you been...?</i>	duration with precision — and deliberate vagueness
L04	Ongoing projects & efforts	the four-part status update : effort · evidence · honesty · direction
L05	Unit task 🎤	a 2-minute talk + an exchange — and your Stage-3 baseline recording

Grammar spine: present perfect continuous · the continuous/simple contrast · *for* and *since* with duration nuance · integration with the simple perfect and a future form. **Accent Lab:** thought groups across a long turn · the squeezed *I've been* /aɪvbiːn/ · contrastive stress on *been* and on quantities · weak *for* /fə/ · the falling tune on a *How long* question. **Mindset:** identity lock-in — you are an English speaker now, not someone trying to learn. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A **reusable ninety-second status update** — the answer to "*what are you working on?*", ready for interviews, stand-ups and introductions.
- Your **Stage-3 baseline recording**, which is what makes the Unit-12 comparison mean anything.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** present perfect continuous form · continuous against simple (activity/result) · *how long* with *for/since* · error-spotting on the two interference errors.
- **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute talk plus one live follow-up, scored on Fluency, Accuracy and Pronunciation at the B2 threshold.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — aspect-choice flags, phrasing notes, and each learner's residual sound for the Unit-12 clinic.

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 2 — PAST PERFECT & NARRATIVE MASTERY

the tense that sits *behind* your story: what had already happened, and how to sequence a complex narrative without losing your listener.

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PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS: *HAVE / HAS BEEN + -ING*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 present perfect
 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md](#) · **S3-U1-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Build *have/has been + -ing* without thinking about it.
- Talk about what you've been doing lately — activity, not just outcome.
- Say **how long** something has been going on. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You already have a present perfect. *I've worked here for five years* is correct, useful, and it will get you through most conversations. So why add another form on top of it?

Because English splits one idea into two, and speakers hear the difference immediately. *I've read that report* tells me the reading is **finished** — you have the information, ask me anything. *I've been reading that report* tells me it is **in progress** — I should not expect you to know the end yet. Same book, same person, same afternoon, and two completely different messages about what you are ready for. When a colleague asks how the work is going, the form you choose answers a question they did not have to ask.

There is a second reason, and at B2 it matters more than the grammar. This is the tense of ordinary professional life: what you have been working on, what you have been meaning to do, what you have been trying to fix. It is how people describe effort that has not resolved yet — which is most effort. Without it you can only report finished things, and you end up sounding either boastful or oddly silent about the whole middle of your work.

The third reason is about you rather than the language. From here on, the course assumes you are not studying English so much as using it. Someone who says *I've been learning English since I was fifteen* is describing a life. Someone who says *I've learned English* has closed the file. The continuous is the honest form for anything you are still doing, and that includes this.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE B1 PERFECT)

Thirty seconds each, no preparation:

1. Somewhere you **have** lived.

2. Something you **have never** done but would like to.
3. How long you **have** had your current job or course.
4. Something you **have** finished this month.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the "what have you been up to?" clip in the portal, then read along:

A: Hey — I haven't seen you in ages. What have you been up to? **B:** Honestly? I've been working on a project all week. I've barely left the house. **A:** Doing what? **B:** We've been rebuilding the booking system. It's been taking longer than anyone expected. **A:** And how's your sister? Still studying? **B:** She's been studying for her exams since January. She's been sleeping about five hours a night. **A:** Poor thing. Have you two been getting any time together? **B:** Not much. We've been meaning to have dinner for a month.

Count them: **eight** uses of the new form in eight exchanges. Notice that not one of them describes something finished. Every single one is about effort that is still running.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (HAVE / HAS BEEN + -ING)

Three parts, always in this order, and the middle one never changes:

Subject	have / has		-ing
I / you / we / they	have	been	working
he / she / it	has	been	working

I've been working. · She's been studying. · They've been waiting.

Negative: put *not* on the auxiliary — *I haven't been sleeping well.* · *He hasn't been trying.* **Question:** invert the auxiliary — *Have you been waiting long?* · *How long has she been studying?*

What it actually means. The activity started in the past and either continues now, or stopped so recently that you can still see the effects:

I've been running. — I may have stopped, but I am still out of breath. *It's been raining.* — Perhaps it stopped, but the street is wet.

That second use is worth dwelling on, because it is the one learners miss: the form often describes something **just finished** whose consequences are visibly present. This is why "You've been crying" works

as an observation. Nobody claims the crying is ongoing; they are reading the evidence on your face.

Which verbs. This form belongs to verbs of activity and duration — *work, study, learn, wait, try, live, practise, read, look for, think about*. It resists verbs that describe states rather than activities: we say *I've known her for years*, not *I've been knowing her*. If a verb describes something you **do** rather than something you **are**, the continuous is available.

The one thing to get right today. *been* is not optional and it is not *being*. Drop it and you have the old B1 form with a different meaning; swap it and you have nothing at all. It is unstressed, squeezed, almost swallowed in fast speech — and it still has to be there.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I've been working on...	<i>I've been working on the report.</i>
I've been meaning to...	<i>I've been meaning to call you.</i>
I've been trying to...	<i>I've been trying to fix it.</i>
lately / recently	<i>What have you been doing lately?</i>
all week / all day	<i>I've been travelling all week.</i>
It's been taking...	<i>It's been taking forever.</i>
barely	<i>I've barely slept.</i>
I've been looking for...	<i>I've been looking for a flat.</i>
ever since	<i>She's been studying ever since.</i>
make progress	<i>I've been making good progress.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THOUGHT GROUPS + I'VE BEEN)

Cue 1 — *I've been* is one squeezed shape. Not three words. The *have* collapses to a /v/ on the pronoun and *been* reduces to /bɪn/:

I've been → /aɪvbɪn/ · *she's been* → /ʃɪzbɪn/ · *they've been* → /ðeɪvbɪn/

Say the three words separately once, then let them collapse. The reduction is not laziness — it is what makes the stressed word after it audible.

Cue 2 — thought groups. B2 phrasing is about **where you break**, not how fast you go. Mark the break with a small pause and a slight rise, then continue:

I've been working // on a new project // for about three weeks. She's been studying // ever since January.

Try the same sentence with the break in the wrong place — *I've been // working on a new // project* — and hear how much harder it is to follow. Nothing is mispronounced. The information is just packaged badly.

 **Record:** *"I've been working on something new, and it's been taking longer than I expected."* Save it. You will compare against it in U12.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Build it. Say each aloud in the continuous:

1. she / study / all morning → *She's been studying all morning.*
2. they / wait / an hour
3. I / not sleep / well
4. how long / you / learn English
5. it / rain / since Tuesday
6. we / try / to reach you

B. Fix it. Every sentence has one error:

1. *I'm working here since March.* → *I've been working here since March.*
2. *She has been study for hours.*
3. *I've working on it all week.*
4. *He's been knowing her for years.*
5. *Have you been wait long?*

C. Ask and answer. In pairs, four rounds:

*What have you been working on? · What have you been watching? What have you been meaning to do?
· What have you been trying to improve?*

Answer in a full sentence, then add **one** detail.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** things you've been doing recently. For each one, add a duration or a consequence:

I've been working on a presentation for two weeks. I've been trying to sleep earlier, and it's actually helping. I've been meaning to fix my bike since the summer.



Record all three. Listen back once and check: is *been* audible in every sentence?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "Lately I've been ___, ___, and ___."
- Answer "What have you been up to?" out loud, in English, once a day this week. It is the most common opening question in the language and it should never catch you.
- Notice the form in what you watch. It is everywhere once you hear it.



REMEMBER — افكر

- **have / has + been + -ing*** — three parts, and **been** never changes.
- It means **still going**, or **just stopped with visible results**.
- Activity verbs, not state verbs: *been working* ✓, *been knowing* ✗.
- **I'm working since March** is the error to kill. English uses the perfect for duration up to now.
- *I've been* is **one squeezed shape**, /aɪvbiɪn/.
- **Where you break** matters as much as how you sound.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can form the continuous with *have, has*, negatives and questions.
- ☐ I said *been* in every sentence, and I can hear it in my recording.
- ☐ I know why *I'm working since March* is wrong.
- ☐ I marked my thought groups in one long sentence.
- ☐ I recorded three sentences with a duration or a consequence.

Empire English 🏰 — Stage 3 begins: precision, not just correctness

PERFECT CONTINUOUS VS SIMPLE PERFECT — ACTIVITY OR RESULT

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md](#) · S3-U1-L02

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Choose the continuous when the **activity** is the point.
- Choose the simple when the **result** is the point.
- Say both about one project, in one breath. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Last lesson gave you a second perfect. Now you have a problem you did not have before: two forms, one situation, and a choice to make every time. This is the shape of most of Stage 3 — you are not collecting structures any more, you are deciding between ones you already own.

The decision matters because it changes what your listener does next. Say *I've been writing the report* and a manager understands there is nothing to read yet, and probably stops asking. Say *I've written the report* and they will expect it in their inbox. Neither sentence is more correct. One of them creates an expectation you can meet and the other creates one you cannot, and the only difference is which part of your own effort you chose to put in front.

There is a quieter reason too, and it is about how you sound rather than what you mean. Learners who only have the simple perfect are pushed toward describing themselves in finished achievements — *I've done this, I've completed that* — because it is the only form available. That is a strange way to talk, and in an interview it reads as either boastful or thin. The continuous gives you a way to talk about effort honestly: long, ongoing, not finished, going reasonably well. Most real work sounds like that, and being able to say so is a large part of sounding like an adult professional rather than a candidate reciting a list.

So the pair is not two grammar items. It is the difference between reporting your outcomes and describing your work, and fluent speakers move between the two constantly without noticing.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01)

Answer aloud, full sentences, thirty seconds each:

1. What **have you been doing** this week?

2. What **have you been trying** to improve lately?
3. How long **have you been** studying English?

Then one deliberately harder question: *Have you been reading anything?* — and notice you probably want to add what you **have** finished. Hold that thought.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. Every line pairs the two:

A: The house looks different. What have you been doing? **B:** I've been painting. I've painted two rooms so far — the kitchen's next. **A:** How long has that been going on? **B:** Three weekends. I've been watching a lot of tutorials, and I've learned that I'm bad at ceilings. **A:** How's the book you started? **B:** I've been reading it for a month. I've read about half. **A:** And the garden? **B:** I've been meaning to start. I haven't done anything at all.

Look at what happens in each pair. The **continuous** carries the effort and the time. The **simple** carries the count: two rooms, half a book, nothing at all. Neither could do the other's job.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (ACTIVITY OR RESULT)

Foregrounds	the activity, the duration	the result, the completion
Answers	<i>How long?</i>	<i>How many? How much?</i>
Feels	unfinished, in progress	finished, countable
Example	<i>I've been reading that book.</i>	<i>I've read three books.</i>

The test that works under pressure. Ask which question your sentence is answering:

How long have you been waiting? — **twenty minutes.** → continuous. *How many emails have you written?* — **nine.** → simple.

If a number or a quantity belongs in the answer, you want the simple. If a stretch of time belongs there, you want the continuous. You do not need to remember anything else.

Why a number forces the simple. A quantity is a completed count, and you cannot count something that is still happening. This is why *I've been writing three emails* sounds wrong to a native ear even though every word is fine — the form says *unfinished* and the number says *finished*, and the sentence contradicts itself.

The pair is the natural unit. In real speech the two forms usually arrive together, because people want to report both effort and progress:

I've been learning Spanish for a year, and I've learned enough to order dinner badly. We've been interviewing all week. We've seen eleven people.

Where both are genuinely fine. *I've lived here for ten years* and *I've been living here for ten years* are both correct. With *live, work, study, teach* — long-term states that are also activities — the choice barely changes the meaning; the continuous just sounds slightly more temporary. Do not hunt for a difference that is not there. The distinction bites hardest with verbs that have a clear finish line: *read, write, paint, build, fix, watch*.

The error to avoid. Do not use the continuous with a state verb to sound more advanced. *I've been having a car for three years* is not a more sophisticated *I've had a car for three years*; it is wrong.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
so far	<i>I've painted two rooms so far.</i>
up to now	<i>Up to now I've read half.</i>
I've almost finished	<i>I've almost finished it.</i>
I've managed to...	<i>I've managed to fix two of them.</i>
I haven't got round to it	<i>I've been meaning to — I haven't got round to it.</i>
It's been going on for...	<i>It's been going on for weeks.</i>
I've made a start	<i>I've made a start, at least.</i>
how far have you got?	<i>How far have you got with it?</i>
in progress	<i>It's still in progress.</i>
a fair bit	<i>I've done a fair bit.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (CONTRASTIVE STRESS)

When you pair the two forms, the **stress tells the listener which half matters**. Push the word that carries the new information:

*I've **been** painting — I've painted **two** rooms. I've **been** reading it — I've read **half**.*

In the continuous half, the stress lands on **been**, because *been* is the thing that makes it about activity. In the simple half it lands on the **quantity**, because the number is the news. Say the pair with flat stress on everything and the contrast disappears entirely; the words are identical and the meaning does not arrive.

Keep the thought group from L01 running underneath:

I've been reading it // for about a month // and I've read // maybe half.



Record one pair about something real. Listen for two things: is *been* audible, and is the number stressed?



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Sort them. Continuous or simple? Say why in four words:

1. I ____ (wait) for two hours.
2. She ____ (send) six messages.
3. We ____ (try) to call you all morning.
4. He ____ (finish) three chapters.
5. They ____ (build) that bridge since 2019.
6. How many times ____ you ____ (watch) it?

B. Make the pair. One continuous, one simple, about the same thing:

learn Spanish → I've been learning Spanish for a year. I've learned about 500 words.

Now do: *write a report · clean the flat · look for a job · watch a series*

C. Spot the contradiction. Each is wrong for the same reason. Fix it:

1. *I've been writing three emails.*
2. *She's been reading five books this month.*
3. *We've been solving two of the problems.*

D. Both fine? Decide whether the pair genuinely differs:

1. *I've worked here for five years / I've been working here for five years*
2. *I've read that book / I've been reading that book*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Describe **one real ongoing effort** — a project, a habit, a course, a repair. In about forty-five seconds, include:

- how long you've **been** doing it
- what you **have** achieved so far, with a number
- what is still unfinished

I've been trying to get fit since March. I've lost about four kilos and I've joined a gym twice, which tells you something. I still haven't managed to run five kilometres.

 **Record it.** Then check: does the continuous carry the time, and does the simple carry the count?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post an **activity + result** pair about a current project.
- This week, when someone asks how something is going, answer with **both** halves. It is the most natural way to give a status update in English and it takes one sentence.
- Ask yourself the question test once a day: *does a number belong in the answer?*

REMEMBER — افكر

- Continuous = **activity and duration**. Simple = **result and quantity**.
- The test: *How long?* → continuous · *How many / how much?* → simple.
- A **number forces the simple**. *I've been writing three emails* contradicts itself.
- The two usually arrive **as a pair**, because people report effort and progress together.
- With *live, work, study* the two barely differ — do not invent a rule.
- Stress **been** in the continuous half and the **number** in the simple half.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can state the question test without looking.
- ☐ I know why a quantity cannot take the continuous.
- ☐ I produced a clean activity + result pair about something real.
- ☐ I can name a case where both forms are equally fine.
- ☐ My recording stresses *been* and the number.

Empire English 🏰 — you are not adding forms now, you are choosing between them

HOW LONG HAVE YOU BEEN...? — DURATION WITH PRECISION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md](#) · **S3-U1-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Ask *How long have you been...?* without assembling it.
- Answer with **precision or vagueness**, on purpose.
- Talk about something you've done for years and make it sound interesting. 🎤

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

How long have you been...? is one of the highest-frequency questions in English, and the answer is where a lot of learners quietly lose ground. Not because the grammar defeats them — most people at this level can produce *for two years* — but because that is all they produce. Every answer comes out the same length and the same shape, and the conversation runs out of anywhere to go.

Consider what actually happens. Someone asks how long you have been learning English. *For seven years* is accurate and closes the topic. *Ever since I was at school, on and off — properly for about two years* is the same fact, and it hands the other person three things to ask about. Fluency at B2 is much less about speed than about giving the other person material. A precise answer is often a worse answer.

The second reason is that duration is how people are read. In an interview, in a first conversation, in any professional introduction, *how long* is a proxy for how seriously to take you — and English has a lot of ways to shade it. *Just over a year* and *nearly two years* can describe the same fourteen months, and they land differently. *On and off* is honest about a gap that *for five years* would quietly hide. Choosing among these is not decoration; it is the difference between a true answer and a technically true one.

And there is a practical trap here. Arabic and many other languages measure duration with a present tense, so *"How long are you living here?"* feels completely natural and is completely wrong in English. English insists on a perfect for anything that runs from the past up to now. This lesson is where that habit gets broken, because from here on it will appear in every conversation you have.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE THE PAIR)

Rapid round, in pairs. One of you asks, the other answers in a full sentence:

1. Something you **have been doing** for a long time.
2. Something you **have** finished recently — with a number.
3. Something you **have been meaning** to do for ages.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the *how long* clip, then read:

A: How long have you been learning English? **B:** Ever since I was a teenager, really — but properly, only for about two years. **A:** And how long have you been living in Cairo? **B:** Nearly six years now. Since 2020, just after everything shut down. **A:** Have you been working at the same place all that time? **B:** On and off. I was there for three years, left for a bit, and I've been back since last spring. **A:** How long have you been playing the guitar? **B:** Oh, ages. I honestly couldn't tell you — twelve years? Longer?

Four questions, four answers, and **not one of them is just a number**. Each one shades the fact: *ever since*, *nearly*, *on and off*, *ages*. That is what a fluent answer sounds like.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (FOR, SINCE, AND EVERYTHING BETWEEN)

The question. Fixed shape, and the auxiliary comes before the subject:

How long has she been working here? · *How long have you been waiting?*

The two anchors. This is the distinction that decides half your answers:

	Takes	Example
for	a length of time	<i>for two years</i> · <i>for ten minutes</i> · <i>for ages</i>
since	a starting point	<i>since 2019</i> · <i>since March</i> · <i>since I graduated</i>

✗ *since two years* — a length cannot be a starting point. ✓ *for two years* · ✓ *since two years ago* (now it is a point)

Since can also take a whole clause, and that is where it gets useful: *since I moved here*, *since we last spoke*, *since the baby was born*. A clause anchors the time to an event rather than a date, which is almost always more interesting.

Shading the amount. English has a full scale between exact and vague, and you should be able to move along it deliberately:

Precise	Approximate	Vague
<i>for exactly two years</i>	<i>for about two years</i>	<i>for a couple of years</i>
<i>since March</i>	<i>since early spring</i>	<i>since some point last year</i>
<i>for fourteen months</i>	<i>just over a year · nearly a year and a half</i>	<i>for ages · for a while</i>

The honest qualifiers. These describe the *shape* of the duration, not its length, and they are the most natural thing in the list:

on and off — with gaps. *properly, only for...* — the serious part is shorter than the whole. *ever since* — continuously from that moment. *off and on for years* — never really stopped or started.

The two errors to kill.

✗ *How long **are you learning** English?* → ✓ *How long **have you been learning** English?* English uses a perfect for time running up to now. A present tense means only *right now*.

✗ *I'm here **since** March.* → ✓ *I've been here **since** March.*

Both mistakes come from languages that mark duration with a present tense. Knowing that is why you keep making it makes it much easier to stop.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
ever since	<i>Ever since I was a teenager.</i>
for ages	<i>I've been doing this for ages.</i>
for a while	<i>I've been thinking about it for a while.</i>
on and off	<i>On and off for about five years.</i>
just over / just under	<i>Just over a year.</i>
nearly / almost	<i>Nearly six years now.</i>
a couple of years	<i>A couple of years, maybe more.</i>
properly, only for...	<i>Properly, only for two years.</i>
I couldn't tell you	<i>Ages — I couldn't tell you.</i>
all that time	<i>Have you been there all that time?</i>

**ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (WEAK FOR, AND THE QUESTION TUNE)**

Cue 1 — for almost disappears. In a duration phrase it reduces to /fə/, never the number *four*:

for ages → /fə'eɪdʒɪz/ · *for about two years* → /fəɹə'baʊt/

If *for* comes out heavy, the number after it stops being the focus — and the number is what you were trying to say.

Cue 2 — since keeps its /s/ endings. Both of them. Dropping the final /s/ turns it into something else entirely, and it is a common casualty at speed.

Cue 3 — the question falls. *How long* questions are wh-questions, so the tune comes **down** at the end:

How long have you been working there? 📉

Take it up and you sound surprised or disbelieving — which changes a neutral question into a challenge. This is one of the few places where intonation alone can make a polite question rude.



Record: "How long have you been working there?" — falling — then answer it: "On and off for about three years."

**TRAIN — تدرّب****A. for or since?**

1. ____ 2019 · 2. ____ six months · 3. ____ I left school · 4. ____ ages
2. ____ last Tuesday · 6. ____ a couple of weeks · 7. ____ the pandemic started

B. Build the question. From the prompt, ask a full *How long...?*:

1. she / live / in Alexandria
2. you / wait / for the results
3. they / work / on this project
4. he / play / the piano

C. Fix it.

1. *How long are you studying here?*
2. *I'm working here since January.*
3. *I've been learning it since three years.*

4. *How long you have been waiting?*

D. Shade the answer. Give the **same** fact three ways — precise, approximate, vague:

fourteen months of going to the gym → *for fourteen months / just over a year / on and off for a while*

Now do: *learning English · living in your city · working at your job*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Choose **two** long-running activities. For each, speak for about thirty seconds:

- how long, with a **shaded** duration — not just a number
- how it started
- how it has **changed** over that time

I've been playing football since primary school, on and off. I was in a team for a few years, then stopped completely, and I've been playing casually again since last summer. I'm slower and I enjoy it more.

 **Record both.** Check: is *for* weak? Does the question tune fall? Did you shade the duration?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "*I've been ___ for/since ___*" for two activities, using a **shaded** duration in at least one.
- Ask three people this week — in English, out loud — how long they have been doing something. Listen to how they shade the answer.
- Kill the habit: if you catch yourself starting "*I'm working here since...*", stop and restart the sentence.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **How long + have/has + subject + been + -ing?** — auxiliary before subject.
- **for** = a length · **since** = a starting point, including a whole clause.
- **since two years** is the error. A length can never be a start point.
- English uses a **perfect** for time up to now — never a present tense.
- **Shade** the duration: *ages, a while, on and off, just over, properly only for...*
- *for* is weak /fə/, and a *How long* question **falls**.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can build the question without assembling it piece by piece.
 - ☐ I never say *since* with a length of time.
 - ☐ I can give one duration three ways: precise, approximate, vague.
 - ☐ I said *for* as /fə/ and let the question fall.
 - ☐ I described how a long-running activity has changed.
-

Empire English 🏰 — *a precise answer is not always the best answer*

ONGOING PROJECTS & EFFORTS — THE STATUS UPDATE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 · **Lesson 4** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md](#) · **S3-U1-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Give a **ninety-second status update** on something you're actually doing.
- Move between *have been doing*, *have done* and *going to* without stalling.
- Answer "So what are you working on?" like a professional. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

So what are you working on at the moment? You will be asked this for the rest of your working life — by a manager, an interviewer, a new colleague, someone at a conference, a relative who does not understand your job. It is the single most reusable answer in professional English, and almost nobody prepares it.

Watch what happens without preparation. The instinct is the present simple: *I work in software. I work on an app.* Grammatically perfect, and it tells the listener nothing. It describes a job title, not a piece of work in motion. There is no effort in it, no progress, no direction, and no hook for a follow-up question. The conversation stops and you have not said anything untrue — you have just been forgettable.

A real status update has four moving parts and takes about twenty seconds: **what you've been doing** (the effort), **what you've achieved** (the evidence), **what's still open** (the honesty), and **what's next** (the direction). Three tenses, one shape. Once you have built it, you can redeploy it endlessly by swapping the content, and it works identically in a stand-up meeting, a job interview and a chat over coffee.

This is also where Unit 1 stops being about grammar. You have the perfect continuous, the perfect simple and the contrast between them. Alone, each is a form. Assembled into an update, they become a way of presenting yourself as someone with work in motion — which is what *confident* actually sounds like in a professional room. B2 is graded on how comfortable you are to talk to, and having a ready answer to the commonest question in professional life is a large part of that.

One more thing. Notice how much of the update is about unfinished work. Learners often think a good answer must report success. It does not. *It's been taking longer than I expected* is a completely normal, competent thing to say, and it makes you sound more credible rather than less. Fluency includes being able to describe difficulty without apologising for it.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (ALL THREE TIME REFERENCES)

One sentence each, fast, no preparation:

1. Something you've **been working on** — continuous.
2. Something you've **finished** this week — simple, with a number.
3. Something you're **going to** do next week — future.
4. How long you've **been** at your job or course — shaded duration.

Now say all four about the **same** thing. That is today's lesson in one move.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the "my current project" clip, then read the transcript. Four parts, marked:

[EFFORT] So I've been developing an app for a booking system — I've been on it since about February. **[EVIDENCE]** I've finished the design and I've built most of the back end, so maybe two thirds of it is done. **[HONESTY]** The payment side has been giving me trouble. I've been going round in circles with it for about two weeks, honestly. **[DIRECTION]** But I'm going to test it with a few real users next month, and if that goes well we'll launch in the spring.

Then the follow-up, unscripted:

A: What's been the hardest part? **B:** Probably deciding what to leave out. I've been adding features I don't need — I've cut about half of them since I started.

Ninety seconds, and you know what he does, how it's going, what's hard and where it's heading. Count the tenses: **five** perfect continuous, **four** perfect simple, **two** futures. He is not thinking about any of them.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE FOUR-PART UPDATE)

Part	Tense	What it does
Effort	<i>have been + -ing</i>	the work in motion, and how long
Evidence	<i>have + participle</i>	what's actually done — with a number
Honesty	<i>have been + -ing</i>	what's difficult or unresolved
Direction	<i>going to / will</i>	the next concrete step

Why this order. Effort first establishes that something is happening. Evidence proves it. Honesty makes the whole thing believable — an update with no difficulty in it sounds rehearsed. Direction gives the listener somewhere to go, which is how the conversation continues instead of ending.

The joins matter more than the parts. What makes it sound fluent rather than assembled is how the sections connect. Four joins do almost all the work:

so — moves effort into evidence: ...*since February*, **so** *I've finished the design*. **though / honestly** — introduces honesty without drama: *The payment side*, **honestly**, *has been a nightmare*. **but** — pivots to direction: ...**but** *I'm going to test it next month*. **and if that goes well** — makes the future conditional and therefore credible.

Length discipline. Twenty seconds per part, ninety seconds total. Longer than that and you are presenting rather than conversing, and the other person stops being a participant. If they want more they will ask — and because you included honesty and direction, they will.

Two errors that flatten it.

✗ *I work on an app.* — a job description. No motion, no duration, no hook. ✗ *I've been developing an app since two years.* — the *since* error from L03, and it will follow you into every update you ever give.

Reusability is the point. Build this once about something real, and the shape survives every change of content. In an interview it becomes your answer to "*tell me about a current project.*" In a stand-up it becomes your daily thirty seconds. At a conference it becomes what you say when someone asks what you do — which is a far better answer than your job title.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I've been working on...	<i>I've been working on a new system.</i>
making progress	<i>We've been making steady progress.</i>
so far	<i>So far I've finished the design.</i>
about two thirds done	<i>It's about two thirds done.</i>
it's been giving me trouble	<i>The payment side has been giving me trouble.</i>
going round in circles	<i>I've been going round in circles with it.</i>
taking longer than expected	<i>It's been taking longer than expected.</i>
the next step is...	<i>The next step is user testing.</i>
I'm going to...	<i>I'm going to test it next month.</i>
if that goes well	<i>If that goes well, we'll launch.</i>
the hardest part has been...	<i>The hardest part has been scope.</i>
I've cut / dropped...	<i>I've cut about half the features.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PHRASING A LONG TURN)

A ninety-second turn fails for one of two reasons: no breaks, or breaks in the wrong places. Both are fixable.

Cue 1 — one thought group per idea, and breathe at the joins. The four joins from *Decode it* are your breathing points:

I've been developing an app // for a booking system // since about February // so I've finished the design // and built most of the back end.

Cue 2 — stress the progress words. These carry the news, so push them:

I've **finished the design.* · *It's about **two thirds** done.* · **It's been taking **longer** than I expected.***

Say that last one with flat stress and it becomes a complaint. Stress *longer* and it becomes information.

Cue 3 — do not accelerate into the difficulty. Learners speed up when they reach the honesty part, because they want it over with. Slow down slightly instead. It reads as command rather than apology.



Record your effort + evidence sentences. Listen for one thing: are the breaks at the joins, or at random?



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Build each part separately. Choose a **real** project. One sentence each:

1. **Effort** — *I've been ___ since / for ___.*
2. **Evidence** — *I've ___, so about ___ is done.*
3. **Honesty** — *___ has been ___.*
4. **Direction** — *I'm going to ___, and if that goes well, ___.*

B. Join them. Say all four as one continuous turn, using *so*, *honestly* and *but*. Time it — aim for sixty to ninety seconds.

C. Fix the flat version. Each is grammatical and useless. Rewrite it as a real update:

1. *I work on a website. It is not finished.*
2. *I study for an exam since three months.*
3. *I have a project. It is difficult.*

D. Peer Q&A. Deliver your update to a partner. They must ask **two** follow-ups from this list:

What's been the hardest part? · How long has that been going on? · What have you got left? What made you start? · What would you do differently?

Answer without notes.



YOUR TURN — دورك

Record about **ninety seconds** on a real ongoing project. All four parts, in order, joined.

Then answer **one** live question from your coach or partner, unprepared.



Keep this recording. You will re-record the same update in U12 and the difference will be the clearest evidence of progress in the whole stage.



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your update: effort, evidence, honesty, direction.

- **Rehearse it until it is not a rehearsal.** This is the answer to "*what are you working on?*" and it should arrive without thought.
 - Update it weekly. The content changes; the shape never does.
 - Listen for the shape in podcasts and meetings. Once you know the four parts you will hear people using them.
-



REMEMBER — افكر

- Four parts: **effort → evidence → honesty → direction.**
 - Three tenses: *have been doing* · *have done* · *going to*.
 - **A number in the evidence.** Without it there is no proof.
 - **Include the difficulty.** An update with no problem in it sounds rehearsed.
 - *I work on an app* describes a job. It is not an update.
 - Ninety seconds maximum. Breathe **at the joins**, and stress the progress words.
-



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ My update has all four parts, in order.
 - ☐ There is a number in my evidence.
 - ☐ I named a real difficulty without apologising for it.
 - ☐ My next step is concrete, not vague.
 - ☐ I answered a follow-up without notes.
 - ☐ I stayed under ninety seconds.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the most reusable ninety seconds you will ever build

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: "WHAT YOU'VE BEEN WORKING ON" 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 1 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) · Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit1-perfect-aspect.md](#) · **S3-U1-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you deliver the whole unit at once:

- ~**2 minutes** on what you've been working on
- perfect continuous for the **activity**, perfect simple for the **result**
- a **shaded duration** and a concrete **next step**
- then hold an exchange: answer a question, and **ask one back** 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سخن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each. No preparation, no notes:

1. What have you **been doing** this week?
2. What have you **finished** — with a number?
3. *How long have you been...?* — ask your partner, and shade your own answer.
4. One thing that's **been taking longer** than you expected.
5. One thing you're **going to** do next.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clean two-minute model in the portal. It is the L04 update, extended and put under questioning.

[EFFORT] I've been running a small team on a redesign project since the start of the year — so about eight months, on and off. **[EVIDENCE]** We've rebuilt the whole booking flow and we've cut the number of steps from nine to four. I've also been training two new people, which I hadn't expected to be doing. **[HONESTY]** The part that's been difficult is getting everyone to agree on scope. We've been having the same argument in different meetings for weeks, honestly. **[DIRECTION]** We're going to freeze the feature list next Monday, and if that holds, we'll ship before the end of the quarter.

Coach: What's been the hardest part personally? **Learner:** Saying no, probably. I've been agreeing to things I shouldn't have — I've learned that the hard way this year. **Coach:** And how long have you

been managing people? **Learner:** Properly, only since January. Before that I'd helped out informally for a year or so. **Learner:** Can I ask — how do you handle scope arguments? Because I clearly don't.

Three things to notice. The four parts are all there. The follow-ups are answered **without restarting**. And the learner **asks a question back** — which is what turns a test into a conversation.

THE UNIT-1 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

Before you record, confirm your talk contains all six:

#	Must contain	Example
1	perfect continuous — the activity	<i>I've been rebuilding...</i>
2	perfect simple — a result with a number	<i>We've cut it from nine to four.</i>
3	a shaded duration	<i>about eight months, on and off</i>
4	an honest difficulty	<i>It's been taking longer than...</i>
5	a concrete next step	<i>We're going to freeze it Monday.</i>
6	a question back to your partner	<i>How do you handle...?</i>

Items 4 and 6 are the ones people drop. Difficulty gets skipped because it feels like admitting weakness — it is not, it is what makes the rest believable. The question back gets skipped because nobody asked for it — which is exactly why it lands.

ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (PERSONAL CLINIC)

Two minutes each, on **one** target only.

Everyone — thought groups across a long turn. The failure mode in a two-minute talk is never a sound; it is running out of breath in the wrong place. Mark your breaks at the joins:

I've been running a small team // on a redesign project // since the start of the year // so about eight months.

Everyone — I've been stays squeezed. /aɪvbiɪn/, unstressed, but *been* audible. Under the pressure of a long turn it is the first thing to vanish.

Then your own residual target. Take the one sound from your tracker that most affects how easy you are to follow — not the one that annoys you most. One cue, one phrase, one sentence, stop.



Record one sentence with your target in it, before the task. Do not chase perfection on task day.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + PEER EXCHANGE)

Round 1 — rehearse alone. Deliver the two minutes quietly to yourself with the checklist visible. Time it.

Round 2 — peer exchange. In pairs, take turns:

- **Speaker:** deliver the talk. Card allowed on the support route, not read from.
- **Listener:** tick the six items, then ask **two** questions from this set:

What's been the hardest part? · How long has that been going on? · What have you got left to do? What made you start? · What would you do differently? · Who else has been involved?

- **Speaker:** answer, then **ask one question back.**

Round 3 — one polish pass. Swap one piece of feedback each: one thing that worked, one thing to fix. Deliver only the weakest part again.



YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** on what you've been working on, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **one live question** from your coach, unrehearsed.



Save this recording. It is your Stage-3 baseline. In Unit 12 you will record the same update again, and this file is what makes that comparison mean anything.



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your two-minute talk.
- Complete the **Unit-1 quiz** — perfect continuous form, activity against result, *how long* with *for/since*, and error-spotting.
- Keep the recording somewhere you will find it in three months.
- Use the update for real this week. Say it to one actual person, in English.



REMEMBER — افكر

- Continuous for **activity and duration**; simple for **result and quantity**.
- A **number** in the evidence, or there is no evidence.

- **Shade** the duration — *on and off, just over, properly only since*.
 - Include the **difficulty**. It is what makes the rest credible.
 - **Ask a question back**. That is what makes it a conversation.
 - Breathe at the **joins**, and keep *been* audible when the turn gets long.
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes without switching out of English.
 - ☐ I used the continuous for activity and the simple for a result with a number.
 - ☐ My duration was shaded, not just a figure.
 - ☐ I named a real difficulty.
 - ☐ I gave a concrete next step.
 - ☐ I answered a follow-up without restarting, and asked one back.
 - ☐ I saved the recording as my Stage-3 baseline.
-

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 1 complete — *precision, and a talk you'll reuse for years*



STAGE 3 · UNIT 2

PAST PERFECT & NARRATIVE MASTERY

👑 UNIT 2 — PAST PERFECT & NARRATIVE MASTERY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: own the whole past. Narrate a complex event so clearly that a listener always knows what happened first — and explain **why** it happened, not just what.

This unit completes the English tense system. After it there is no time you cannot express. What remains in Stage 3 is not new time but new work: conditions, deduction, register, argument. The past stops growing here.

The skill being built is bigger than the grammar. Sequencing and cause are what the Unit-12 benchmark spends most of its twenty to thirty minutes on, and they are what makes someone easy to talk to. Half of professional English is telling what happened and explaining why.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Past perfect — <i>had done</i>	mark the event that came first , and know when not to
L02	Past perfect continuous	the activity behind a past state — <i>I was tired because I'd been...</i>
L03	Sequencing a complex narrative	four past tenses, one spine , a marked flashback
L04	Causes & backstory	answer <i>why?</i> in layers — and survive being asked twice
L05	Unit task 🎙️	a 2–3 minute turning point , told with depth, plus probing questions

Grammar spine: past perfect · past perfect continuous · the four-tense past system integrated · sequence markers (*by the time, already, before, after, it turned out that*) · causal chaining. **Accent Lab:** the '**d**' that carries the tense · /aɪd bɪn/ as two beats with the /d/ intact · narrative prosody — slow at the complication, **drop pitch** for the flashback, pause **before** the reveal · never stress *because*. **Mindset:** owning your progress story — you can now narrate cause and sequence, not just events. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A **turning-point narrative** you can tell for the rest of your life — and, with consent, one of the strongest proof clips in the programme.

- The ability to answer *why?* twice in a row without repeating yourself.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** past perfect for the earlier event · past perfect continuous for cause and duration · sequence in a complex story · error-spotting on **over-use** of the past perfect.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 turning-point narrative plus two probing questions, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — sequencing and phrasing flags, each learner's residual sound, and a note of who ran out of material on the second *why*.
-

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 3 — FUTURE FORMS (ADVANCED)

will be doing, will have done, and the far more useful skill underneath them: saying how **certain** you actually are.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · sequence, cause, and a story worth telling

PAST PERFECT: *HAD + PARTICIPLE* — THE PAST BEFORE THE PAST

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 narrative past
 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md](#) · **S3-U2-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Build *had + participle* for anything that happened **first**.
- Make the order of two past events unmistakable.
- Use *by the time*, *already*, *before* and *after* naturally. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You can already tell a story. B1 gave you the past simple for events, the past continuous for the scene, and *before* and *after* to put things in order. So what is missing?

Consider two sentences. *When I arrived, the meeting started.* *When I arrived, the meeting had already started.* The first says I walked in and it began — I was on time, possibly early. The second says I walked in and it was underway — I was late. One word of difference, and the entire situation changes, including how the listener judges me. There is no way to express that difference with the past simple alone; you would have to add an explanation that a native speaker gets from a single auxiliary.

This is the tense of **consequences and context**, and that is why it matters more at B2 than it looks. Most interesting things you say about the past involve something that was already true when the story began. You arrive and the food has gone. You apply and the position has been filled. You call and they have moved. Without the past perfect you can only report events in the order you experienced them, which makes you sound like someone reading a log rather than telling a story.

There is also a professional edge to it. *We launched late because the supplier had changed the specification* places the cause clearly before the effect and, incidentally, places the blame accurately. *We launched late because the supplier changed the specification* is muddier — did they change it before, or during, or as a result? When you explain what went wrong at work, the past perfect is how you make the sequence honest.

A word of warning, because it is the mistake everyone makes. Having met this tense, you will want to use it everywhere, and a paragraph where every verb is *had done* is much harder to follow than one with none. The past perfect is a signpost, not a decoration. One well-placed *had* tells the listener where in time to stand. Six of them tell the listener nothing.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE BI NARRATION)

Tell a partner about something that went wrong recently. Sixty seconds. Use the past simple for events and the past continuous for the background.

Then answer one question: *what was already true before your story started?* Most of you will find you need a form you do not have yet.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the layered-story clip, then read:

A: How was the interview? **B:** Honestly? By the time I got there, they'd already interviewed four people. And when I walked in, I realised I'd forgotten my portfolio. **A:** Oh no. **B:** It was fine in the end. They'd read my application properly, which surprised me — the last three companies hadn't even opened it. **A:** So what happened? **B:** They offered me the job. But I'd already accepted something else the day before, so I had to say no. **A:** You'd accepted another offer? **B:** Two days earlier. It had taken them three weeks to reply, and then everything arrived at once.

Every *had* marks something that happened **before** the moment being described. Take them all out and the story still makes sense — but you lose exactly the thing that makes it a story: knowing what was already the case.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (HAD + PARTICIPLE)

One form, every subject. This is the easiest tense in English to build:

Subject		
I / you / he / she / it / we / they	had	finished · gone · seen · left

I had finished. → I'd finished. · She had gone. → She'd gone. Negative: I hadn't finished. · Question: Had you finished?

No agreement, no third-person change, one auxiliary. All the difficulty is in **when to use it**, not how.

What it means. Two past events, and this one came first:

PAST — **they had interviewed four people** — **I arrived** — NOW

The past simple carries the main story. The past perfect steps **back** from it.

The sequence markers it lives with.

Marker	Example
by the time	<i>By the time I arrived, they'd already started.</i>
already	<i>She'd already left when I called.</i>
before	<i>I'd never flown before that trip.</i>
after	<i>After I'd sent it, I noticed the mistake.</i>
when	<i>When I got home, someone had been in the flat.</i>
it had taken...	<i>It had taken them three weeks to reply.</i>

When you genuinely need it — and when you don't. This is the whole lesson:

✓ *When I arrived, the meeting **had** started.* — I was late. The order carries the meaning. ✗ *First I **had** woken up, then I **had** eaten, then I **had** left.* — chronological order is already clear. Use the past simple: *I woke up, ate, and left.*

The rule that keeps you out of trouble: if the events are already in the order they happened, you do not need the past perfect. It exists to mark the one that is **out of order** — the step backwards.

A useful side-effect. *I'd never done X before* is the natural way to say something was a first, and it is much stronger than *it was my first time*. Learners under-use this one while over-using everything else.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
by the time	<i>By the time I got there, they'd left.</i>
already	<i>They'd already started.</i>
I'd never ... before	<i>I'd never flown before.</i>
it turned out that...	<i>It turned out he'd resigned.</i>
it had taken...	<i>It had taken three weeks.</i>
by then	<i>By then I'd made up my mind.</i>
I realised (that) I'd...	<i>I realised I'd forgotten it.</i>
I hadn't expected...	<i>I hadn't expected that at all.</i>
the day before	<i>I'd accepted it the day before.</i>
in the end	<i>It was fine in the end.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE 'D THAT CARRIES THE MEANING)

Cue 1 — 'd is one consonant, and it must survive. *had* almost never appears in full in speech. It collapses onto the pronoun:

I had → *I'd* /aɪd/ · *she had* → *she'd* /ʃɪd/ · *they had* → *they'd* /ðeɪd/

Now the problem: drop that /d/ and *I'd finished* becomes *I finished* — a different tense and a different sequence. This is the smallest sound in the lesson and the one that carries the whole meaning. It is also easily confused with *would*: *I'd finished* (past perfect) against *I'd finish* (conditional). The participle tells you which, so the ending of the **next** word matters too.

Cue 2 — *had* goes full only when you contradict.

"You didn't tell me." — "I **had** told you. Twice."

Stressing *had* is how English disagrees about the past. Learners rarely do it, and it is a very natural move.

Cue 3 — group the two clauses. One break, at the comma:

By the time I got there // they'd already interviewed four people.



Record: "By the time I arrived, they'd already started, and I realised I'd forgotten my notes." Listen back for both 'd sounds. If you cannot hear them, neither can anyone else.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Which came first? Put the earlier event into the past perfect:

1. When I got to the station, the train (leave).
2. She (not eat) all day, so she was starving.
3. By the time we arrived, they (already / order).
4. I (never / see) snow before I moved there.
5. He was upset because someone (take) his seat.

B. Do you need it? Say yes or no, and why:

1. I got up, I had made coffee, and then I had left.
2. When she called, I had already gone to bed.
3. He had studied law, then he had worked in a bank, then he had moved abroad.
4. They cancelled the trip because the airline had gone bankrupt.

C. Join the pair. One sentence, using the marker given:

1. I finished the report. Then my manager asked for it. — **by the time**
2. He left. I got there. — **already**
3. I sent the email. I noticed the typo. — **after**
4. That was my first flight. — **I'd never ... before**

D. Contradict. Respond with a stressed *had*:

"You never told me about the meeting." → "I **had** told you — on Monday."

Now: "You didn't finish it." · "Nobody warned me." · "You forgot to call."



YOUR TURN — دورك

Tell **three** short things, each containing an earlier past event:

By the time I got to the airport, the gate had closed. I was exhausted because I hadn't slept. I'd never lived alone before that year.

 **Record all three.** Check one thing: is the 'd audible every time?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "By the time ____, I had already ____."
- Tell one real story this week that includes something which was **already true** before it started.
- Watch for it in subtitles. Count the *hads* in one scene — you will find far fewer than you expect, and each one will be doing real work.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **had + participle** — one form, every subject, no agreement.
- It marks the event that happened **first** — the step backwards.
- **Only when the order needs it.** Already in order? Use the past simple.
- *by the time · already · before · after · it turned out that*
- 'd is one consonant and it carries the whole meaning. Drop it and you change the tense.
- Full **had** = contradiction: "I **had** told you."

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can build it for every subject without thinking.
- ☐ I can say when the past perfect is **not** needed.
- ☐ I can hear the difference between *I finished* and *I'd finished*.
- ☐ I used three sequence markers correctly.
- ☐ My 'd is audible in my recording.

Empire English 🏰 — one auxiliary, and your listener always knows what happened first

PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS: *HAD BEEN + -ING* — THE CAUSE BEHIND THE PAST

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md](#) · S3-U2-L02

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Build *had been + -ing* for activity running up to a past moment.
- Explain **why** a past situation was the way it was.
- Choose between *had been doing* and *had done*. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Last lesson gave you the step backwards. This lesson gives you the **reason**.

She was exhausted. Fine, but incomplete — and the obvious next question is why. *She was exhausted because she'd been working all night* answers it in one clause, and notice what the form is doing: it takes an activity, stretches it across a period, and lands it at the moment your story begins. The tiredness is not an event; it is the residue of something that had been going on. English has a dedicated tense for exactly that, and once you have it, a large category of explanation opens up.

This is why the form matters far more than its frequency suggests. Most of what makes a past situation understandable is invisible activity that preceded it. The road was wet because it had been raining. He was nervous because he had been rehearsing for a week. The team was behind because they had been waiting on a decision. In every case the visible state is the effect and the past perfect continuous is the cause. Without it you are left with *she was tired because she worked all night*, which is not wrong but flattens a stretch of time into a single event and loses the sense of accumulation.

There is a second, more strategic reason. B2 is the level at which you are expected to explain, not just report, and explanation is what separates a competent narrator from an interesting one. When someone asks *why did that happen?* at work, a good answer usually reaches back into activity that was already underway — and the tense you need for that reaching back is this one. Unit 4 will build a whole lesson on backstory; this is the grammar that makes it possible.

And there is a pleasing economy here. You already made this exact distinction in Unit 1 between *I've been working* and *I've worked*. This is the same choice, shifted one step into the past. If you understood activity against result once, you already understand it here.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE PAST PERFECT)

Three sentences, fast:

1. Something that had **already happened** by the time you arrived somewhere.
2. Something you'd **never done before** a particular year.
3. Something that had **taken longer** than expected.

Then one more, and notice it is harder: *why* was something the way it was, when you got there?

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: How was she when you saw her? **B:** Completely wrecked. She'd been working all night — she'd been on that proposal since Thursday. **A:** Did she finish it? **B:** She'd finished about half. Which tells you how big it was. **A:** Why was it so late? **B:** They'd been waiting on legal for two weeks, so nothing could move. And the client had been changing the brief the whole time. **A:** And the office was empty when you got there? **B:** Everyone had gone home. I'd been sitting there for twenty minutes before I realised I was alone.

Look at the pairing in the second exchange: *she'd been working* (activity, all night) against *she'd finished about half* (result, with a quantity). Exactly the Unit-1 contrast, one step further back.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (HAD BEEN + -ING)

Four parts, and only *had* ever contracts:

Subject	<i>had</i>		<i>-ing</i>
every subject	had → 'd	been	working

She'd been working. · They'd been waiting. · I hadn't been sleeping. · Had you been waiting long?

What it means. Activity that ran for a period **up to** a point in the past — and usually explains the state at that point:

PAST — **she had been working (all night)** —→ **she was exhausted** — NOW

Its natural home is a *because* clause. This is the shape to memorise:

He was out of breath because he'd been running. The ground was wet because it had been raining. I was annoyed because I'd been waiting for an hour.

The choice — and you already know it. Same as Unit 1, moved back:

	<i>had been + -ing</i>	<i>had + participle</i>
Foregrounds	activity, duration	result, completion
Answers	<i>how long?</i>	<i>how much / how many?</i>
Example	<i>She'd been reading all evening.</i>	<i>She'd read three chapters.</i>

I'd been writing the report — the effort. · I'd written the report — it exists, it's done.

And the same trap: **a quantity forces the simple.** *I'd been writing three reports* contradicts itself, exactly as *I've been writing three emails* did.

State verbs still refuse it. *I'd known her for years*, not *I'd been knowing her*. If the verb describes something you **are** rather than something you **do**, use the simple.

A caution about stacking. You now own four past tenses, and it is tempting to use all of them in one sentence. Resist. One past perfect continuous per explanation is plenty; the point is clarity of cause, not a demonstration of range.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
because I'd been...	<i>I was tired because I'd been travelling.</i>
all night / all day	<i>She'd been working all night.</i>
since Thursday	<i>He'd been on it since Thursday.</i>
for two weeks	<i>They'd been waiting for two weeks.</i>
that's why...	<i>That's why she was so upset.</i>
it explained why...	<i>It explained why he'd looked worried.</i>
the whole time	<i>He'd been changing it the whole time.</i>
I'd been meaning to...	<i>I'd been meaning to call her.</i>
out of breath	<i>He was out of breath.</i>
wrecked / exhausted	<i>She was completely wrecked.</i>

🎤 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (SMOOTHING FOUR WORDS INTO TWO BEATS)

had been is the longest weak string you have met. In natural speech it is almost nothing:

she had been → *she'd been* → /ʃɪdbɪn/ · *I had been* → /aɪdbɪn/ · *they had been* → /ðeɪdbɪn/

Cue — two beats, not four. The whole auxiliary string is unstressed; the stress lands on the *-ing* verb:

* /ʃɪdbɪn/ **WORK**ing all night. * /aɪdbɪn/ **WAIT**ing for an hour. *

Say it as four separate words and it sounds like dictation. Squeeze it and the sentence finally has a shape.

But keep the /d/. *She'd been* against *she been* is the difference between a tense and an error, and the /d/ is the only thing marking it. Squeezed is not the same as deleted — this is the balance the whole of Stage 3 pronunciation turns on.

Group the explanation. Break before *because*, not inside it:

She was completely wrecked // because she'd been working all night.

🎧 **Record:** "I was annoyed because I'd been waiting for nearly an hour." Listen for the /d/, and for the stress landing on *waiting*.

🏋️ TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Build the explanation. *Result + because + had been -ing:*

1. *He was covered in paint... → ...because he'd been decorating.*
2. *The kitchen smelled amazing...*
3. *I couldn't concentrate...*
4. *Her eyes were red...*
5. *The car wouldn't start...*

B. Continuous or simple?

1. *She was tired because she ____ (work) all night.*
2. *By then he ____ (finish) three chapters.*
3. *They ____ (wait) for two hours when the news came.*

4. I ____ (send) four emails before anyone replied.
5. We ____ (live) there for years before we noticed the noise.

C. Spot the contradiction. All wrong for the same reason:

1. I'd been writing three reports.
2. She'd been reading four books that month.
3. They'd been solving two of the problems.

D. Explain a past state. Your partner names a state; you invent the cause:

"He looked furious." → "He'd been sitting in traffic for two hours."

Now: "She was soaking wet." · "The office was completely silent." · "He seemed nervous." · "They were all laughing."

 YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** sentences of the shape *result + because I'd been...*, about real things:

I was exhausted on Monday because I'd been travelling all weekend. I failed that test because I hadn't been revising properly. I was so relieved, because I'd been worrying about it for weeks.

 **Record all three.** Check: is the /d/ there? Does the stress land on the -ing word?

 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "I was ____ because I'd been ____."
- Once a day, explain a past state out loud using this form. It is the most natural *why* answer in English.
- Notice the pairing in what you watch: a state, then the activity behind it. The two travel together.

 REMEMBER — افكر

- **had been + -ing** — activity running **up to** a point in the past.
- Its home is a **because clause**: state first, cause second.
- Continuous = **activity and duration**. Simple = **result and quantity**. Same choice as Unit 1, one step back.
- A **quantity forces the simple**: *I'd been writing three reports* contradicts itself.
- State verbs refuse it: *I'd known her*, not *I'd been knowing her*.

- /aɪdbɪn/ — two beats, not four — but **never lose the /d/**.
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can build *had been* + *-ing* for any subject.
 - ☐ I used it inside a *because* clause to explain a past state.
 - ☐ I can say why a quantity cannot take the continuous.
 - ☐ I said /aɪdbɪn/ as two beats with the /d/ intact.
 - ☐ I can name the Unit-1 lesson this is the mirror of.
-

Empire English 🏰 — now you can say *why*, not just *what*

SEQUENCING A COMPLEX NARRATIVE — ALL FOUR PAST TENSES

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md](#) · S3-U2-L03

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Tell a story where **four tenses** work together without collision.
- **Flash back** mid-story and return without losing your listener.
- Keep six to eight sentences perfectly clear about what came first. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You now own the whole past. The past simple for events, the past continuous for the scene, the past perfect for what came earlier, the past perfect continuous for the activity behind a state. Individually you have practised all four. This lesson is about what happens when they have to share a paragraph.

The reason that is hard has nothing to do with grammar. It is that a story is not told in the order it happened. Real narration jumps: you start at the interesting moment, step back to explain how you got there, come forward again, and drop in a detail from even earlier. Every one of those jumps has to be signalled, or your listener quietly loses the thread and starts nodding without following. The four tenses are how English signals the jumps — they are not decoration, they are the navigation.

Watch what happens without them. *I went to the office. Everyone left. I waited for an hour. I went home.* Four past simples, and the sequence is genuinely ambiguous — did everyone leave before or after I arrived? Was I waiting while they left? Now: *When I got to the office, everyone had already left. I'd been waiting for an hour before I realised, so I went home.* Same events, and now the order is unmistakable. Nothing was added except tense choice.

This is also the single most transferable skill in the stage. Explaining what went wrong on a project, telling a story in an interview, recounting a decision to a colleague — all of it is complex narration under mild pressure. The B2 benchmark in Unit 12 is a twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation, and a large part of it will be you telling things that happened. Being easy to follow across a long turn is worth more than any individual structure you could deploy inside it.

One warning, and it is the opposite of what you might expect. The risk in this lesson is not using too few tenses. It is using too many. A learner who has just met the past perfect starts marking everything, and a story where every clause steps backwards has no forwards left. **Your story needs a spine of past simple.**

The other three tenses are departures from it. If you cannot point to the main line of events in your own story, your listener certainly cannot.

WARM-UP — سخن (ALL FOUR, ONE EACH)

Thirty seconds each, aloud:

1. Past simple — an **event** last week.
2. Past continuous — what was **going on** when it happened.
3. Past perfect — something **already true** before it.
4. Past perfect continuous — the **activity** behind how you felt.

Then say all four about the **same** event, in any order you like.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the complex-story model, then read. The tenses are marked:

I'll never forget my first day at that job. **[EVENT]** I turned up twenty minutes early, which I thought was impressive. **[EARLIER]** It turned out they'd moved the office the week before and nobody had told me. **[SCENE]** So I was standing outside an empty building at eight in the morning, in the rain, **[ACTIVITY BEHIND A STATE]** and by then I'd been travelling for over an hour, so I wasn't in a good mood.

[FLASHBACK] I should say — I'd applied for that job three times. They'd rejected me twice, and I'd almost given up on it. So this was not the morning I'd imagined.

[EVENT] Anyway, I called the number on my contract. **[EARLIER]** The woman who answered said she'd been trying to reach me all week — **[EARLIER STILL]** she'd sent an email to an address I'd stopped using years before. **[EVENT]** In the end she gave me a taxi fare and I arrived an hour late, soaked. **[REFLECTION]** And I still got the job.

Three things to notice. There is a clear **spine** of past simple — *turned up, called, gave, arrived, got*. Everything else steps away from it and comes back. And the whole second paragraph is a **flashback**, marked by one phrase — *I should say* — and carried entirely by *had*.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE FOUR-TENSE SYSTEM IN ONE STORY)

Tense	Job in a story	Signal
Past simple	the spine — events in order	<i>I turned up, I called, I arrived</i>
Past continuous	the scene around an event	<i>I was standing outside...</i>
Past perfect	something already true	<i>They'd moved the office.</i>
Past perfect continuous	the activity behind a state	<i>I'd been travelling for an hour.</i>

Rule one: build the spine first. Decide the three or four things that actually happened, in order, in the past simple. That is your story. Everything else is added to it.

Rule two: step back only when the order is not obvious. If it happened next, use the past simple. Save *had* for the genuine step backwards.

Rule three: mark your flashback and mark your return. English lets you leave the timeline and come back, but you have to say so:

Going back: *I should say... · This was after... · To explain... · A bit of background:* **Coming forward:** *Anyway... · So, back to that morning... · In the end...*

Without those two markers a flashback reads as confusion. With them it reads as control, and *anyway* is doing more work in that model than any tense in it.

Rule four: one idea per thought group. A long narrative fails on breathing before it fails on grammar. Break at the joins, not at random.

The structure underneath. Most good short narratives are the same four moves:

Set-up (where, when, what was going on) → **Complication** (the event, plus what had already happened) → **Development** (the activity behind it, the flashback) → **Resolution and reflection** (how it ended, what you now think).

That is the arc card, and you will use it again in L05, in Unit 11 and in the Unit-12 benchmark.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Set the scene	<i>This was back when... · At the time I was... · It was the middle of...</i>
Move forward	<i>Anyway... · So... · The next thing I knew... · A couple of days later...</i>
Step back	<i>I should say... · To explain... · A bit of background... · This was after...</i>
Reveal	<i>It turned out that... · What I didn't know was... · As it happened...</i>
Give the cause	<i>...because I'd been... · By then I'd... · Which explained why...</i>
Reach the point	<i>In the end... · The upshot was... · And that's when I realised...</i>
Reflect	<i>Looking back... · I've never forgotten... · It taught me that...</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (NARRATIVE PROSODY)

Storytelling has its own music, and three moves carry almost all of it.

Cue 1 — slow down at the complication. The most common narrative failure is a flat, even pace throughout. Speed up slightly through the set-up, then **slow** at the turn:

I turned up twenty minutes early — // and the building // was empty.

Cue 2 — drop your pitch for the flashback. When you step out of the timeline, step **down** in pitch. It is what a parenthesis sounds like:

I should say — ↘ I'd applied for that job three times — ↗ anyway.

Come back up on *anyway*. Your listener hears the return without being told.

Cue 3 — the reveal takes a pause before it, not after. *It turned out... (pause) they'd moved the office.* Learners instinctively pause after the interesting part, which throws the emphasis away.

And keep the auxiliaries squeezed. *I'd /aɪd/, I'd been /aɪdbɪn/, they'd /ðeɪd/* — unstressed, fast, and the /d/ intact. In a long turn these are the first casualties, and losing them costs you the sequence.



Record three sentences of your story: an event, a step back, a return. Listen for the pitch drop on the step back.



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ (BUILD A COMPLEX STORY)

A. Find the spine. Take this jumble and identify the three main events, then put everything else in the right tense:

lose my wallet · look for it for an hour · realise I left it in the taxi · call the company · they already hand it in · someone find it and return it

B. Fix the flat version. All past simple. Rewrite it so the order is unmistakable:

I arrived at the venue. The doors closed. I stood outside. I waited for forty minutes. My friend texted. She went to the wrong venue.

C. Build from the arc card. In pairs, use the four moves — set-up, complication, development, resolution — for one of these:

- a journey that went wrong
- a day when everything changed
- a time you were completely mistaken about something
- a decision you nearly didn't make

Include **one flashback**, marked and returned from.

D. Non-linear telling (stretch). Tell the same story again, starting with the **complication**, then flashing back to the set-up. Notice how much more *had* you suddenly need — and that this is exactly what a good opening line does.



YOUR TURN — دورك

Tell a complex story in **six to eight sentences**, containing at least **three** past tenses and one marked flashback.

Before you speak, do two things: name your **spine** aloud, and decide where your **flashback** goes.



Record it. Listen back once and ask the only question that matters: *would someone who wasn't there know what happened first?*



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a complex story using three or more past tenses.

- Before telling any story this week, decide your **spine** in one breath. It is the habit that makes long turns survivable.
- Listen to how podcast guests flash back. Count the markers — *I should say, this was before, anyway.* They are everywhere and they are learnable.



REMEMBER — افكر

- Build the **spine** in past simple first. Everything else departs from it.
- Step back with *had* **only** when the order needs it.
- **Mark the flashback and mark the return.** *I should say... anyway...*
- The arc: **set-up → complication → development → resolution and reflection.**
- Slow at the complication; **drop your pitch** for the flashback.
- Clarity of sequence beats number of tenses. Every time.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can state my story's spine in one sentence.
- ☐ I used three or more past tenses without collision.
- ☐ My flashback was marked, and I returned from it.
- ☐ A listener could say what happened first.
- ☐ I varied my pace instead of telling it flat.

Empire English 🏰 — *four tenses, one story, and nobody lost*

EXPLAINING CAUSES & BACKSTORY — ANSWERING WHY? WITH DEPTH

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md](#) · S3-U2-L04

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Explain **why** something happened, across more than one time frame.
- Give a cause **behind** the cause — and say which one really mattered.
- Survive being asked *why?* twice in a row. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

There is a question that separates learners who sound competent from learners who sound convincing, and it is just *why?*

Most people can answer it once. *The project was late. Why? Because we started too late.* That is a complete, correct, B1 answer, and it stops. Now watch someone answer it properly: *Because we started too late — although really that was a symptom. We'd been waiting on a legal review since February, and by the time it came back the original spec had changed, so we were effectively starting from scratch in April.* Same question, and the second answer has a **chain**: an immediate cause, an underlying cause, and a judgement about which one mattered.

That is what depth means, and it is not a vocabulary problem. It is a time problem. A real explanation almost always reaches back past the event into things that were already happening — which is precisely what the past perfect and past perfect continuous are for. You spent two lessons building those forms; this is the lesson where they earn their keep. *We were late because the spec had changed* and *we were late because we'd been waiting since February* do different work, and a good explanation uses both.

Why this matters beyond storytelling: explanation is the most professionally valuable thing you can do in a second language. Reporting what happened is useful. Explaining why it happened is what gets you consulted. In a post-mortem, an interview, a performance review or a client conversation, the person who can lay out a causal chain calmly — without blaming, without waffling — is the person who sounds senior. That skill is language, not seniority, and you can build it here.

And there is a hard-headed reason to practise the **second why**. A single prepared explanation is easy. The follow-up is not, because you cannot rehearse it. In the Unit-12 benchmark you will be asked to justify things and then pushed on the justification, and the moment where learners run out of material is almost always the second question, not the first. Better to discover that now.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE COMPLEX NARRATION)

Tell a partner, in sixty seconds, about something that did not go to plan. Use your **spine** and at least one step back.

Then your partner asks *why?* — once. Then again. Notice which one is harder.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip — someone explains why a plan failed. Then read:

A: So what actually went wrong with the launch? **B:** On the surface, we ran out of time. But that's not really the reason. **A:** Go on. **B:** We'd been building it around one supplier since the beginning. And in January they changed their pricing — which we found out about in March, because nobody had been checking their updates. **A:** Why not? **B:** Honestly, because the person who'd been handling it had left in December and we hadn't replaced her. So the real cause wasn't time. It was that we'd built a dependency and then lost the only person watching it. **A:** Couldn't you have switched suppliers? **B:** By then, no. We'd already signed the hardware order. If we'd known in January we could have — that's what makes it frustrating.

Count the layers: *ran out of time* → *supplier changed pricing* → *nobody was checking* → *the person had left and wasn't replaced*. Four levels deep, and at the end he **names** which one was the real cause. That is a B2 explanation.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (BUILDING A CAUSAL CHAIN)

The three-layer shape. Almost every good explanation has these, in this order:

Layer	What it does	Language
Surface	the obvious reason	<i>On the surface... · The immediate cause was...</i>
Underlying	what was already happening	<i>We'd been... since... · The real issue was that we'd...</i>
Judgement	which one actually mattered	<i>The real cause wasn't X, it was Y.</i>

Why the tenses do the work. The surface layer sits in the past simple. The underlying layer almost always needs a step back:

We were late — past simple, the effect. *because the spec **had changed*** — past perfect, an earlier event. *because we'd been waiting** since February* — past perfect continuous, ongoing activity

behind it.

Choose by the same test as ever: a **single earlier event** takes *had done*; **activity across a period** takes *had been doing*.

Naming the real cause is the B2 move. This one sentence pattern is worth memorising:

The real cause wasn't ____, it was _____. That was a symptom, not the reason. The actual problem was that we'd ____.

It signals that you have thought about it rather than merely remembered it, and it is the difference between reciting events and analysing them.

Chain your links, do not stack them. Each cause should attach to the one before:

*X happened **because** Y, **and** Y happened **because** Z.*

Do not put three causes in one sentence with two *becauses* — it collapses. One link per clause, connected.

Handle the impossible follow-up honestly. Sometimes you do not know:

I still don't fully know why. · My best guess is... · Nobody ever explained it, to be honest.

Saying that is fluent. Inventing a cause to fill silence is not, and a listener can always tell.

Do not blame while explaining. *Because they were incompetent* is a judgement pretending to be a cause. English professional register prefers the mechanism: *because nobody had been checking the updates* says the same thing and is far stronger.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Surface cause	<i>On the surface... · The immediate cause was... · Officially...</i>
Go deeper	<i>But that's not really the reason. · That was a symptom. · The underlying issue was...</i>
Reach back	<i>We'd been ... since ... · By then we'd already ... · Nobody had been ...</i>
Reveal	<i>It turned out that... · What we didn't know was... · As it happened...</i>
Name the real cause	<i>The real cause wasn't X, it was Y. · The actual problem was that we'd...</i>
Chain it	<i>...which meant that... · and that was because... · so by the time...</i>
Concede uncertainty	<i>My best guess is... · I still don't fully know why... · Nobody ever explained it.</i>
Judge with hindsight	<i>Looking back... · If we'd known earlier... · That's what makes it frustrating.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (STRESSING THE CAUSE, NOT THE CONNECTOR)

Cue 1 — never stress *because*. It is a signpost, not news. The stress belongs on what follows:

*...because the **SPEC** had changed. — not ...be*CAUSE the spec had changed.**

Learners heavily stress connectors, which sounds like arguing rather than explaining, and buries the actual reason.

Cue 2 — contrastive stress carries the correction. In the *real cause* sentence, both halves need pushing:

The real cause wasn't **TIME — it was that we'd built a **DE**pendency.**

Flatten those two and the whole analytical move disappears.

Cue 3 — group each link. One cause per thought group, break between links:

We'd been building it around one supplier // since the beginning // and in January // they changed their pricing.

Cue 4 — do not rush the admission. *Honestly, because...* — slow slightly. Speeding up through a difficulty sounds defensive; the same words delivered steadily sound like command.



Record: "The real cause wasn't the deadline — it was that we'd been waiting on a decision since February." Listen for the two stresses and the weak *because*.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Add the layer. Each has a surface cause. Add an underlying one with a step back:

1. *We missed the deadline because we started late. → ...and we started late because the brief hadn't been approved.*
2. *She didn't get the job because she was nervous.*
3. *The event was half empty because we advertised late.*
4. *I failed the test because I ran out of time.*

B. Name the real cause. Rewrite using *The real cause wasn't ____, it was ____*:

1. *The delivery was late. The driver got lost. The address on the system was wrong.*
2. *I overslept. My alarm didn't go off. My phone had died in the night.*

C. Survive the chain. In pairs. One learner gives a situation; the other explains it and then answers *why?* **three times.** No repeating a reason.

"The team missed the target." → why? → why? → why?

D. Situation cards. Explain the backstory of one, in about forty-five seconds, with all three layers:

- a plan that fell apart
- a decision that turned out to be right for the wrong reasons
- something that took far longer than it should have
- a misunderstanding that got out of hand



YOUR TURN — دورك

Explain the backstory of a **real** decision or event, in about forty-five seconds. Include:

- the surface cause
- the underlying cause, using a **step back**
- a sentence naming which one actually mattered

Then answer **two** *why* questions from your partner.



Record the explanation. Listen back and check: is there a chain, or just a list?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a backstory explanation of a real event, with all three layers.
- This week, when you explain something, force yourself one layer deeper than feels necessary. Ask yourself *and why was that?* before you stop talking.
- Notice how interviewers push. The second question is always the real one.



REMEMBER — افكر

- Three layers: **surface** → **underlying** → **judgement**.
- The underlying layer needs a **step back**: *had done* for an event, *had been doing* for activity.
- **The real cause wasn't X, it was Y** — the sentence that makes you sound analytical.
- **Chain** your causes, one link per clause. Do not stack two *because*s.
- **Never stress because**. The reason is the news, not the connector.
- Give the **mechanism**, not the blame. And if you don't know, say so.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ My explanation had a surface cause and an underlying one.
- ☐ I used a step back to reach the underlying cause.
- ☐ I named which cause actually mattered.
- ☐ I answered *why?* twice without repeating myself.
- ☐ I described a mechanism rather than blaming someone.

Empire English 🏰 — reporting gets you understood; explaining gets you consulted

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: "A TURNING POINT IN YOUR LIFE" 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 2 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit2-past-perfect-narrative.md](#) · **S3-U2-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you tell one real story properly:

- **2–3 minutes** on a turning point
- a **spine** of events, plus **backstory** stepped back with *had*
- a **marked flashback**, and a **reflection** at the end
- then handle probing *why* questions 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each, no notes:

1. Something that had **already happened** by the time your day started.
2. A state, plus the **activity behind it** — *I was ... because I'd been ...*
3. A story spine: three events in the **past simple**, in order.
4. A **flashback marker**, and the phrase you use to **return**.
5. *Why?* — answered twice, without repeating yourself.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model turning-point narrative, then read:

[SET-UP] So this was about six years ago. I was working at a company I'd been at since university — five years, same desk, same team. It was comfortable, and I'd stopped noticing that I was bored.

[COMPLICATION] Then in the March they restructured, and my manager — who'd hired me, and who I'd learned basically everything from — was let go. Not for performance. They'd been cutting a whole layer of management and she happened to be in it.

[FLASHBACK] I should say, I'd been thinking about leaving for about a year at that point. I'd even had two interviews. But I'd always talked myself out of it, because on paper there was nothing wrong with the job.

[DEVELOPMENT] Anyway, she called me the week after she left. She'd already found something else, and she asked whether I wanted to come with her. And I said no.

[RESOLUTION] I said no because I was frightened, and I told myself it was because of the pension. She went, the team fell apart within a year, and I ended up leaving anyway — eight months later, for less money, to a job I liked much less.

[REFLECTION] Looking back, the turning point wasn't the restructure. It was that phone call. I'd been given exactly the thing I'd been wanting for a year, and I wasn't ready to take it. I've never made that particular mistake again.

Three things to study. The **reflection reframes the story** — the turning point turns out not to be the obvious event. The **flashback is fully marked** and returned from with *anyway*. And it is **honest**: *I was frightened, and I told myself it was the pension*. That sentence is why the story is good.

🧩 THE UNIT-2 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a set-up — where, when, what was going on	<i>I was working at a company I'd been at since...</i>
2	backstory with a step back	<i>They'd been cutting a whole layer.</i>
3	the activity behind a state	<i>I'd been thinking about leaving for a year.</i>
4	a marked flashback , and a return	<i>I should say... / Anyway...</i>
5	a clear spine of events	<i>she called · I said no · I left</i>
6	a reflection that reinterprets	<i>The turning point wasn't X, it was Y.</i>

Items 4 and 6 are the ones that get dropped. An unmarked flashback reads as confusion. A reflection that only summarises — *so that was a big moment for me* — wastes the strongest sentence you have.

🎧 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (NARRATIVE PROSODY + YOUR OWN SOUND)

Everyone — the three narrative moves from L03. Slow at the complication. **Drop your pitch** for the flashback and come back up on *anyway*. Pause **before** the reveal, not after.

Everyone — the auxiliaries must survive the long turn. *I'd* /aɪd/, *I'd been* /aɪdbɪn/, *they'd* /ðeɪd/ — squeezed, unstressed, /d/ intact. Across two or three minutes these are the first things to disappear, and losing them costs you the entire sequence you worked two lessons to build.

Then your own residual target. One sound from your tracker — the one that most affects how easy you are to follow, not the one that irritates you most. One cue, one phrase, one sentence, stop.

🎧 **Record one sentence** containing a *had been* and your own target, before the task.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + PROBING QUESTIONS)

Round 1 — plan, don't script. Two minutes, on paper, and only these four things: your **spine** (three events), where your **flashback** goes, the **state** you will explain with *had been*, and your **reflection** in one sentence. No full sentences anywhere.

Round 2 — tell it. In pairs, 2–3 minutes each. Listener ticks the six checklist items and writes down **two** probing questions from this set:

*Why did you decide that? · What had been going on before? · Why do you think you reacted that way?
What would you do differently? · When did you realise? · And why was that?*

Round 3 — the second why. The listener asks their two questions, and then asks *why?* to the answer. No repeating a reason.

Round 4 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-tell only the weakest thirty seconds.



YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record **2–3 minutes** on a turning point, with all six checklist items. Then answer **two** probing questions, unrehearsed.



Save this recording. With your consent it may sit beside your earlier milestone samples — this is often the clip where the distance travelled is most audible. Consent is separate from the course, granular, and you can withdraw it later.



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your turning-point narrative.
- Complete the **Unit-2 quiz** — past perfect for the earlier event, past perfect continuous for cause and duration, sequence in a complex story, and error-spotting on **over-use** of the past perfect.
- Keep the recording. You will want it at the end of the stage.
- Tell this story to one real person this week, in English. It will be better the second time.



REMEMBER — افكر

- **Spine first**, in the past simple. Everything else departs from it.
- *had done* for an earlier **event**; *had been doing* for the **activity** behind a state.

- **Mark the flashback. Mark the return.**
 - The **reflection should reinterpret**, not summarise: *the turning point wasn't X, it was Y.*
 - Honesty is what makes a story good. *I was frightened* beats any amount of vocabulary.
 - Clarity of **sequence** before accuracy of tense.
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for 2–3 minutes in English, without a script.
 - ☐ My set-up placed the story in time.
 - ☐ I stepped back with *had* for backstory, and *had been* for a state.
 - ☐ My flashback was marked and I returned from it.
 - ☐ My reflection reinterpreted the story rather than summarising it.
 - ☐ I answered two probing questions without restarting.
-

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 2 complete — you own the whole past now



STAGE 3 · UNIT 3

FUTURE FORMS (ADVANCED)

👑 UNIT 3 — FUTURE FORMS (ADVANCED)

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: stop having one future and start having five — and learn to say how **certain** you actually are, which is the skill underneath all of them.

Two of these lessons are not really about the future at all. L01 is about asking without demanding. L04 is about being trusted. Both are professional skills that happen to be delivered by future grammar, and both are things learners are usually missing when people describe their English as "a bit blunt".

The unit ends with a date in your calendar. Stage 3's mindset thread is planning your English life after this programme, and the future perfect is the grammar that turns an intention into something checkable.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Future continuous	be inside a future moment — and ask <i>Will you be...?</i> without pressure
L02	Future perfect	<i>by December I'll have...</i> — a deadline you can be held to
L03	Arrangements · plans · predictions	five forms, five messages — switch mid-turn on purpose
L04	Degrees of certainty	<i>bound to</i> → <i>may well</i> → <i>probably won't</i> — sound calibrated , not vague
L05	Unit task 🎤	2 minutes on your next five years, hedged honestly

Grammar spine: *will be* + *-ing* · *will have* + *participle* (+ *will have been* + *-ing* for recognition) · present continuous for arrangements against *going to* against *will* · the certainty scale, with modal + adverb and *be* + *adjective* + *to* patterns. **Accent Lab:** /aɪlbi/ and /aɪləv/ as single unstressed runs with the 'll intact · /aɪləv/ against /aɪdəv/ (pre-empting Unit 4) · *going to* → /gənə/ · **certainty falls, doubt rises** · stress on the hedge · the pause before the reason. **Mindset:** planning your post-programme English life — concretely, with dates. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A **two-minute five-year vision** that sounds credible rather than impressive.

- One **English milestone with a date on it**, in your calendar.
 - The ability to ask a colleague something without putting them on the spot.
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END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** future continuous · future perfect with *by* · arrangement against plan against prediction · certainty-scale matching · the *will probably* / *probably won't* word order.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute future talk plus one live question, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — future-form choice, **certainty intonation** (a named U12 clinic input), and each learner's dated English milestone.
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NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 4 — THIRD & MIXED CONDITIONALS

the unreal past: what **would have happened** if things had gone differently — regret, criticism, and the most grammatically demanding structure in the stage.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · five futures, and the honesty to say which one you believe

FUTURE CONTINUOUS: *WILL BE + -ING*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 · **Lesson 1** ⌚ ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 *will / going to*
 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U3-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Say what you'll **be doing** at a specific future moment.
- Ask about someone's arrangements **without sounding pushy**.
- Picture a future day and describe it. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You already have two futures. *I'm going to call her* for an intention, *I'll call her* for a decision made now. Between them they cover most of what you need. So why a third?

Because neither of them can place you **inside** a future moment. *This time next week I'll be flying to Dubai* does something the others cannot: it drops the listener into a specific point in the future and shows the action already underway. Not starting, not finished — in progress. *I'll fly to Dubai next week* gives the fact. *I'll be flying* gives the picture. When you describe a future day, a future routine, or where you expect to be when something happens, this is the only form that works.

But the reason this lesson genuinely matters is not the timeline. It is politeness, and almost nobody teaches it. Compare these:

Are you going to use the meeting room at three? Will you be using the meeting room at three?

The first sounds like the beginning of a negotiation — you want the room and you are checking whether you have to fight for it. The second is a neutral question about arrangements, and it carries no pressure at all. The reason is structural: *going to* implies intention, so asking about someone's intention makes them account for it. The future continuous asks only what will happen to be the case, which puts nobody on the spot.

That difference runs through professional English. *Will you be joining us? Will you be needing anything else? Will you be sending the report today?* Every one of them is a soft, unloaded enquiry, and every one of them has a blunter alternative that learners reach for instead. When people say a non-native speaker sounds abrupt in email or in meetings, this is very often the specific thing missing — not vocabulary, not grammar errors, but the absence of the form that lets you ask without demanding.

There is a small trap. Having met a third future you may start using it everywhere, and *will be* for every future event is as flat as *will* for every future event. The form has two jobs: an action in progress at a future point, and a neutral enquiry. Outside those two, keep the future you already had.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE B1 FUTURES)

Thirty seconds each:

1. Something you're **going to** do this weekend — an intention.
2. A prediction about next year, with **will**.
3. A decision you're making **right now**, with **I'll**.

Then a harder one: *what will you be doing at eight o'clock tomorrow morning?* Notice that none of the three forms above quite fits.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the *future plans* clip, then read:

A: Are you around next week? **B:** Not really — this time next week I'll be flying to Dubai. I'll be there until the twelfth. **A:** Working? **B:** Mostly. I'll be running a workshop on the Tuesday, and the rest of the week I'll be sitting in meetings. **A:** Will you be taking your laptop? **B:** Obviously. Why — will you be needing something? **A:** Just the file for the audit. Will you be sending that before you go? **B:** I'll send it tonight.

Notice the last line. When he commits to a decision, he switches straight back to **I'll send**. The future continuous was for the arrangements and the enquiries; the plain future is for the promise. He is moving between forms deliberately, and that is the skill.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (WILL BE + -ING)

Four parts, one shape, every subject the same:

Subject	will		-ing
every subject	will → 'll	be	working

I'll be working. · She'll be travelling. · We won't be attending. · Will you be joining us?

Job one — in progress at a future point. You name a moment, and the action is already running:

NOW ————— **8am tomorrow** ————— FUTURE ← *I'll be sitting on a plane* →

The future time expressions that go with it: *this time next week · at eight tomorrow · when you arrive · by then · all next month.*

This time next year I'll be living somewhere else. When you get here I'll be finishing lunch.

Job two — the neutral enquiry. This is the one worth real practice:

Blunt	Neutral
<i>Are you going to use the car?</i>	<i>Will you be using the car?</i>
<i>Do you want anything else?</i>	<i>Will you be needing anything else?</i>
<i>Are you coming to the review?</i>	<i>Will you be joining the review?</i>
<i>Are you going to send it today?</i>	<i>Will you be sending it today?</i>

Why it softens. *Going to* asks about your **intention**, so you have to justify it. The future continuous asks only what will **happen to be the case** — no intention implied, nothing to defend. It is the grammatical equivalent of not standing too close.

When not to use it. Do not use it for a decision or a promise made in the moment:

✗ "The phone's ringing." "I'll be getting it." → ✓ "I'll get it." ✗ I'll be sending it tonight, I promise. → ✓ I'll send it tonight.

A commitment wants the plain future. The continuous makes a promise sound like a weather forecast.

A quiet extra use. It can also mean "*this is just what's happening anyway*", which is a graceful way to decline pressure: *I'll be in meetings all afternoon* is a much softer no than *I can't*.

✂ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
this time next week	<i>This time next week I'll be flying.</i>
at eight tomorrow	<i>At eight tomorrow I'll be travelling.</i>
Will you be using...?	<i>Will you be using the room?</i>
Will you be joining us?	<i>Will you be joining us later?</i>
Will you be needing...?	<i>Will you be needing anything else?</i>
I'll be in meetings	<i>I'll be in meetings all afternoon.</i>
by then	<i>I'll be finishing up by then.</i>
I won't be around	<i>I won't be around on Friday.</i>
all next month	<i>I'll be travelling all next month.</i>
when you arrive	<i>When you arrive I'll be waiting.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (I'LL BE AS ONE SQUEEZE)

Cue 1 — three words, one beat. *I will be* never appears in full. It reduces hard:

I'll be → /aɪlbi/ · *she'll be* → /ʃɪlbi/ · *we'll be* → /wɪlbi/ · *they'll be* → /ðeɪlbi/

The whole auxiliary string is unstressed. The stress lands on the *-ing* verb:

* /aɪlbi/ **FLY**ing to Dubai.* · * /ʃɪlbi/ **RUN**ning a workshop.*

Cue 2 — the 'll must survive. Squeeze it, but do not delete it. *I be working* is not a sentence, and *I'll be* against *I've been* is a two-consonant difference carrying a three-decade difference in time. This is the same discipline as the 'd in Unit 2: reduced is not the same as gone.

Cue 3 — the enquiry rises, gently. A *Will you be...?* question is a yes/no question, so the tune goes **up** — but only a little. A steep rise sounds incredulous; a flat delivery sounds like an interrogation:

Will you be sending it today?

Cue 4 — won't is stressed. The negative is the news, so it stays full and strong: /wəʊnt/. Learners weaken it and the whole sentence flips meaning in the listener's ear.



Record two things: "This time next week I'll be flying to Dubai." and "Will you be needing anything else?" Check the squeeze on the first and the gentle rise on the second.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Put yourself in the moment. Answer in the future continuous:

1. *What will you be doing at 8am tomorrow?*
2. *Where will you be living this time next year?*
3. *What will you be doing when this course finishes?*
4. *Will you be working next Friday?*

B. Soften it. Rewrite each as a neutral enquiry:

1. *Are you going to use the projector?*
2. *Do you need the car tonight?*
3. *Are you coming to the client call?*
4. *Are you going to finish that today?*

C. Which form? Future continuous or plain *will*?

1. *"There's someone at the door." "I ___ get it."*
2. *At this time tomorrow I ___ (sit) on a train.*
3. *"Can you send it?" "Yes, I ___ send it tonight."*
4. *Don't call at six — I ___ (drive).*
5. *I ___ (be) in meetings all afternoon, so email me instead.*

D. Decline gracefully. Use *I'll be...* to say no without saying no:

"Can you join at four?" → "I'll be finishing the audit until about five, unfortunately."

Now: *"Can you help me move on Saturday?" · "Are you free Thursday morning?" · "Can you take this on as well?"*



YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** future-continuous sentences about your week or year, each anchored to a specific future moment. Then ask your partner **one** neutral enquiry.

This time next month I'll be starting a new course. At nine tomorrow I'll be sitting in a review meeting. By December I'll be working somewhere new, I hope. Will you be coming to the session on Thursday?



Record all four. Check the squeeze on *I'll be*, and the gentle rise on the question.



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "This time next ____, I'll be ____."
- **Use one neutral enquiry for real this week.** Replace an *Are you going to...?* with a *Will you be...?* and notice the difference in how the answer comes back.
- Watch for it in professional English — in emails especially. It is everywhere once you know it.



REMEMBER — افكر

- **will be + -ing** — an action **in progress** at a future moment.
- Its second job is the **neutral enquiry**: *Will you be using...?* — no intention implied, nothing to defend.
- **Not for decisions or promises.** "I'll get it", never "I'll be getting it."
- *I'll be...* is a soft way to **decline** without refusing.
- /aɪlbi/ — one squeeze, stress on the -ing word — but the 'll must survive.
- **won't** stays **full and stressed**. It is the news.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can place myself inside a future moment and describe it.
- ☐ I can turn a blunt question into a neutral enquiry.
- ☐ I know why "I'll be getting it" is wrong.
- ☐ I said /aɪlbi/ as one beat with the 'll audible.
- ☐ My *Will you be...?* question rose gently, not steeply.

Empire English 🏰 — the future that lets you ask without demanding

FUTURE PERFECT: *WILL HAVE + PARTICIPLE — DONE* BEFORE A DEADLINE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U3-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say what you'll **have finished** by a future date.
- Talk about deadlines and milestones like a professional.
- Combine *by then I'll have...* with *I'll be...* 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Last lesson placed you inside a future moment. This lesson lets you look **back** from one.

That sounds like a curiosity, and it is actually one of the most practical things in professional English. *By the end of the month I'll have finished the migration.* Consider what that sentence does. It sets a boundary in the future, and it commits to a state of completion at that boundary. It is a deadline expressed as an accomplishment rather than as an activity — and that is exactly how deadlines are discussed at work, in project plans, in reviews, in interviews.

Compare the alternatives. *I'll finish the migration at the end of the month* pins completion to a single day, which is both less realistic and more fragile. *I'm going to finish the migration* states an intention with no deadline at all. Only the future perfect says: *whenever exactly it happens, it will be done before this line.* That is a more honest promise and a more defensible one, which is why it is the form that appears in every status report you will ever read.

There is a second use that matters more personally. This is the tense of a **plan you can hold yourself to**. *By this time next year I'll have taken the exam. By December I'll have had twenty conversations in English.* A goal phrased in the future perfect has a deadline and a completed shape, which makes it checkable. A goal phrased as *I'm going to improve my English* has neither, and that is why it never happens. Stage 3's mindset thread is about planning your English life after this programme ends, and this is the grammar that makes such a plan real rather than aspirational.

One more thing worth noticing. You now have three tenses built on the same participle: *had finished* looking back from the past, *have finished* looking back from now, *will have finished* looking back from the future. It is the same move performed from three different standing points. English asks you to learn one participle and then reuses it everywhere — which means the difficulty here is almost entirely the irregular participles you already met in Unit 1.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE L01 + THE PARTICIPLES)

Fast round:

1. What will you **be doing** at this time tomorrow? (future continuous)
2. Ask your partner a **neutral enquiry** about their week.
3. Participle sprint — say the third form: *write · take · go · make · give · see · begin · leave*

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the milestone clip, then read:

A: How's the degree going? **B:** Good — by next summer I'll have finished it. Two exams left. **A:** And then what? **B:** By this time next year I'll have moved out of my parents' place, hopefully, and I'll have started work somewhere. That's the plan. **A:** Ambitious. **B:** Not really. It sounds like a lot, but by then I'll have been studying for six years. It's time. **A:** What about the driving test? **B:** Ah. I will not have passed that by next summer. Let's be realistic.

Four uses, and every one of them attaches to a **boundary**: *by next summer, by this time next year, by then*. The boundary is doing as much work as the tense.

Notice the last line too — *I will not have passed* in full, unreduced. That is deliberate emphasis, and it is funnier and more human than a contraction would be.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (WILL HAVE + PARTICIPLE)

One shape, every subject:

Subject	<i>will</i>	<i>have</i>	participle
every subject	will → 'll	have	finished · gone · taken

I'll have finished. · She'll have left. · We won't have started. · Will you have arrived by then?

What it means. Completed **before** a future boundary — not at it, before it:

NOW ——— (sometime in here it gets done) ——— | **by December** | ——— FUTURE

It needs a boundary. Almost always *by*:

Boundary	Example
<i>by + date</i>	<i>By 2030 I'll have paid it off.</i>
<i>by the end of...</i>	<i>By the end of the week I'll have sent all of them.</i>
<i>by then</i>	<i>By then we'll have decided.</i>
<i>by the time...</i>	<i>By the time you arrive I'll have cooked.</i>
<i>in + period</i>	<i>In three years I'll have qualified.</i>

If you cannot add a *by*, you probably want a different tense. That is the fastest self-check in this lesson.

The family it belongs to. Same participle, three standing points:

*I **had** finished* — looking back from the **past** / *I **have** finished* — looking back from **now** / *I **will have** finished* — looking back from the **future**

With a duration — *will have been + -ing*. The stretched version, for how long something will have been running:

By then I'll have been studying for six years. Next month she'll have been working here for a decade.

Use it only for duration up to a future point. It is rarer than the others, and forcing it is worse than not using it.

The professional register. This is the natural tense of a status commitment:

By Friday we'll have completed testing. By the time the board meets, we'll have signed both contracts.

And a caution about honesty. *I'll have finished by Friday* is a promise. Do not use it for something you merely hope will happen — that is what Unit 3's next two lessons are for. Saying *I'll probably have finished* costs you one word and buys you a great deal of credibility.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
by the end of the year	<i>By the end of the year I'll have moved.</i>
by then	<i>By then we'll have decided.</i>
by the time you arrive	<i>By the time you arrive I'll have finished.</i>
in three years	<i>In three years I'll have qualified.</i>
I'll have finished	<i>I'll have finished it by Friday.</i>
we'll have completed	<i>We'll have completed testing.</i>
I won't have...	<i>I won't have finished by then.</i>
I'll have been ... for	<i>I'll have been studying for six years.</i>
hopefully	<i>Hopefully I'll have started by then.</i>
that's the plan	<i>...and that's the plan.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (WILL HAVE BECOMES ALMOST NOTHING)

Cue 1 — the whole auxiliary is one squeezed run. *will have* reduces to /ləv/ or even /lə/ after the pronoun:

I'll have → /aɪləv/ · *she'll have* → /ʃiləv/ · *we'll have* → /wiləv/

* /aɪləv/ **FIN**ished by Friday.*

Three words arriving as one unstressed run, with the stress on the participle. Learners who say *I will have finished* fully are not wrong, but they sound like they are reading a contract.

Cue 2 — do not confuse it with I'd have. /aɪləv/ against /aɪdəv/ — one consonant apart, and one is a future commitment while the other is an unreal past. Unit 4 is built on *I'd have*, so this contrast matters now:

I'll have finished (future) · *I'd have finished* (if things had been different)

Cue 3 — the boundary phrase gets its own group. Break after it:

By the end of the month // I'll have finished the migration.

Cue 4 — full *will not have* for emphasis. As in the clip: *I **will not have** passed that by next summer.*

Unreduced auxiliaries are how English underlines things.

 **Record:** "By the end of the year I'll have finished the course." Then say it again fully — *I will have* — and hear how much more formal it becomes. Both are correct; know which one you are choosing.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Add the milestone. Complete each with a future perfect:

1. *By the end of this month, I ____.*
2. *By this time next year, I ____.*
3. *By the time I'm forty, I ____.*
4. *By Friday, we ____.*

B. Boundary check. Each sentence is missing its boundary. Add one:

1. *I'll have finished the report.*
2. *She'll have left.*
3. *They'll have made a decision.*

C. Which tense? Future perfect, future continuous, or plain *will*?

1. *At three tomorrow I ____ (drive) to the airport.*
2. *By three tomorrow I ____ (arrive) at the airport.*
3. *"The door's open." "I ____ (close) it."*
4. *By December she ____ (work) here for ten years.*
5. *Don't call at eight — I ____ (eat).*

D. Make it checkable. Turn each vague goal into a future perfect with a real deadline:

1. *I want to improve my English. → By June I'll have had thirty conversations in English.*
2. *I should get fitter.*
3. *I need to read more.*
4. *I want to change jobs.*

YOUR TURN — دورك

State **three real milestones**, each with a boundary. Then add one sentence combining the two forms from this unit:

By the end of the year I'll have finished this course. By next summer I'll have taken the exam. By this time next year I'll have moved out. And this time next year I'll be working somewhere new, hopefully — by then I'll have been in my current job for four years.



Record all four. Check: is /aɪləv/ one squeezed run? Does every milestone have a boundary?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** future milestones in the future perfect, each with a deadline.
- Take one vague intention you have been carrying and **rewrite it as a future perfect with a boundary**. Then put the date in your calendar. That is the whole point of the lesson.
- Notice this tense in project plans and status emails. It is the standard professional form for a commitment.



REMEMBER — افكر

- **will have + participle** — completed **before** a future boundary.
- **It needs a by**. No boundary usually means you wanted a different tense.
- Same participle, three standing points: *had / have / will have finished*.
- *will have been + -ing* for **duration** up to a future point — recognise it, don't force it.
- /aɪləv/ is one squeezed run — and it is **one consonant** from *I'd have*.
- A goal with a **deadline and a completed shape** is checkable. Without them it is a wish.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ Every future perfect I said had a boundary.
- ☐ I can tell *at three I'll be arriving* from *by three I'll have arrived*.
- ☐ I said /aɪləv/ as one run, not three words.
- ☐ I can hear the difference between *I'll have* and *I'd have*.
- ☐ I turned one real goal into a checkable milestone with a date.

Empire English 🏰 — a deadline you can actually be held to

ARRANGEMENTS, PLANS & PREDICTIONS — CHOOSING YOUR FUTURE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U3-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *I'm meeting him at three* for something **in the diary**.
- Switch between five future forms in one turn without stalling.
- Hear the difference between a **fixed** arrangement and a loose plan. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You now have five ways to talk about the future: the present continuous, *going to*, *will*, *will be doing* and *will have done*. That is not five synonyms. Each carries a different message about **how settled the thing is**, and choosing correctly is a large part of what people mean when they say someone sounds fluent.

Here is the sentence pattern that shows it. *I'm meeting a client at three. I'm going to meet a client at some point. I'll meet a client if that helps.* Same verb, same client, three completely different situations. The first is in the diary and cannot easily move. The second is an intention with no fixed time. The third is an offer I am making right now. If you use the wrong one, nothing sounds broken — but you have quietly misled someone about whether the meeting exists.

The one to notice is the first. The present continuous for a fixed arrangement is under-used by almost every learner at this level, and it is the most professionally useful of the five. When a colleague asks what your afternoon looks like, *I'm seeing the auditors at two and I'm on a call at four* sounds organised and settled. *I'm going to see the auditors* sounds like you are thinking about it. The difference is not politeness or formality; it is credibility. A diary entry gets the present continuous, and English speakers hear the absence of it.

There is also a real cost to over-using *will*. Because it is the first future most learners meet, it becomes the default, and *will* carries a specific flavour: a prediction, or a decision being taken at the moment of speaking. Applied to a settled arrangement it sounds oddly tentative — *I will meet the client at three* reads as though you have just decided, or are being slightly formal about a promise. Native speakers use plain *will* for the future far less than learners do.

So this lesson is not new grammar. It is the point where your future stops being one tense with variations and becomes a set of choices you make deliberately — which is what precision means at B2, and precision is what fluency actually rests on.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01 AND L02)

Fast round, one sentence each:

1. What you'll **be doing** at nine tomorrow.
2. A **milestone** with a *by* boundary.
3. A **neutral enquiry** for your partner.

Then: *what's actually in your diary for tomorrow?* Hold your answer — we come back to how you phrased it.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the mixed-forms clip, then read. Each form is marked:

A: What does your Thursday look like? **B:** Busy. **[ARRANGEMENT]** I'm meeting a client at ten, and **[ARRANGEMENT]** I'm having lunch with the design team at one. **[PLAN]** I'm going to try to get the proposal drafted in between, though **[PREDICTION]** that probably won't happen. **A:** Do you need the big room? **B:** **[ARRANGEMENT]** No, we're using the small one. **[FUTURE CONTINUOUS — ENQUIRY]** Will you be needing it? **A:** Maybe later. **[INSTANT DECISION]** Actually — I'll just book it now, to be safe. **B:** Good idea. **[FUTURE PERFECT]** By Friday we'll have finished with it anyway. **A:** **[PREDICTION]** It'll be quieter next week, I think. **B:** **[PLAN]** I'm going to take Monday off, actually.

Seven forms in a forty-second exchange, and not one of them is a mistake. Look at what carries what: everything in the **diary** is present continuous. Everything **intended** is *going to*. Everything **predicted** is *will*. The booking decision, made mid-sentence, is *I'll*.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (FIVE FORMS, FIVE MESSAGES)

Form	Message	Example
present continuous	it's arranged — in the diary, agreed with someone	<i>I'm meeting him at three.</i>
going to	I intend to — decided, but not fixed	<i>I'm going to redo the slides.</i>
will	a prediction , or a decision made now	<i>It'll be fine. · I'll get it.</i>
will be + -ing	in progress at a future point, or a soft enquiry	<i>I'll be travelling. · Will you be joining?</i>
will have + participle	completed before a future boundary	<i>By Friday we'll have finished.</i>

The test that decides it. Ask yourself one question: **is it in the diary?**

Yes, agreed with someone, has a time → present continuous. **I've decided, but nothing is fixed** → *going to*. **I'm guessing, or deciding right now** → *will*.

Why the present continuous means *arranged*. It borrows the sense of something already underway — the arrangement exists now, even though the event is later. That is why it needs a time expression to work: *I'm seeing her* alone is ambiguous; *I'm seeing her on Tuesday* is a diary entry.

The three that overlap. Be honest about this:

I'm flying to Rome on Tuesday / *I'm going to fly to Rome on Tuesday* — both fine. The first sounds booked; the second sounds decided. *It's going to rain* / *It'll rain* — both fine. *Going to* suggests you can see evidence; *will* is a plainer forecast.

Where they overlap, the difference is a shade of settledness, not a rule. Do not hunt for a rule that is not there.

Where the choice really bites.

✗ *I will meet the client at three.* — sounds like you have just decided, or are being oddly formal. ✓ *I'm meeting the client at three.* ✗ *"The phone's ringing." "I'm going to get it."* — sounds like a long-held ambition. ✓ *"I'll get it."*

Switching mid-turn is the skill. Fluency here is not picking one form and staying in it. It is moving:

I'm seeing the auditors at two (diary), and I'm going to try to prep beforehand (intention), though I probably won't have time (prediction).

One breath, three forms, and it sounds effortless because each one is doing its own job.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Diary entry	<i>I'm meeting... · I'm having lunch with... · We're using... · I'm on a call at...</i>
Intention	<i>I'm going to try to... · I'm planning to... · I'm hoping to...</i>
Prediction	<i>It'll be... · That probably won't... · I imagine it'll...</i>
Instant decision	<i>Actually, I'll... · You know what, I'll... · I'll just...</i>
In progress later	<i>I'll be ... all afternoon · This time next week I'll be...</i>
Completed by then	<i>By Friday we'll have... · By then I'll have...</i>
Ask about the diary	<i>What does your Thursday look like? · Have you got anything on?</i>
Flag the unfixed	<i>...though nothing's confirmed yet. · ...in theory.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (SWITCHING CLEANLY)

The difficulty here is not any single sound. It is **changing gear** without a stumble.

Cue 1 — each form gets its own thought group. Break between them and the switch sounds intentional rather than uncertain:

I'm seeing the auditors at two // and I'm going to prep beforehand // though I probably won't have time.

Cue 2 — going to becomes /gənə/. Fully. In connected speech it is *gonna*, and there is nothing informal about it in spoken English:

/aɪmgənə/ TRY to get it done.

Say *I am going to* in full and you will sound like you are dictating. Note it stays *going to* in writing.

Cue 3 — stress the time expression in an arrangement. The time is what makes it a diary entry, so it carries the stress:

*I'm meeting him at THREE. · *We're using the small one on TUESday.**

Cue 4 — actually opens a decision. When you change your mind mid-conversation, English marks it with *actually* on a slight rise, then the decision falls:

Actually ↗ — I'll book it now. ↘

 **Record the three-form sentence:** "I'm seeing the auditors at two, and I'm going to prep beforehand, though I probably won't have time." Listen for the breaks at the switches and the /gənə/.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Is it in the diary? Choose the form and say why in three words:

1. I ____ (see) the dentist at four. (appointment booked)
2. I ____ (start) going to the gym. (decided last week)
3. "There's no milk." "I ____ (get) some." (deciding now)
4. We ____ (have) a team lunch on Friday. (booked)
5. I think it ____ (be) a difficult year. (guess)
6. By June I ____ (finish) the course. (deadline)
7. At six tomorrow I ____ (drive). (in progress then)

B. Fix the flavour. Each is grammatical but sends the wrong message:

1. I will meet the client at three. (it's booked)
2. "The phone's ringing." "I'm going to answer it."
3. I'm meeting someone at some point next week. (nothing arranged)
4. It's going to be fine, don't worry. (pure reassurance, no evidence)

C. Your real Thursday. Describe tomorrow using **at least four** of the five forms — diary entries, an intention, a prediction, and one *by then I'll have...* Say it in one continuous turn.

D. Justify it. Your partner interrupts after each clause and asks *why that form?* Answer in four words: *it's in the diary, it's an intention, I'm guessing, deciding now.*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Talk for about **forty-five seconds** about your week ahead, using **at least three** future forms. Include at least one real diary entry in the present continuous.

So on Tuesday I'm presenting to the whole department — that's been in the diary for weeks. I'm going to rewrite the second half over the weekend, although I probably won't get to it until Sunday night. And by Wednesday I'll have finished with it either way, thankfully.

 **Record it.** Check: did you use the present continuous for anything that is genuinely arranged?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a "my week ahead" using three or more future forms.
- **Use the present continuous for your diary this week.** When someone asks what you are doing, say *I'm meeting...*, not *I'm going to meet...* It is the single change that will make you sound most organised.
- Count the plain *wills* in your own speech for one day. Most learners find far too many.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Is it in the diary?** → present continuous. **Decided but not fixed?** → *going to*. **Guessing or deciding now?** → *will*.
- The **present continuous for arrangements** is the under-used one, and the most professional.
- Plain **will** is a prediction or an instant decision. It is **not** the default future.
- Some pairs genuinely overlap. The difference is **settledness**, not a rule.
- **Switching mid-turn** is the skill — one thought group per form.
- *going to* is /gənə/ in speech, and the **time expression** carries the stress in an arrangement.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can name the message each of the five forms sends.
- ☐ I used the present continuous for something actually arranged.
- ☐ I know why "*I will meet him at three*" sounds odd for a booked meeting.
- ☐ I switched between three forms in one turn without stalling.
- ☐ I can name a pair where both forms are genuinely fine.

Empire English 🏰 — five futures, and you choose on purpose

DEGREES OF CERTAINTY — HEDGED PREDICTIONS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md](#) · S3-U3-L04

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Place a prediction anywhere on the scale from **certain** to **very unlikely**.
- Hedge without sounding as if you have no opinion.
- Sound **thoughtful** rather than either dogmatic or vague. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Educated speakers of English almost never make bare predictions. Listen to any professional discussion and you will hear predictions arriving wrapped in something: *bound to*, *likely to*, *may well*, *I'd imagine*, *probably won't*. That wrapping is not hesitation. It is information.

Consider the difference. *Prices will rise* claims certainty about the future, which nobody actually has. *Prices are bound to rise* says: this is close to inevitable, and I am confident. *Prices may well rise* says: there is a real chance, more than half perhaps, but I am not committing. *Prices probably won't rise* says the opposite, with the same degree of care. Four sentences about the same subject, and each one tells the listener exactly how much weight to put on it. That is a service you are performing for them.

Here is why it matters practically. Unhedged claims are fragile. If you say *this will take two weeks* and it takes four, you were wrong, and next time you are believed less. If you say *it'll probably take a couple of weeks, though it could slip if the data's messy*, you have said the same thing and stayed credible when it slips. In any professional setting — estimates, forecasts, risk, timelines — the person who calibrates their confidence is trusted more than the person who sounds most certain. Sounding certain is easy. Being right is not.

And there is a trap in the other direction, which is the one learners fall into. Because hedging feels like weakness, many learners either avoid it entirely and sound dogmatic, or over-do it and sound as if they have no view at all. *Maybe, I'm not sure, it depends, I don't know* is not hedging — that is an absence of opinion, and it reads as evasion. Real hedging always contains a claim: *I'd say it's likely, mainly because of the supply issue*. There is a position in there, and a reason, and an honest marker of confidence. That combination is what educated B2 speech sounds like.

One last thing. This scale will come back twice. Unit 5 applies exactly the same logic to the present and past — *she must be stuck in traffic, he can't have known* — and Unit 11 puts you in a debate where an

unhedged claim is the easiest thing in the world to attack. Learn the scale properly now and you get two later units almost free.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE FIVE FORMS)

Fast round, one sentence each:

1. A **diary entry** for this week.
2. An **intention**.
3. A **prediction** about next year.
4. A **milestone** with a *by*.

Then look at your prediction in item 3 and ask yourself: *how sure am I, really?* Most people find they were more confident in the grammar than in the content.

WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: Do you think the market's going to recover this year? **B:** Some of it is bound to — the housing side, definitely. That's almost guaranteed. **A:** And the rest? **B:** Less clear. Manufacturing may well pick up in the second half, but I wouldn't put money on it. It's likely to depend entirely on energy prices. **A:** What about hiring? **B:** Hiring probably won't move much before the autumn. And honestly it's unlikely to return to where it was — that whole model has changed. **A:** You sound fairly confident. **B:** About some of it. The housing thing I'd stake something on. The rest is guesswork with a bit of reading behind it.

Look at the range: *bound to, almost guaranteed, may well, wouldn't put money on it, likely to, probably won't, unlikely to, guesswork*. Eight different confidence levels in one short exchange — and the final line explicitly separates what he is sure of from what he is not. That last move is the mark of someone worth listening to.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE CERTAINTY SCALE)

Confidence	Language
~95%+	<i>is bound to · is certain to · will definitely · there's no way it won't</i>
~80%	<i>is very likely to · I'd expect it to · almost certainly will</i>
~60%	<i>is likely to · may well · I'd imagine · the chances are</i>
~50%	<i>might · could · may · it's possible that · it could go either way</i>
~30%	<i>probably won't · I doubt it will · I'd be surprised if it did</i>
~10%	<i>is unlikely to · almost certainly won't · there's very little chance</i>
~0%	<i>definitely won't · there's no way · I can't see it happening</i>

Two grammatical patterns, and both are worth owning:

be + adjective + to: *is bound to rise · is likely to slow · is unlikely to change* **modal + adverb:** *will probably rise · may well slow · probably won't change*

Word order with adverbs. This is where learners slip:

✓ *It will **probably** rise.* — adverb **after** will ✓ *It **probably** won't rise.* — adverb **before** won't

Positive: *will probably*. Negative: *probably won't*. Say them both aloud a few times; the asymmetry is real and it is not intuitive.

may well is the most useful phrase in the table. It means *there is a genuine chance, and I am taking it seriously* — roughly sixty percent. Learners never produce it, and it does work nothing else does:

It may well be the best option we have.

Hedging is not vagueness. Compare:

✓ *I'd say it's likely, mainly because of the supply issue.* — a claim, a level, a reason. ✗ *Maybe. I don't know. It depends.* — no claim at all.

A real hedge always contains a position. If you strip out the hedge and nothing is left, you were not hedging; you were declining to answer.

Separate what you're sure of from what you're not. The single most credible move on the scale:

The housing side I'm confident about. The rest is guesswork.

A note on *bound to*. It is strong and slightly informal, and it implies inevitability from circumstances rather than from evidence: *prices are bound to rise* means *given everything, how could they not?* Do not use it for something you merely think is likely — it over-claims, and a listener who knows the topic will notice.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
bound to	<i>Prices are bound to rise.</i>
likely to	<i>It's likely to slow down.</i>
may well	<i>It may well change.</i>
the chances are	<i>The chances are it'll slip.</i>
I'd imagine	<i>I'd imagine so, yes.</i>
it could go either way	<i>Honestly, it could go either way.</i>
probably won't	<i>It probably won't move.</i>
I'd be surprised if...	<i>I'd be surprised if it did.</i>
unlikely to	<i>It's unlikely to recover fully.</i>
I can't see it happening	<i>I can't see it happening.</i>
I wouldn't put money on it	<i>I wouldn't put money on it.</i>
mainly because...	<i>...mainly because of the supply issue.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (INTONATION CARRIES THE CONFIDENCE)

Your words say one level of certainty. Your **voice** says another. When they disagree, listeners believe the voice.

Cue 1 — certainty falls; doubt rises. A confident prediction lands flat and low at the end. An uncertain one lifts slightly:

Prices are bound to rise. 📉 — settled. *It may well pick up.* 📈 — genuinely open.

Say *bound to* with a rising tail and it stops sounding certain. Say *may well* with a hard fall and you have over-claimed with hedged words, which is worse than either.

Cue 2 — stress the hedge itself. The confidence marker is the news:

*It's **BOUND** to rise. · It **MAY** well change. · *It **PROB**ably won't.**

Cue 3 — may well has two stresses. Both words: /meɪ 'wel/. Weaken *well* and it degrades into a bare *may*, which is a different, lower level.

Cue 4 — pause before the reason. The hedge, then a small break, then the justification:

It's likely to slip // mainly because of the data.

That pause is what makes it sound considered rather than defensive.



Record two predictions — one you're confident about, one you're not. Play them to a partner **without** telling them which is which. If they can't tell, your intonation is not carrying the difference.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Place it on the scale. Where does each sit — roughly what percentage?

1. *It may well happen.* · 2. *It's bound to happen.* · 3. *I'd be surprised if it happened.*
2. *It's unlikely to happen.* · 5. *The chances are it'll happen.* · 6. *I can't see it happening.*

B. Fix the word order.

1. *It probably will rain.* · 2. *It won't probably work.* · 3. *She will definitely not agree.*

C. Calibrate honestly. Make a prediction about each, using a phrase that matches how sure you **actually** are — and add a reason:

- the cost of living in your city next year
- whether you'll still be in the same job in two years
- whether remote work will keep growing
- whether you'll take an English exam

D. Separate the two. Talk about one topic for thirty seconds, explicitly dividing what you're confident about from what you're guessing:

The demand side I'm fairly sure about — that's bound to keep growing. What happens to prices is guesswork.

🎤 YOUR TURN — دورك

Make **three** predictions about one topic — your industry, your city, your own next five years — using **three different** points on the scale. Add a reason to each.

AI is bound to change how my job works — that's already happening. It may well remove some of the junior roles, though I'd guess more slowly than people say. And I'd be surprised if it replaced the client-facing side, mainly because people want to argue with a person.

🎤 **Record all three.** Then check the hardest thing: does your **voice** match your words on each one?

📋 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** predictions across the certainty scale, each with a reason.
- **Use *may well* once this week, out loud.** It is the most useful phrase in the lesson and the one you will otherwise never produce.
- Before you next state something about the future at work, ask yourself how sure you are — then pick the phrase that matches. That habit is worth more than the vocabulary.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- Educated speakers **calibrate**: *bound to* → *likely to* → *may well* → *might* → *probably won't* → *unlikely to*.
- **Positive**: *will probably*. **Negative**: *probably won't*. The asymmetry is real.
- ***may well*** ≈ 60% and taken seriously. Nobody produces it. Produce it.
- **A hedge contains a claim.** *Maybe, I don't know* is not hedging — it is declining to answer.
- **Certainty falls, doubt rises.** If your voice contradicts your words, the voice wins.
- Say which part you're **sure** of and which part is **guesswork**. That is what credibility sounds like.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can order the scale from most to least certain.
- ☐ I get *will probably* and *probably won't* the right way round.
- ☐ I used *may well* in a real sentence.
- ☐ Every hedge I made contained an actual claim and a reason.
- ☐ A partner could tell which prediction I was confident about, from my voice alone.

Empire English 🏰 — *sounding certain is easy; being calibrated is what gets you trusted*

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: "WHERE YOU'LL BE IN FIVE YEARS" 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 3 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit3-future-forms-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U3-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you put the whole unit into one turn:

- ~2 minutes on where you'll be in five years
- a **diary-level plan**, a **future-perfect milestone**, a **future-continuous picture**
- **hedged certainty** — and a voice that matches it
- then answer live questions 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each, no notes:

1. What you'll **be doing** at nine tomorrow. (*future continuous*)
2. A milestone with a **by** boundary. (*future perfect*)
3. Something actually **in your diary** this week. (*present continuous*)
4. A prediction you're **confident** about. (*bound to / likely to*)
5. A prediction you're **not** confident about. (*may well / probably won't*)

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model future talk, then read:

[PLAN] So the immediate thing is that I'm starting a part-time diploma in September — that's booked, I've paid for it. **[MILESTONE]** By the end of next year I'll have finished the first half of it, and by 2031 I'll have qualified properly.

[PICTURE] Five years out, I'd like to think I'll be leading a small team somewhere — probably still in logistics, because I actually like it. **[HEDGE]** I may well end up somewhere completely different, though. Nobody I know is doing what they planned five years ago.

[CERTAIN] What I'm fairly sure of is that I'll be working in English every day. That's already bound to happen — most of my clients are outside Egypt now. **[MILESTONE — ENGLISH]** So by next summer I'll have taken the exam, and I'll have got my speaking to the point where I'm not preparing before calls.

[HEDGE + REASON] The part I genuinely don't know is whether I'll stay in this city. It's unlikely to be a decision I make on purpose — it'll probably depend on where my sister ends up.

[REFLECTION] Which is fine. Five years ago I couldn't have had this conversation at all.

Study three things. The talk **separates the certain from the guessed** — *what I'm fairly sure of against the part I genuinely don't know*. Every claim carries a **reason**. And the milestones are **specific and dated**, including the English one.

🧩 THE UNIT-3 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a diary-level plan — present continuous	<i>I'm starting a diploma in September.</i>
2	a future-perfect milestone with a boundary	<i>By 2031 I'll have qualified.</i>
3	a future-continuous picture	<i>I'll be leading a small team.</i>
4	a confident prediction + reason	<i>That's bound to happen, because...</i>
5	an uncertain prediction + reason	<i>I may well end up somewhere else.</i>
6	one milestone about English , with a date	<i>By next summer I'll have taken the exam.</i>

Items 5 and 6 get dropped. Learners cut the uncertainty because it feels weak — it is the opposite, it is what makes items 4 and 1 believable. And they forget the English milestone because it feels like homework rather than life. It is the one you will still be using after this course ends.

🎧 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (CERTAINTY IN THE VOICE)

Everyone — the scale must be audible. This is the unit's signature pronunciation target:

*That's **bound** to happen.* 📉 — flat, low, settled. *It **may** well change.* 📈 — lifted, genuinely open.

Record both. Play them to a partner without saying which is which. If they cannot tell, no amount of vocabulary will save the talk.

Everyone — the auxiliary squeezes. /aɪlbi/ for *I'll be*, /aɪləv/ for *I'll have* — one unstressed run each, stress on the verb, and the *'ll* intact. Across two minutes these are the first casualties.

Everyone — pause before the reason. *It's unlikely to happen // mainly because...* That break is what makes a hedge sound considered instead of evasive.

Then your own residual target. One sound from your tracker. One cue, one phrase, one sentence, stop.

 **Record one confident and one uncertain sentence** before the task, and check a partner can tell them apart.

TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + Q&A)

Round 1 — plan on paper, two minutes. Six bullets only, no sentences: your plan, your milestone, your picture, your confident claim, your uncertain claim, your English milestone. A scripted future talk collapses at the first question.

Round 2 — deliver it. In pairs, two minutes each. Listener ticks the six and prepares **two** questions from:

What makes you confident about that? · What would have to happen for that to work? What's the part you're least sure about? · Why that, and not something else? What will you have done by this time next year? · And if that doesn't happen?

Round 3 — answer, then get pushed. The listener asks their two questions and then asks *why?* to one answer.

Round 4 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver only the weakest thirty seconds, with the certainty intonation corrected.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** on where you'll be in five years, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **one live question**, unprepared.

 **Save this recording.** You will listen to it again at the end of Stage 3 — and, more to the point, the English milestone in it has a date on it. That date is the reason this task exists.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your two-minute future talk.
- Complete the **Unit-3 quiz** — future continuous, future perfect with *by*, arrangement against plan against prediction, and certainty-scale matching.
- **Put your English milestone in your calendar with its date.** Not a note — a calendar entry. That is the difference between a milestone and a wish.
- Ask one person this week what they think they'll be doing in five years, and listen to how they hedge.

**REMEMBER — افكر**

- Five futures, five messages: **arranged · intended · predicted · in progress · completed by.**
- A milestone needs a **by** and a **date**. Otherwise it is a wish.
- **Calibrate:** *bound to → likely to → may well → probably won't → unlikely to.*
- **Every claim gets a reason.** A hedge with no claim in it is just evasion.
- Say which part you're **sure** of and which part is **guesswork**.
- **Certainty falls, doubt rises.** If your voice contradicts your words, the voice wins.

**SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك**

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes in English, unscripted.
- ☐ I used a diary plan, a dated milestone and a future-continuous picture.
- ☐ I made one confident and one uncertain prediction, each with a reason.
- ☐ My English milestone has a date and it is in my calendar.
- ☐ A partner could hear which prediction I was confident about.
- ☐ I answered a follow-up without restarting.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 3 complete — a future you can be held to, and one you can honestly hedge



STAGE 3 · UNIT 4

THIRD & MIXED CONDITIONALS

👑 UNIT 4 — THIRD & MIXED CONDITIONALS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: talk about the past that **didn't happen** — and about how the past you did have is still shaping today. Then turn one regret into a rule you actually follow.

This is the hardest grammar in Stage 3, and it will feel wrong for a week. Not because the pieces are new — you already own the past perfect and *would* — but because these structures deliberately **refuse to match their tenses**. That is the point of them, and the discomfort passes.

Half of this unit is not grammar at all. L02 is about how English criticises without starting an argument. L04 is about the discipline of naming a regret once and extracting something from it. Both are skills that happen to be carried by conditional forms.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Third conditional — form	<i>If I'd known, I'd have told you</i> — and the sound /dæv/
L02	Third conditional — in use	regret, gentle criticism, hypothesis — one form, three jobs
L03	Mixed conditionals	past cause → present result: <i>I'd be there now</i>
L04	<i>wish / if only</i>	a past regret — and how it differs from a present wish by one syllable
L05	Unit task 🎧	2 minutes on a decision you'd change, ending in a rule you follow

Grammar spine: *If* + past perfect → *would/could/might have* + participle · mixed conditionals (past condition → present result, with the reverse for recognition) · *wish / if only* + past perfect against the B1 present wish · modal perfects for softened criticism. **Accent Lab:** /dæv/ — the reduction that **is** this structure · the three near-identical openings /ɪfaɪd/, /aɪdbɪ/, /aɪdæv/ carrying three time frames · /aɪwɪfaɪd/ as one run · stressed, slowed *if only* · **never stress the subject** in a criticism. **Mindset:** reframing regret as data — name it, take the lesson, let it go. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- The ability to **complain without accusing** — the single most useful professional move in this stage.
- A **two-minute reflection** on a real decision that ends in something you now do differently.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** third conditional form and use · the mixed time-frame link · *wish / if only* + past perfect against the present wish · reduced *would have* · spotting the double *would have*.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute reflection plus two reflective questions, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — conditional accuracy, **would have reduction** (a named U12 clinic input), and each learner's stated rule.
-

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 5 — MODALS OF DEDUCTION & SPECULATION

she must be stuck in traffic · he can't have known · they might have forgotten — the certainty scale from Unit 3, now applied to the present and the past.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · the past that didn't happen, and the one that's still happening

THIRD CONDITIONAL: *IF I'D KNOWN, I WOULD HAVE...*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 first & second conditionals Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md](#) · **S3-U4-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Build *If I'd ____, I would have ____* without assembling it.
- Talk about the past that **didn't happen**.
- Say and hear /aɪdəv/ — the way this structure actually sounds. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You already have two conditionals. The first for real futures — *if it rains, I'll stay in*. The second for unreal presents — *if I had more time, I'd learn the piano*. Both point forward or sideways. Neither can touch the past.

And the past is where most of the interesting conditionals live, because the past is the only part of life that is finished. *If I'd taken that job, I would have moved to Dubai*. That sentence describes a complete alternative version of events — a road not taken, fully specified. You cannot express it with anything you already own. The second conditional gets you *if I took that job, I'd move*, which describes a decision still open. The past perfect on its own gets you what happened, not what didn't.

This is the grammar of hindsight, and hindsight is most of how adults talk about their own lives. Every decision you reflect on, every mistake you learn from, every near miss you retell, every project post-mortem — all of it runs on this structure. *If we'd tested it earlier, we would have caught it. If I hadn't missed that train, I would never have met her*. Without the third conditional you can report your past but you cannot reason about it, and reasoning about the past is a large part of sounding thoughtful in any language.

There is a second, less obvious payoff, and Unit 4 will spend a whole lesson on it: this structure is how English criticises **gently**. *You could have asked me* is a complaint with the sting removed, because grammatically it describes an unreal past rather than accusing anyone of anything. Every professional culture in English leans on that move. It is the difference between *why didn't you ask me?* and *you could have asked me* — the same content, and one of them ends a conversation while the other continues it.

Now the honest warning about difficulty. This is the longest structure you have met — two clauses, two auxiliaries, two participles — and it will feel unwieldy for a week. That is normal, and it is not the real obstacle. The real obstacle is that **fluent speakers do not say it the way it is written**. *If I had known, I*

would have told you comes out as /ɪfaɪd ˈnəʊn aɪdəv təʊld ju/. Almost nothing survives. If you only ever practise the full form, you will produce something correct that nobody says, and — much worse — you will not recognise the structure when it comes at you in conversation. So the pronunciation work in this lesson is not decoration. It is half the content.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE THE SECOND CONDITIONAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. *If you had more free time, what would you do?*
2. *If you could live anywhere, where would you live?*
3. *If I were you, I'd...* — give your partner advice about something real.

Now the shift: those are all about **now**. What about something that is already over?

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. **Read the second column aloud** — that is what you actually hear:

Written	Spoken
<i>If I had studied harder, I would have passed.</i>	/ɪfaɪd ˈstʌdɪd ˈhɑːdər, aɪdəv ˈpæst/
<i>If they had told me, I could have helped.</i>	/ɪfðeɪd ˈtəʊld mi, aɪkʊdəv ˈhelpt/
<i>I wouldn't have gone if I'd known.</i>	/aɪ ˈwʊdəntəv ˈɡɒn ɪfaɪd ˈnəʊn/

Now the dialogue:

A: Did you know the flight was cancelled? **B:** Nobody told me. If they'd sent an email, I would have checked. **A:** They put it on the app. **B:** I'd have seen it if I'd opened the app. Which I didn't, obviously. **A:** Well, if you'd got there earlier you might have got on the other one. **B:** Honestly? If I'd known there was another one, I'd have run.

Count how many times you hear a full *would have*. Zero. Every single one is /dəv/ or /wʊdəv/, and every single one is completely clear to a native listener.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (IF + PAST PERFECT, WOULD HAVE + PARTICIPLE)

The shape:

If clause — the unreal condition	Result clause — the unreal outcome
If + had + participle	would have + participle
<i>If I had studied...</i>	<i>...I would have passed.</i>

*If I'd studied, I would have passed. If she hadn't helped, we would have failed. **Either order:** I would have passed if I'd studied. — no comma when the if comes second.*

What it means: none of it happened. That is the whole point. *If I'd studied, I would have passed* tells you two facts about reality — **I didn't study**, and **I didn't pass**. The structure describes an alternative universe in order to say something about this one.

The three errors, in order of frequency.

1. would of. The reduction /dəv/ sounds exactly like *of*. It is always **have**:

✗ *I would of gone.* → ✓ *I would have gone.* → spoken /aɪ 'wʊdəv 'gɒn/

2. Double would have. The *if*-clause takes the **past perfect only**:

✗ *If I'd have known...* → ✓ *If I'd known...*

This one is an overcorrection — learners hear /aɪd/ in both halves and duplicate the wrong thing. **One would have per sentence.**

3. Wrong tense in the if-clause.

✗ *If I would have studied...* → ✓ *If I had studied...* ✗ *If I studied harder, I would have passed.* — that is a second conditional welded to a third.

Vary the result with modal perfects. This is where the structure becomes expressive rather than mechanical:

Modal	Meaning	Example
would have	certain outcome	<i>I would have passed.</i>
could have	it was possible	<i>I could have helped.</i>
might have	perhaps	<i>You might have caught it.</i>
wouldn't have	it wouldn't have happened	<i>I wouldn't have gone.</i>

Could have and *might have* are the ones learners neglect, and they are more honest — you rarely know for certain what would have happened.

Negatives on either side, or both:

If I hadn't missed the train, I would never have met her. — I did miss it, and I did meet her.

Read that sentence twice. Two negatives, and the meaning is entirely positive. English does this constantly in retellings of good luck.

✂ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
If I'd known...	<i>If I'd known, I'd have called.</i>
I would have...	<i>I would have gone with you.</i>
I could have...	<i>I could have helped.</i>
I might have...	<i>You might have caught it.</i>
I wouldn't have...	<i>I wouldn't have said that.</i>
if it hadn't been for...	<i>If it hadn't been for her, we'd have failed.</i>
otherwise	<i>I didn't know — otherwise I'd have come.</i>
as it turned out	<i>As it turned out, it didn't matter.</i>
in hindsight	<i>In hindsight, I'd have done it differently.</i>
I'd never have...	<i>I'd never have met her otherwise.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (/Də V/ — THE SOUND OF THE WHOLE STRUCTURE)

This is the most important pronunciation work in Stage 3, because it is the only one that affects your **listening** as much as your speaking.

*Cue 1 — *would have* → /wʊdəv/, and after a pronoun → /dəv/*

I would have → /aɪdəv/ *she would have* → /ʃɪdəv/ *they would have* → /ðeɪdəv/ *we would have* → /widəv/

Cue 2 — the *if*-clause reduces too:

if I had → if I'd → /ɪfaɪd/ · if she had → /ɪffɪd/

So the whole sentence becomes two compressed runs with two stressed content words:

/ɪfaɪd/ **KNOWN // /aɪdəv/ **TOLD** you.*

Cue 3 — the negative stays strong. *wouldn't have → /'wʊdəntəv/,* with *wouldn't* stressed. The negative is the news and it never reduces away.

Cue 4 — stress the content words, squeeze everything else. In a two-clause sentence there are usually exactly two stresses:

*If I'd **LEFT** earlier, I'd have **CAUGHT** it.*

Everything between them is unstressed connective tissue. That is what makes it sound fluent rather than assembled.

Perception first. Listen and write down which you hear:

I'd have gone / I'd gone — /aɪdəv 'gɒn/ against /aɪd 'gɒn/ I'll have finished / I'd have finished — /aɪləv/ against /aɪdəv/ (you drilled this in U3-L02)

 **Record:** "If I'd known you were coming, I would have waited." Say it three times — full, then reduced, then fast. Keep only the third.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Say what didn't happen. Turn each fact into a third conditional:

1. *I didn't study, so I failed. → If I'd studied, I would have passed.*
2. *She didn't call, so I didn't know.*
3. *We left late, so we missed it.*
4. *He didn't ask, so nobody helped him.*
5. *It rained, so we cancelled.*

B. Fix the error. Each contains one of the three classic mistakes:

1. *If I would have known, I'd have come.*
2. *I would of helped you.*

3. *If I'd have asked, she'd have said yes.*
4. *If I studied harder, I would have passed.*
5. *If she hadn't have left, we'd still be there.*

C. Choose the modal. *would have, could have or might have?*

1. *If you'd told me, I ____ (definitely help).*
2. *If we'd left earlier, we ____ (possibly catch) it.*
3. *If he'd asked, it ____ (be possible to arrange).*

D. Reduce it. Say each at natural speed, three times, until the auxiliaries disappear:

If I'd seen it, I'd have said something. She wouldn't have come if she'd known. If it hadn't been for you, I'd have given up.

 YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** third conditionals about your own past. Real ones.

If I'd taken that internship, I would have finished a year later. If I hadn't moved here, I'd never have met most of my friends. I could have applied for that job if I'd seen it in time.

 **Record all three.** Listen back for one thing only: did *would have* come out as /dəv/, or did you say it in full?

 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post three sentences: "*If I'd ____, I would have ____.*"
- **Listen for /dəv/ deliberately.** Pick one show and count how many third conditionals you catch. The first day you will catch few; by the end of the week you will hear them constantly.
- Never write *would of*. It is /əv/ and it is always **have**.

 REMEMBER — افكر

- **If + past perfect → would have + participle.** The unreal past.
- It tells you **two facts about reality**: neither half happened.
- **One would have per sentence.** *If I'd have known* is the commonest error at this level.
- *would of* does not exist. It is /əv/ and it means **have**.
- Vary the result: *could have* (possible), *might have* (perhaps), *wouldn't have* (not at all).

- /aɪdəv/ — and the **negative stays strong**: /'wʊdəntəv/.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can build both clauses without assembling them piece by piece.
- ☐ I know why *If I'd have known* is wrong.
- ☐ I never write *would of*.
- ☐ I used *could have* or *might have* instead of always *would have*.
- ☐ My recording has /dəv/, not a full *would have*.
- ☐ I can hear the difference between *I'd gone* and *I'd have gone*.

Empire English 🏰 — the grammar of hindsight, and it barely makes a sound

THIRD CONDITIONAL IN USE — REGRET, CRITICISM, HYPOTHESIS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md](#) · **S3-U4-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Express **regret** without sounding self-pitying.
- **Criticise gently** — the most useful move in professional English.
- Discuss *what would have happened if...* about something real. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

The third conditional has one form and three completely different jobs, and knowing which job you are doing is more important than the grammar.

Job one is regret. *If I'd started earlier, I would have finished on time.* You are describing a better past and implicitly taking responsibility for the worse one. It is honest, and — used well — it makes you sound reflective rather than defensive. Used badly it becomes a loop of self-blame that nobody wants to sit through, which is why the mindset frame for this unit is *regret becomes data*. A regret is only useful once it has produced a lesson.

Job two is criticism, and this is the one worth learning properly. Consider two ways to say the same thing to a colleague who left you out of a decision:

Why didn't you ask me? You could have asked me.

The content is identical. The first is a demand for justification and it puts the other person into defence. The second is a statement about an unreal past — it says *a better version of this existed* without accusing anyone of choosing against it. That grammatical distance is exactly why English professional culture reaches for it constantly. *We could have caught that earlier. They might have told us. It would have helped to know.* Every one of those is a complaint that leaves the relationship intact.

Notice the third one especially: *it would have helped to know* has no subject at all. English can criticise without naming anyone, and in a meeting that is often the difference between a problem being fixed and an argument starting.

Job three is hypothesis — genuinely neutral speculation. *If the supplier hadn't changed the price, would we have launched on time?* No blame, no regret, just reasoning about cause. This is what post-mortems are made of, and it is how you test whether a cause was really a cause.

And here is the part learners miss. **The three jobs share one grammar and are told apart by intonation.** *You could have told me* said with a falling, level tune is a mild observation. Said with stress on *told* and a rise it is a complaint. Said with stress on *you* it is an accusation. Same eight words. If your voice does not match your intention, the grammar will not save you — and this is a structure where getting it wrong is expensive, because you will have criticised someone while believing you were being diplomatic.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE FORM)

Fast round, and reduce your auxiliaries:

1. *If I'd known ____, I would have ____.*
2. *I wouldn't have ____ if ____.*
3. *If it hadn't been for ____, I'd have ____.*

Then one to notice: say "*You could have told me*" twice — once as a neutral remark, once as a complaint.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. The **function** of each is marked:

A: So we found out on Friday that the deadline had moved. **B:** [SOFTENED CRITICISM] Right. It would have helped to know that on Monday. **A:** I know. [REGRET] If I'd checked the shared calendar, I'd have seen it — that's on me. **B:** [SOFTENED CRITICISM] And they could have sent something round, to be fair. It's not only you. **A:** [HYPOTHESIS] Would we have made it anyway, if we'd started on Monday? **B:** Honestly, probably not. [HYPOTHESIS] We might have got the first half done. The testing would still have slipped. **A:** [REGRET → LESSON] Well — if I'd asked once, none of this would have happened. I'm going to check that calendar every morning now.

Study what B does. Two criticisms, and neither one accuses: *it would have helped to know* has no subject at all, and *they could have sent something round* is immediately softened with *to be fair*. Then the whole conversation turns to hypothesis — *would we have made it anyway?* — which quietly establishes that the real problem was elsewhere.

And A's last line is the mindset in one sentence: a regret, then a change of behaviour.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (ONE FORM, THREE JOBS)

Job	Typical shape	Example
Regret	<i>If I'd..., I would have...</i>	<i>If I'd started earlier, I'd have finished.</i>
Softened criticism	<i>You could have... / It would have helped to...</i>	<i>You could have asked me.</i>
Hypothesis	<i>Would we have..., if...?</i>	<i>Would we have made it, if we'd started Monday?</i>

Regret — and the rule that keeps it useful. Always attach the lesson. A regret with no consequence is self-pity; a regret with a change is analysis:

If I'd asked once, none of this would have happened — so I'm checking it every morning now.

Criticism — the softening ladder. From most to least direct:

Directness	Form
harsh	<i>Why didn't you tell me?</i>
direct	<i>You should have told me.</i>
softened	<i>You could have told me.</i>
softer	<i>It would have helped to know. (no subject)</i>
softest	<i>I suppose we might have caught it earlier. (we, hedged)</i>

Three moves do all the work: **swap should for could**, **remove the subject**, and **shift to we**. That last one is the diplomatic reflex of professional English — *we should have caught that* is often said by the one person who obviously did not cause it, precisely because it makes the problem shared.

Hypothesis — the neutral one. *Might have* and *could have* are the honest modals here, because you genuinely do not know:

Would it have made a difference? · We might have got half of it done. · It probably wouldn't have changed anything.

Hypothesis is also how you **test a cause**: if the answer to *would it have happened anyway?* is yes, then the thing you were blaming was not the cause.

The trap: should have is not a soft form. It carries obligation, so it always implies fault:

You should have told me — you were wrong not to. *You could have told me* — it was available to you.

Learners use *should have* believing it is polite because it is indirect. It is indirect and it is still an accusation.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Regret	<i>If I'd only... · In hindsight I'd have... · I wish I'd... · That's on me.</i>
Regret → lesson	<i>So from now on I'm... · Which is why I now... · Lesson learned.</i>
Soften a criticism	<i>You could have... · It would have helped to... · We might have... · I suppose we could have...</i>
Add fairness	<i>...to be fair. · It's not only you. · In their defence...</i>
Hypothesise	<i>Would it have...? · Might we have...? · Would that have changed anything?</i>
Concede the hypothesis	<i>Honestly, probably not. · It might not have made any difference.</i>
Close it down	<i>Either way... · As it turned out... · There's no point going over it.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THREE TUNES, ONE SENTENCE)

Take "*You could have told me*" and perform all three jobs with it. Nothing changes except your voice.

1 — Neutral observation. Level, falling at the end, stress on *told*. No emphasis on *you*:

/jukʊdəv/ **TOLD** me. 📉

2 — Mild complaint. Slight rise, slower, small pause before *told*:

/jukʊdəv/ ... **TOLD** me. 📈

3 — Accusation. Stress on *you*, and everything after it flat:

YOU could have told me. 📉

Say all three aloud. The third is the one you produce accidentally when you stress the wrong word, and it is how a diplomatic sentence becomes a confrontation.

Cue — never stress the subject in a softened criticism. Stress the **verb**. Stressing the person is what turns the sentence into blame, and it is the most common accident learners have with this structure.

Cue — regret falls and slows. *If I'd asked once...* delivered fast sounds like an excuse. Slow it slightly and it sounds like reflection.

Cue — hypothesis rises and stays light. *Would it have made any difference?* 📌 — genuinely open. A falling delivery turns a neutral question into a rhetorical one, which is a challenge.

And keep the reduction. /kʊdəv/, /maɪtəv/, /wʊdəv/. In full these sound heavy, and heavy is not diplomatic.



Record the same sentence three times — observation, complaint, accusation. Play them to a partner. If they cannot tell which is which, the grammar will not protect you.



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Soften it. Rewrite each as a softened criticism. Then rewrite it again with **no subject**:

1. *Why didn't you check with me?*
2. *You should have read the brief.*
3. *They didn't warn us.*
4. *You forgot to include the numbers.*

B. Regret plus lesson. Complete each with both halves:

1. *If I'd prepared properly, ____ — so now I ____.*
2. *If I hadn't left it until the last night, ____ — which is why I ____.*

C. Test the cause. Answer each hypothesis honestly, using *might have* or *probably wouldn't have*:

1. *If we'd started a week earlier, would we have finished on time?*
2. *If you'd taken the other job, would you have been happier?*
3. *If the price hadn't changed, would the project have worked?*

D. Scenario role-play. In pairs. One of you raises the issue using a **softened criticism**; the other responds with a **regret and a lesson**; then both move to **hypothesis**:

- a report went out with an error in it
- nobody told you a meeting had moved
- a decision was made without you
- a deadline slipped and you found out late

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak for about **forty-five seconds** about something at work or in your studies that went wrong. Include all three jobs:

- one **softened criticism** — ideally with no subject
- one **regret**, with the lesson attached
- one **hypothesis** — would it have mattered anyway?

We shipped it with the wrong figures in. It would have helped to have one more review before it went out — although if I'd read the summary properly I'd have caught it myself, so I now read everything twice before I approve it. Whether an extra review would have found it, honestly, I'm not sure. We might have missed it anyway.



Record it. Check: does your criticism sound like an observation, or an accusation?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post one **regret with its lesson**, and one *what would have happened if...* question.
- **This week, replace one *why didn't you...?* with *it would have helped to...*** and watch what happens to the reply. That single swap is the most useful thing in this lesson.
- Notice the **we** move in meetings — someone taking shared responsibility for a problem they did not cause. It is everywhere in English professional culture.

REMEMBER — افكر

- One form, **three jobs**: regret · softened criticism · hypothesis.
- **Regret needs a lesson.** Without one it is self-pity.
- The softening ladder: *should have** → *could have* → *no subject* → **we*.
- ***should have* is not soft.** It carries obligation, so it always implies fault.
- Hypothesis **tests a cause**: if it would have happened anyway, that wasn't the cause.
- **Never stress the subject** in a criticism. Stress the verb, or you have accused someone.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can soften a criticism three ways, including with no subject.
- ☐ I know why *should have* is not the polite option.
- ☐ Every regret I expressed came with a lesson.
- ☐ I used *might have* for a genuine hypothesis.

- ☐ A partner could tell my observation from my accusation, by voice alone.

Empire English 🏰 — how English complains without starting an argument

MIXED CONDITIONALS — WHEN THE PAST IS STILL HAPPENING

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md](#) · **S3-U4-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *If I'd ____, I'd be ____ now.*
- Connect a decision you made years ago to your life today.
- Recognise the reverse pattern when you hear it. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Every conditional you have met so far keeps both halves in the same time. First conditional: real future, real future. Second: unreal present, unreal present. Third: unreal past, unreal past. Tidy, and not how life works.

Because the past does not stay in the past. A decision you made at twenty-two is why you live where you live now. A course you did not take is why you are not doing the job you might have been doing. The cause is finished; the consequence is still running. English has a structure for exactly that, and it is the only one that can say it:

If I'd taken that job, I'd be in Dubai now.

Look at what the two halves are doing. *If I'd taken* is the unreal past — I did not take it. *I'd be... now* is the unreal present — I am not in Dubai. Past condition, present result. Neither the second nor the third conditional can produce that sentence, because both are locked into a single time frame.

This is the most autobiographical grammar in English. Once you own it you can talk about how you became who you are: *If I hadn't failed that exam, I wouldn't be doing this job. If my father hadn't moved us, I wouldn't speak English.* Those are not grammar exercises — they are the sentences people use to explain their own lives, and until now you have not been able to build them.

There is a professional version too, and it appears constantly in analysis. *If we'd invested in the platform three years ago, we wouldn't be having this conversation.* One sentence connecting a historical decision to a present problem — which is precisely what a senior person is being paid to be able to say.

Now, honestly: this is the hardest structure in Stage 3, and not because the forms are new. You already know both halves. The difficulty is that your brain wants to match the tenses, and this structure deliberately does not. It will feel wrong for a while, and the only cure is the timeline: *cause finished, effect still here*. If you can see that shape, the grammar follows. If you cannot, no amount of rule-learning will help.

One reassurance. There is a second mixed pattern that runs the other way, and it is much rarer. Learn to recognise it and do not worry about producing it. One pattern used confidently is worth more than two used hesitantly.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (THE TWO PURE CONDITIONALS)

Say one of each, quickly:

1. **Second** — unreal present: *If I had more time, I'd ____.*
2. **Third** — unreal past: *If I'd ____, I would have ____.*

Now hold them side by side. Today's sentence takes the **front half of the third** and the **back half of the second**.



WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: Do you ever think about that job in Dubai? **B:** All the time. If I'd taken it, I'd be earning about double what I earn now. **A:** Would you be happier, though? **B:** Probably not. If I'd gone, I wouldn't know any of you — I'd be living on my own in a tower block. **A:** So no regrets. **B:** Some. If I'd said yes, my English would be a lot better by now, for a start. **A:** Your English is fine. **B:** It's fine because I stayed and had to work at it. If it had been easy, I wouldn't be this good.

Look at what every result clause has in common: **now, by now, this good**, and present forms — *I'd be earning, I wouldn't know, I'd be living, would be*. The condition is finished. The result is happening.

The last line is worth reading twice, because it reverses the expected feeling: *if it had been easy, I wouldn't be this good*. A past condition producing a present strength.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (PAST CAUSE, PRESENT RESULT)

The pattern that matters — learn this one properly:

If clause —	Result —
If + had + participle	would + base form
<i>If I'd taken that job...</i>	<i>...I'd be in Dubai now.</i>

PAST — **the decision (didn't happen)** —————> NOW — **the consequence (isn't true)**

If I'd studied medicine, I'd be a doctor now. If she hadn't moved, we wouldn't be friends. If I'd saved that money, I wouldn't be worrying about rent.

The tell is the time expression. *now, *today*, *still*, *by now*, **at this point*** — one of these in the result clause is what makes it mixed. Learn to listen for that word:

If I'd taken it, I would have earned more. — third conditional. Past money, past tense. *If I'd taken it, I'd be earning more **now**.* — mixed. Present money, present situation.

Both are correct, and they say different things. The first is about what happened then; the second is about your life today.

The result clause can take any present shape:

Shape	Example
<i>would be</i> + adjective/noun	<i>I'd be a doctor.</i>
<i>would be</i> + -ing	<i>I'd be living abroad.</i>
<i>would</i> + base verb	<i>I'd know everyone.</i>
<i>wouldn't have</i> + noun	<i>I wouldn't have this job.</i>

Careful with that last one. *I wouldn't have this job* is a **present** result — *have* meaning *possess*, not an auxiliary. It looks like a third conditional and is not. Read by meaning, not by shape.

The other direction — recognise it, don't chase it:

If clause —	Result —
If + past simple	would have + participle
<i>If I were more organised...</i>	<i>...I wouldn't have missed it.</i>

This says: a permanent trait of mine (present) explains a specific past event. *If he weren't so stubborn, he'd have apologised weeks ago.* It is genuinely rarer. **Understand it when you hear it; do not force it into your speech.**

The self-check. Ask two questions:

When was the cause? Past → *If* + had + participle. **When is the effect?** Now → *would* + base. Then → *would have* + participle.

That is all the machinery. Two questions, two answers.

✂️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I'd be ... now	<i>I'd be a doctor now.</i>
I wouldn't be ...	<i>I wouldn't be here.</i>
by now	<i>My English would be better by now.</i>
I wouldn't have this...	<i>I wouldn't have this job.</i>
I'd still be...	<i>I'd still be living there.</i>
looking back	<i>Looking back, I'd be somewhere else.</i>
that's why I'm...	<i>That's why I'm here.</i>
if it hadn't been for...	<i>If it hadn't been for her, I wouldn't be doing this.</i>
I wouldn't know...	<i>I wouldn't know any of you.</i>
it shaped...	<i>That decision shaped everything.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (STRESS ACROSS A MIXED SENTENCE)

A mixed conditional is long, and long sentences fail on **stress placement** rather than on sounds.

Cue 1 — two stresses, one per clause. Find the content word in each half and push it. Everything else squeezes:

/ɪfaɪd/ **TAKEN that job // */aɪdbi/ in **DU**bai now.**

Cue 2 — the two auxiliaries reduce differently, and the difference is the meaning:

**/ɪfaɪd/ — *if I'd* (past perfect, the condition) */aɪdbi/ — *I'd be* (would + base, the present result)*

Both start /aɪd/. What follows tells the listener which time frame you are in. Rush them together and the sentence collapses.

Cue 3 — stress the time word. NOW, by NOW, STILL — this is the word that makes the sentence mixed, so it carries weight:

*I'd be earning double what I earn **NOW**.*

Cue 4 — break at the clause boundary. One clear break, at the comma. Not two, not none.

Perception check. These differ by one syllable and one time frame:

* /aɪdəv bɪn/ — *I'd have been* (past result) * /aɪdbi/ — *I'd be* (present result)

 **Record the pair:** "If I'd taken it, I would have earned more" and "If I'd taken it, I'd be earning more now." If they sound the same, the distinction is not landing.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Past cause, present result. Complete each:

1. If I'd studied engineering, I ____ now.
2. If I hadn't moved to this city, I ____.
3. If I'd started learning English as a child, my accent ____.
4. If my parents hadn't pushed me, I ____.

B. Third or mixed? Look at the time word and decide:

1. If I'd left earlier, I ____ (catch) the train.
2. If I'd left earlier, I ____ (be) home by now.
3. If she'd taken the job, she ____ (live) in Berlin now.
4. If she'd taken the job, she ____ (move) in September.

C. Two questions. For each, ask *when was the cause?* and *when is the effect?*, then build it:

1. I didn't save any money. Now I can't afford a car.
2. She left the company. Now she runs her own.
3. We didn't invest in the platform. Now we're rebuilding it.
4. I took that internship. Now I have this job.

D. Your own life, in three links. Pick one decision from your past and say three present consequences of it — all mixed conditionals.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **two** mixed conditionals about your own life. Real ones, and make them matter.

*If I hadn't failed my first year, I wouldn't be doing this job — I'd probably be an accountant somewhere.
If I'd carried on with piano, I'd be able to play something by now instead of nothing.*

Then add one hedged version, using U3's certainty language: *I'd probably be..., I might well be...*

 **Record all three.** Check: is there a **present** time word in every result clause?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post: "If I'd ___, I'd be ___ now."
- **Find the decision that made your life.** Write three present consequences of one past choice. It is a genuinely interesting thing to do in any language, and it happens to be this grammar.
- Listen for *now* and *still* in conditionals. That word is your signal that the speaker has mixed the time frames.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Past cause → present result.** *If I'd taken it, I'd be there now.*
- **The tell is the time word:** *now, today, still, by now.*
- Two questions decide everything: **when was the cause? when is the effect?**
- The reverse pattern (*If I were more organised, I wouldn't have missed it*) — **recognise it, don't chase it.**
- /aɪdəv bɪn/ = past result · /aɪdbi/ = present result. One syllable, two time frames.
- **Meaning first.** Linking the cause to the consequence matters more than a flawless participle.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can splice the front of a third conditional onto the back of a second.
- ☐ Every result clause I built had a present time word in it.
- ☐ I can tell a third conditional from a mixed one by listening for that word.
- ☐ I can hear /aɪdəv bɪn/ against /aɪdbi/.
- ☐ I connected one real past decision to my life today.

Empire English 🏰 — the cause is finished; you're still living in the result

I WISH I'D... / IF ONLY... — NAMING A REGRET

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 🎧 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L03; B1 *wish* + past
 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md](#) · **S3-U4-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Say *I wish I'd* ____ and *If only I hadn't* ____.
- Tell a **present wish** from a **past regret** — and hear the difference.
- Name a real regret and extract something useful from it. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You met *wish* at B1: *I wish I had more time*. That is a present wish — you are complaining about now, and the past tense after *wish* is doing something odd, marking unreality rather than past time. English uses a backshift to mean *this isn't true*.

Now push it one step further back. If a past tense after *wish* means an unreal **present**, then a past perfect after *wish* means an unreal **past**:

I wish I had more time. — I don't have enough time, now. *I wish I'd had more time.* — I didn't have enough time, then.

One auxiliary between them, and they are about different decades of your life. That single contrast is the grammar content of this lesson, and learners conflate the two constantly — usually collapsing both into the simpler form and losing the ability to talk about the past at all.

Why this matters beyond accuracy: *I wish I'd...* is how people describe the shape of their own past, and it is enormously more natural than the third conditional for the same job. *If I'd started learning English earlier, I would have been more fluent by now* is correct and heavy. *I wish I'd started earlier* says the same thing in five words and sounds like a person rather than a grammar exercise. In real speech the *wish* form is what you will actually use; the third conditional is what you use when you want to specify the consequence.

If only is the same structure with more feeling. *If only I hadn't sent that email*. It is more emotional, more emphatic, and it often stands alone as a complete sentence — which the *wish* form does too, but less dramatically. Knowing that difference is knowing when you are being expressive and when you are being matter-of-fact.

And now the thing that actually matters more than the grammar. A regret is only worth naming if something comes out of it. Said once with a lesson attached, *I wish I'd started earlier — so I'm not putting off the exam this time* is analysis. Said repeatedly with nothing attached, it is rumination, and rumination in a second language is just as useless as it is in your first. This unit's mindset thread is deliberate about that: **name it, take the lesson, let it go**. The English is easy. The discipline is the part worth building.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE B1 PRESENT WISH)

Three sentences about **now**:

1. *I wish I had ____.*
2. *I wish I could ____.*
3. *I wish I were ____.*

Notice what all three are complaining about: the present. Today we move the complaint backwards.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: Do you regret not going abroad to study? **B:** Sometimes. I wish I'd applied, at least. If only to know whether I'd have got in. **A:** Why didn't you? **B:** Money, mostly. And I wish I'd asked more people about it — I assumed it was impossible and I never checked. **A:** Would it have changed things? **B:** Maybe. I wish I'd learned English properly back then, that's the real one. If I'd done that, I'd be further along now. **A:** You're doing it now. **B:** I am. That's why I don't put things off any more — if only because I know exactly what it costs.

Notice three things. There are two *wish* forms and one *if only*, and the *if only* is the most emotional of them. The regret about English is immediately followed by a **mixed conditional** — *I'd be further along now* — which is how the two structures pair naturally. And the last line closes the loop: the regret produced a rule.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (PRESENT WISH OR PAST REGRET)

The contrast — this is the lesson:

	Form	Meaning	Example
Present wish	<i>wish</i> + past simple	not true now	<i>I wish I had more time.</i>
Past regret	<i>wish</i> + past perfect	not true then	<i>I wish I'd had more time.</i>

I wish I knew her. — I don't know her now. *I wish I'd known her.* — I didn't know her then.

Say both aloud. The difference is /aɪd/ — one syllable — and it moves the sentence years.

The forms you need:

I wish I'd + participle — *I wish I'd studied harder. I wish I hadn't + participle* — *I wish I hadn't said that.*
If only I'd + participle — *If only I'd known. If only I hadn't + participle* — *If only I hadn't sent it.*

wish or if only? Same grammar, different temperature:

	Feel	Behaviour
<i>I wish I'd...</i>	matter-of-fact	usually part of a longer sentence
<i>If only I'd...</i>	emotional, emphatic	often stands alone

If only I'd listened. — complete on its own, and it carries feeling.

How it pairs with the conditionals. *Wish* **names** the regret; a conditional **specifies** the consequence:

I wish I'd started earlier + I'd be much better by now. (mixed) *I wish I'd checked + I would have caught it.* (third)

That pairing is what a fluent reflection sounds like, and it is exactly what L05 will ask for.

Two things to avoid.

Not for things that are still possible. *Wish* means unreal. If you can still do it, use *should*:

✗ *I wish I'd called her* — when you could still call her today. ✓ *I should call her.*

The other wish. *I wish you'd stop doing that* is not a regret at all — it is a present complaint about someone else's behaviour, with *would*. Recognise it; do not confuse it with the past perfect form.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I wish I'd...	<i>I wish I'd applied.</i>
I wish I hadn't...	<i>I wish I hadn't sent it.</i>
If only I'd...	<i>If only I'd listened.</i>
that's the real one	<i>I wish I'd learned English — that's the real one.</i>
at least	<i>I wish I'd applied, at least.</i>
looking back	<i>Looking back, I wish I'd waited.</i>
I don't regret...	<i>I don't regret leaving, actually.</i>
what it costs	<i>I know exactly what it costs.</i>
lesson learned	<i>Lesson learned, honestly.</i>
that's why I now...	<i>That's why I don't put things off now.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (I WISH I'D AS ONE RUN)

Cue 1 — four words, one squeeze. *I wish I had* becomes /aɪwɪfaɪd/ — the whole thing unstressed until the participle:

* /aɪwɪfaɪd/ **STUD**ied harder.* /aɪwɪfaɪd/ **ASKED** more people.

Cue 2 — the /aɪd/ is the entire difference. *I wish I knew* against *I wish I'd known*. Drop it and you have changed the time frame:

/aɪwɪfaɪ 'nu/ — present wish. /aɪwɪfaɪd 'nuv/ — past regret.

This is the same discipline as every reduction in Stage 3: squeezed, but never deleted.

Cue 3 — if only is stressed and slow. Where *I wish* squeezes, *if only* does the opposite. Both words carry weight and the phrase slows:

IF ONLY I'd **LIS**tened. 📌

That deliberate slowness is what makes it emotional. Rushed, it loses all its force.

Cue 4 — regret falls. A rising tail turns a regret into a question or a complaint. Let it drop and stop.

Cue 5 — don't over-perform it. English regret is usually understated. *I wish I'd asked, honestly* delivered quietly carries far more than the same words delivered dramatically.

 **Record the contrast pair:** "*I wish I knew her*" and "*I wish I'd known her*." Play them to a partner. If they cannot tell which is which, the /aɪd/ is not surviving.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Present or past? Choose the form:

1. *I wish I ____ (have) more free time now.*
2. *I wish I ____ (have) more time to prepare last week.*
3. *I wish I ____ (speak) Spanish.*
4. *I wish I ____ (learn) Spanish at school.*
5. *If only I ____ (not / say) that in the meeting.*

B. Turn it into a regret. From the fact, build a *wish* or *if only*:

1. *I didn't apply for the scholarship.*
2. *I sent the email before checking it.*
3. *I stopped playing football.*
4. *I didn't ask for help.*

C. Pair it with a conditional. Name the regret, then specify the consequence:

I wish I'd started earlier → If I'd started earlier, I'd be much further along now.

Now do the same for two of your own.

D. Is it still possible? Say whether each should be *wish* or *should*:

1. *You haven't called your friend back — you could still do it today.*
2. *You didn't take the course, and it finished last year.*
3. *You haven't started revising, and the exam is in a month.*

YOUR TURN — دُورُكَ

Name **three real regrets** — study, work, language or habit. For each one, attach **the lesson**.

I wish I'd started speaking English out loud years earlier. I read for ages and never spoke, so now I make myself speak before I feel ready. If only I hadn't dropped maths. I'd have more options now — which is why I don't quit things just because they're hard. I wish I'd asked more questions in my first job. Nobody minded. I just assumed they would.

 **Record all three.** Check two things: is the /aɪd/ audible, and does every regret have a lesson?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **two** past regrets and what you learned from each.
- **Say each one once, then stop.** The point of naming a regret is the lesson; after that it has done its job.
- Notice the contrast in what you watch — *I wish I knew* against *I wish I'd known*. It is a one-syllable difference carrying a whole time frame.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **wish + past simple** = unreal **now**. **wish + past perfect** = unreal **then**.
- The whole difference is /aɪd/. Drop it and you change the decade.
- **If only** = same grammar, **more feeling**, and it stands alone.
- **Wish names** the regret; a **conditional specifies the consequence**. Use them together.
- **Not for things still possible.** That is *should*, not *wish*.
- Every regret gets a **lesson**. Then let it go.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can say the contrast pair and hear the difference.
- ☐ I used both *wish* and *if only*, and I know which is more emotional.
- ☐ I paired one regret with a conditional consequence.
- ☐ I know when to use *should* instead of *wish*.
- ☐ Every regret I named came with something I now do differently.

Empire English 🏰 — name it, take the lesson, let it go

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: "A DECISION YOU'D CHANGE"



Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 4 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK ⌚ ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·

Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit4-third-mixed-conditionals.md](#) · **S3-U4-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you reflect on one real decision, properly:

- ~2 minutes on a decision you'd change
- a **third conditional**, a **mixed conditional**, a **wish regret**
- the **lesson**, and what you now do differently
- then handle reflective follow-ups 🗣️

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each, reduced auxiliaries throughout:

1. *If I'd ____, I would have ____.* — third conditional
2. *If I'd ____, I'd be ____ now.* — mixed
3. *I wish I'd ____.* — regret
4. A **softened criticism** with no subject: *It would have helped to ____.*
5. The contrast pair: *I wish I knew / I wish I'd known.*

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model reflection, then read. The structures are marked:

[THE DECISION] About four years ago I turned down a transfer to the Dubai office. I'd been at the company two years, I was comfortable, and I said no in about a day.

[THIRD CONDITIONAL] If I'd taken it, I would have earned roughly double for three years. That's just arithmetic. **[MIXED CONDITIONAL]** And if I'd gone, I'd probably be running a regional team by now — that was the whole point of the offer.

[WISH REGRET] What I actually regret isn't the money. I wish I'd taken longer over the decision. I said no in a day because I was frightened, and I told myself it was about my family.

[SOFTENED CRITICISM] It would have helped to have someone ask me why, to be fair. Nobody did. But that's not really an excuse.

[HYPOTHESIS, HEDGED] Would I have been happier? Honestly, I don't know. I might well have hated it. The people I know who went are not obviously happier than I am.

[THE LESSON — FORWARD MOTION] So the thing I took from it is that I now refuse to decide anything big in a day. If it matters, I sit on it for a week and I tell two people. I've done that twice since and both times I changed my mind halfway through.

Study the shape. The regret is **not the obvious one** — not the money, but the speed of the decision. The consequences are **hedged** rather than claimed. And the ending is a **rule he now follows**, with evidence that he follows it.

🧩 THE UNIT-4 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	the decision , stated plainly	<i>I turned down a transfer.</i>
2	a third conditional — the past consequence	<i>I would have earned double.</i>
3	a mixed conditional — the present consequence	<i>I'd probably be running a team now.</i>
4	a wish regret	<i>I wish I'd taken longer over it.</i>
5	a hedged hypothesis	<i>I might well have hated it.</i>
6	the lesson , as something you now do	<i>I don't decide anything big in a day.</i>

Items 5 and 6 are the ones that get dropped, and they are the two that make the difference. Without the hedge you are claiming to know an alternative universe. Without the lesson you have simply been sad in English for two minutes.

🎧 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (REDUCTION UNDER PRESSURE)

Everyone — /dəv/ must survive two minutes. This is the unit's signature target:

/aɪdəv/ · /kʊdəv/ · /maɪtəv/ · /'wʊdəntəv/

In a two-minute reflection with three conditional structures, these appear eight or ten times. Under pressure learners revert to the full form, and it makes fluent content sound assembled.

****Everyone** — the two /aɪd/s. /ɪfaɪd/ for the condition, /aɪdbi/ for a present result, /aɪdəv/ for a past result. Three near-identical openings carrying three different time frames. Say the trio five times.

Everyone — never stress the subject in a softened criticism. Stress the verb, or you have accused someone.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker. One cue, one phrase, one sentence, stop.

 **Record the trio** before the task: "If I'd known..." / "I'd be there now." / "I'd have gone."

TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + REFLECTIVE PROBING)

Round 1 — plan, don't script. Two minutes, six bullets, no sentences: the decision, the past consequence, the present consequence, the real regret, the hedge, the rule you now follow.

Round 2 — deliver it. In pairs, two minutes each. Listener ticks the six and chooses **two** questions:

What would you have done differently? · Would you actually have been happier? What's the real regret — is it the decision, or how you made it? What would have to have been true for you to say yes? Has anything changed because of it? · And why do you think you did that?

Round 3 — the second why. The listener pushes once more on whichever answer was thinnest.

Round 4 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver only the weakest thirty seconds, with the reductions corrected.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** on a decision you'd change, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **two reflective questions**, unrehearsed.

 **Save this recording.** Two units ago you recorded a turning point that happened to you. This one is a decision you *made*. Together they are the two halves of talking about your own past.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your reflection.
- Complete the **Unit-4 quiz** — third conditional form and use, the mixed time-frame link, *wish / if only* + past perfect against the present wish, and reduced *would have*.
- **Act on your own lesson once this week.** The rule you named in item 6 — use it on one real decision. That is the only part of this lesson that changes anything.
- Never write *would of*.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- **If + past perfect** → **would have + participle** = unreal past. → **would + base** = present result.
- **wish + past perfect** names the regret; a **conditional specifies the consequence**.
- **Hedge the alternative universe**. You do not know that you would have been happier.
- **Soften criticism** by dropping *should*, dropping the subject, or shifting to *we*.
- A **lesson is a behaviour**, not a feeling.
- /dəv/ — and it has to survive two minutes of talking.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes, unscripted, in English.
- ☐ I used a third conditional **and** a mixed conditional, each for the right time frame.
- ☐ My *wish* regret was clearly about the past, not the present.
- ☐ I hedged the consequences instead of claiming to know them.
- ☐ My lesson is something I actually do differently.
- ☐ My *would have* came out as /dəv/, even at the end.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 4 complete — regret turned into a rule you follow



STAGE 3 · UNIT 5

MODALS OF DEDUCTION & SPECULATION

👑 UNIT 5 — MODALS OF DEDUCTION & SPECULATION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: read the evidence and say what is probably true — about now and about the past — with an honest confidence level attached. Then learn to reason out loud so that other people can follow you.

This unit is Unit 3's certainty scale pointed at the present and the past. There you hedged predictions. Here you hedge conclusions. The skill is the same and the modals are different, which is why the two units sit close together.

It is also the direct run-up to the end of the stage. The reasoning chain built in L04 becomes an argument in Unit 11 and carries most of the twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation in Unit 12. Nothing here is a detour.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Present deduction	<i>must be · might be · can't be</i> — and never <i>mustn't</i>
L02	Past deduction	<i>must have · might have · can't have</i> — and /məstəv/
L03	Speculating	thinking aloud: hedges, revision, and behaviour not character
L04	Evidence & conclusions	the reasoning chain — and killing an alternative with a fact
L05	Unit task 🎙️	2 minutes solving a scenario, then defending it against a partner

Grammar spine: *must / might / could / may / can't* + base for present deduction · the same modals + *have* + participle for the past · hedging (*it looks like, presumably, I get the impression, in which case*) · reasoning connectors (*given that, this suggests, which would mean, therefore, on balance*). **Accent Lab: stress the modal** — it is your confidence level · /əv/ on all six modal perfects · /ka:ntəv/ keeps its /t/ or the meaning inverts · **certainty falls, doubt rises** · never stress a connector · the upward step that signals *I'm changing my mind*. **Mindset:** confident uncertainty — reasoning aloud without needing to be sure. **Arabic support:** 0% — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- The ability to **offer a hypothesis for correction** instead of asserting something you don't know.
 - A **reasoning chain** you can use for any recommendation, diagnosis or disagreement in English.
-

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** present deduction (*must / might / can't be*) · past deduction (*must / might / can't have been*) · certainty matching · the *mustn't* against *can't* error · reduced modal perfects.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute deduction talk plus a one-minute competing-theory discussion, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **modal-perfect reduction** and **certainty intonation** (both named U12 clinic inputs), plus a note of who reverts to full auxiliary forms under load.
-

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 6 — THE PASSIVE (ADVANCED)

the passive across every tense, modal perfect passives, the impersonal reporting passive, and *have something done* — the grammar of systems, services and processes.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · sounding certain is easy; being calibrated is what gets you trusted

PRESENT DEDUCTION: *MUST BE · MIGHT BE · CAN'T BE*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 modals *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md](#) · **S3-U5-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *he must be busy / it might be broken / that can't be right*.
- Attach the **evidence** that justifies your conclusion.
- Never say *mustn't* when you mean *can't*. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

There is a use of *must* that has nothing to do with obligation, and it is far more common in real speech than the one you learned first.

You must be tired. Nobody is ordering anyone to be tired. The speaker has looked at the evidence — you have been travelling for nine hours — and drawn a conclusion. That is deduction, and English marks it with the same modals it uses for obligation and permission, which is confusing for about a week and then becomes one of the most useful things you own.

Why it matters: deduction is how you talk about anything you cannot verify. Somebody is not answering their phone. A system is behaving oddly. A colleague seems annoyed. In every case you have partial evidence and you need to say something about what is probably true. Without these modals your options are to assert something you do not know — *he is busy* — or to say nothing. Both are worse than *he must be busy, he's not answering*.

The professional value is specific. Reading a situation aloud is a large part of what senior people do in meetings: *that must be a data problem rather than a bug, it might just be the timezone, that can't be the whole story*. Each of those is a hypothesis offered with an honest confidence level attached, which invites correction instead of demanding agreement. Somebody who only ever asserts flatly is exhausting to work with and frequently wrong.

Then the trap, and it catches almost everyone. English is **not symmetrical** here. For positive certainty you use *must be*. For negative certainty you do **not** use *mustn't be* — you use ***can't be***. *It must be true* has the opposite *it can't be true*. *Mustn't* means *don't do it*, which is a completely different idea, and using it for deduction produces a sentence that sounds like a strange prohibition. Learners reach for *mustn't* because the symmetry looks obvious, and it is one of the most reliable B2 errors there is. Get this one thing right and you will sound more accurate than most people at your level.

Finally, notice how little separates these sentences from arrogance. *He must be busy* offered with the evidence is reasoning. The same sentence with no evidence is just you deciding things about people. English deduction almost always travels with its clue attached — *the lights are off, so they must have gone out* — and that habit is what makes it sound thoughtful rather than presumptuous.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE B1 MODALS)

Fast round:

1. Something you **must** do this week — obligation.
2. Something that **might** happen tomorrow — possibility.
3. Something you **can't** do — inability.

Now look at those three words again. Today all three mean something completely different.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: I've called Omar three times. He's not picking up. **B:** He must be in a meeting. He had that review thing this morning. **A:** At six in the evening? **B:** Then he might be driving. Or his phone could be dead — it usually is. **A:** Do you think he's ignoring me? **B:** He can't be ignoring you. He messaged you an hour ago. **A:** True. So what do I do? **B:** Text him. If it's urgent he'll see it — he must be looking at his phone at some point.

Six deductions in eight lines, and look at what every single one has attached: *he had that review thing, it usually is, he messaged you an hour ago*. The evidence is never optional.

And notice the one negative certainty: **he can't be ignoring you**. Not *mustn't*. That is the sentence to memorise.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THREE LEVELS, ONE STRUCTURE)

The form is identical for all of them — modal + *be* or a base verb, with no *to* and no third-person -s:

Certainty	Modal	Example
Sure it IS	must	<i>He must be busy.</i>
Possible	might · could · may	<i>It might be broken.</i>
Sure it ISN'T	can't	<i>That can't be right.</i>

She must be tired. · He might be waiting. · They could be lost. · It can't be true. With a continuous: *He must be driving. · She can't be sleeping — the light's on.*

The asymmetry — the single most important thing in this lesson:

must be ↔ can't be ✗ *It mustn't be true.* — that means *it is forbidden to be true*, which is nonsense.
✓ *It can't be true.*

Say it as a pair five times: *must be / can't be*. That is the whole error, prevented.

Where the three possibility modals differ. Barely, and honestly:

might — the neutral default, most common in speech. *could* — slightly more open, often about capability or an option. *may* — slightly more formal, more common in writing.

Do not hunt for a distinction. Use *might* unless you have a reason.

Evidence is part of the sentence. A deduction without a clue is an assertion:

He must be busy. — on what basis? *He must be busy — he's not answering.* — now it is reasoning.

Three ways to attach it:

Position	Example
after	<i>He must be busy — he's not answering.</i>
before	<i>He's not answering, so he must be busy.</i>
embedded	<i>Given that he's not answering, he must be busy.</i>

Strength check. Choose the modal that matches what you actually know:

Strong evidence → *must*. Some evidence → *might*. Contradicting evidence → *can't*.

Over-claiming with *must* on thin evidence is the same failure as *bound to* in U3-L04 — it costs you credibility with anyone who knows more than you.

Not for the future. These modals read **present** evidence. For the future you want U3's certainty scale:

✓ *It must be raining.* (now — look at the window) ✗ *It must rain tomorrow.* → *It's likely to rain tomorrow.*

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
he must be...	<i>He must be in a meeting.</i>
it might be...	<i>It might be broken.</i>
it could be...	<i>It could be the connection.</i>
that can't be right	<i>That can't be right.</i>
she can't be...	<i>She can't be ignoring you.</i>
judging by...	<i>Judging by the queue, it must be good.</i>
given that...	<i>Given that the lights are off...</i>
that would explain...	<i>That would explain the delay.</i>
the only explanation is...	<i>The only explanation is that he forgot.</i>
there must be a reason	<i>There must be a reason for it.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE MODAL CARRIES THE CERTAINTY)

Cue 1 — stress the modal. In a deduction the modal is the news, because it is your confidence level:

*He **MUST** be busy. · It **MIGHT** be broken. · That **CAN'T** be right.*

Compare with obligation, where the stress moves off the modal onto the verb: *you must **FIN**ish it*. Same word, different job, different stress.

Cue 2 — can't is the loudest word in the sentence. /kænt/ with a clear final /t/. Two reasons: it is your strongest claim, and without the /t/ it becomes *can*, which reverses your meaning entirely. This is the meaning-changing contrast learners were first warned about at A2, and it matters more here than it did then:

*That **can't** be right. / That **can** be right.*

Cue 3 — certainty falls, doubt rises. Same rule as U3-L04:

He must be busy. 📌 — settled. It might be the connection. 📌 — open.

Cue 4 — the evidence gets its own group, and the conclusion lands last:

He's not answering // so he **MUST** be busy. 📩

Putting the conclusion at the end and letting it fall is what makes reasoning sound like reasoning.

 **Record three:** "He must be busy." / "It might be broken." / "That can't be right." Then play them to a partner and ask which one you were most sure about.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Read the evidence. Deduce, and attach the clue:

1. *The lights are off and the car's gone. → They must be out.*
2. *She's not at her desk and her coat's still there.*
3. *He's wearing a suit — he never wears a suit.*
4. *The shop's empty at lunchtime on a Friday.*
5. *My message says "delivered" but not "read."*

B. must or can't?

1. *She's been up since four — she ____ be exhausted.*
2. *He just left the office — he ____ be at home yet.*
3. *That ____ be the right address; the street doesn't exist.*
4. *They've been together ten years — they ____ be happy enough.*

C. Fix the error. All five make the same mistake:

1. *It mustn't be true.*
2. *He mustn't be at home — the car's gone.*
3. *That mustn't be the right number.*
4. *She mustn't be sleeping; the light's on.*
5. *It mustn't be broken — it worked yesterday.*

D. Calibrate. For each, choose *must*, *might* or *can't* based on how strong the evidence really is, and say why:

1. *Your colleague hasn't replied to an email you sent two minutes ago.*
2. *Your colleague hasn't replied to an email you sent three days ago.*
3. *A restaurant has a queue outside at nine on a Tuesday.*
4. *Someone told you a fact you know to be false.*

🎤 YOUR TURN — دورك

Make **three** present deductions about real situations, each with its evidence. Use **all three** levels — *must*, *might* or *could*, and *can't*.

My brother's not replying, and he's usually on his phone — he must be at the gym. The wifi's slow for everyone in the building, so it might be the router downstairs. That price can't be right. The same thing was half that last week.



Record all three. Two checks: is the modal stressed, and is the /t/ audible on *can't*?

📋 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** deductions with their evidence — one *must*, one *might*, one *can't*.
- **Catch yourself over-claiming.** Once a day, notice a moment where you were about to assert something you only suspected, and say *must* or *might* instead.
- Listen for *must be* in what you watch. It is used constantly and almost never for obligation.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- **must be** = sure it is · **might / could be** = possible · **can't be** = sure it isn't.
- ***must be* ↔ **can't be*. Never *mustn't*** — that is a prohibition.
- **Evidence is part of the sentence.** A deduction with no clue is just an assertion.
- Choose the modal that matches the evidence you actually have.
- **Stress the modal** — it is your confidence level. **Certainty falls, doubt rises.**
- ***can't*** keeps its /t/. Without it you have said the opposite.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can say the pair *must be* / *can't be* without thinking.
- ☐ I never use *mustn't* for a deduction.
- ☐ Every deduction I made had its evidence attached.
- ☐ I chose *might* where the evidence was thin.
- ☐ My *can't* has an audible /t/.

Empire English 🏰 — reading the evidence out loud, with an honest confidence level

PAST DEDUCTION: *MUST HAVE* · *MIGHT HAVE* · *CAN'T HAVE*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md](#) · **S3-U5-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *it must have rained* / *she might have forgotten* / *he can't have known*.
- Reason backwards from evidence you can see now.
- Say and **hear** /mʌstəv/. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Yesterday you read present evidence to draw a present conclusion. Today you read present evidence to draw a conclusion about **the past** — which is what most real deduction actually is.

The ground is wet. That is a present fact. What you want to say is about earlier: *it must have rained*. Somebody did not turn up to a meeting: *she must have forgotten*, or *she might have got the time wrong*, or *she can't have seen the invite*. In every case the clue is in front of you and the event is behind you. This is the grammar of reconstruction, and it is used constantly — in conversation, in diagnosis, in any situation where something has already gone wrong and you are working out how.

Professionally this is one of the highest-value structures in the stage. When something breaks, the useful person in the room is the one who can say *the deployment must have overwritten the config — nothing else changed on Tuesday* and then *although it might just be a caching problem, in which case we'd expect to see....* That is a hypothesis with a confidence level and a test attached. Compare it with *the deployment broke it*, asserted flatly, which is either right by luck or wrong and embarrassing.

There is also a diplomatic use worth noticing. *He can't have known* defends someone. *She might have forgotten* excuses someone. *You must have misread it* is much gentler than *you misread it*, because it presents your conclusion as an inference rather than an accusation. Just as in Unit 4, English uses grammatical distance to take the sting out — and this is another form of the same move.

Now the part that decides whether you can actually use any of this: **the reduction**. Nobody says *it must have rained* in four distinct words. It comes out /ɪtmʌstəv 'reɪnd/. Nobody says *she might have forgotten* — it is /ʃɪmaɪtəv fə'ɡatn/. If you only ever practise the full forms, two things happen. You sound like you are reading aloud, which is the smaller problem. And you fail to recognise the structure at conversational speed, which is the real one — because a native speaker's *must've* is barely there, and if you are waiting to hear a *have* you will miss the entire deduction.

You did this work in Unit 4 with /dəv/. This is the same skill on a different modal, and doing it twice is how it becomes automatic.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE PRESENT DEDUCTION)

Fast round, with the evidence attached each time:

1. A *must be* deduction.
2. A *might be* deduction.
3. A *can't be* deduction.

Then the shift: *the ground is wet*. What happened?

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip. Read the spoken column aloud:

Written	Spoken
<i>It must have rained.</i>	/ɪtmʌstəv 'reɪnd/
<i>She might have forgotten.</i>	/ʃɪmaɪtəv fə'ɡatn/
<i>He can't have known.</i>	/hɪkɑːntəv 'noʊn/
<i>They could have missed it.</i>	/ðeɪkʊdəv 'mɪst ɪt/

Now the dialogue:

A: Nobody's turned up. It's ten past. **B:** They must have got the room wrong. I sent the wrong link last week and it happened then too. **A:** Could they have forgotten? **B:** All four of them? They might have — but that seems unlikely. **A:** Maybe the invite didn't go out. **B:** It can't have failed; I got my own copy. Although... I might have sent it to the old list. **A:** That would explain it. **B:** It must have gone to the old list. That's exactly what I've done.

Watch the reasoning move. B starts confident, gets contradicted by evidence — *I got my own copy* — revises, and lands on a new conclusion. That is what deduction sounds like when it is honest: *must* → *might* → *can't* → *must*, tracking the evidence rather than defending the first guess.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (MODAL + HAVE + PARTICIPLE)

One shape, all three levels, every subject the same:

Certainty	Form	Example
Sure it happened	must have + participle	<i>It must have rained.</i>
Possible	might / could / may have + participle	<i>She might have forgotten.</i>
Sure it didn't	can't have + participle	<i>He can't have known.</i>

They must have left. · It might have broken. · We could have missed it. · She can't have seen it.

Continuous version: *He must have been sleeping. · They can't have been waiting long.*

The asymmetry, again:

must have ↔ **can't have** ✗ *He mustn't have known.* → ✓ *He can't have known.*

Same error as yesterday, one tense back. It returns because the symmetry still looks obvious. Say the pair aloud: *must have / can't have*.

Reading a clue backwards. The pattern is always the same:

present evidence → **past conclusion** *The ground's wet → it must have rained. Her coat's gone → she must have left. The file's empty → something must have failed.*

Revise when the evidence changes. This is the professional skill, not the grammar:

It must have failed. — Although I got my copy, so it can't have. — I might have used the old list.

The diplomatic use. Presenting a conclusion as an inference softens it:

You misread it. → You must have misread it. You didn't send it. → It can't have gone out.

The second version of each blames the evidence rather than the person, which is the same move as U4's softened criticism.

Two errors to avoid.

A past participle, not a past simple:

✗ *It must have rain.* · ✗ *She might have went.* → ✓ *rained* · ✓ *gone*

Only one have:

✗ *He must have had known.* → ✓ *He must have known.*

And do not confuse it with U4's *would have*. They are one modal apart and completely different ideas:

He must have known. — I am deducing that he did know. *He would have known.* — if things had been different, he'd have known. He didn't.

✂️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
it must have...	<i>It must have rained.</i>
she might have...	<i>She might have forgotten.</i>
they could have...	<i>They could have missed it.</i>
he can't have...	<i>He can't have known.</i>
that would explain...	<i>That would explain the delay.</i>
something must have...	<i>Something must have gone wrong.</i>
I must have...	<i>I must have sent the wrong one.</i>
that seems unlikely	<i>All four of them? That seems unlikely.</i>
although...	<i>Although I got my own copy.</i>
that's exactly what...	<i>That's exactly what I've done.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (/əv/ ON EVERY MODAL)

This is the U4 reduction applied across the modal system. Do it once properly and it transfers.

Cue 1 — the have becomes /əv/, always:

must have → /mʌstəv/ · *might have* → /maɪtəv/ · *could have* → /kʊdəv/ · *can't have* → /kɑːntəv/ · *should have* → /ʃʊdəv/ · *would have* → /wʊdəv/

Six modals, one reduction. Learn the pattern, not six separate facts.

Cue 2 — stress the modal, squeeze the *have*, stress the participle. Two peaks, one valley:

*It **MUST**əv **RAINED**.* · *She **MIGHT**əv fə**GOT**n.*

Cue 3 — can't have keeps its /t/. /kɑ:ntəv/. Lose it and you have said *can have*, which is a different claim entirely. Same warning as yesterday, and it survives less well with a following consonant.

Cue 4 — it is never of. /əv/ is *have*. Do not write *must of*.

Perception work — the pair that matters most. These are one consonant apart and mean opposite things:

/mʌstəv 'noʊn/ — *must have known* → I deduce he did. /wʊdəv 'noʊn/ — *would have known* → he didn't.

 **Record:** "It must have rained — the ground's soaking." Then say it fully, then reduced, and keep only the reduced version. Play it to a partner and check they can hear /mʌstəv/ rather than four words.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Read the clue backwards. Deduce what happened:

1. *The floor's covered in water.*
2. *His bag is here but he isn't.*
3. *The report has yesterday's date on it.*
4. *Nobody replied to the invitation.*
5. *The lights were on all night.*

B. must have or can't have?

1. *She left at six, so she ___ arrived by now.*
2. *He only got the email this morning — he ___ read it before that.*
3. *There's mud everywhere; they ___ walked through the garden.*
4. *The shop was shut all day, so she ___ bought it there.*

C. Fix the error. Each has one:

1. *He mustn't have known.*
2. *It must have rain.*
3. *She might have went home.*
4. *They must of left already.*

5. *He must have had forgotten.*

D. Revise your conclusion. Start with a *must have*. Your partner introduces a fact that contradicts it. Revise to *can't have* and offer a new *might have*:

"They must have forgotten." → "They all replied yesterday." → "Then they can't have forgotten. They might have gone to the wrong room."

E. Soften it. Rewrite as an inference rather than an accusation:

1. *You sent the wrong file.* · 2. *You didn't read the brief.* · 3. *They ignored my email.*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Make **three** past deductions from real evidence, using all three certainty levels.

My phone was at forty percent this morning and it's dead now — something must have been running in the background. She hasn't replied since Thursday. She might have missed it, or she could just be busy. He can't have read my message. He'd have said something.



Record all three. Check: /mʌstəv/ not *must have*, and the /t/ on *can't*.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post three sentences: *"It must / might / can't have ____."*
- **Reconstruct one thing that went wrong this week.** Out loud, in English, with a confidence level on each step. That is the professional version of this lesson.
- Listen for /mʌstəv/. Once you can hear it, you will notice how much of English conversation is deduction.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **modal + have + participle** — the past deduction.
- *must have** ↔ **can't have*. **Never mustn't have.**
- Direction of travel: **present evidence → past conclusion.**
- **Revise when the evidence changes.** That is the skill, not the grammar.
- *must have known* = I deduce he did. *would have known* = he didn't. One consonant apart.
- /əv/ on every modal — and it is **have**, never *of*.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can build all three levels with a correct participle.
- ☐ I never say *mustn't have*.
- ☐ I revised a conclusion when new evidence appeared.
- ☐ I can hear /mʌstəv/ against /wʊdəv/.
- ☐ My *can't have* has an audible /t/.
- ☐ I softened one accusation into an inference.

Empire English 🏰 — reading the present to reconstruct the past

SPECULATING ABOUT PEOPLE & SITUATIONS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 · **Lesson 3** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md](#) · **S3-U5-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Speculate about what someone is feeling or intending — carefully.
- Move between **present** and **past** deduction inside one turn.
- Sound **thoughtful** rather than certain. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Speculation is the most common kind of extended talk in ordinary conversation, and almost nobody teaches it. Think about what you actually discuss with colleagues and friends: why someone did something, what a decision probably means, what is going on with a situation nobody has explained. None of it is knowledge. All of it is inference spoken aloud, cooperatively, with people adding and correcting.

That is a specific skill and it has a specific sound. It is not fluent assertion — the person who says *he's obviously annoyed with me* has ended the conversation and possibly been unfair. It is layered, hedged, revisable talk: *he seems a bit off, actually. He might just be tired — he's been travelling. Although he was fine with everyone else this morning, so it could be about the report.* Three hypotheses, a piece of evidence, a revision. That is thinking in real time, and it is the single most natural-sounding thing a B2 speaker can do.

Here is why it is worth deliberate practice. When learners speak at length under no pressure to be accurate, they reveal their actual fluency — and speculation is the only genre where being wrong costs nothing. You are explicitly not claiming to know. That freedom is what lets you produce long, connected, exploratory speech, which is exactly what the Unit-12 benchmark measures. Learners who can speculate comfortably do well in extended conversation. Learners who can only report facts run out of things to say in four minutes.

There is a hard edge to this too, and it is worth being direct about. Speculating about people is one step away from deciding things about them, and that step is easy to take in a language you are still building. *He must be lazy* is a deduction about someone's character from very little evidence. *He must be under a lot of pressure* uses the same grammar on the same facts and is a completely different sentence to be on the receiving end of. The hedges in this lesson are not softeners for their own sake — they are what keeps a speculation honest about how little you actually know. Speculate about **what people appear to be doing**, not about what they appear to be.

The professional version of this is reading a room, and it is a genuine skill: *I get the impression they haven't decided yet. It looks like the budget's the real issue. Presumably they've had this conversation internally already.* Every one of those is a hypothesis offered for correction, and offering hypotheses for correction is how useful meetings work.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (BOTH DEDUCTIONS, FAST)

Thirty seconds each, evidence attached:

1. A **present** deduction — *must be / might be / can't be*.
2. A **past** deduction — *must have / might have / can't have*.
3. Both about the **same** situation.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip — two people speculating about a photo, then about a colleague. Read along:

A: What do you think's going on here? **B:** They look like they've just finished something. Everyone's holding a drink and nobody's sitting down, so it can't be a formal thing. **A:** A birthday? **B:** Could be. There's no cake, though. It might be a leaving party — the woman in the middle looks like the centre of attention and everyone else is angled towards her. **A:** She's holding a card. **B:** Then it's presumably a leaving do or a promotion. She must have been there a while, judging by how many people turned up.

A: Changing subject — is Karim all right? He was quiet this morning. **B:** I got the impression something's up, yes. He might just be tired; he's been on early shifts all week. **A:** He was fine with Dina, though. **B:** Was he? Then it could be about the audit. He must have seen the email before the meeting, in which case he sat through the whole thing knowing. **A:** Poor guy. **B:** I'm guessing, to be fair. It could be nothing at all.

Study the last line. After building a plausible theory, B explicitly steps back: *I'm guessing, to be fair. It could be nothing at all.* That is the move that separates speculation from gossip, and it costs one sentence.

Notice also how much of this is **visible evidence**: nobody's sitting, there's no cake, she's holding a card, he was fine with Dina. The speculation is anchored in observation, not in assumptions about who people are.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (DEDUCTION PLUS HEDGING)

The architecture of a speculation. Three components, repeated:

evidence → hedged conclusion → revision when contradicted

The hedges, and what each one signals:

Hedge	Signals
<i>it looks like...</i>	I am reading visible evidence
<i>it seems...</i>	my impression, not a fact
<i>presumably...</i>	I think this is the obvious inference
<i>I'd guess / I'd say...</i>	my opinion, offered for correction
<i>I get the impression...</i>	a feeling from many small signals
<i>apparently...</i>	I was told this; I haven't verified it
<i>in which case...</i>	if this is true, then this follows
<i>I'm guessing, to be fair</i>	explicit retreat — I might be wrong

presumably and in which case are the two nobody produces. They are also the two that make speculation sound educated rather than merely careful. *Presumably they've discussed it already* does a lot of work in five words. *In which case* is how you chain a consequence onto an unproven premise, which is the whole point of speculating.

Combining present and past in one turn. This is the fluency target:

He seems quiet (present observation) — he might just be tired (present deduction) — although he must have seen the email before the meeting (past deduction), in which case he already knew (consequence).

One turn, four moves, and it is far more impressive than any single perfect sentence.

The evidence rule, restated for people. Speculate about **behaviour and circumstance**, not about character:

✓ *He must be under pressure — he's been in every meeting this week.* ✗ *He must be disorganised.*

The grammar is identical. The first is an inference from evidence; the second is a judgement wearing the costume of one. This distinction matters more in a second language, because you have fewer words available to soften it.

Always leave the exit. One sentence at the end that admits you might be wrong:

I could be completely wrong. · That's a guess. · Don't quote me.

And do not over-hedge into nothing. A speculation still needs a claim in it. *Maybe. I don't know. Could be anything.* is not speculation — it is declining to think, which is the same failure as the empty hedge in U3-L04.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Read visible evidence	<i>It looks like... · Judging by... · Going by the fact that...</i>
Offer an impression	<i>It seems... · I get the impression... · There's something a bit off about...</i>
Draw the obvious inference	<i>Presumably... · The obvious explanation is... · Which suggests...</i>
Chain a consequence	<i>In which case... · If that's right, then... · Which would mean...</i>
Offer an alternative	<i>Or it could just be... · Then again... · Unless...</i>
Revise	<i>Was he? Then it can't be... · Actually, in that case...</i>
Retreat	<i>I'm guessing, to be fair. · I could be completely wrong. · Don't quote me.</i>
Keep it about behaviour	<i>He's been ... all week · She was fine with ... this morning</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (TENTATIVE INTONATION)

Speculation has a sound, and it is not the sound of certainty.

Cue 1 — hedged claims stay mid-pitch and slightly rising. Not falling. A falling tail on a hedge makes it sound like a verdict:

It might be a leaving party. 📈 — open. *It might be a leaving party.* 📉 — you have decided.

Cue 2 — presumably and apparently sit on a small plateau, then the clause continues:

PreSUMably — ... they've already discussed it.

Cue 3 — the revision is marked by a jump. When new evidence arrives, your pitch **steps up** on the pivot word:

📈 *Was he? Then it can't be that.*

That upward step is how English signals *I am changing my mind*, and it is the most natural-sounding thing in this lesson.

Cue 4 — slow down on the retreat. *I'm guessing, to be fair* delivered quickly sounds like a throwaway. Slowed and lowered, it reads as genuine.

Cue 5 — keep the reductions. /mʌstəv/, /maɪtəv/, /kʊdbi/. A speculation is exploratory speech; heavy auxiliaries make it sound rehearsed, which defeats the purpose.

 **Record a 30-second speculation.** Play it back and ask one question: does it sound like I am **working something out**, or like I am **announcing a conclusion**?

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Read the evidence. Speculate about each, using a hedge **and** a piece of evidence:

1. A restaurant is completely full at three in the afternoon.
2. Your colleague's desk is clear and their monitor is gone.
3. A shop has a handwritten sign on the door.
4. Someone read your message at 2am and didn't reply.
5. A meeting invite has been moved three times this week.

B. Chain it with *in which case*.

The invite went to the old list, in which case half the team never saw it.

Now do: *the file's empty · she left at four · nobody's replied · the price changed overnight*

C. Behaviour, not character. Rewrite each as an inference from evidence:

1. *He must be lazy.* · 2. *She must be difficult to work with.* · 3. *They must not care.*

D. Revise under new evidence. In pairs. Speculate about a situation; your partner adds one contradicting fact; you revise and offer an alternative. Three rounds, without restarting.

E. Speculate for sixty seconds. One situation, continuous speech. Include at least three hedges, one past deduction, one *in which case*, and an exit line at the end.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speculate for about **a minute** about a real situation you do not have the full story on — a change at work, a decision someone made, something in the news.

You must include:

- at least **three hedges**
- one **past** deduction and one **present** one
- one *in which case*
- an **exit line**

It looks like they're restructuring the team, going by how many one-to-ones have appeared in the calendar this week. Presumably the decision was made before the quarter closed, in which case the announcement's already written. It might just be a normal review round — although they wouldn't book them all in two days for that. My guess is two teams merging. I could be completely wrong about all of this.



Record it. Listen back: does it sound like working something out, or announcing a conclusion?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a speculation about a situation or an image, with hedges and evidence.
- **Use *presumably* and *in which case* once each this week.** They are the two phrases that will make you sound most like an educated speaker, and you will otherwise never produce them.
- Notice how much of ordinary conversation is speculation rather than fact. It is most of it.



REMEMBER — افكر

- The shape: **evidence → hedged conclusion → revision.**
- *presumably* and *in which case* are the two nobody produces. Produce them.
- Combine **present and past** deduction in one turn — that is the fluency, not one perfect sentence.
- Speculate about **behaviour and circumstance**, never about character.
- **Always leave the exit:** *I could be completely wrong.*
- **Hedged claims rise.** A falling hedge is a verdict.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ Every conclusion I offered was anchored in visible evidence.
- ☐ I used at least three different hedges.
- ☐ I combined a present and a past deduction in one turn.
- ☐ I revised when my partner contradicted me, without restarting.
- ☐ I kept it about what people were doing, not what they are like.
- ☐ It sounds like I was thinking, not announcing.

Empire English 🏰 — thinking out loud is a skill, and this is what it sounds like

EVIDENCE & CONCLUSIONS — REASONING OUT LOUD

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 · **Lesson 4** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md](#) · S3-U5-L04

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Lay out evidence, then reach a conclusion — in that order, out loud.
- Use *given that, this suggests, which would mean, therefore*.
- Raise an alternative explanation and **rule it out**. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Yesterday you speculated. Today you **argue** — and the difference is structure.

Speculation is exploratory and cooperative; it wanders on purpose. Reasoning is built. It puts the evidence first, marks the inference explicitly, reaches a conclusion, and — if it is any good — deals with the objection before anyone raises it. The grammar is the same deduction you already own. What is new is the scaffolding that makes it followable.

Here is why the scaffolding matters. Compare two versions of the same thought:

They must have left. The lights are off and the car's gone. Given that the lights are off and the car's gone, they must have left.

The first is a conclusion with evidence trailing after it, which is how people speak when they are thinking. The second puts the listener through the reasoning **in the order it works**, so they arrive at your conclusion at the same moment you do — and are therefore much likelier to agree with it. Same facts. One of them persuades.

This is the single most transferable structure in the stage. It is how you explain a diagnosis, justify a recommendation, defend an estimate, or push back on a decision. *Given that we've already signed the hardware order, switching suppliers now would mean writing off about forty thousand — so my recommendation is that we renegotiate instead.* Evidence, consequence, conclusion. It is the shape of every credible professional argument you will make in English.

And there is one move that separates competent reasoning from rigorous reasoning: **raising the alternative yourself**. *It could just be a caching problem — but that wouldn't explain why it's only affecting*

two accounts. When you do that, three things happen. You demonstrate that you considered other possibilities, which is what makes your conclusion trustworthy. You disarm the objection before anyone makes it. And you invite correction, because if someone can rescue the alternative you just dismissed, they will now tell you. Reasoning that never acknowledges an alternative always sounds like advocacy rather than analysis.

Be honest about the trap. This structure can be used to make a bad conclusion sound authoritative, and at B2 you now have enough language to do that convincingly. The discipline is that the evidence has to actually support the conclusion — and if it only half does, the reasoning chain should say so. *That suggests, though it doesn't prove...* is a completely normal thing to say, and it is what an honest chain looks like when the evidence is thin.

WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE SPECULATION)

One minute in pairs. Speculate about something with at least two hedges and one past deduction.

Then swap and do it again — but this time **put the evidence first** and the conclusion last. Notice which version your partner found more convincing.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip, then read. The reasoning moves are marked:

A: So what's your read on the drop in sign-ups? **B:** **[EVIDENCE]** Given that it started on the fourteenth, and that's the day the new pricing page went live, **[INFERENCE]** the obvious explanation is the pricing. **A:** That's a big claim. **B:** **[SUPPORTING EVIDENCE]** Well — traffic hasn't changed at all. Same visitors, fewer conversions. **[CONSEQUENCE]** Which would mean people are arriving and then deciding not to buy. **A:** Could it be seasonal? **B:** **[ALTERNATIVE RAISED]** It could be. **[ALTERNATIVE REJECTED]** But last year the same fortnight was completely flat, not down — so seasonality doesn't explain a fourteen percent fall. **A:** Fair. **B:** **[HEDGED CONCLUSION]** So my conclusion is that it's the pricing page rather than the price itself. The layout buries the middle tier. **[HONESTY]** That suggests it, though it doesn't prove it — we'd need to A/B it to be sure. **A:** What would you do? **B:** **[RECOMMENDATION]** Given all that, I'd revert the page for a week and watch what happens.

Read B's turns again and notice: the evidence always comes **before** the conclusion, the alternative is raised and then **specifically** dismissed with a fact, and the conclusion is hedged with an explicit statement of what would be needed to prove it. That is what rigour sounds like.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE REASONING CHAIN)

Five moves, in order:

#	Move	Language
1	Lay out the evidence	<i>Given that... · The fact that... · We know that...</i>
2	Mark the inference	<i>This suggests... · Which would mean... · That points to...</i>
3	Raise the alternative	<i>It could be... · One possibility is...</i>
4	Rule it out	<i>But that wouldn't explain... · Except that...</i>
5	Conclude	<i>So my conclusion is... · Therefore... · On balance...</i>

Evidence first. Always. This is the one structural rule:

Given that X and Y, it must be Z.

Putting the conclusion first makes the evidence sound like a defence of a position you had already taken.

The connectors, and what each really does:

Connector	Strength
<i>given that</i>	I am treating this as established
<i>the fact that</i>	I am pointing at one specific piece
<i>this suggests</i>	a soft inference — not proof
<i>which would mean</i>	a consequence if the inference holds
<i>therefore / so</i>	a firm conclusion
<i>on balance</i>	I have weighed competing evidence

This suggests and *which would mean* are the two learners under-use, and they are the honest ones — they mark an inference **as** an inference.

Rule out the alternative with a FACT, not with confidence:

✗ *It could be seasonal, but I don't think so.* — that is just your opinion again. ✓ *It could be seasonal, but last year was flat, not down.* — now the alternative is actually eliminated.

The formula: ***but that wouldn't explain...*** followed by the specific thing it fails to explain. That phrase is the most useful thing in this lesson.

Say what would settle it. The mark of an honest chain:

That suggests it, though it doesn't prove it — we'd need to A/B it to be sure. If I'm right, we'd expect to see X. If we don't, I'm wrong.

Naming your own test is disarming, and it is what separates analysis from advocacy.

Do not over-build. Three pieces of evidence is plenty. A chain with seven links is harder to follow than one with three and no more convincing — the listener loses the thread and stops tracking whether it holds.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Set out evidence	<i>Given that... · The fact that... · We know that... · Going by...</i>
Soft inference	<i>This suggests... · That points to... · Which implies...</i>
Consequence	<i>Which would mean... · In which case... · If that's right, then...</i>
Raise alternative	<i>It could be... · One possibility is... · Unless it's...</i>
Rule it out	<i>But that wouldn't explain... · Except that... · That doesn't account for...</i>
Conclude	<i>So my conclusion is... · Therefore... · On balance, I'd say...</i>
Stay honest	<i>...though it doesn't prove it. · We'd need to check. · If I'm right, we'd expect...</i>
Recommend	<i>Given all that, I'd... · My recommendation would be...</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PHRASING A CHAIN)

A reasoning chain fails on **pacing** long before it fails on grammar. Four cues.

Cue 1 — one thought group per link, and pause between them. The pauses are the punctuation of a spoken argument:

Given that it started on the fourteenth // and that's when the pricing page went live // the obvious explanation is the pricing.

Cue 2 — never stress the connector. *Given that, this suggests, therefore* are signposts, not news. Push the content after them:

*Given that it started on the **FOUR**teenth...* — not *GIVEN* that...

This is the same rule as *because* in U2-L04.

Cue 3 — the conclusion falls, and it comes last. Drop your pitch and stop. That fall is what tells the listener the chain is complete:

...so it must be the pricing page. ↘

Cue 4 — the rejection gets a step up, then a fall. When you dismiss an alternative, the pitch **lifts** on the pivot and lands on the fact:

↗ But that wouldn't explain // a fourteen percent **FALL**. ↘

Cue 5 — slow down on the honesty line. *Though it doesn't prove it* said quickly sounds like a disclaimer nobody means. Slowed, it sounds like integrity.

🎧 **Record a three-link chain.** Play it back and count your pauses. Fewer than two and it is unfollowable.

🏋️ TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Reorder it. Each has the conclusion first. Rebuild it evidence-first with *given that*:

1. *They must have left — the lights are off and the car's gone.*
2. *It must be a software problem. It happens on every device.*
3. *She can't have got the email. She'd have replied.*

B. Rule it out. For each alternative, add a fact that eliminates it:

1. *It could just be the weather, but ____.*
2. *It might be a coincidence, but ____.*
3. *Maybe they forgot, but ____.*

C. Build the chain. Take a scenario and produce all five moves:

- Half the team missed a deadline they have always met.
- A shop that was always busy is empty for a week.
- A friend has stopped replying to the group chat.
- Website sign-ups dropped the day after a redesign.

D. Add the honesty line. For your chain in C, say what would **prove** you right or wrong.

E. Two alternatives (stretch). Raise and reject **two** competing explanations before concluding.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Reason aloud for about **a minute** about something real you have been trying to work out — at work, in your studies, in the news.

Include all five moves and the honesty line:

Given that our response times only got worse after the migration, and nothing else changed that week, the obvious explanation is the new database. Traffic's identical — same volume, slower replies — which would mean the problem is on our side rather than demand. It could be the caching layer, but that wouldn't explain why it's slow at three in the morning as well. So on balance I'd say it's the database configuration. Though that doesn't prove it — if I'm right we'd see it clear up when we roll back, and we haven't tried that yet.

 **Record it.** Check: does the evidence come before the conclusion, and did you rule something out with a fact?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post an evidence → conclusion chain about something real.
- **Use "but that wouldn't explain..." once this week**, out loud, in a real discussion. It is the most useful phrase in this lesson and it will change how your reasoning is received.
- Before you next give a recommendation, put the evidence first. Notice whether you get less pushback.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Five moves: **evidence → inference → alternative → rejection → conclusion**.
- **Evidence first.** Conclusion first makes the evidence sound like a defence.
- **Reject an alternative with a FACT**, not with confidence: *but that wouldn't explain...*
- *this suggests* and *which would mean* mark an inference **as** an inference. Use them.
- **Say what would settle it.** That is the difference between analysis and advocacy.
- **Never stress the connector.** Pause between links; let the conclusion **fall**.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ My evidence came before my conclusion.
- ☐ I marked at least one inference as an inference.

- ☐ I raised an alternative and killed it with a specific fact.
 - ☐ I said what would prove me right or wrong.
 - ☐ I paused between links instead of running them together.
 - ☐ I kept my chain to three links, not seven.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the shape of every argument you'll make in English

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: SOLVE THE MYSTERY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 5 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK ⌚ ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit5-modals-deduction.md](#) · **S3-U5-L05**

YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you reason your way through a problem, out loud:

- ~2 minutes working a scenario
- **present** and **past** deduction, with evidence
- an **alternative raised and ruled out**
- a **hedged conclusion**, and what would prove it 🗣️

WARM-UP — سخن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each, evidence attached, auxiliaries reduced:

1. A present deduction — *must be / might be / can't be*.
2. A past deduction — *must have / might have / can't have*.
3. A hedge: *presumably... or it looks like...*
4. A rejection: *but that wouldn't explain...*
5. The pair, said cleanly: *must have / can't have*.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model deduction talk. The scenario and the reasoning:

THE SCENARIO. A small office. On Monday morning the team arrives to find: the front door unlocked, the lights on, one window open, a half-finished cup of coffee on a desk, the printer out of paper with a print job still queued, and nothing missing.

[EVIDENCE FIRST] Given that nothing's missing and the door was unlocked rather than forced, this can't have been a break-in. **[PAST DEDUCTION]** Somebody must have been here over the weekend and left in a hurry.

[MORE EVIDENCE] The coffee's half-finished and the lights are on, which suggests they didn't plan to leave when they did. **[PRESENT DEDUCTION]** And the print job's still queued, so whatever they were doing, it must be unfinished.

[ALTERNATIVE] It could have been the cleaners — they have a key and they come on Sundays.

[REJECTED WITH A FACT] But that wouldn't explain the print job. Cleaners don't print things.

[HEDGED CONCLUSION] So on balance I'd say someone came in to finish something urgent, got interrupted — a phone call, probably — and left without thinking. Presumably somebody with a key and a deadline.

[THE TEST] Though that doesn't prove it. If I'm right, the print queue will have somebody's name on it, and the door log will show a single entry on Sunday. That would settle it in about a minute.

Study three things. The **first move eliminates** rather than concludes — *this can't have been a break-in* clears the ground. The alternative is rejected with a **specific** fact, not with confidence. And the ending names a test that would take a minute, which is what makes the whole thing sound like reasoning rather than storytelling.

🧩 THE UNIT-5 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	evidence, stated first	<i>Given that nothing's missing...</i>
2	a past deduction	<i>Somebody must have been here.</i>
3	a present deduction	<i>It must be unfinished.</i>
4	an alternative raised	<i>It could have been the cleaners.</i>
5	the alternative ruled out with a fact	<i>But that wouldn't explain the print job.</i>
6	a hedged conclusion + a test	<i>On balance... though that doesn't prove it. If I'm right, we'd see...</i>

Items 5 and 6 are what get dropped, and they are the two that turn a guess into an argument. A rejection without a fact is just a preference. A conclusion without a test is advocacy.

🎧 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (REDUCED MODAL PERFECTS UNDER LOAD)

Everyone — the six-modal reduction, at speed. This is the unit's signature target:

/mʌstəv/ · /maɪtəv/ · /kʊdəv/ · /ka:ntəv/ · /ʃʊdəv/ · /wʊdəv/

In a two-minute deduction talk these appear eight or ten times. Under load learners revert to full forms and the reasoning starts to sound recited.

Everyone — /ka:ntəv/ keeps its /t/. Lose it and *can't have* becomes *can have*, which reverses your elimination. This is the one error here with a real cost.

Everyone — the chain needs pauses. One thought group per link. The rejection steps **up**, the conclusion **falls**.

Everyone — hedges rise, conclusions fall. If both sound the same, the listener cannot tell what you are claiming.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker. One cue, one phrase, one sentence, stop.

 **Record the trio** before the task: *"It must have rained." / "He can't have known." / "That would explain it."* Check the /t/ and the reductions.

TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (WORK THE MYSTERY IN PAIRS)

The scenario — read it, don't memorise it.

A colleague, normally reliable, has missed three deadlines in a row this month. You also know: she has been arriving later than usual but staying much later; she has stopped coming to the Thursday team lunch; her last two pieces of work were unusually good, not rushed; she asked HR about part-time hours six weeks ago; and she has been copying her manager's manager into things she never used to.

Round 1 — build alone, two minutes. Six bullets, no sentences: your evidence, your past deduction, your present deduction, your alternative, your fact that kills it, your conclusion and test.

Round 2 — theory against theory. In pairs, each present a conclusion. Then argue: each of you must attack the other's theory with a **fact from the scenario**, and defend or revise your own.

Round 3 — the third explanation. Together, find a theory neither of you started with that fits **all** the evidence.

Round 4 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver only the weakest thirty seconds with the reductions corrected.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** working through the scenario, containing all six checklist items. Then discuss it with your partner for one minute, unrehearsed — and be willing to change your mind.

 **Save this recording.** It is your longest piece of pure reasoning so far. Unit 11 will ask for the same skill with a topic instead of a mystery, and Unit 12 will ask for it for twenty minutes.

📖 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your deduction talk.
- Complete the **Unit-5 quiz** — present deduction (*must / might / can't be*), past deduction (*must / might / can't have been*), certainty matching, and the *mustn't* against *can't* error.
- **Reason out loud about one real thing this week** — evidence first, one alternative ruled out, a test at the end. Do it in a conversation, not in your head.
- Keep noticing */mʌstəv/* in what you watch. It is everywhere.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- **must be / can't be · must have / can't have. Never *mustn't*.**
- **Evidence first**, conclusion last. Starting with an **elimination** is the strongest opening.
- **Rule out the alternative with a fact.** *But I don't think so* eliminates nothing.
- **Name the test.** A conclusion with no test is advocacy.
- **Revise when the evidence changes.** That is the skill, not the grammar.
- */əv/* on every modal — and */kɑ:ntəv/* keeps its **/t/**.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes, unscripted, in English.
- ☐ I used both present and past deduction, each with evidence.
- ☐ I raised an alternative and killed it with a specific fact.
- ☐ My conclusion was hedged and I said what would settle it.
- ☐ I changed my mind when my partner found something I'd missed.
- ☐ My modal perfects reduced, and my *can't have* kept its */t/*.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 5 complete — confident uncertainty, which is what expertise sounds like



STAGE 3 · UNIT 6

THE PASSIVE (ADVANCED)

👑 UNIT 6 — THE PASSIVE (ADVANCED)

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: describe systems, rules and services precisely — and impersonally. By the end you can explain how something works without naming anyone, state a requirement without giving an order, and criticise a process without accusing a person.

This unit completes the "structures for precision" set. Units 1–5 gave you time and certainty. This one gives you **register** — the ability to sound institutional, objective or professional when the situation asks for it.

A word of warning that runs through all five lessons. Once you own the passive you will want to use it everywhere, and that makes writing vague and speech evasive. The passive is a **choice with a reason**: the doer is unknown, obvious, or irrelevant. There is a fourth reason — hiding someone — and you should know when you are using it.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Passive across tenses	one engine — be in any tense + participle
L02	Modal & perfect passives	a rule with no you · <i>that should have been checked</i>
L03	Reporting passive	<i>it is believed that...</i> / <i>he is said to...</i> — the register of reports
L04	Causative	<i>I had my car repaired</i> — the grammar of things you arrange
L05	Unit task 🎤	2 minutes explaining a real system, then answering clarifying questions

Grammar spine: *be* + participle across every tense · modal + *be* + participle · *modal* + *have been* + participle · both reporting-passive patterns with the infinitive-time rule · *have / get* + object + participle.

Accent Lab: the auxiliary string as one unstressed run — /əzbaɪn/, /ɪzbaɪn/, /ʃʊdəvbaɪn/ · **one stress, on the participle** · the three *-ed* endings surviving at speed · **been** squeezed but never deleted · **rules stress the modal, criticisms stress the participle**. **Mindset:** sounding precise and professional. **Arabic support:** 0% — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- The ability to **state a requirement with no *you* in it** — the register of every policy and instruction in English.
 - *That should have been checked* — a complete criticism with no subject anywhere in it.
 - *I'll get it looked at* — a commitment to an action without a commitment to doing it yourself.
-

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** passive across tenses · modal and perfect passives · *mustn't be* against *doesn't have to be* · both reporting-passive patterns · causative word order · *was happened*.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute system description plus one clarifying question answered by rephrasing, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **weak-auxiliary strings** and **participle clarity** (both named U12 clinic inputs), plus a note of anyone over-using the passive.
-

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 7 — RELATIVE CLAUSES (ADVANCED)

non-defining clauses, the comma that changes the meaning, reduced relatives, and *which* standing for a whole idea — how to pack detail into one sentence instead of three.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · precise, professional, and nobody has to be named

THE PASSIVE ACROSS EVERY TENSE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 simple passive
 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U6-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Build the passive in **any** tense you already own.
- Say *is being repaired*, *has been sent*, *will be reviewed* without assembling them.
- Describe a process where **nobody needs naming**. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You met the passive at B1 in two tenses: *it is made in Turkey*, *it was built in 1998*. Useful, and enough to describe facts. Not enough to describe **work in progress**, which is most of what gets described at work.

Here is the gap. *The road is repaired* says it is finished. *The road is being repaired* says there are people out there with drills right now. *The report has been sent* says it has arrived and you can go and read it. *The report will be reviewed* says nothing about who will review it, which is often exactly the point. Each of those needs a different tense of *be*, and without them you can only describe the passive as a completed state.

Why the passive matters so much in professional English is worth being precise about, because learners are often taught it as a stylistic curiosity. It exists for three honest reasons. Sometimes **nobody knows** who did it — *the file was deleted at some point on Tuesday*. Sometimes **everybody knows** and saying it is noise — *your application has been received* (obviously by us). And sometimes **the doer is irrelevant** to what you are saying — *the system is checked every night* is about the checking, not the checker. In all three cases naming an agent would make the sentence worse.

There is a fourth reason, and it deserves to be named rather than pretended away: the passive can **remove responsibility**. *Mistakes were made*. *The decision was taken*. Nobody did anything; things simply occurred. This is a real feature of English and you should be able to both use it and hear it. Used deliberately — to depersonalise a criticism, to describe a problem without accusing a colleague — it is diplomacy. Used habitually, it is evasion, and readers notice. When you see three passives in a row in a company email, someone is avoiding something.

So the skill in this lesson has two halves. Build the passive in any tense, which is mechanical once you see that only *be* moves. And **choose** it for a reason, which is judgement. A learner who can produce *has been being processed* but uses the passive for everything has gone backwards in clarity while going forwards in grammar.

One structural note that makes this easier than it looks. You already own every tense of *be*. You already own the participles from Unit 1. This lesson does not add a new form — it shows you that two things you have can be combined mechanically. That is why the table below is worth memorising as a shape rather than as six facts.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE THE B1 PASSIVE)

Three sentences, fast:

1. Something that *is made* somewhere specific.
2. Something that *was built* in a particular year.
3. Something that *wasn't finished* on time.

Now try one you cannot yet build: *what is happening to your street / your office right now?*

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: Any progress on the office move? **B:** Some. The new floor is being fitted this week, and the desks have already been ordered. **A:** What about the network? **B:** That was being installed when I went past yesterday. It should be finished by Friday. **A:** And the old building? **B:** It's been sold. Contracts were signed last month — we weren't told until afterwards, which was fun. **A:** So when do we move? **B:** The date will be confirmed once the fit-out's signed off. Nothing's been decided yet.

Six tenses of the passive in eight lines. Now look at the pattern: *is being fitted, have been ordered, was being installed, has been sold, were signed, will be confirmed*. The participle at the end of each is the same kind of word every time. **Only the front half moves.**

And notice how natural it is that nobody is named. Who is fitting the floor? Contractors, presumably. It does not matter, and saying so would clutter the sentence.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (BE IN THE TENSE + PARTICIPLE)

One engine:

be (conjugated in whatever tense you want) + **past participle**

That is the entire grammar. The participle never changes.

Tense	Passive	Example
present simple	<i>is / are + participle</i>	<i>The system is checked nightly.</i>
present continuous	<i>is / are being + participle</i>	<i>The road is being repaired.</i>
past simple	<i>was / were + participle</i>	<i>Contracts were signed last month.</i>
past continuous	<i>was / were being + participle</i>	<i>It was being installed yesterday.</i>
present perfect	<i>has / have been + participle</i>	<i>The report has been sent.</i>
past perfect	<i>had been + participle</i>	<i>It had been approved before I joined.</i>
future	<i>will be + participle</i>	<i>The date will be confirmed.</i>
future perfect	<i>will have been + participle</i>	<i>It will have been finished by Friday.</i>

The four you will actually use, in order of frequency:

is being + participle — happening now *has been* + participle — done, and it matters now *was* + participle — done, at a point in the past *will be* + participle — will happen, agent unstated

Master those four and you have ninety percent of the passive in real use.

When to choose it. Three good reasons and one to be careful with:

Reason	Example
the doer is unknown	<i>The file was deleted on Tuesday.</i>
the doer is obvious	<i>Your application has been received.</i>
the doer is irrelevant	<i>The system is checked every night.</i>
⚠️ to remove responsibility	<i>Mistakes were made.</i>

That last one is real English and it is sometimes exactly what you want — depersonalising a problem so nobody has to defend themselves. Just know when you are doing it.

by + agent, only when the agent is news:

The bridge was built in 1998. — nobody cares who. *The bridge was built **by the same firm that built ours**.* — now it is the point.

What cannot go passive. Verbs with no object. *Happen, arrive, occur, seem, exist:*

✗ *The accident was happened.* → ✓ *The accident happened.*

This is a persistent error and it is worth naming: if there is no object in the active sentence, there is nothing to promote.

Do not build monsters. *It has been being processed* is grammatically possible and nobody says it. If a form feels like an achievement to construct, choose a different sentence.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
is being + participle	<i>The floor is being fitted.</i>
has been + participle	<i>The desks have been ordered.</i>
will be confirmed	<i>The date will be confirmed.</i>
nothing's been decided	<i>Nothing's been decided yet.</i>
it's been sold	<i>The building's been sold.</i>
we weren't told	<i>We weren't told until afterwards.</i>
is checked every...	<i>The system is checked nightly.</i>
once ... is signed off	<i>Once the fit-out is signed off...</i>
is due to be...	<i>It's due to be replaced.</i>
it's still being...	<i>It's still being reviewed.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (WEAK AUXILIARIES, CLEAR PARTICIPLES)

The passive is a **string of unstressed function words followed by one stressed content word**. Get that shape and it sounds effortless.

Cue 1 — the auxiliaries all reduce:

is being → /ɪzbɪŋ/ · *has been* → /əzbɪn/ · *have been* → /əvbɪn/ · *will be* → /wɪlbi/ · *was being* → /wəzbɪŋ/

Cue 2 — the stress lands on the participle. One peak per clause:

Say it like this/ɪzbaɪŋ/ rɪ**PAIRED**/əzbɪn/ **SENT**/wɪlbi/ kən**FIRMED**/wəzbaɪŋ/ **IN**stalled

Cue 3 — the participle ending must survive. This is the meaning-bearing part and it is where the passive is lost:

checked /t/ · *ordered* /d/ · *decided* /ɪd/ · *sent* · *built* · *sold*

The three -ed endings are the Stage-1 work coming back. At speed, in a long auxiliary string, the ending is the first thing to disappear — and without it *has been checked* becomes *has been check*, which is nothing.

Cue 4 — *been* is /bɪn/, unstressed, but present. Same discipline as every reduction in Stage 3: squeezed, never deleted. Drop it and *has been sent* becomes *has sent*, which is active and means something else entirely.

 **Record:** "The desks have been ordered, and the floor is being fitted this week." Listen for two things: are the auxiliaries squeezed, and can you hear the -ed on *ordered*?

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Convert to the passive. Keep the tense:

1. *They are repairing the road.*
2. *Someone has sent the report.*
3. *They were installing the network yesterday.*
4. *We will confirm the date on Friday.*
5. *Nobody had approved it before I joined.*

B. Choose the tense. From the context, pick the right passive:

1. *Don't use that door — it ____ (paint) at the moment.*
2. *Your application ____ (receive). We'll be in touch.*
3. *The contracts ____ (sign) last month.*
4. *Nothing ____ (decide) yet.*
5. *By Friday, everything ____ (finish).*

C. Should it be passive at all? Say yes or no, and give the reason:

1. *The file was deleted on Tuesday.* (nobody knows who)
2. *A mistake was made by me.*
3. *The system is checked every night.*
4. *The email was sent by me this morning.*

D. Fix the error.

1. *The accident was happened at six.*
2. *The report has sent already.*
3. *The road is repairing at the moment.*
4. *It was been approved last week.*

 YOUR TURN — دورك

Describe a **real** project or process — at work, at home, in your city — using at least **three** passive tenses.

The building next to ours is being demolished at the moment. The permits were approved back in January, and about half the structure has already been taken down. The whole site will be cleared by the spring, apparently, although nothing's been confirmed.

 **Record it.** Check: can you hear every participle ending?

 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post three passive sentences in **different** tenses.
- **Notice the passive in one work email.** Count them, and ask of each: is the doer unknown, obvious, irrelevant — or being hidden? The last one is the interesting answer.
- Say *has been* out loud until /əzbiːn/ is automatic. It is the most frequent passive in English.

 REMEMBER — افكر

- One engine: **be (in any tense) + participle**. Only **be** moves.
- The four you need: **is being · has been · was · will be**.
- Choose it because the doer is **unknown, obvious** or **irrelevant** — and know when it is **hiding** someone.
- **by only when the agent is news.**
- No object, no passive: **was happened** does not exist.

- **Squeeze the auxiliaries, land on the participle** — and keep the *-ed*.
-

✓ **SELF-CHECK** — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can build the passive in any tense by conjugating only *be*.
 - ☐ I used *is being*, *has been* and *will be* correctly.
 - ☐ I can say why each of my passives was the right choice.
 - ☐ I can hear *has been sent* against *has sent*.
 - ☐ My participle endings survived at speed.
-

Empire English 🏰 — *one engine, every tense, and nobody has to be named*

MODAL & PERFECT PASSIVES — *MUST BE DONE* · *SHOULD HAVE BEEN CHECKED*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md](#) · S3-U6-L02

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- State a rule with **no you** in it: *forms must be submitted by Friday.*
- Say *it can be done, it has to be approved, it should be checked first.*
- Criticise a process without blaming a person: *that should have been caught.* 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Read any set of instructions written in English — a form, a policy, a safety notice, a submission guideline — and count how many times it says *you*. Usually never. Instead: *applications must be received by the 30th. Documents should be signed in black ink. Payment can be made online.* Nobody is addressed and nothing is ordered, yet the requirements are perfectly clear.

That is the modal passive, and it is the default register for anything institutional. Learning it does two things. It lets you understand instructions that seemed oddly impersonal. And it lets you **give** requirements without sounding like you are giving orders — which matters enormously if you ever have to tell colleagues, clients or students what to do.

Compare: *You must send the form by Friday* and *The form must be submitted by Friday*. The first makes it about the person and creates an obligation between you and them. The second makes it about the requirement, which exists independently of either of you. If the deadline is not your rule — if it comes from a process, a client, a regulation — the passive is not just politer, it is more **accurate**. You are reporting a requirement, not imposing one.

Then there is the perfect passive, and this is where the lesson earns its place. *That should have been checked before it went out.* Read that carefully: something did not happen, it is clearly a criticism, and there is **no subject anywhere in the sentence**. Nobody is accused. This is precisely the softening move from Unit 4 — drop the subject and the sting goes — but built with passive grammar rather than a modal perfect alone.

That construction is a genuine professional tool. In a post-mortem, *the figures should have been double-checked* is a statement everyone can agree with and act on. *You should have double-checked the figures* is an accusation that will be defended rather than fixed. Same content, completely different meeting. English professional culture leans on this constantly, and learners who do not have it end up sounding

harsher than they intend — not through rudeness, but because the only structure available to them requires naming somebody.

One warning. Because these forms are so impersonal, they are also the easiest place to hide. *It could have been handled better* with no agent anywhere is sometimes tact and sometimes cowardice. Know which one you are doing. If the answer is *I should have checked it*, say that — taking responsibility in the active voice is stronger than any passive, and everyone in the room can tell the difference.

WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01)

Three sentences, auxiliaries reduced:

1. Something that *is being* done right now.
2. Something that *has been* finished.
3. Something that *will be* done later.

Then: *what is a rule where you work or study?* Notice whether you said *you must...* or something else.

WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: What's the process for expenses now? **B:** Everything has to be submitted through the portal. Receipts must be attached — it gets rejected without them. **A:** Can it be done retrospectively? **B:** Up to thirty days. After that it has to be approved by a director, which takes forever. **A:** And the one from March that bounced? **B:** That should have been flagged to you at the time, honestly. It shouldn't have been left for three months. **A:** Nobody told me. **B:** No, and it should have been. That's not on you.

Count the subjects in B's sentences. There are almost none. *Everything has to be submitted. Receipts must be attached. It has to be approved. That should have been flagged.* Requirements and criticisms, and nobody named anywhere.

Then look at the last exchange. *It should have been* — three words, and it is a complete criticism of a process plus an exoneration of the person. That is the sentence to steal.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (MODAL + BE + PARTICIPLE)

The modal passive. The modal never changes; *be* stays in the base form:

modal + be + participle

Modal	Meaning	Example
must be	requirement	<i>Forms must be submitted by Friday.</i>
has to be	external requirement	<i>It has to be approved by a director.</i>
should be	recommendation	<i>It should be checked first.</i>
can be	possibility	<i>Payment can be made online.</i>
can't be	impossibility	<i>It can't be changed once submitted.</i>
needs to be	practical necessity	<i>This needs to be signed.</i>
doesn't have to be	no requirement	<i>It doesn't have to be in English.</i>

The perfect passive — for something that has been completed, or should have been:

have / has / had + been + participle — *The report **has been approved**.* **modal + have been + participle** — *That **should have been checked**.*

The four-word criticism. This is the professional payload of the lesson:

Form	Effect
<i>You should have checked it.</i>	accuses a person
<i>It should have been checked.</i>	criticises a process
<i>It should have been checked and it wasn't.</i>	states the failure, still no subject

Never *mustn't be* for a lack of requirement. This is the same asymmetry trap as Unit 5:

*It **mustn't be sent**.* = it is **forbidden** to send it. *It **doesn't have to be sent**.* = sending it is **optional**.

Two completely different meanings, and learners collapse them constantly. *Mustn't* is prohibition; *don't have to* is absence of obligation.

Where you still need an agent. If the *who* is the requirement, keep it:

*It **has to be approved by a director**.* — the *by* is the whole point.

And when to go back to the active voice. If you are taking responsibility, say so:

That should have been checked — the process failed. *I should have checked that* — I failed. Stronger, and everyone can hear the difference.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
must be submitted	<i>Forms must be submitted by Friday.</i>
has to be approved	<i>It has to be approved by a director.</i>
should be checked	<i>It should be checked first.</i>
can be done online	<i>Payment can be made online.</i>
can't be changed	<i>It can't be changed once submitted.</i>
needs to be signed	<i>This needs to be signed.</i>
doesn't have to be...	<i>It doesn't have to be in English.</i>
should have been...	<i>That should have been flagged.</i>
it shouldn't have been left	<i>It shouldn't have been left that long.</i>
that's not on you	<i>And it should have been. That's not on you.</i>

🎤 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (LONG AUXILIARY STRINGS)

should have been checked is four words before the meaning arrives. The whole front reduces to almost nothing.

Cue 1 — the string collapses:

should have been → /ʃʊdəvbɪn/ · *must have been* → /mʌstəvbɪn/ · *could have been* → /kʊdəvbɪn/ *has to be* → /hæstəbi/ · *needs to be* → /nidstəbi/

Cue 2 — one stress: the participle.

/ʃʊdəvbɪn/ **CHECKED.** · /mʌstbi/ sə**MIT**ted. · /hæstəbi/ ə***PROVED.***

Everything before the participle is a single unstressed run. If a learner stresses *should* or *been*, the sentence sounds like an accusation, which defeats the diplomatic purpose entirely.

Cue 3 — *must* is stressed in a rule. Different from the criticism: when you are stating a requirement, the modal carries weight because the strength of the obligation is the news:

*Receipts **MUST** be attached.*

So the stress moves depending on the job: **rules stress the modal, criticisms stress the participle.**

Cue 4 — the participle ending survives. /ʃʊdəvbɪn 'tʃekt/ — the /t/ is the entire verb. Lose it after a four-syllable unstressed run and there is nothing left.

 **Record two:** "Receipts must be attached." (rule — stress *must*) and "That should have been checked." (criticism — stress *checked*). Play them to a partner and ask which one sounded like a complaint.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Depersonalise the rule. Rewrite with no *you*:

1. *You must submit the form by Friday.*
2. *You have to get it approved by a manager.*
3. *You should check it before sending.*
4. *You can pay online.*
5. *You can't change it afterwards.*

B. *mustn't be* or *doesn't have to be*?

1. *It ___ translated — English is fine.* (optional)
2. *This ___ shared outside the team.* (forbidden)
3. *The form ___ printed; digital is accepted.* (optional)
4. *Confidential files ___ emailed.* (forbidden)

C. Criticise the process, not the person. Rewrite each:

1. *You didn't check the figures.*
2. *Nobody told me about the change.*
3. *They left it for three months.*
4. *You sent it without the attachment.*

D. Say the rules. Choose a real process you know — expenses, holiday requests, submitting work, a visa application — and state **four** requirements using four different modals. No *you* anywhere.

E. Take responsibility (stretch). For one item in C, give the active version where **you** are the subject. Which sounds stronger?

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak for about **forty-five seconds**. Include:

- **three** rules using different modal passives, with no *you*
- **one** *should have been* criticism of a process

At my company everything has to be logged in the system within a week. Receipts must be attached, and expenses over five hundred need to be approved by a director. Anything older than thirty days can't be claimed at all — which, honestly, should have been explained properly when the policy changed. It shouldn't have been left in a PDF nobody read.

 **Record it.** Check: is the modal stressed in the rules and the **participle** stressed in the criticism?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** modal-passive rules from your own workplace or studies.
- **Replace one *you should have...* with *it should have been...*** this week, in a real conversation. Notice that the problem gets discussed instead of defended.
- Read one policy document in English and count the passives. That register is now available to you.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **modal + be + participle** — a requirement with **no you** in it.
- ***should have been* + participle** criticises a **process**, not a person. Four words, no subject.
- ***mustn't be*** = forbidden. ***doesn't have to be*** = optional. Never confuse them.
- Keep **by** when the **who** is the requirement.
- **Rules stress the modal. Criticisms stress the participle.**
- If you are taking responsibility, **go active**. It is stronger and everyone hears it.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I stated rules with no *you* in them.
- ☐ I know the difference between *mustn't be* and *doesn't have to be*.
- ☐ I criticised a process without naming anyone.
- ☐ My criticism stressed the participle, not the modal.

- ☐ I can say when the active voice would be the better choice.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the register of every rule you'll ever be given in English

THE REPORTING PASSIVE — *IT IS SAID THAT...* / *HE IS THOUGHT TO...*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U6-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *it is believed that prices will rise*.
- Say the same thing the other way: *prices are believed to be rising*.
- Sound **objective** — and notice when someone else is using it to avoid a source. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

There is a register in English that never says *I think* and never names anybody, and you have been reading it for years without being able to produce it. *It is widely believed that...* *The company is thought to be preparing...* *Prices are expected to rise*. Journalism, research summaries, reports, analyses — all of it runs on this construction.

Its job is to present a claim as **held**, without saying who holds it. Sometimes that is because the holders are too many to list: *it is generally accepted that exercise improves sleep* — by whom? By the field. Naming them would be absurd. Sometimes it is because the source cannot be named: *he is understood to have resigned* means somebody told a journalist and that somebody will not be identified. And sometimes it is because the claim is in the air and nobody owns it: *it is said that...*

Why this matters for you specifically: it is the difference between sounding like you are giving an opinion and sounding like you are reporting a state of knowledge. In a discussion about a serious topic — which is exactly what Unit 11 and the Unit-12 benchmark will ask for — *I think remote work is more productive* is a personal claim that invites *well, I disagree*. *Remote work is generally thought to be more productive, although the evidence is mixed* is a summary of a debate, and it positions you as someone who has read about it rather than someone with a view. Both sentences might reflect the same belief. Only one of them sounds informed.

There is a second, practical benefit. It lets you talk about things you are **not certain of the source of**, which is most things. You read something six months ago and cannot remember where. *It's supposed to be the best in the city* is honest about that. *It's the best in the city* is a claim you cannot support.

Now the double edge, and you should be able to see it working in both directions. This construction can **launder** a claim. *It is believed that the policy will create jobs* might mean serious economists believe it, or it might mean the person speaking believes it and would rather not say so. The grammar looks identical.

When you hear *it is thought, it is understood, sources suggest* — the useful question is always *by whom?* Sometimes there is a good answer. Sometimes the passive is doing exactly the job it was chosen for, which is making an unsourced claim sound established.

So learn to produce it, because the register is genuinely required. And learn to hear it, because it is one of the most common ways English carries an assertion nobody has to stand behind.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE L01–L02)

Three sentences:

1. Something that *has been* done.
2. A rule with *must be*.
3. A criticism with *should have been*.

Then: *tell me something people generally believe about learning languages* — and notice how you started the sentence.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the news-style clip, then read:

PRESENTER: It is believed that interest rates will be held again next month. The decision is thought to have been made at last week's meeting, although nothing has been confirmed officially.

The company's chief executive is said to be considering her position. She is understood to have met the board on Tuesday. It has been reported that two other senior figures may follow.

Locally, the bridge is expected to reopen in March. It is estimated that the repairs will cost around forty million. The delay is widely thought to have been caused by a shortage of materials rather than by funding.

Read it again and ask the question that matters: **who** believes, thinks, says, understands, estimates any of this? The text does not tell you once. And yet nothing in it sounds evasive — because in this register the impersonality is the convention, not a dodge.

Notice two shapes appearing:

*It is believed **that** interest rates will be held.* — starts with *it* *The chief executive **is said to be** considering her position.* — starts with the person

Same construction, different starting point.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (TWO PATTERNS, ONE MEANING)

Pattern 1 — start with *it*:

It + is/was + reporting verb + that + clause

It is said that he has resigned. It is believed that prices will rise. It has been reported that two others may follow. It was thought that the bridge was safe.

Pattern 2 — start with the subject:

Subject + is/was + reporting verb + to + infinitive

He is said to have resigned. Prices are believed to be rising. She is understood to have met the board.

The transformation. Take the subject out of the *that*-clause and promote it to the front:

*It is said that **he** has resigned. → **He** is said **to have** resigned. It is thought that **she** is leaving. → **She** is thought **to be** leaving.*

Which infinitive? This is the only real difficulty, and it follows the time:

Time of the reported event	Infinitive	Example
same time as the reporting	<i>to be / to + base</i>	<i>He is said to be unwell.</i>
earlier than the reporting	<i>to have + participle</i>	<i>He is said to have resigned.</i>
ongoing	<i>to be + -ing</i>	<i>She is said to be considering it.</i>

He is said to be ill — he is ill now. He is said to have been ill — he was ill earlier.

The reporting verbs, and what each signals:

Verb	Signals
<i>is said</i>	in circulation, source unstated
<i>is believed / is thought</i>	held by many, no single source
<i>is understood</i>	a source exists and will not be named — very journalistic
<i>is reported</i>	a specific outlet said it
<i>is expected</i>	a forecast
<i>is estimated</i>	a calculation
<i>is alleged</i>	a claim, specifically an accusation, legally unproven
<i>is supposed to be</i>	informal — <i>it's supposed to be very good</i>

is alleged deserves a note: it is the verb English uses for an accusation that has not been proved, and it appears in every crime report for legal reasons. It is not a neutral synonym for *is said*.

is supposed to be is the everyday spoken version of this whole register, and the one you will use most in conversation: *it's supposed to be the best place in town*. Same job — a claim you are passing on rather than making.

Adverbs strengthen it: *widely* believed · *generally* thought · *commonly* accepted · *reportedly*.

The trap. Do not use it to dress up your own opinion:

✗ *It is believed that this is the best approach.* — believed by you, alone. ✓ *I'd argue this is the best approach.*

Passing your own view off as a general one is the misuse, and a listener who asks *by whom?* will expose it immediately.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
it is believed that...	<i>It is believed that rates will hold.</i>
it is said that...	<i>It is said that he's leaving.</i>
it is widely thought...	<i>It is widely thought to be safe.</i>
he is understood to...	<i>He is understood to have resigned.</i>
it has been reported...	<i>It has been reported that two others may follow.</i>
it is expected to...	<i>The bridge is expected to reopen in March.</i>
it is estimated that...	<i>It is estimated that repairs will cost 40 million.</i>
it is alleged that...	<i>It is alleged that funds were misused.</i>
it's supposed to be...	<i>It's supposed to be excellent.</i>
although nothing has been confirmed	<i>...although nothing has been confirmed.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE FRAME IS UNSTRESSED)

The reporting frame is scaffolding. The content is what your listener needs.

Cue 1 — the whole frame reduces to one run:

It is said that → /ɪtɪz'sedðæt/ · *It is believed that* → /ɪtɪzbɪ'livdðæt/ *is thought to have* → /ɪz'θɒttəv/ · *is understood to have* → /ɪzʌndər'stʊdtəv/

Cue 2 — stress the content, not the frame:

/ɪtɪzbɪ'livdðæt/ **RATES** will be **HELD**.

Stressing *believed* makes the belief the news, which it is not — the rates are.

Cue 3 — *that* almost disappears. /ðæt/, and in fast speech it can vanish entirely: *it's said he's resigned*.

Both are correct.

*Cue 4 — *to have is* /təv/. * Same reduction as every modal perfect in this stage:

is thought to have caused → /ɪz'θɒttəv 'kɔzd/

Cue 5 — the adverb is stressed. *It is **WIDE**ly believed* — because the adverb is the claim about how many people hold the view, and that is genuinely informative.

 **Record:** "It is widely believed that the delay was caused by a shortage of materials." Then convert it to Pattern 2 — "The delay is widely believed to have been caused by..." — and say that too.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Make it impersonal. Use Pattern 1:

1. People think the economy is recovering.
2. Everyone says the new manager is difficult.
3. Experts believe the figures are wrong.
4. They reported that the factory will close.

B. Convert to Pattern 2. Same information, subject first:

1. It is said that he has left the company.
2. It is believed that she is considering resigning.
3. It is thought that the repairs were badly done.
4. It is expected that prices will fall.

C. Choose the infinitive. *to be, to have been, or to be + -ing?*

1. He is said ____ (be) very wealthy. (now)
2. He is said ____ (be) very wealthy. (in the past)
3. She is understood ____ (consider) her position. (ongoing)
4. The delay is thought ____ (cause) by materials. (earlier, passive)

D. Which verb? *said, understood, estimated, alleged or supposed to be?*

1. A source told a journalist and won't be named.
2. A calculation produced a number.
3. An accusation that hasn't been proved in court.
4. A restaurant everyone recommends.

E. By whom? For each, decide whether the impersonal form is honest or hiding something:

1. It is generally accepted that sleep affects concentration.
2. It is believed that this is the best solution for everyone.
3. The minister is understood to have known since March.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Report **three** things impersonally — one about your field, one about your city, one about language learning. Use **both** patterns, and hedge at least one.

It is widely believed that immersion is the fastest way to learn a language, although the evidence is more mixed than people assume. Rents here are expected to rise again this year. The new line is understood to have been delayed by a funding problem, though nothing's been confirmed.

 **Record all three.** Check: is the frame unstressed, and does the content carry the stress?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** impersonal reports, using both patterns.
- **Read one news article in English and count the reporting passives.** Then ask *by whom?* of each. You will find that some have excellent answers and some have none.
- Use *it's supposed to be...* once in conversation this week. It is the spoken door into this whole register.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Pattern 1:** *It is said that he has resigned.* **Pattern 2:** *He is said to have resigned.*
- The transformation: **promote the subject** out of the *that*-clause.
- The infinitive follows the **time**: *to be* (same), *to have been* (earlier), *to be* + *-ing* (ongoing).
- *is understood* = a source exists and won't be named. *is alleged* = unproven accusation.
- *it's supposed to be* is the everyday spoken version.
- **The frame is unstressed.** And when you hear it, ask **by whom?**

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can produce both patterns from the same idea.
- ☐ I choose the infinitive by the time relation, not by guessing.
- ☐ I know what *is understood* and *is alleged* actually signal.
- ☐ I did not use the register to disguise my own opinion.
- ☐ My frame was unstressed and the content carried the weight.

Empire English 🏰 — the register of reports, and the question it invites: *by whom?*

THE CAUSATIVE: *HAVE / GET SOMETHING DONE*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U6-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Say *I had my car repaired* — not *I repaired my car*.
- Use *get* for the same job, informally.
- Talk about every service you arrange, in any tense. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

I cut my hair. In English that means you picked up scissors and did it yourself. If a barber did it — which is almost certainly what happened — the sentence is *I had my hair cut*, or *I got my hair cut*.

That gap catches nearly every learner, and it produces a particular kind of confusion: you say something perfectly grammatical that describes an event which did not occur. *I fixed my laptop* claims a repair skill you may not have. *I painted the flat* suggests a weekend with a roller rather than a phone call to a decorator. Native speakers do not misunderstand you exactly, but the sentence carries a claim you did not intend, and there is no way to correct it without the causative.

Why this matters more than it looks: this is the grammar of **arranging** things, and arranging things is most of adult life. You do not repair your car, cut your hair, service your boiler, translate your certificates, deliver your furniture or renew your passport. You have those things done. Every one of those situations needs this structure, and without it you are stuck either claiming to have done everything yourself or producing long paraphrases — *a man came and he repaired my car* — which are correct and clumsy.

There is a professional register too, and it is quietly useful. *We're having the figures verified externally. I'll get it looked at. We had the contract reviewed by a lawyer.* Each one states that work is being done and — like every passive in this unit — declines to make the doer the subject. The focus stays on the thing and on the fact that you arranged it, which is usually exactly the point. *I'll get it looked at* is one of the most useful sentences in professional English: it commits you to an action without committing you to doing it yourself.

The choice between *have* and *get* is worth knowing because it is about register, not meaning. *I had my car serviced* is neutral. *I got my car serviced* is slightly more informal and more common in speech, especially in American English. And *get* carries a faint sense of effort or arranging — *I need to get it fixed* sounds more like a task on a list than *I need to have it fixed*.

One genuine second meaning to be aware of. The same structure can describe something **unpleasant that happened to you**: *I had my phone stolen. She had her flight cancelled.* Nobody arranged anything. Here the structure means you were on the receiving end, and the difference is entirely in whether the event is something anyone would want.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE PASSIVE)

Three sentences, fast:

1. Something that *is being* done to your street or building.
2. A rule with *must be*.
3. Something that *has been* finished recently.

Then: *when did you last go to a barber or hairdresser?* Say what happened, in one sentence.

WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read:

A: You look different. **B:** I got my hair cut. Finally. **A:** And the car? Is it back? **B:** Yeah, I had it serviced last week — they found about four things wrong with it. **A:** Expensive? **B:** Enough. I'm having the brakes done next month, which I'm not looking forward to. **A:** Did you sort the flat out in the end? **B:** Half of it. We've had the kitchen painted and we're getting the windows replaced in the spring. I'd have had it all done at once if I'd had the money. **A:** How's your brother after the trip? **B:** Fine, but he had his bag stolen at the airport. Sorted now.

Look at the last line. *He had his bag stolen* — nobody arranged that. Same structure, and the meaning is *this happened to him*. Everything else in the dialogue is a service he paid for.

And note the shape in every single one: *have / get* → *the thing* → *the participle*. The object always sits in the middle.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (HAVE / GET + OBJECT + PARTICIPLE)

The shape — and the object goes in the middle:

have / get + something + past participle

✓	✗
<i>I had my car repaired.</i>	<i>I had repaired my car.</i>
<i>I'm getting the windows replaced.</i>	<i>I'm getting replaced the windows.</i>

That second column is the error. *I had repaired my car* is a past perfect and means you did the repairing yourself, earlier. The object **must** separate the auxiliary from the participle. If you remember one thing, remember the sandwich.

Self against service:

You did it	Someone did it for you
<i>I cut my hair.</i>	<i>I had my hair cut.</i>
<i>I fixed the laptop.</i>	<i>I got the laptop fixed.</i>
<i>We painted the kitchen.</i>	<i>We had the kitchen painted.</i>
<i>I translated the documents.</i>	<i>I had the documents translated.</i>

It works in every tense, because only *have* or *get* conjugates:

Tense	Example
present	<i>I have my car serviced every year.</i>
present continuous	<i>I'm having the brakes done next month.</i>
past	<i>I had it serviced last week.</i>
present perfect	<i>We've had the kitchen painted.</i>
future	<i>I'll get it looked at.</i>
infinitive	<i>I need to get my passport renewed.</i>
third conditional	<i>I'd have had it all done at once.</i>

have or get? Same meaning, different register:

have — neutral, slightly more formal. *We had the contract reviewed.* **get** — more informal, more common in speech, and carries a faint sense of arranging or effort. *I need to get it fixed.*

In an imperative or a to-do context, *get* is far more natural: *get it checked*, not *have it checked*.

The second meaning — something unpleasant happened to you:

I had my phone stolen. · She had her flight cancelled. · They had their offer rejected.

Nobody arranged these. The structure here means **you were affected**, and you can tell which meaning is intended by whether anyone would want it.

The agent, when it matters:

*We had the contract reviewed **by a lawyer**.* — the *by* is the reassurance.

Related but different — *have someone do something*:

*I had the plumber **look** at it.* — base form, and the person is named.

This is worth recognising, not drilling. The participle version is the one you need.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I had my hair cut	<i>I had my hair cut yesterday.</i>
I got it fixed	<i>I got the laptop fixed.</i>
I'm having it done	<i>I'm having the brakes done next month.</i>
I need to get... done	<i>I need to get my passport renewed.</i>
I'll get it looked at	<i>I'll get it looked at.</i>
we've had ... painted	<i>We've had the kitchen painted.</i>
serviced	<i>I had the car serviced.</i>
replaced	<i>We're getting the windows replaced.</i>
translated	<i>I had the documents translated.</i>
I had my phone stolen	<i>He had his bag stolen at the airport.</i>
reviewed by a lawyer	<i>We had it reviewed by a lawyer.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THREE BEATS, STRESS ON THE PARTICIPLE)

Cue 1 — the participle carries the stress. *have* or *get* is unstressed; the object is light; the participle lands:

*I had my hair **CUT**. · I'm getting the windows re***PLACED**.* · I'll get it **LOOKED** at.*

If a learner stresses *had*, it sounds like a past perfect and the service meaning is lost.

Cue 2 — the participle ending must survive. This is where the structure dies:

cut · fixed /t/ · painted /ɪd/ · replaced /t/ · serviced /t/ · renewed /d/

I had it paint is nothing. The *-ed* is the verb.

Cue 3 — have reduces hard. /aɪd/ in the past, /aɪv/ in the perfect, /aɪl get/ in the future:

I'd had it done → /aɪd hædɪt 'dʌn/ · I've had it done → /aɪv hædɪt 'dʌn/

Cue 4 — get keeps its /t/, but links forward. *get it looked at → /getɪt 'lʊktət/*. The /t/s join the following vowels; nothing is dropped, everything is connected.

Cue 5 — the unpleasant meaning is slower and lower. *I had my phone stolen* delivered briskly sounds like you arranged it. Slowed slightly, the meaning is unmistakable.



Record the contrast pair: "I cut my hair" and "I had my hair cut." Then: "I'm having the brakes done next month." Check the participle endings.



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Self or service? Which is true for you? Say the correct sentence:

1. cut / hair · 2. repair / car · 3. clean / flat · 4. translate / documents · 5. fill / tooth

B. Fix the word order.

1. *I had repaired my car last week.*
2. *We're getting replaced the windows.*
3. *She had cut her hair yesterday.*
4. *I need to get renewed my passport.*

C. Change the tense. Take *I have my car serviced* and put it into:

1. last week · 2. next month (arranged) · 3. every year · 4. already, this year · 5. I need to...

D. Arranged or unfortunate? Say which meaning each has:

1. *She had her flight cancelled.*
2. *She had her kitchen redone.*
3. *They had their offer rejected.*
4. *They had the contract reviewed.*

E. Your real logistics. Name **five** things you have had done, are having done, or need to get done in the next month.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** things about services, using **different tenses** and at least one *get*:

I had my laptop repaired last month — it cost almost as much as a new one. We're having the flat repainted in the spring. I still need to get my documents translated before the application closes.

Then add one of the unpleasant kind, if you have one: *I had my bike stolen last year.*

 **Record all of them.** Check: is the object in the **middle**, and can you hear every participle ending?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** causative sentences about real services.
- **Use *I'll get it looked at this week*** if the chance comes up. It is one of the most useful sentences in professional English — a commitment to an action without a commitment to doing it yourself.
- Catch yourself claiming credit. Next time you nearly say *I fixed it*, ask whether you actually did.

REMEMBER — افكر

- ***have / get* + the thing + participle.** The object goes **in the middle**.
- *I cut my hair* = **you** did it. *I had my hair cut* = **someone else** did.
- Only ***have or get*** conjugates — it works in every tense.
- ***get*** is more informal and more natural in a to-do context. ***have*** is neutral.
- Second meaning: *I had my phone **stolen*** — something happened **to** you.
- **Stress the participle**, and keep the *-ed*. *I had it paint* is nothing.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ My object always sits between *have/get* and the participle.
- ☐ I can say the contrast pair and hear the difference.

- ☐ I used the structure in at least two tenses.
 - ☐ I know when *get* sounds more natural than *have*.
 - ☐ I can spot the *something happened to me* meaning.
 - ☐ My participle endings survived.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the grammar of everything you arrange rather than do

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: DESCRIBE A SYSTEM OR SERVICE 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 6 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) · Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit6-passive-advanced.md` · **S3-U6-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you explain how something works:

- ~**2 minutes** on a real system or service
- the passive in **three tenses**, a **modal passive** rule, a **causative**
- clear **participle endings** at speed
- then answer clarifying questions 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each, auxiliaries reduced:

1. Something that *is being* done right now.
2. A rule: *must be* or *has to be*.
3. An impersonal report: *it is believed that...*
4. A service: *I had / I'm getting ... done*.
5. A process criticism: *it should have been...*

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model description, then read. The structures are marked:

[WHAT IT IS] So the way expenses work at my company — everything goes through one portal now.

[MODAL PASSIVE — THE RULE] Anything you spend has to be logged within thirty days, and receipts must be attached. **[MODAL PASSIVE — NEGATIVE]** Claims can't be edited once they've been submitted, which catches everybody at least once.

[PASSIVE — PRESENT] Each claim is checked automatically first, and then **[PASSIVE — PRESENT CONTINUOUS]** anything over five hundred is being reviewed manually at the moment because of an audit. **[PASSIVE — PERFECT]** Mine's been sitting in that queue for three weeks.

[CAUSATIVE] For bigger things you have to get them pre-approved — so last month I had the equipment order signed off before I bought anything.

[PASSIVE — FUTURE] Apparently the whole system will be replaced next year. **[REPORTING PASSIVE]** It's said to be much faster, though nobody's seen it.

[PROCESS CRITIQUE] Honestly, the thirty-day rule should have been explained properly when it changed. It shouldn't have been left in a PDF.

Then the clarifying exchange:

A: Sorry — is the thirty days from when you spend, or when you claim? **B:** From when you spend. The claim has to be **in** by day thirty, not started. **A:** And what happens after thirty days? **B:** It has to be approved by a director, which in practice means it doesn't get approved.

Count the passives: seven, across four tenses, plus a causative and a reporting passive. And notice that **nobody is named anywhere** — no *they*, no *the finance team*. The description is about the system.

Then look at the clarifying answers. B does not repeat the original sentence; B **re-explains the specific point** and adds the distinction that was missing. That is the skill.

THE UNIT-6 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	passive — present or present continuous	<i>Each claim is checked automatically.</i>
2	passive — perfect or past	<i>Mine's been sitting there three weeks.</i>
3	passive — future	<i>The system will be replaced next year.</i>
4	a modal passive rule	<i>Receipts must be attached.</i>
5	a causative	<i>I had the order signed off.</i>
6	clear participle endings throughout	<i>check*ed · attacheded · replaced*</i>

Item 6 is not a stylistic nicety — it is the verb. Under a two-minute load, in long auxiliary strings, the *-ed* is the first thing to go, and *has been check* is not a sentence.

Stretch: add a reporting passive (*it's said to be...*) and a *should have been* critique.

ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (WEAK STRINGS, HARD ENDINGS)

Everyone — the auxiliary string reduces to one run:

/əzbiɪn/ (has been) · /ɪzbiɪŋ/ (is being) · /ʃʊdəvbiɪn/ (should have been) · /hæstəbi/ (has to be)

Everyone — one stress per clause, on the participle:

/əzbɪn/ **SENT.** · /ʃʊdənbɪn/ **CHECKED.** · /ɪzbɪŋ/ ri***VIEWED.***

Everyone — the endings survive. The three -ed sounds, back from Stage 1 and doing critical work here:

checked /t/ · attached /t/ · logged /d/ · reviewed /d/ · submitted /ɪd/ · replaced /t/

Everyone — been is /bɪn/, unstressed, present. Drop it and *has been sent* becomes *has sent* — passive becomes active and the meaning changes.

Everyone — rules stress the modal, criticisms stress the participle. Receipts **MUST** be attached against that should have been **CHECKED**.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker, one cue, one sentence, stop.

 **Record before the task:** "Each claim has been checked and anything over five hundred is being reviewed." Play it to a partner and ask them to write down the two participles. If they cannot, the endings are not there.

TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + CLARIFYING QUESTIONS)

Round 1 — plan, don't script. Two minutes, six bullets, no sentences: what the system is, one rule, what happens now, what has already happened, what will happen, one thing you have had done within it.

Round 2 — explain it. In pairs, two minutes each. The listener's job is to **not understand something** and say so. They must ask **two** genuine clarifying questions:

Sorry — is that from when you spend or when you claim? · Who actually does that? What happens if you miss it? · Is that automatic or does someone check it? How long does that usually take? · Can it be changed afterwards?

Round 3 — re-explain, don't repeat. The speaker must answer by **rephrasing**, not by saying the same sentence again. Adding the missing distinction is the skill.

Round 4 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver the weakest thirty seconds with the endings corrected.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** describing a real system or service, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **one live clarifying question** by rephrasing rather than repeating.

 **Save this recording.** This is your most professionally transferable two minutes so far — explaining how something works, impersonally and precisely, is a large part of what Unit 10 assesses.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your system or service description.
- Complete the **Unit-6 quiz** — passive across tenses, modal and perfect passives, both reporting-passive patterns, and the causative word order.
- **Explain one process to someone in English this week** and let them interrupt you. Answering the interruption is the part that improves.
- Say /əzbn/ until it is automatic. It is the most frequent passive in the language.

REMEMBER — افكر

- One engine: **be in any tense + participle**. Only *be* moves.
- **modal + be + participle** states a rule with **no you** in it.
- **should have been** criticises a **process**, not a person.
- **have / get + the thing + participle** — object in the **middle**.
- Choose the passive for a **reason**: unknown, obvious, or irrelevant doer. Otherwise go active.
- **Squeeze the auxiliaries, land on the participle, keep the -ed.**

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes, unscripted, in English.
- ☐ I used at least three passive tenses, each for a reason.
- ☐ I stated one rule with no *you* in it.
- ☐ I used a causative with the object in the middle.
- ☐ A partner could write down my participles from the recording.
- ☐ I answered a clarifying question by rephrasing, not repeating.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 6 complete — precision, and the whole structures-for-professionalism set



STAGE 3 · UNIT 7

RELATIVE CLAUSES (ADVANCED)

👑 UNIT 7 — RELATIVE CLAUSES (ADVANCED)

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · **Unit 7 of 12** Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: pack detail into one sentence instead of three — and keep your listener with you while you do it.

This unit is about ranking information. Deciding what is your point and what is context, then building a sentence that shows the difference. It is the clearest single marker of a speaker who has stopped assembling sentences one idea at a time.

Half of it is pronunciation, and that is not a metaphor. In writing you mark these clauses with commas. **In speech there are no commas** — there is a pause, a pitch dip, and a return. A learner with perfect clause grammar and no pauses has not learned this unit, because the prosody is what carries the meaning.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Non-defining clauses	tuck extra information into the middle of a sentence and get out again
L02	Defining or non-defining	the comma that changes how many sisters you have
L03	Reduced relatives	<i>the man standing there</i> — the cheapest naturalness upgrade in the stage
L04	Prepositions + <i>which/whom</i> , and sentential <i>which</i>	<i>..., which meant we had to start again</i>
L05	Unit task 🎙️	2 minutes of rich, layered description — and the pauses to match

Grammar spine: non-defining clauses (*who/which*, no *that*, no omission, commas both sides) · the defining/non-defining meaning distinction · reduced relatives, active *-ing* against passive *-ed* · preposition placement across registers · *which* referring to a whole clause. **Accent Lab:** the **spoken comma** — pause, pitch dip, return · **no break at all** inside a defining or reduced clause · the pause before sentential *which* · participle endings surviving at speed · unstressed end-position prepositions. **Mindset:** adding detail without losing the listener — richness and clarity together. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- The ability to say in **one** sentence what you used to say in three.
 - ..., **which meant...** — stating a fact and its significance in a single breath.
 - Sentences that sound like an adult telling you something, rather than a form being filled in.
-

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** non-defining clauses (commas, *who/which*, no *that*, no omission) · the defining against non-defining meaning distinction · reduced relatives (*-ing* against *-ed*) · preposition + *which/whom* · sentential *which* and the *what* error.
 - **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute rich description plus one clarifying question, scored on the B2 rubric.
 - **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **clause pausing and intonation** (a named U12 clinic input), participle clarity, and a note of anyone stuffing clauses at the cost of clarity.
-

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 8 — REPORTED SPEECH (ADVANCED)

beyond *said* and *told*: the reporting-verb range, the patterns each verb takes, and how to report a meeting or a negotiation accurately enough to be quoted on it.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · in speech the comma is a pause, and it carries the meaning

NON-DEFINING RELATIVE CLAUSES — ADDING DETAIL WITH COMMAS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 7 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 defining relatives
 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md` · **S3-U7-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *my brother, who lives in Cairo, is a doctor.*
- Drop extra detail into the **middle** of a sentence and get out again.
- Hear the **pause** that does the job of a comma. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You already have relative clauses from B1. *The man who lives next door. The book that I lent you.* Those clauses do a specific job: they tell your listener **which** one you mean. Take them away and the sentence stops making sense — *the man* is nobody in particular.

This lesson is about the other kind, and it does the opposite job. *My brother, who lives in Cairo, is a doctor.* The clause is not identifying anybody. I have told you which brother by saying *my brother*; the extra information is simply extra. Remove it and the sentence still works perfectly: *my brother is a doctor.* That is what makes it **non-defining** — it adds, it does not identify.

Why bother, if the sentence works without it? Because this is the single most efficient way English packs information, and its absence is one of the clearest markers of a learner still building sentences one idea at a time. Compare:

I have a brother. He lives in Cairo. He's a doctor. My brother, who lives in Cairo, is a doctor.

Same content. The first is three sentences and sounds like a form being filled in. The second is one sentence with a main point and a piece of background tucked inside it — which is how adults actually speak. At B2 you are being assessed on whether you can subordinate information: decide what is the point and what is context, and structure the sentence to show it. Non-defining clauses are the main tool for that.

There is a professional version that appears constantly. *The client, who we've worked with for years, wants to renegotiate. The deadline, which was already tight, has moved.* In both cases the extra clause is doing quiet argumentative work — it is telling you why this matters — without interrupting the sentence. That is a sophisticated move and it costs nothing once you can hear the shape.

And here is the part that is genuinely difficult, and it is not the grammar. In writing you mark this with commas. **In speech there are no commas.** There is a small pause before, a drop in pitch through the clause, and a return to normal pitch afterwards. If you say *my brother who lives in Cairo is a doctor* as one flat run, you have said something different — you have implied you have several brothers and are identifying one of them. The prosody carries the meaning. That is why half of this lesson is in the Accent Lab, and why learners who master the punctuation and skip the pause still sound wrong.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE THE BI DEFINING CLAUSE)

Three sentences, fast:

1. The person **who** ____.
2. The place **where** ____.
3. The thing **that** ____.

Now say: *I have one sister.* Then add, in one sentence, where she lives and what she does.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip. **Listen for the pauses** — they are marked here with // :

A: Who's taking over the account? **B:** Layla // who joined in March // is doing it. She used to work at their agency // which is why they asked for her. **A:** Is that the client who complained last year? **B:** That's the one. Their new marketing director // who I actually quite like // has completely changed the brief. **A:** Great. **B:** The deadline // which was already unrealistic // has moved forward two weeks. **A:** And Layla knows? **B:** She knows. Her husband // who's a lawyer // told her to get it in writing.

Every clause between the double slashes could be deleted and every sentence would survive. That is the test.

Now notice one that is **not** marked: *the client **who complained** last year* — no pauses. That one is identifying which client, so it is a defining clause, which is L02's lesson. Even in a short dialogue both kinds appear, and only the voice tells them apart.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (EXTRA INFORMATION, SET OFF BOTH SIDES)

What it does: adds information that is **not needed** to identify anything.

My brother, who lives in Cairo, is a doctor. Delete the clause → *My brother is a doctor.* Still complete.
Non-defining.

Where it goes. Two positions:

Position	Example
in the middle — commas both sides	<i>Layla, who joined in March, is doing it.</i>
at the end — one comma	<i>I spoke to Layla, who joined in March.</i>

If it sits in the middle, you need **both** commas. One comma is the commonest written error.

Three rules, and these really are rules:

1. Use *who* or *which*. Never *that*.

✓ My brother, **who** lives in Cairo... · ✗ My brother, **that** lives in Cairo... ✓ The deadline, **which** was already tight... · ✗ The deadline, **that** was already tight...

2. You cannot omit the pronoun.

✓ My boss, **who** I met last year, is leaving. · ✗ My boss, I met last year, is leaving.

In a defining clause you often can drop it — *the book I lent you* — but never here.

3. It goes with something already identified: a name, *my* + family member, a unique thing.

Cairo, which I've never visited... · *My mother, who's a teacher...* · *The CEO, who's new...*

What the clause can refer to:

Pronoun	For
<i>who</i>	people
<i>which</i>	things
<i>whose</i>	possession — <i>my neighbour, whose car was stolen...</i>
<i>where</i>	places — <i>Alexandria, where I grew up...</i>
<i>when</i>	times — <i>2020, when everything closed...</i>

Why it earns its place. It lets you rank information. The **main clause** is your point; the **non-defining clause** is context:

The deadline, which was already unrealistic, has moved forward two weeks. Point: the deadline

moved. Context: it was already bad. One sentence, two levels.

And the discipline. One extra clause per sentence. Two is a stretch. Three and your listener has lost the main verb:

✗ *My brother, who lives in Cairo, which is a city I've never liked, who works as a doctor, is visiting.*

If you cannot find your own main clause, neither can anyone else.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
..., who joined in March, ...	<i>Layla, who joined in March, is doing it.</i>
..., which was already tight, ...	<i>The deadline, which was already tight, has moved.</i>
..., whose ...	<i>My neighbour, whose car was stolen, is furious.</i>
..., where I grew up, ...	<i>Alexandria, where I grew up, has changed.</i>
..., when everything closed, ...	<i>2020, when everything closed, was strange.</i>
which is why...	<i>She worked there, which is why they asked for her.</i>
who I actually quite like	<i>Their director, who I actually quite like, changed it.</i>
..., none of which...	<i>Three emails, none of which were answered.</i>
..., most of whom...	<i>Twelve people, most of whom left early.</i>

🎤 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE SPOKEN COMMA)

There are no commas in speech. There is a pause, a pitch dip, and a return. That is the entire mechanism, and it is what this lesson lives or dies on.

Cue 1 — the three-part shape. Say the sentence and let your voice do this:

My brother 🗡️ (small pause) — who lives in Cairo — (low, level, slightly faster) (pause) — is a doctor. 🗡️

The clause sits **lower** than the main sentence and moves **slightly faster**. Then you come back up to finish. It is the sound of a parenthesis, and it is the same move you used for a flashback in U2-L03.

Cue 2 — get back out. The second pause is the one learners drop. Without it the clause bleeds into the main verb and the sentence has no shape:

✗ *My brother who lives in Cairo is a doctor* — one flat run. Now it identifies a brother. ✓ *My brother // who lives in Cairo // is a doctor.*

Cue 3 — do not stress inside the clause. The extra information is extra. If you push *CAIRO*, you have made the background the point.

Cue 4 — which is why takes a pause before it and carries a small fall:

She used to work there // which is why they asked for her. 🔊

Perception test. These two are identical on paper without the commas, and completely different in meaning:

My sister who lives in Dubai is a doctor. — I have several sisters. *My sister // who lives in Dubai // is a doctor.* — I have one.

🔊 **Record both versions.** Play them to a partner and ask: *how many sisters do I have?* If they cannot tell, the prosody is not there.

🏋️ TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Add the extra information. One sentence, non-defining clause in the middle:

1. *My manager ____ is leaving.* (she's been here twelve years)
2. *Cairo ____ is enormous.* (I visited it last year)
3. *The report ____ arrived this morning.* (we've been waiting weeks for it)
4. *My neighbour ____ never says hello.* (his dog barks all night)

B. The delete test. Which of these clauses can be removed without breaking the sentence? Mark it non-defining and add the commas:

1. *The woman who called yesterday left a message.*
2. *My father who is seventy still works.*
3. *The email that you forwarded was the wrong one.*
4. *Alexandria which is on the coast is cooler.*

C. Fix the error.

1. *My brother, that lives in Cairo, is a doctor.*
2. *My boss, I met last year, is leaving.*

3. *The deadline which was already tight, has moved.*
4. *Layla who joined in March is doing it. (she's the only Layla)*

D. Rank the information. Turn each set of three sentences into **one**, with the main point in the main clause:

1. *The client wants to renegotiate. We've worked with them for years. They're our biggest account.*
2. *The system is being replaced. It's fifteen years old. Nobody likes it.*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Say **three** sentences with non-defining clauses, about real people or places. Pause both sides.

My oldest friend, who I've known since we were six, has just moved to Canada. My last job, which I stayed in far too long, taught me a lot anyway. Alexandria, where my mother grew up, is completely different now.

 **Record all three.** Then play one to a partner and ask them to tell you where the clause started and stopped.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** non-defining sentences about people you know.
- **Combine before you speak.** Once a day, catch yourself about to say three short sentences and put the middle one inside the first. That habit alone will change how your English sounds.
- Listen for the dip in podcasts. Once you hear the parenthesis, you cannot un-hear it.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Non-defining = **extra**, not identifying. Apply the **delete test**: does the sentence survive?
- **who** and **which**. **Never that**. Never omit the pronoun.
- **Commas both sides** if it sits in the middle.
- It lets you **rank information**: main clause = your point, clause = context.
- In speech there is **no comma — there is a pause and a pitch dip**, and you must get back out.
- **One extra clause per sentence**. Two is a stretch. Three is lost.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can apply the delete test to decide which kind of clause I have.

- ☐ I used *who* or *which*, never *that*.
 - ☐ I paused on **both** sides, not just the first.
 - ☐ I did not stress anything inside the clause.
 - ☐ A partner could hear where my clause began and ended.
 - ☐ I turned three short sentences into one, with the right main point.
-

Empire English 🏰 — in speech the comma is a pause, and it carries the meaning

DEFINING OR NON-DEFINING — THE COMMA THAT CHANGES THE MEANING

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 7 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U7-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Ask the one question that decides it: **does the clause identify, or just add?**
- Hear the difference between *my sister who...* and *my sister, who...*
- Explain why one comma changes how many sisters you have. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Consider two sentences that differ by two commas:

My sister who lives in Dubai is a doctor. My sister, who lives in Dubai, is a doctor.

The first tells you I have **more than one sister**, and that I am specifying which one — the Dubai one, as opposed to the others. The second tells you I have **exactly one sister**, and mentions in passing that she lives in Dubai. The information about my family is different, and the only thing that changed is punctuation.

That is unusual and worth pausing on. Most punctuation in English is about clarity or convention — where you put a comma in a list rarely changes what is true. Here it does. The comma is carrying propositional content: it is asserting something about how many sisters exist. This is one of a very small number of places where getting a comma wrong makes a sentence **false** rather than merely awkward.

Which brings us to why this matters practically. In writing, the consequences are small but real: *the employees who were consulted supported the change* means some employees were consulted and those ones agreed. *The employees, who were consulted, supported the change* means **all** the employees were consulted and all agreed. In a report, in a summary, in an email about a decision — those are different claims and a reader will act on the difference.

In speech the stakes are higher, because the pause is easier to get wrong than a comma. If you flatten a non-defining clause into the sentence, you have accidentally implied a contrast that was not there. *My manager who's been here twelve years is leaving* sounds like you are distinguishing her from a newer manager. You probably have one manager. Native listeners will not stop you, but they will have received a slightly different picture than the one you meant.

The good news is that you do not need to remember rules about commas at all. There is a single question, and it works every time: **does the clause tell your listener which one you mean?** If yes, it is defining — no commas, no pauses, and you may use *that*. If it merely adds something, it is non-defining — commas, pauses, and never *that*. The punctuation follows automatically from the meaning, which is why teaching this the other way round produces confident errors.

One more reason to get this right. Nouns that are **already unique** cannot take a defining clause, because there is nothing to distinguish. *My mother, Cairo, the CEO, 2020*, anybody's name — these are already identified, so any clause about them must be non-defining. That single observation resolves most real cases before you have to think.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE L01)

Two sentences with **non-defining** clauses — extra information only, pauses both sides.

Then one with a **defining** clause from B1 — no pauses. Say them one after the other and listen to the difference in your own voice.

WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip. Two speakers, and the difference matters:

A: How many people did you interview? **B:** Four. The candidate who had agency experience was much stronger. **A:** So you're hiring her? **B:** Probably. Although the candidate, who's currently in Dubai, would need a visa — so it's complicated. **A:** Wait — same person? **B:** Same person, yes. Sorry.

Look at what B did. First sentence: *the candidate who had agency experience* — no pauses, because it identifies which of the four. Second sentence: *the candidate, who's currently in Dubai* — pauses, because by now we know which candidate and the visa detail is extra. **Same noun, two clause types, in consecutive sentences**, and the switch is entirely appropriate.

Now the other pair:

A: Did the team agree? **B:** The engineers who were consulted agreed. Nobody asked the rest. **A:** And the designers? **B:** The designers, who were all consulted, hated it.

The engineers who were consulted — only some were. *The designers, who were all consulted* — all of them. The clause type is doing real work: it tells you how much of the group is being talked about.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (ONE QUESTION DECIDES IT)

The question:

Does the clause tell me WHICH one? Yes → defining. **No, it just adds something** → non-defining.

Job	identifies which one	adds extra information
Commas / pauses	none	both sides
<i>that</i> allowed?	yes	no
Can omit the pronoun?	often, if it's the object	never
Delete test	sentence breaks	sentence survives

The pair, side by side:

*My sister **who lives in Dubai** is a doctor.* → I have several sisters. This is the Dubai one. *My sister, **who lives in Dubai**,* is a doctor.** → I have one sister. She happens to live in Dubai.

Already-unique nouns can only take non-defining clauses. There is nothing to distinguish:

*My mother, **who's a teacher**, ...* — I have one mother. *Cairo, **which is enormous**, ...* — there is one Cairo. *Layla, **who joined in March**, ...* — a name is already unique. ✗ *Layla **who joined in March**...* — implies there are several Laylas and you are picking one.

This single rule settles most real sentences immediately.

How much of the group? This is where it bites hardest:

*The employees **who were consulted** supported it.* — **some** were consulted; those ones agreed. *The employees, **who were consulted**,* supported it.** — **all** were consulted, and all agreed.

In a report those are different facts.

Both types can appear about the same noun in consecutive sentences, as in the clip. Nothing is fixed about a noun; it depends on whether your listener already knows which one you mean.

Where *that* is a signal. If you see or hear *that*, the clause is defining. It cannot be otherwise:

*The report **that arrived this morning**...* — defining, necessarily.

That makes *that* useful as a diagnostic when you are reading.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
the one who...	<i>The candidate who had experience was stronger.</i>
..., who happens to...	<i>My sister, who happens to live in Dubai, is a doctor.</i>
the ones that...	<i>The files that were corrupted are gone.</i>
all of whom	<i>The designers, all of whom were consulted, hated it.</i>
some of whom	<i>Twelve people, some of whom left early.</i>
which means...	<i>..., which means we start again.</i>
specifically	<i>Do you mean specifically the Dubai one?</i>
as opposed to	<i>The Dubai one, as opposed to the others.</i>
just to be clear	<i>Just to be clear — I have one sister.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PAUSE OR NO PAUSE IS THE MEANING)

Cue 1 — the two versions, back to back. Practise until you can produce either on demand:

My sister who lives in Dubai is a doctor. — one continuous run, no break anywhere. *My sister // who lives in Dubai // is a doctor.* — two breaks, clause lower and slightly faster.

Cue 2 — a defining clause has NO break at all. Not even a small one. Learners inserting a courtesy pause before every relative clause turn defining clauses into non-defining ones by accident, which is the commonest error here.

Cue 3 — the defining clause can carry stress. Because it is doing identifying work, the distinguishing word takes weight:

*The candidate who had **AG**ency experience was stronger.* — as opposed to the others.

In a non-defining clause you do the opposite: no stress inside it.

Cue 4 — if you need to be unambiguous, say so. Native speakers do this too:

My sister — I've only got one — lives in Dubai. Do you mean specifically the Dubai one?

Clarifying out loud is fluent behaviour, not a failure.



Record the pair. Play both to a partner and ask, for each: *how many sisters?* Then swap. If either version is misread, work the pauses before moving on.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Defining or non-defining? Ask the question. Add commas where needed:

1. *My father who is a teacher retires next year.* (I have one father)
2. *The students who attended the workshop passed.* (only some attended)
3. *Alexandria which is on the coast is cooler.*
4. *The email that you sent yesterday never arrived.*
5. *Layla who joined in March is running it.*

B. What does it mean? Explain the difference:

1. *My colleagues who work remotely prefer it.* / *My colleagues, who work remotely, prefer it.*
2. *The changes that were approved take effect Monday.* / *The changes, which were approved, take effect Monday.*

C. Some or all? Which clause type do you need?

1. All twelve people were invited, and all twelve came.
2. Only three of the twelve were invited; those three came.
3. Every file was backed up, and every file survived.
4. Only the backed-up files survived.

D. Say it both ways. Take *my brother lives in Canada* and produce:

1. a version implying you have **several** brothers
2. a version implying you have **one**

Then have your partner tell you which was which, from your voice alone.



YOUR TURN — دورك

Produce **one of each**, about your own life, and **explain the difference** between them:

My cousin who lives in Germany is getting married. — I have several cousins; this is the German one.
My cousin, who lives in Germany, is getting married. — I have one cousin, and she happens to live in

Germany.

Then say which one is true for you, and why.



Record both. Check: is there genuinely **no** pause in the defining version?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a defining sentence, a non-defining one, and **the meaning difference** between them.
- **Check one thing you write this week.** Find a relative clause and ask: does it identify, or add? Then check your commas match.
- Listen for the some/all distinction. Once you hear it, you will notice how often it decides what a sentence actually claims.



REMEMBER — افكر

- One question: **does the clause tell me WHICH one?** Yes → defining. No → non-defining.
- **Punctuation follows meaning**, never the reverse.
- **Already-unique nouns** — names, *my mother*, *Cairo* — can only take **non-defining** clauses.
- The clause type says **how much of the group**: *the employees who were consulted* = some. *The employees, who were consulted,* = all.
- **that** is only possible in a **defining** clause. It is a useful diagnostic.
- A **defining clause has no pause at all** — not even a courtesy one.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I ask the meaning question before I think about commas.
- ☐ I know why a name cannot take a defining clause.
- ☐ I can explain the some/all consequence with an example.
- ☐ My defining clauses have no pause anywhere.
- ☐ A partner could tell my two versions apart from my voice.

Empire English 🏰 — one of the few commas in English that changes what is true

REDUCED RELATIVE CLAUSES — *THE MAN STANDING THERE · THE REPORT WRITTEN BY X*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 7 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U7-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Turn *the man **who is** standing there* into *the man standing there*.
- Choose **-ing** or **-ed** correctly, every time.
- Describe a scene in half the words. 🎙️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

This lesson does not add a structure. It **removes** words from a structure you already have, and the result sounds dramatically more natural.

*The woman **who is** talking to Ali is my manager.* → *The woman talking to Ali is my manager.* *The book **which was** written in 1990 is still the best one.* → *The book written in 1990 is still the best one.*

Two words gone in each case, no meaning lost. And here is the thing worth knowing: in real English, the reduced version is **more common than the full one**. Native speakers reduce automatically, constantly, without noticing. Learners produce the full form, which is correct and immediately identifiable as careful non-native English.

So this is the cheapest naturalness upgrade available to you at B2. You are not learning anything new. You are learning to delete two words you were already saying, and the effect on how you sound is out of all proportion to the effort.

There is a comprehension payoff too, and it is larger. Because reduced relatives look nothing like relative clauses — there is no *who*, no *which*, no *that* — they are genuinely hard to parse if you have never studied them. *The proposals submitted before Friday will be considered.* Where is the verb of that sentence? A learner unfamiliar with reductions reads *proposals submitted* and expects the sentence to be about somebody submitting something. The actual main verb is *will be considered*. Academic and professional English is dense with this pattern, and until you can see it, long sentences will keep collapsing on you.

The professional register uses it heavily for exactly the reason that Unit 6's passive existed: it lets you attach information to a noun without a full clause. *The changes agreed at the last meeting. Anyone*

wanting to attend. The figures used in the forecast. Each of those is a compressed clause, and the compression is what makes professional prose feel tight rather than padded.

The one real difficulty is the *-ing* / *-ed* choice, and it maps onto something you already know. If the noun is **doing** the action, use *-ing* — that is the active reduction. If the noun is **having it done** to it, use *-ed* — that is the passive reduction, and it is the participle from Unit 6 doing the same job in a shorter frame. *The man carrying the boxes* is carrying. *The boxes carried by the man* are being carried. Once you see it as active against passive rather than as two endings, it stops being arbitrary.



WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE BOTH CLAUSE TYPES)

Fast round:

1. A **defining** clause — no pauses.
2. A **non-defining** clause — pauses both sides.
3. The question that tells them apart, said aloud.

Then look at your defining sentence and try to say it in **two fewer words**.



WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. The reductions are in bold:

A: Which one's your manager? **B:** The woman **talking to Ali**. Blue jacket. **A:** And the man **standing by the window**? **B:** That's the consultant **brought in to review the process**. Nobody's sure what he does. **A:** Is this the report **written last year**? **B:** No — that's the one **commissioned by the board**. The one **written last year** was much shorter. **A:** Right. And anyone **wanting to comment** has until Friday? **B:** Anyone **wanting to comment** should have done it in March, honestly. The changes **agreed at that meeting** are already in the contract.

Seven reductions in a short exchange, and every single one could be expanded:

the woman **who is** talking · the consultant **who was** brought in · the report **which was** written anyone **who wants** to comment · the changes **which were** agreed

Now sort them: *talking, standing, wanting* are all **active** — those nouns are doing something. *Brought in, written, commissioned, agreed* are all **passive** — those nouns had it done to them.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (DELETE WHO/WHICH + BE)

The mechanism. In a **defining** clause, delete the relative pronoun and the form of *be*:

*the woman ~~who is~~ **talking** to Ali the book ~~which was~~ **written** in 1990 the people ~~who were~~ **invited** last week*

The choice — active or passive:

	Use	Meaning	Example
Active	-ing	the noun is doing it	<i>the man carrying the boxes</i>
Passive	-ed (participle)	the noun has it done to it	<i>the boxes carried by the man</i>

*the people **waiting** outside* — they are waiting. Active. *the seats **reserved** for guests* — someone reserved them. Passive.

This is the only real decision, and the test is simple: **ask what the noun is doing**. If it is doing nothing — if something is being done to it — you want *-ed*.

It works with a simple present or past too, not only with *be*:

*anyone ~~who wants~~ **wanting** to comment* — a present-simple clause reduced to *-ing*. *people ~~who live~~ **living** abroad*

What cannot reduce. Keep the scope tight:

X Do not reduce	Why
non-defining clauses	<i>my brother, who lives in Cairo</i> → <i>my brother living in Cairo</i> is odd
clauses with a modal	<i>the report which must be signed</i>
clauses where the pronoun is the object	<i>the book that I read</i> — nothing to reduce
perfect clauses	<i>the man who has finished</i>

If a reduction sounds strange to you, it probably is. This is one of the few places in Stage 3 where instinct is a reliable guide, because the reduced form is either idiomatic or it is not.

Reading long sentences. This is the comprehension skill:

*The proposals **submitted before Friday** will be considered.*

submitted is not the main verb. It is attached to *proposals*. The main verb is *will be considered*. When you meet a noun followed directly by a participle, expect the real verb later — and if you cannot find the main verb of a long sentence, look for a reduced relative you have mistaken for one.

Do not overload. Two reductions in a sentence is comfortable. Four and the sentence turns into a list of attachments with no clear spine.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
the woman talking to...	<i>The woman talking to Ali is my manager.</i>
the man standing by...	<i>The man standing by the window.</i>
the report written last year	<i>The report written last year was shorter.</i>
the changes agreed at...	<i>The changes agreed at that meeting.</i>
anyone wanting to...	<i>Anyone wanting to comment has until Friday.</i>
people living abroad	<i>People living abroad pay more.</i>
the seats reserved for...	<i>The seats reserved for guests.</i>
brought in to...	<i>The consultant brought in to review it.</i>
the figures used in...	<i>The figures used in the forecast.</i>
commissioned by...	<i>The report commissioned by the board.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (ONE SMOOTH PHRASE, NO BREAK)

Cue 1 — the noun and the participle are one unit. No pause between them, ever:

the woman talking to Ali — /ðəwʊmən 'tɒkɪŋtə'ali/ — one continuous phrase.

If you pause after *woman*, you have accidentally produced a non-defining clause and changed the meaning. This is where L01's prosody work pays off in reverse: **defining means no break**, and a reduced clause is always defining.

Cue 2 — stress on the participle, then on its object:

*the woman **TALK**ing to **Ali*** · *the report **WRIT**ten last **YEAR***

Cue 3 — the -ed ending must survive. Same discipline as Unit 6, and here it is the only thing marking the passive:

written · *agreed* /d/ · *reserved* /d/ · *submitted* /ɪd/ · *used* /t/

The changes agree at that meeting is nothing. The /d/ is the grammar.

Cue 4 — -ing links straight into the next word. /'tɒkɪŋtu/, /'stændɪŋbaɪ/, /'waɪntɪŋtu/. Let the /ŋ/ join forward; do not stop after it.

Cue 5 — the break comes AFTER the whole noun phrase, before the main verb:

The proposals submitted before Friday // will be considered.

That single break is what tells your listener the subject has finished. Without it, long sentences with reductions are genuinely hard to follow.

 **Record:** "The woman talking to Ali is my manager, and the report written last year was much shorter." Two reductions, no break inside either.



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Reduce it. Delete two words:

1. *The man who is waiting outside is my brother.*
2. *The email which was sent yesterday never arrived.*
3. *The people who were invited didn't come.*
4. *Anyone who wants to join should sign up.*
5. *The building which was destroyed in the fire has been rebuilt.*

B. -ing or -ed? Ask what the noun is doing:

1. *the students* ____ (wait) for their results
2. *the results* ____ (publish) yesterday
3. *the woman* ____ (run) the meeting
4. *the decisions* ____ (make) at the meeting
5. *the man* ____ (carry) the boxes / *the boxes* ____ (carry) by the man

C. Can it reduce? Say yes or no:

1. *My sister, who lives in Dubai, is a doctor.*

2. *The report which must be signed today.*
3. *The people who are standing at the back.*
4. *The book that I borrowed from you.*

D. Find the main verb. In each long sentence, identify the reduced relative and the real main verb:

1. *The proposals submitted before the deadline will be reviewed next week.*
2. *Anyone arriving after nine will need to sign in at reception.*
3. *The figures used in the original forecast were later found to be wrong.*

E. Describe a scene. Look around the room, or at a photograph. Describe **four** things using reductions — at least one active and one passive.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Describe a scene — your office, a café, a photograph, a street — using **three** reduced relatives, including at least one passive.

The two people sitting by the window have been there for hours. There's a laptop left open on the table next to them, and a man standing at the counter who clearly can't decide. The music playing is the same track as last time.

 **Record it.** Check two things: no pause between the noun and the participle, and every *-ed* audible.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** descriptions using reduced relatives.
- **Delete two words.** Whenever you catch yourself saying *the man who is...* or *the thing which was...*, stop and say it without them. This is a habit, and it takes about a week.
- Reading practice: find a long sentence in an English article and locate the main verb. If it is hard, there is probably a reduced relative in the subject.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Delete **who/which + be**. Two words gone, no meaning lost.
- **-ing** = the noun is **doing** it. **-ed** = it is **having it done**. Ask what the noun is doing.
- Only **defining** clauses reduce — so there is **never a pause** inside one.
- Reduced relatives are **more common than full ones** in real English.

- When a noun is followed by a participle, the **main verb comes later**.
 - The **-ed** is the grammar. Lose it and the passive disappears.
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can reduce a full defining clause by deleting two words.
 - ☐ I choose *-ing* or *-ed* by asking what the noun is doing.
 - ☐ I never pause between the noun and the participle.
 - ☐ My *-ed* endings are audible.
 - ☐ I can find the main verb in a long sentence with a reduction in the subject.
 - ☐ I know which clauses cannot be reduced.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the cheapest naturalness upgrade in the whole stage

PREPOSITIONS + *WHICH* / *WHOM*, AND *WHICH* FOR A WHOLE IDEA

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 7 · **Lesson 4** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U7-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *the person I spoke to* — and know when *to whom* is right instead.
- Comment on your whole sentence: ..., *which meant we had to start again*.
- Never say ..., *what meant...* 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Two things in this lesson, and the second is the valuable one.

First, prepositions. When a relative clause contains a preposition, English gives you two options:

*The colleague **with whom** I work* — formal, written, and slightly stiff in speech. *The colleague **I work with*** — normal, spoken, and completely correct.

You need to know both, but you need them for different reasons. The end-preposition version is what you should actually say, almost always. The *with whom* version you need to **recognise** in formal writing, and to produce occasionally when the register genuinely calls for it — a legal document, a formal letter, a very formal speech.

This matters because learners are often taught that *to whom* is "more correct", which is not true and leads somewhere bad. If you say *the person to whom I spoke* over coffee, you do not sound educated; you sound like you have swallowed a style guide. Register errors in the formal direction are just as noticeable as errors in the informal one, and they are harder to unlearn because the learner believes they are doing something right.

Second, and this is the real content: *which* can refer to your whole previous clause.

*The client changed the brief again, **which meant** we had to start over.*

What does *which* refer to? Not the client, not the brief — the **entire event** of the client changing the brief. English lets you attach a comment to a whole sentence, and this is how it is done.

That construction is enormously useful and learners almost never produce it. It lets you state a fact and then say what it **meant**, all in one breath: ..., *which is why I left*. ..., *which was fine*. ..., *which nobody had expected*. ..., *which is exactly the problem*. Each of those is a piece of evaluation attached to a piece of information, and that combination — fact plus significance — is what makes speech sound analytical rather than merely descriptive. In a discussion, in a debate, in the Unit-12 benchmark, this is the difference between listing things that happened and explaining what they added up to.

There is one specific error to kill on sight, and it comes straight from other languages: using **what** instead of *which*. *The client changed the brief, what meant we had to start over*. This feels natural to speakers of many languages, and in English it is simply wrong. The relative is *which*; *what* cannot do this job. It is a small correction and it is very visible.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE THE UNIT SO FAR)

Fast round:

1. A **non-defining** clause, paused both sides.
2. A **reduced** relative — active or passive.
3. The question that separates defining from non-defining.

Then: *who did you speak to yesterday?* Answer with a relative clause and notice where you put the preposition.



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. First a normal conversation, then a formal extract:

A: Did you get hold of anyone useful? **B:** The woman I spoke to was helpful, actually. The department she works in handles all of it. **A:** So it's sorted? **B:** Not quite. They changed the reference number, which meant my whole application had to be resubmitted. **A:** You're joking. **B:** Three weeks, gone. Which is why I'm not doing it by email again. **A:** Did they apologise? **B:** They did, which was something. The man I dealt with the second time was much better — he called me back, which nobody ever does.

Now the same content in a formal register:

The department in which she works is responsible for all applications. The reference number was subsequently changed, as a result of which the application had to be resubmitted in full. The officer with whom the matter was discussed has since confirmed...

Both are correct English. The first is how people speak; the second is how a formal letter is written. Read them both aloud and notice how wrong each would sound in the other's place.

And count the sentential *whiches* in the conversation: **four** — *which meant*, *which is why*, *which was something*, *which nobody ever does*. Every one comments on the whole preceding clause, and none of them refers to a noun.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (TWO TOPICS)

1. WHERE THE PREPOSITION GOES

Register	Form	Example
normal, spoken	preposition at the end	<i>the woman I spoke to</i>
formal, written	preposition + which/whom	<i>the woman to whom I spoke</i>

*the department she works **in** / the department **in which** she works the colleague I work **with** / the colleague **with whom** I work the meeting we talked about it **at** / the meeting **at which** we discussed it*

Rules for the formal version. *whom* for people, *which* for things, and the pronoun can **never** be omitted:

✓ *the person **to whom** I spoke* · ✗ *the person **to who** I spoke* ✓ *the tool **with which** it was made*

Rules for the normal version. You can often drop the pronoun entirely:

*the woman (**who**) I spoke to · the department (**that**) she works in*

Which should you use? The end-preposition version, almost always. Reserve the formal form for formal writing and for the rare spoken moment that genuinely calls for it. This is a **register** choice, not a correctness one — and a formal-register error is as visible as an informal one.

2. WHICH FOR A WHOLE IDEA

clause + comma + which + comment

*They changed the reference number, **which meant** my application had to be resubmitted. He called me back, **which nobody ever does**. They apologised, **which was something**.*

which here refers to **the whole preceding clause** — the event, not any noun in it.

The high-frequency patterns. These are worth memorising as units:

Pattern	Use
..., <i>which meant...</i>	the consequence
..., <i>which is why...</i>	the reason for what follows
..., <i>which was fine / annoying / a relief</i>	your evaluation
..., <i>which nobody expected</i>	a comment on the event
..., <i>which is exactly the problem</i>	pointing at the significance
..., <i>all of which...</i>	a comment on several things
..., <i>none of which...</i>	a negative comment on several things

Two rules.

Always a comma. It is non-defining by nature — it is a comment, never an identification.

Never *what*.

✗ They changed it, **what** meant we had to restart. ✓ They changed it, **which** meant we had to restart.

Formal version of the same idea: *as a result of which, in which case, at which point:*

The number was changed, **as a result of which** the application was rejected. The supplier withdrew, **at which point** the whole thing collapsed.

at which point is worth having — it is the formal way to say *and then*, and it is common in professional narrative.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
the person I spoke to	<i>The woman I spoke to was helpful.</i>
the department she works in	<i>The department she works in handles it.</i>
to whom / in which (formal)	<i>The officer with whom I spoke.</i>
..., which meant...	<i>..., which meant we had to restart.</i>
..., which is why...	<i>..., which is why I'm not doing it by email.</i>
..., which was something	<i>They apologised, which was something.</i>
..., which nobody expected	<i>He called back, which nobody ever does.</i>
..., all of which...	<i>Three emails, all of which were ignored.</i>
..., none of which...	<i>Four options, none of which worked.</i>
at which point...	<i>The supplier withdrew, at which point it collapsed.</i>
as a result of which	<i>..., as a result of which it was rejected.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE PAUSE BEFORE *WHICH*)

Cue 1 — sentential *which* needs a pause before it and a small pitch reset. Without that pause it sounds as though *which* is describing the last noun you said, which is exactly the wrong reading:

They changed the reference number // which meant my application had to be resubmitted.

Say it without the break and listen: it starts to sound as though the **number** meant something.

Cue 2 — the comment falls. After the pause, the clause moves down and lands:

...// which meant we had to start again. ↘

Cue 3 — *which* itself is unstressed. /wɪtʃ/, light and quick. The stress belongs on the comment:

...which MEANT we had to start again. • ...which is WHY I left.

Cue 4 — end-position prepositions are unstressed and linked. *the woman I spoke to* — /aɪ'spəʊktu/, the preposition attaches to the verb and carries no weight. Learners often stress it, which makes it sound stranded.

Cue 5 — the formal register is slower and more evenly stressed. *the officer with whom I spoke* has more full vowels and fewer reductions than normal speech. That is part of what marks it as formal — and part of why it sounds strange in a casual sentence.

 **Record:** "They changed the reference number, which meant my whole application had to be resubmitted." Then record it with no pause before *which*, and hear the difference.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Move the preposition. Give the natural spoken version:

1. *The colleague with whom I work is leaving.*
2. *The department in which she works handles applications.*
3. *The meeting at which it was discussed was last Tuesday.*
4. *The person to whom I spoke was very helpful.*

B. Now the other direction. Give the formal version — for a formal letter:

1. *The manager I reported to has left.*
2. *The conditions we agreed on have changed.*

C. Add the comment. Complete each with a sentential *which*:

1. *They moved the deadline forward two weeks, ____.*
2. *She replied within an hour, ____.*
3. *Nobody told me about the change, ____.*
4. *The system logged me out three times, ____.*

D. Fix the error.

1. *They changed it, what meant we had to restart.*
2. *He called me back which nobody ever does.*
3. *The person to who I spoke was helpful.*
4. *The colleague with who I work.*

E. Register check. Which version would you actually use — and where?

1. *the client with whom we have worked for years / the client we've worked with for years*
2. *as a result of which the project was cancelled / which meant the project got cancelled*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Tell a short story about something frustrating — bureaucracy, a delay, a mistake — in about forty-five seconds. Use:

- at least **two** sentential *which* comments
- at least **one** end-position preposition
- optionally, one formal form where it genuinely fits

I applied in January and heard nothing for six weeks, which is normal apparently. Then they emailed to say the reference number had changed, which meant the whole thing had to be resubmitted. The woman I spoke to was sympathetic but couldn't do anything, which was the most frustrating part. They did send a confirmation the second time, which nobody had bothered with in January.

 **Record it.** Check: is there a pause before every *which*?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a story with **two** sentential *which* comments.
- **Use *which meant once a day this week*.** State a fact, then say what it meant. It is the single most useful construction in this lesson and you will otherwise never produce it.
- Read one formal document and find a *preposition + which*. Notice that you would never say it out loud.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **End-position preposition is normal English:** *the person I spoke to*. The formal form is **register**, not correctness.
- *whom* for people, *which* for things, and in the formal form the pronoun **cannot** be dropped.
- ***which*** can refer to **your whole previous clause** — the event, not a noun.
- Memorise the units: ***which meant* · *which is why* · *which was fine* · *all of which***.
- **Always a comma**, and a **pause**, before sentential *which*.
- **Never *what***. That is the error to kill.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I know the end-position preposition is normal, not sloppy.
- ☐ I can produce the formal version when a formal register requires it.
- ☐ I used *which* to comment on a whole clause, at least twice.

- ☐ I never said *what* in place of *which*.
 - ☐ I paused before every sentential *which*.
 - ☐ I can say where each register belongs.
-

Empire English 🏰 — *state the fact, then say what it meant*

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: DESCRIBE SOMEONE OR SOMETHING WITH RICH DETAIL 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 7 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·

Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit7-relative-clauses-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U7-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you describe one thing properly:

- ~2 minutes of rich, layered description
- a **non-defining** clause, a **reduced** relative, a **sentential which**
- **audible pauses** doing the work of commas
- then answer clarifying questions 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. A **non-defining** clause — pauses both sides.
2. A **defining** clause — no pause anywhere.
3. A **reduced** relative — one active, one passive.
4. A **sentential which** comment.
5. An **end-position preposition**: *the person I spoke to...*

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model description, then read. Structures marked, pauses shown:

[NON-DEFINING] The person who had the biggest effect on my working life was a woman called Nadia // who ran the department when I joined // and who left about a year later.

[REDUCED — ACTIVE] She was the only manager there actually doing the work rather than delegating all of it. **[DEFINING — NO PAUSE]** The first thing she said to me was something I still repeat to people. **[SENTENTIAL WHICH]** She told me I'd been hired for what I didn't know yet, which sounded like a threat at the time.

[REDUCED — PASSIVE] There was a project inherited from the previous team that nobody wanted, **[NON-DEFINING]** and Nadia // who could have handed it to anyone // gave it to me in my second week. **[SENTENTIAL WHICH]** It went badly for about three months, which turned out to be the point.

[NON-DEFINING + REDUCED] The office // which was on the fourth floor of a building being renovated the whole time // was genuinely awful. **[SENTENTIAL WHICH]** We all worked in coats that winter, which nobody complained about, oddly.

[CLOSING EVALUATION] She's the reason I stayed in the industry. **[SENTENTIAL WHICH]** I've never told her that, which I should probably fix.

Study three things. The **pauses are doing the punctuation** — you can hear where each non-defining clause opens and closes. The **reductions are invisible** — *actually doing the work, inherited from the previous team, being renovated* — they compress without drawing attention. And every **which** attaches to a whole event and adds an **evaluation**, which is what makes the description feel like a person telling you something rather than listing facts.

🧩 THE UNIT-7 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a non-defining clause, paused both sides	<i>Nadia, who ran the department, ...</i>
2	a defining clause with no pause	<i>the first thing she said to me</i>
3	a reduced relative — active	<i>the only manager actually doing the work</i>
4	a reduced relative — passive	<i>a project inherited from the previous team</i>
5	a sentential which	<i>..., which turned out to be the point.</i>
6	rich detail — specifics, not adjectives	<i>fourth floor · that winter · second week</i>

Item 6 is what separates a rich description from a long one. *She was a great manager* is an adjective. *She gave me a project nobody wanted in my second week* is detail, and it does the adjective's job better.

Item 2 matters as much as item 1. Under pressure learners pause before everything, which turns every defining clause into a non-defining one and quietly changes what they are claiming.

🎧 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (THE PAUSE IS THE PUNCTUATION)

Everyone — the three-part shape of a non-defining clause. Pause, drop, faster, pause, come back up:

Nadia 📌 // who ran the department when I joined (lower, quicker) // left a year later. 📌

Everyone — get back out. The second pause is the one that disappears. Without it the clause bleeds into the main verb and the sentence has no spine.

Everyone — a defining clause and a reduced relative have NO break. /ðəwʊmən 'tɒkɪŋtu/ is one phrase.

If you breathe after the noun, you have said something else.

Everyone — pause before sentential *which*. Then let the comment fall. No pause and it sounds as though *which* describes your last noun.

Everyone — participle endings survive. *inherited*, *renovated*, *agreed*. In a long description these are the first casualties, and the *-ed* is the passive.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker. One cue, one sentence, stop.

 **Record two sentences** before the task — one with a non-defining clause, one with a reduced relative. Play them to a partner and ask them to tell you where each clause started and stopped. If they cannot, work the pauses.

TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + CLARIFYING QUESTIONS)

Round 1 — plan, don't script. Two minutes, six bullets, no sentences: who or what, one extra fact to tuck into a non-defining clause, one thing to reduce, one moment to comment on with *which*, and two **specific** details — a number, a place, a time.

Round 2 — describe it. In pairs, two minutes each. The listener ticks the six items and notes **where** each non-defining clause opened and closed, from the voice alone.

Round 3 — clarifying questions. The listener asks **two**:

When was this? · What exactly did they do? · Why did that matter to you? Which one do you mean — you mentioned two? · What happened in the end?

Answer by **adding detail**, not by repeating.

Round 4 — trim it. Find one sentence with too many clauses in it and say it again as **two** sentences. Then decide which version is better. Often it is the shorter one, and noticing that is the lesson.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** describing a person, place or object that matters to you, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **one live clarifying question** by adding detail.

 **Save this recording.** Unit 11 will ask you to tell a detailed story and Unit 12 will ask you to sustain a conversation for twenty minutes. Packing detail into single sentences is what makes both

of those possible.

📖 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your rich description.
- Complete the **Unit-7 quiz** — non-defining clauses (commas, *who/which*, no *that*, no omission), the defining against non-defining meaning distinction, reduced relatives (*-ing* against *-ed*), and preposition + *which/whom* plus sentential *which*.
- **Combine before you speak.** Take three short sentences you were about to say and put the middle one inside the first. That single habit is the whole unit.
- Use ***which meant*** once a day. Fact, then significance.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- **Non-defining adds; defining identifies.** The **delete test** decides it.
- ***who*** and ***which*** in non-defining clauses. **Never *that***, never omitted.
- **Reduce** by deleting *who/which* + *be*: ***-ing*** if the noun is doing it, ***-ed*** if it is having it done.
- ***which*** can comment on your **whole clause**. Never ***what***.
- **In speech the comma is a pause** — and you have to get back out of the clause.
- **Detail beats adjectives.** A number, a place and a time say more than *great*.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes, unscripted, in English.
- ☐ My non-defining clauses had pauses on both sides.
- ☐ My defining and reduced clauses had no pause at all.
- ☐ I used at least one sentential *which* to comment on an event.
- ☐ I gave specific details rather than adjectives.
- ☐ A partner could hear where each clause began and ended.
- ☐ I trimmed one over-stuffed sentence into two.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 7 complete — detail packed in, and the listener still with you



STAGE 3 · UNIT 8

REPORTED SPEECH (ADVANCED)

👑 UNIT 8 — REPORTED SPEECH (ADVANCED)

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: report what people said accurately enough that someone can **act** on your summary without checking it — and fairly enough that nobody would object to how you described them.

This unit has an ethical edge, and it is not decoration. Reporting verbs carry judgement. *He admitted* and *he explained* can report identical words and make different claims about a person. Choosing carelessly misrepresents people, and in a second language the care has to be deliberate because the vocabulary is new.

It is also the most directly professional unit so far. Summarising a meeting is a task you will be given, and people notice whose summaries can be relied on.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	The reporting-verb range	report what kind of act it was — <i>admitted</i> · <i>insisted</i> · <i>refused</i> · <i>warned</i>
L02	Patterns 1	verb + -ing and verb + that — and never <i>suggested to</i>
L03	Patterns 2	verb + to and verb + object + to — and <i>not to</i>
L04	Reporting a meeting	the six-move summary , and the decided-versus-discussed split
L05	Unit task 🎧	2 minutes reporting a discussion someone could act on

Grammar spine: reporting-verb range in five functional groups · the four patterns (+ *-ing*, + *that*, + *to*,

- object + *to*) · the *not to* negative · backshift maintained throughout. **Accent Lab:** stress the reporting verb — it is your analysis · the word-stress list (*Ob*jected but *ad*MITted) · weak or absent *that* · weak *to* /tə/ · **not stays strong*** · the *-ed* on the reporting verb carrying the tense · commitment strength carried by stress (*agreed to LOOK at it*). **Mindset:** professional, accurate retelling. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A **ninety-second meeting summary** that separates what was decided from what was only discussed.

- The judgement to know that *admitted*, *claimed* and *complained* make claims about people — and to choose them on purpose.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** choosing the precise reporting verb · verb + *-ing* / *that* · verb + *to* / object + *to* · the *not to* negative · spotting pattern mismatches.
- **Speaking task:** the L05 two-minute report plus two clarifying questions, scored on the B2 rubric with **accuracy weighted above range**.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — verb-pattern accuracy, **reporting-frame rhythm** (a named U12 clinic input), and a note of anyone over-reporting commitments or reaching for loaded verbs.

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 9 — REGISTER & NUANCE

formal against informal, diplomatic softening, collocations, and the skill underneath all of them: matching how you speak to the room you are in.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · accurate, fair, and worth relying on

BEYOND SAID — THE REPORTING-VERB RANGE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 · **Lesson 1** ⌚ ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 reported speech

Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U8-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Report **what kind** of thing someone said, not just that they said it.
- Use *admitted*, *denied*, *suggested*, *insisted*, *refused*, *warned*.
- Notice that choosing a verb is making a claim. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

At B1 you learned to report speech: *he said he was tired*, *she told me she'd finished*. The grammar was the backshift, and *say* and *tell* were enough to carry it.

They are not enough now, and here is why. Compare these three reports of the same sentence:

*He said the figures were wrong. He **admitted** the figures were wrong. He **insisted** the figures were wrong.*

The words spoken could be identical in all three cases. But *said* reports neutrally, *admitted* tells me he was reluctant and it counted against him, and *insisted* tells me he was pushing against resistance. The reporting verb is not a delivery mechanism for the content — it is your **analysis of what kind of act it was**, and your listener takes it as information.

This is why the range matters professionally. When you summarise a meeting, most of what you communicate is carried by your verb choice. *She proposed we delay* and *she wanted us to delay* describe the same intervention and position her completely differently — one is a contribution, the other is a preference. *They objected* and *they refused* are worlds apart in a negotiation report. Anyone reading your summary will act on those distinctions.

And that is also the responsibility. Because these verbs carry judgement, using them carelessly misrepresents people. If a colleague explains a mistake in a meeting and you report that he *admitted* it, you have quietly turned an explanation into a confession. If someone raises a concern and you report that they *complained*, you have converted a professional contribution into a grievance. Nobody said anything untrue, and the summary is now unfair. In your first language you probably navigate this instinctively; in English you need the vocabulary before you can be careful with it.

There is a plainer benefit too. *Said* repeated ten times in a summary is exhausting to listen to, and it is one of the most obvious markers of a learner working with a small verb set. Twelve well-chosen verbs make a two-minute report sound like an account rather than a transcript.

One organisational point that will save you time. Every one of these verbs comes with a **pattern** — *suggest* takes *-ing* or *that*, *promise* takes *to*, *warn* takes an object and *to*. Getting the pattern wrong is the commonest error in the whole unit. That is the next two lessons, and it is much easier once the verbs themselves are familiar. Today, learn the verbs and what each one **claims**.



WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE B1 BACKSHIFT)

Report each in one sentence:

1. "I'm tired." → He said...
2. "I've finished the report." → She told me...
3. "Where do you live?" → He asked me...

Then a harder one: "Fine, it was my fault." — report it. Notice that *said* loses something.



WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. Notice that **not one report uses said**:

A: How did the meeting go? **B:** Better than expected. Karim admitted the timeline had been unrealistic from the start. **A:** That's a first. **B:** He did. Then Dina suggested splitting it into two phases, and finance objected — they insisted the budget couldn't be reopened. **A:** Predictably. **B:** But then Karim offered to cover the second phase from his own budget, which nobody expected. Finance still refused to sign anything today, though they promised to look at it by Thursday. **A:** So no decision. **B:** Not yet. Oh — and Dina reminded everyone that the client presentation is next week, and warned us not to assume it'll move.

Count them: **admitted, suggested, objected, insisted, offered, refused, promised, reminded, warned**. Nine verbs, and between them you know exactly what kind of meeting it was. Replace all nine with *said* and reread it — you would know what was discussed and nothing about what happened.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (FIVE FUNCTIONAL GROUPS)

Do not learn these as a list. Learn them as **five groups by what the person was doing**.

1. PROPOSING

Verb	Claims
suggest	put forward an idea, not pushing
recommend	advised it, with some authority
propose	formal — put it on the table
offer	volunteered to do it themselves

2. ADMITTING AND DENYING

Verb	Claims
admit	conceded something against their own interest
deny	said it wasn't true, having been accused
confess	admitted something they felt bad about

3. WARNING AND REMINDING

Verb	Claims
warn	flagged a risk
remind	pointed at something already known
point out	drew attention to a fact, neutrally

4. PROMISING, REFUSING, AGREEING

Verb	Claims
promise	committed
refuse	declined, firmly
agree	accepted a proposal
threaten	said they'd do something bad

5. PUSHING AND PUSHING BACK

Verb	Claims
insist	maintained it against resistance
object	opposed it, professionally
complain	expressed dissatisfaction
claim	asserted it, and I'm signalling I'm not sure it's true

Three verbs carry a judgement — use them carefully.

admit implies the person was reluctant and that the thing counts against them. If they simply explained something, say *explained*. **claim** signals that you doubt it. *He claimed he'd sent it* means you are not sure he did. That is a real implication and it is sometimes unfair. **complain** turns a contribution into a grievance. If someone raised a legitimate concern, *raised a concern* or *pointed out* is the honest report.

The neutral options, when you genuinely do not want to characterise it:

said · mentioned · noted · pointed out · explained · asked

These are not failures. Choosing a neutral verb deliberately is better than choosing a loaded one carelessly.

And a caution about backshift. With this many verbs, learners often forget the tense shift underneath:

*"The timeline is unrealistic." → He admitted the timeline **was** unrealistic.*

The B1 backshift still applies. The verb changed; the machinery did not.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
he admitted...	<i>He admitted the timeline was unrealistic.</i>
she denied...	<i>She denied saying that.</i>
he suggested...	<i>He suggested splitting it in two.</i>
she recommended...	<i>She recommended waiting.</i>
they objected	<i>Finance objected.</i>
he insisted...	<i>He insisted the budget was closed.</i>
she offered to...	<i>She offered to cover it.</i>
they refused to...	<i>They refused to sign.</i>
he promised to...	<i>He promised to look at it.</i>
she reminded us that...	<i>She reminded us the deadline is next week.</i>
he warned us not to...	<i>He warned us not to assume.</i>
she claimed...	<i>She claimed she'd sent it.</i>
he pointed out that...	<i>He pointed out that the data was old.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE REPORTING VERB CARRIES THE WEIGHT)

Cue 1 — stress the reporting verb. It is the news, because it is your analysis:

*He adMITted the timeline was unrealistic. She suGGESTed splitting it. They re*FUSED to sign.**

If you stress the content instead, the verb becomes a formality and the distinction you chose is thrown away.

Cue 2 — the frame is one group, then a break, then the content:

He admitted // the timeline had been unrealistic from the start.

Cue 3 — that is weak and often absent. /ðæt/, or gone entirely: *he admitted the timeline was...* Both correct. Do not put a full vowel in it.

Cue 4 — the stressed syllable in the longer verbs. These are worth saying aloud a few times, because misplacing the stress makes them unrecognisable:

ad**MIT**ted · su**GGES**Ted · re**COM**mended · **OB**jected · in**SIST**ed · re**MIND**ed **PROM**ised · re**FUSED** ·
WARNED · **POINT**ed out

Note that *objected* and *promised* stress the **first** syllable while *admitted* and *insisted* stress the **second** — there is no rule, and getting it wrong is a very audible error.

Cue 5 — -ed endings survive. /əd'mɪtɪd/, /sə'dʒestɪd/, /rɪ'fjuzd/. In a fast summary these disappear first, and without them the report loses its tense.

 **Record three reports** using three different verbs, each with the verb stressed. Then say them again with the stress on the content and hear how much flatter they are.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Choose the verb. Which reporting verb fits what actually happened?

1. "Alright, it was my mistake."
2. "Why don't we do it in two stages?"
3. "I didn't say that."
4. "I'll definitely have it by Friday."
5. "No. I'm not signing that."
6. "Don't forget the client meeting is Monday."
7. "Be careful — the data's six months old."
8. "I'm telling you, the budget is closed."

B. Same words, different claim. Explain the difference:

1. *He admitted the data was old.* / *He pointed out the data was old.*
2. *She claimed she'd sent it.* / *She said she'd sent it.*
3. *They complained about the deadline.* / *They raised a concern about the deadline.*

C. Is it fair? For each situation, choose the honest verb:

1. A colleague explains in a meeting why a task slipped. Did he *admit* or *explain*?
2. Someone flags that a plan has a legal risk. Did she *complain* or *point out*?
3. Someone states they emailed you, and you have no reason to doubt it. Did they *claim* or *say*?

D. De-flatten it. Rewrite using precise verbs:

He said the timeline was too short. She said we should split it. They said they couldn't reopen the budget. He said he'd pay for part of it. They said they'd look at it on Thursday.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Report **three** things people actually said to you recently — at work, at home, in a shop — using **three different** reporting verbs, none of them *said* or *told*.

My manager admitted the handover had been badly planned. A colleague suggested moving the review to next week. The letting agent promised to send the contract by Monday, which I'm not counting on.

 **Record all three.** Check: is the **verb** stressed, and did you keep the backshift?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** reports using verbs other than *say* and *tell*.
- **Ban said for one conversation this week.** Report something to someone using only precise verbs. It is uncomfortable for about a minute and then it is permanent.
- Notice loaded verbs in the news. *Admitted, claimed, insisted* — every one is doing editorial work.

REMEMBER — افكر

- The reporting verb is your **analysis of the speech act**, not a delivery mechanism.
- Learn them in **five groups**: proposing · admitting/denying · warning/reminding · promising/refusing · pushing.
- *admit, claim* and *complain* carry **judgement**. Using them carelessly misrepresents people.
- Neutral verbs — *said, mentioned, pointed out, explained* — are a **deliberate choice**, not a failure.
- The **backshift still applies**. The verb changed; the machinery didn't.
- **Stress the reporting verb**, and get the word stress right: *OBjected* but *adMITted*.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can name a verb for each of the five functions.
- ☐ I know what *admit, claim* and *complain* imply about the person.
- ☐ I chose a neutral verb where a loaded one would have been unfair.
- ☐ I kept the backshift.

- ☐ My reporting verbs were stressed and correctly stressed.
-

Empire English 🏰 — choosing the verb is making a claim; choose it on purpose

PATTERNS 1 — VERB + *-ING* AND VERB + *THAT*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 · **Lesson 2** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md](#) · S3-U8-L02

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *she suggested taking a break* — never *suggested to take*.
- Choose between *suggested doing* and *suggested that we do*, on purpose.
- Report an admission, a denial or a claim with the right structure. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Yesterday you learned the verbs. Today you learn what each one does to the sentence after it — and this is where nearly all the errors in the unit live.

Here is the problem stated plainly. English reporting verbs each demand a particular structure, and **there is no rule that predicts which**. *Suggest* takes *-ing* or a *that*-clause. *Promise* takes *to*. *Warn* takes an object and *to*. *Admit* takes *-ing* or *that*. If you look for a pattern in the meanings you will not find one — *suggest* and *propose* are near-synonyms with different structures. This is vocabulary masquerading as grammar, which means it is learned by chunk rather than by rule.

The reason it matters is that the error is highly visible. *She suggested to take a break* is one of the most recognisable non-native sentences in English. It is grammatical nowhere, it appears constantly, and it comes from a very reasonable assumption: that a verb of proposing should behave like *want* or *ask*. It does not. Almost every language that has an infinitive of purpose produces this error, so if you make it, you are in enormous company — and it is still worth eliminating, because it is the kind of small structural error that draws attention away from otherwise strong English.

There is something genuinely interesting underneath, though, and it is worth the lesson on its own. Where a verb takes **both** patterns, the two are not always interchangeable:

*He suggested **going** to the client directly.* — he is proposing something the group does, himself included. *He suggested **that we go** to the client directly.* — he is proposing something for **us**, and he may not be part of it.

That difference is real and native speakers use it. The *-ing* version includes the speaker in the action; the *that*-clause version can hold them outside it. In a meeting report that distinction can matter quite a lot — whether somebody volunteered the group or volunteered themselves.

The same applies to admission:

*She admitted **making** a mistake.* — she made it. *She admitted **that the process was flawed**.* — she conceded a fact about something else.

One is a personal admission; the other is agreement about a situation. Learners who only have one pattern cannot make that distinction, and end up reporting a concession about a process as a personal confession.

So today has two objectives that look small and are not. Get the pattern right so the error disappears. And where both patterns exist, know what you are choosing.



WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01)

Report three things with **precise** verbs, no *said* or *told*:

1. Something someone admitted.
2. Something someone suggested.
3. Something someone insisted on.

Notice how you built the sentence after each verb. Hold that.



WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. The pattern is marked after each verb:

A: What came out of it? **B:** Dina suggested **[+ -ing]** splitting the project into two phases. Karim admitted **[+ that]** that the original estimate had been optimistic. **A:** Did anyone push back? **B:** Finance denied **[+ -ing]** ever having approved the extra spend, which is not quite true. They insisted **[+ that]** that the budget was closed. **A:** And Dina? **B:** She mentioned **[+ -ing]** having raised the same risk in March. Then she recommended **[+ -ing]** getting the client's view before we decide anything. **A:** Sensible. **B:** Karim admitted **[+ -ing]** he'd been the one who cut the review stage — actually he admitted **[+ -ing]** cutting it, which took some nerve.

Read the last line again. *He admitted cutting it* — an *-ing* pattern, and he is admitting **his own action**. Compare with *he admitted that the estimate had been optimistic*, which is a concession about a **fact**. Same verb, two patterns, two different kinds of admission.

And note: **not one suggested to**, not one *recommended to*. That absence is the lesson.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (TWO PATTERNS, LEARNED AS CHUNKS)

PATTERN A — VERB + *-ING*

She suggested **taking** a break. · He denied **saying** it. · They recommended **waiting**.

Verb	Chunk to memorise
suggest	suggested doing ✓ · suggested to do ✗
recommend	recommended doing ✓ · recommended to do ✗
deny	denied doing
admit	admitted doing
mention	mentioned doing
propose	proposed doing
regret	regretted doing

The rule you must simply accept: *suggest* and *recommend* **never** take *to* + infinitive. This is the error to kill:

✗ She suggested to take a break. · ✗ He recommended to wait. ✓ She suggested taking a break. · ✓ He recommended waiting.

For a past action, use *having* + participle — or just the *-ing*, which is more common in speech:

He denied **having seen** it. · He denied **seeing** it. — both fine, the second more natural.

PATTERN B — VERB + (*THAT*) + CLAUSE

He admitted **that he'd forgotten**. · She insisted **the budget was closed**.

Verb	Chunk
admit	<i>admitted that...</i>
deny	<i>denied that...</i>
insist	<i>insisted that...</i>
claim	<i>claimed that...</i>
explain	<i>explained that...</i>
point out	<i>pointed out that...</i>
complain	<i>complained that...</i>
suggest	<i>suggested that we...</i>
recommend	<i>recommended that we...</i>

that is optional and usually dropped in speech: *he admitted he'd forgotten.*

WHERE BOTH PATTERNS EXIST — AND THE DIFFERENCE IS REAL

*He suggested **going** to the client.* — including himself. *He suggested **that we go** to the client.* — proposing for us; he may not be part of it.

*She admitted **making** a mistake.* — her own action. *She admitted **that the process was flawed**.* — a fact about something else.

*They denied **approving** the spend.* — their own action. *They denied **that it had been approved**.* — the fact itself, by anyone.

The subjunctive, for recognition only. In formal English, *suggest* and *recommend* can take a bare base form:

*He recommended **that she be** informed. · I suggest **that he go** immediately.*

You will meet this in formal writing. It is correct and it is not what you need to produce.

And the backshift still applies in Pattern B:

*"The budget is closed." → They insisted the budget **was** closed.*

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
suggested + -ing	<i>She suggested taking a break.</i>
recommended + -ing	<i>He recommended waiting.</i>
denied + -ing	<i>They denied approving it.</i>
admitted + -ing	<i>She admitted making a mistake.</i>
mentioned + -ing	<i>He mentioned having raised it before.</i>
suggested that we...	<i>She suggested that we ask the client.</i>
admitted that...	<i>He admitted that the estimate was optimistic.</i>
insisted that...	<i>They insisted the budget was closed.</i>
claimed that...	<i>She claimed she'd sent it.</i>
pointed out that...	<i>He pointed out that the data was old.</i>
which is not quite true	<i>...which is not quite true.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (RHYTHM ACROSS THE FRAME)

Cue 1 — stress the reporting verb, then the -ing verb. Two peaks:

She suGGESTed TAKing a break. They de*NIED apPROVing it.*

Cue 2 — that is /ðæt/ or absent. Never a full vowel. This is the same weak *that* as U6-L03:

**He admitted /ðæt/ he'd forgotten. · He admitted he'd forgotten.*

Both natural. A stressed *THAT* sounds like you are pointing at something.

Cue 3 — link the verb into the -ing. No gap:

suggested taking → /sə'dʒestɪd 'teɪkɪŋ/ — the /d/ joins the /t/. *denied approving* → /dɪ'naɪd ə'pruːvɪŋ/ — the /d/ links into the vowel.

Cue 4 — the -ed on the reporting verb survives. /sə'dʒestɪd/ has three syllables and the last one is the tense. Drop it and your report loses its past.

Cue 5 — *having* + participle compresses. /'hævɪŋ 'sɪn/ → in fast speech /'ævɪŋ 'sɪn/. Recognise it; produce the simpler *-ing* if you prefer.

 **Record two:** "*She suggested taking a break*" and "*He admitted that the estimate had been optimistic.*" Check the two stresses in the first and the weak *that* in the second.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Report it. Use the verb given, with the right pattern:

1. "Let's take a break." — **suggest**
2. "I didn't send it." — **deny**
3. "You should wait until Monday." — **recommend**
4. "Yes, it was me who cut the review." — **admit**
5. "The budget is definitely closed." — **insist**
6. "I did mention this in March." — **point out**

B. Fix the error. All six are the same family of mistake:

1. *She suggested to take a break.*
2. *He recommended to wait.*
3. *They denied to approve it.*
4. *She suggest taking a break.*
5. *He admitted to make a mistake.*
6. *I suggest you to go.*

C. Which pattern, and why? Choose *-ing* or *that*, and explain the meaning:

1. He is admitting **his own action** of cutting the review.
2. He is conceding **a fact** about the estimate.
3. He is proposing something **the group including himself** should do.
4. He is proposing something for **other people** to do.

D. Both versions. Say each idea twice, once with each pattern, and state the difference:

1. suggest / ask the client
2. admit / miss the deadline
3. deny / approve the spend

🎤 YOUR TURN — دورك

Report **three** things from a real discussion, using **at least one of each pattern**.

My manager suggested moving the review to the following week, which suited everyone. She admitted that the original plan had been too ambitious. One of the team denied having seen the email at all — I'm fairly sure he had.

🎤 **Record all three.** Check: no *suggested to*, and can you hear the *-ed* on each reporting verb?

📋 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** reports, using both patterns.
- **Say suggested taking ten times.** Out loud, today. Chunk memory is the only thing that beats this error, and it takes about two minutes of deliberate repetition.
- When you learn a new reporting verb, learn it **with its pattern**. *Promise to. Warn someone to. Suggest doing.* Never store the verb alone.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- Each verb demands a pattern and **there is no rule**. Learn the **chunk**.
- *suggest* and *recommend* **never take to**. This is the error to kill.
- *that* is optional and usually **dropped** in speech — and always weak.
- Where **both** patterns exist, they differ: *-ing* is usually **your own action or the group's**; *that* + clause can hold you **outside** it.
- The **backshift still applies** after *that*.
- Keep the **-ed** on the reporting verb. It carries the tense.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I never say *suggested to* or *recommended to*.
- ☐ I can produce both patterns for *suggest*, *admit* and *deny*.
- ☐ I can explain what changes between *admitted making* and *admitted that*.
- ☐ My *that* is weak or absent, never stressed.
- ☐ The *-ed* on my reporting verbs is audible.
- ☐ I store new reporting verbs together with their pattern.

Empire English 🏰 — the verb decides the structure, and there is no rule to help you

PATTERNS 2 — VERB + *TO* AND VERB + OBJECT + *TO*

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 · **Lesson 3** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md](#) · S3-U8-L03

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Say *he promised to call* and *she warned me not to be late*.
- Know which verbs **need** a person and which cannot take one.
- Report an offer, a refusal and a piece of advice accurately. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

This lesson finishes the pattern set, and it covers the verbs that report **actions people committed to** — offers, promises, refusals, warnings, advice. These are the reports that have consequences. If you summarise a meeting and get who promised what wrong, that is not a language error with a language cost.

The structure splits cleanly in two, and the split is about whether a **person** is required.

Some verbs take *to* directly, with no person in between: *he offered to help*, *she promised to send it*, *they refused to sign*. Notice what these have in common — the subject is committing **themselves**. Who is going to help? He is. There is nobody else to name, so the pattern does not allow one.

Other verbs need a person, because the whole point is that the speech act was **directed at somebody**: *she warned **me** not to be late*, *he advised **us** to wait*, *she reminded **him** to call*. You cannot warn into empty space. If the verb involves affecting someone else's behaviour, English demands that you say whose.

That distinction is not arbitrary — it follows the meaning — and it is worth seeing that way rather than memorising two lists. *Promise* is about you; *advise* is about them. The pattern reflects who the action belongs to.

Where learners go wrong is predictable and worth naming in advance. First, dropping the object: *he advised to wait* is missing the person and is not a sentence. Second, adding one: *she promised me to send it* feels reasonable and is wrong — *promise* takes *to* directly, or *promised me that she would send it* if you want the person in. Third, and most consequentially, the negative.

The negative here is **not to**, and it goes before the verb:

*She warned me **not to** be late.*

Learners produce *she warned me to not be late*, which is clumsy but understandable, or *she didn't warn me to be late*, which means she failed to give a warning — the opposite of what happened. That second one is a real miscommunication, not a stylistic slip, and it appears in reports where accuracy matters.

One more reason to get this right. These patterns are how English reports the **commitments** in a conversation, and commitments are what people go back and check. *They promised to look at it by Thursday* is a sentence somebody may quote you on. Getting the verb, the pattern and the negative right is part of being someone whose summaries can be trusted.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE L02)

Three reports, and watch the pattern:

1. Something someone **suggested** — *-ing*.
2. Something someone **admitted** — either pattern.
3. Something someone **denied** — *-ing*.

Then one you cannot build yet: "*I'll send it tomorrow, I promise.*" Report it.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. The pattern is marked:

A: Did you get anywhere with them? **B:** Some. They offered **[+ to]** to extend the deadline by a week, but they refused **[+ to]** to change the price. **A:** Did you push? **B:** I did. Their lawyer advised **[+ obj + to]** them not to move on price at all, apparently. **A:** Of course he did. **B:** Karim promised **[+ to]** to send the revised terms today, and he asked **[+ obj + to]** me to look at clause nine specifically. **A:** Anything else? **B:** Dina reminded **[+ obj + to]** me to copy legal in, and warned **[+ obj + to]** me not to reply before Thursday. She also agreed **[+ to]** to sit in on the next call. **A:** So where does that leave us? **B:** They've agreed **[+ to]** to extend. We've agreed **[+ to]** to think about it. Nobody's agreed **[+ to]** to anything real.

Sort them. **No person:** *offered to, refused to, promised to, agreed to* — every one is the subject committing themselves. **Person required:** *advised them to, asked me to, reminded me to, warned me not to* — every one is directed at somebody.

And note both negatives: *advised them **not to** move, warned me **not to** reply*. Never *not* after the verb.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (DOES IT NEED A PERSON?)

PATTERN C — VERB + TO · NO PERSON ALLOWED

He offered **to help**. · She promised **to send** it. · They refused **to sign**.

Verb	Chunk
offer	<i>offered to do</i>
promise	<i>promised to do</i>
refuse	<i>refused to do</i>
agree	<i>agreed to do</i>
threaten	<i>threatened to do</i>
decide	<i>decided to do</i>
claim	<i>claimed to have done</i>

The subject is committing themselves, so there is nobody else to name:

✗ *She promised me to send it.* → ✓ *She promised to send it.* · ✓ *She promised me **that** she'd send it.*

If you want the person in with these verbs, you need a *that*-clause, not *to*.

PATTERN D — VERB + OBJECT + **TO** · PERSON REQUIRED

She warned **me** to be careful. · He advised **us** to wait. · She reminded **him** to call.

Verb	Chunk
advise	<i>advised someone to do</i>
warn	<i>warned someone (not) to do</i>
remind	<i>reminded someone to do</i>
ask	<i>asked someone to do</i>
tell	<i>told someone to do</i>
encourage	<i>encouraged someone to do</i>
invite	<i>invited someone to do</i>
persuade	<i>persuaded someone to do</i>
urge	<i>urged someone to do</i>

The act is directed at somebody, so the person is not optional:

✗ *He advised to wait.* → ✓ *He advised **us** to wait.*

THE NEGATIVE — **NOT TO**, BEFORE THE VERB

✓ *She warned me **not to** be late.* ✗ *She warned me to not be late.* — clumsy. ✗ *She **didn't** warn me to be late.* — **different meaning**: she gave no warning at all.

That last one is the one to be careful about. It is a real error of fact, and in a report it changes who is responsible for what.

THE VERBS THAT DO BOTH

asked — *asked me **to** wait* (a request) · *asked **if** I could wait* (a question) *agreed* — *agreed **to** extend* (committed) · *agreed **that** it was unfair* (shared an opinion)

THE FULL PICTURE — ALL FOUR PATTERNS

Pattern	Verbs	Example
+ -ing	suggest, recommend, deny, admit, mention	<i>suggested waiting</i>
+ that	admit, insist, claim, explain, point out	<i>insisted that it was closed</i>
+ to	offer, promise, refuse, agree, threaten	<i>promised to send it</i>
+ obj + to	advise, warn, remind, ask, tell, encourage	<i>warned me not to reply</i>

Four patterns, and the verb decides. There is still no rule.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
he offered to...	<i>He offered to help.</i>
she promised to...	<i>She promised to send it today.</i>
they refused to...	<i>They refused to change the price.</i>
we agreed to...	<i>We agreed to extend.</i>
she advised us to...	<i>She advised us to wait.</i>
he warned me not to...	<i>He warned me not to reply yet.</i>
she reminded me to...	<i>She reminded me to copy legal in.</i>
he asked me to...	<i>He asked me to check clause nine.</i>
they encouraged us to...	<i>They encouraged us to apply.</i>
she threatened to...	<i>She threatened to escalate it.</i>
he persuaded them to...	<i>He persuaded them to reconsider.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (WEAK TO, AND THE LINKING OBJECT)

*Cue 1 — *to* reduces to /tə/. * Always, in these patterns:

promised to send → /'prəməst tə 'send/ → /'prəməstə 'send/ *refused to sign* → /rɪ'fuzdə 'saɪn/

A full /tu/ makes the sentence sound dictated.

Cue 2 — the object links both ways. *warned me to* becomes one run:

warned me to → /'wɔːndmɪtə/ · *asked me to* → /'æsktɪtə/ · *reminded me to* → /rɪ'maɪndɪdɪtə/

These are three-word strings arriving as one unstressed bridge between two stressed verbs.

Cue 3 — two stresses: the reporting verb and the action verb:

She **WARNED** me not to be **LATE**. · *He **PROM**ised to **SEND** it.*

Cue 4 — *not* is stressed. It is the meaning:

He warned me **NOT** to reply.

Weaken it and your listener may hear the opposite. Of all the reductions in this lesson, *not* is the one that must stay strong.

Cue 5 — the -ed on the reporting verb survives. /rɪ'maɪndɪd/, /'æskt/, /'prəməst/. Four syllables of unstressed material and the tense lives in the first word.



Record two: "She warned me not to reply before Thursday" and "He promised to send the terms today." Check the weak *to*, the strong *not*, and the linked object.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Report it. Use the verb given:

1. "I'll help you with it." — **offer**
2. "Don't reply until Thursday." — **warn**
3. "No, I'm not signing." — **refuse**
4. "Remember to copy legal in." — **remind**
5. "You should wait." — **advise**
6. "Fine, we'll extend it by a week." — **agree**
7. "Could you look at clause nine?" — **ask**

B. Person or no person? Fix each:

1. He advised to wait.
2. She promised me to send it.
3. They refused us to sign.
4. He reminded to call.
5. She offered me to help.

C. The negative. Report each correctly:

1. "Don't be late." — **warn**
2. "Don't tell anyone." — **ask**
3. "I wouldn't reply yet." — **advise**

Then explain what "She didn't warn me to be late" actually means.

D. Mixed — all four patterns. Report this exchange using at least one of each:

Dina: Why don't we split it into two phases? **Karim:** Yes, the original estimate was too optimistic — that was my fault. **Finance:** The budget is closed. We're not reopening it. **Karim:** I'll cover phase two from my own budget. **Dina:** Please copy legal in, and don't send anything before Thursday.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Report **four** things from a real discussion, using **at least one** *to* pattern and **one** object + *to* pattern, including **one negative**.

My manager offered to take the client call herself, which was a relief. She asked me to send the figures before Friday. She warned me not to promise anything about the timeline. Finance refused to release the budget until the forecast is signed off.

 **Record all four.** Check: weak *to*, strong *not*, and the right pattern for every verb.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** reports using *to* and object + *to* patterns, with one negative.
- **Say the three chunks aloud:** *promised to* · *warned me not to* · *suggested doing*. Ten times each. That covers the three highest-frequency errors in the unit.
- Next time someone commits to something, report it accurately in English, in your head. Getting commitments right is the professional half of this unit.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **+ to** (no person): *offer, promise, refuse, agree, threaten* — the subject commits **themselves**.
- **+ object + to:** *advise, warn, remind, ask, tell, encourage* — the act is **directed at someone**.
- Ask: **whose action is it?** That decides the pattern.
- The negative is **not to, before** the verb. *Didn't warn me to* means **no warning was given**.
- With Pattern C verbs, put the person in a **that-clause**: *promised me that she would...*
- **to** is weak /tə/. **not** is stressed.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I know which verbs need a person and which cannot take one.
- ☐ I never say *he advised to wait* or *she promised me to send it*.
- ☐ My negative is *not to*, before the verb.

- ☐ I can explain what *didn't warn me to* actually means.
 - ☐ My *to* is weak and my *not* is stressed.
 - ☐ I can produce all four patterns in one report.
-

Empire English 🏰 — whose action is it? That decides everything

REPORTING A MEETING OR NEGOTIATION ACCURATELY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 · **Lesson 4** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U8-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Summarise a meeting in **ninety seconds** so that nobody needs the recording.
- Say clearly what was **decided** and what was only **discussed**.
- Attribute each position to the right person, accurately. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You now have the verbs and the patterns. This lesson is about what to do with them under real conditions: someone who was not in the room asks *what happened?* and you have ninety seconds.

That is a genuinely difficult task and it is not mainly a language task. A forty-minute meeting contains perhaps four things that matter. Everything else is process, repetition, and people thinking aloud. The skill is **selection** — knowing which four — and then attributing each of them correctly. A summary that reports everything is a transcript, and it fails for exactly the reason the meeting was too long.

Here is why the accuracy matters more than the fluency. A summary is **acted on**. If you report that finance agreed to release the budget when they actually agreed to look at it, someone will plan work that cannot be paid for. If you report that a colleague objected when she raised a question, you have put her on record as an opponent of something she may support. Nobody in either case said anything you invented; you simply chose the wrong verb, and the consequence is real.

This is also how professional trust gets built or lost, quietly and quickly. People notice whose summaries they can rely on. Someone whose account of a meeting is consistently accurate becomes the person asked to attend and report; someone whose summaries have to be checked against the actual participants becomes an additional step in the process. That is not about English — it is about care — but in a second language the care has to be deliberate, because the loaded verbs from L01 are easy to reach for carelessly.

The one structural thing to get right, and it is the move learners skip, is **separating decisions from discussion**. A meeting produces three categories: things that were **agreed**, things that were **proposed but not decided**, and things that were **raised and left**. If your summary runs them together, your listener cannot tell what is now true. Native professional English marks the difference explicitly — *what we actually agreed was...*, *there was some discussion about...*, *nobody committed to anything on...* — and those markers are worth more than any amount of verb variety.

The last piece is **open items**. A summary that ends with *so those are the main points* is incomplete. A summary that ends with *the open questions are X and Y, and Karim is sending the terms by Thursday* has told your listener what happens next, which is usually the thing they wanted.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (ALL FOUR PATTERNS, FAST)

Thirty seconds each:

1. *suggested + -ing*
2. *admitted / insisted + that*
3. *promised / refused + to*
4. *warned / reminded + object + not to*
5. One **loaded** verb, and what it claims: *admitted, claimed or complained*.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

The source meeting — read it, do not memorise it:

DINA: Before we start — the client presentation is the 14th, not the 21st. I've checked. **KARIM:** Then we're two weeks short. I'll be honest, the original estimate was never realistic. That was on me. **FINANCE (Omar):** Whatever we do, the budget isn't reopening. That was closed in Q2. **DINA:** What if we split it — a working demo for the 14th, full delivery in March? **KARIM:** I'd support that. And I can cover the demo build from my own line if that unblocks it. **OMAR:** I'm not signing anything today. Send me the numbers and I'll look at it by Thursday. **DINA:** Fine. Karim, can you get the revised scope over to Omar by tomorrow? And please copy legal — don't send it round the whole group yet. **KARIM:** Will do. **OMAR:** One thing — if the March date slips as well, I'm escalating it.

The model summary — ninety seconds:

[HEADLINE] Short version: the presentation's two weeks earlier than we thought, and we're proposing to split the delivery.

[ATTRIBUTED POSITIONS] Dina pointed out that the client date is the 14th, not the 21st. Karim admitted the original estimate had been unrealistic. Omar insisted the budget wasn't being reopened.

[THE PROPOSAL] Dina suggested splitting it — a working demo for the 14th, full delivery in March. Karim agreed to that and offered to fund the demo build from his own line.

[DECIDED vs DISCUSSED] What was actually agreed: Karim is sending the revised scope to Omar by tomorrow, and Omar promised to come back on it by Thursday. What was **not** agreed: the split itself. Omar refused to sign anything today, so the March date is still a proposal.

[INSTRUCTIONS AND WARNINGS] Dina asked Karim to copy legal in, and warned him not to circulate it to the whole group yet.

[OPEN ITEMS AND RISK] So: two open questions — whether the split is accepted, and where the demo money actually comes from. And Omar warned that if March slips too, he'll escalate.

Study three things. The **headline comes first** — one sentence, before any detail. The **decided/discussed split is explicit**, with a sentence for each. And the summary **ends with open items and a risk**, not with a list of who said what.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE SUMMARY SHAPE)

Six moves, in this order:

#	Move	Language
1	Headline	<i>Short version... · In one sentence... · The main thing is...</i>
2	Attributed positions	<i>X pointed out... · Y admitted... · Z insisted...</i>
3	The proposal	<i>X suggested... · Y agreed to... · Z offered to...</i>
4	Decided vs discussed	<i>What was actually agreed... · What wasn't agreed...</i>
5	Instructions and warnings	<i>X asked Y to... · X warned Y not to...</i>
6	Open items and risk	<i>Two open questions... · X warned that if...</i>

Move 1 is not optional. Your listener needs to know what the meeting was **about** before they can process who said what. A summary that starts with the first speaker forces them to hold everything in suspense.

Move 4 is the one that gets skipped and the one that matters most. Mark it explicitly:

What we actually agreed was... — the decisions. There was some discussion about..., but nothing was decided. — the proposals. X was raised and left. — the open threads.

Without this, your listener cannot tell what is now true, and that is the entire purpose of the summary.

Attribute precisely, and stay fair. Each position belongs to a named person and a verb that accurately reports it:

*Omar **insisted** the budget wasn't reopening — he maintained it against pressure. Accurate. Omar **refused to sign** today — he declined. Accurate. Omar **complained** about the budget — he did not. That would be a misrepresentation.*

Report the strength of a commitment accurately. This is where summaries do damage:

What happened	Report it as
said they'd do it	<i>promised to / agreed to</i>
said they'd consider it	<i>agreed to look at it — not agreed to it</i>
said no	<i>refused to</i>
said nothing definite	<i>didn't commit to anything on...</i>

Agreed to look at it and *agreed to it* differ by three words and by everything.

Compress ruthlessly. Leave out process, hedging, repetition, and anything nobody will act on. Ninety seconds. If it runs to three minutes you have reported the meeting rather than summarised it.

And name what you don't know:

I'm not sure whether that was a firm commitment or not. · I'd check that with Omar directly.

Flagging your own uncertainty is what makes the rest of the summary trustworthy.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Headline	<i>Short version... · The main thing is... · In one sentence...</i>
Attribute	<i>X pointed out that... · Y admitted... · Z insisted...</i>
Proposal	<i>X suggested ... -ing · Y offered to... · Z agreed to...</i>
Mark a decision	<i>What was actually agreed was... · The one firm outcome is...</i>
Mark a non-decision	<i>Nothing was decided on... · That's still a proposal. · Nobody committed to...</i>
Weak commitment	<i>agreed to look at it · said he'd consider it · promised to come back on it</i>
Instructions	<i>X asked Y to... · X warned Y not to...</i>
Open items	<i>Two open questions... · Still outstanding...</i>
Risk	<i>X warned that if ... , he'd... · The risk flagged was...</i>
Flag uncertainty	<i>I'm not sure whether that was firm. · I'd check with X.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PHRASING A SUMMARY)

Cue 1 — the headline gets its own breath, then a full stop. Do not run it into the detail:

Short version: the presentation's two weeks earlier than we thought. 🗑️ (pause)

Cue 2 — one attributed position per thought group. Each name, then a break:

Dina pointed out that the date is the 14th // Karim admitted the estimate had been unrealistic // Omar insisted the budget wasn't reopening.

Run them together and your listener loses track of who held which position, which is the one thing a summary must preserve.

Cue 3 — stress the names on first mention, then the verbs. The name is new information the first time; after that the verb carries the weight:

***DINa** pointed out... then ...Karim ad**MIT**ted...*

Cue 4 — the decided/discussed pivot needs a clear break and a pitch reset:

... 🗑️ (pause) What was actually agreed // was that Karim sends the scope by tomorrow.

Cue 5 — the strength of the commitment is carried by stress:

*Omar agreed to **LOOK** at it. — the stress on look is what stops it sounding like agreement to the thing itself.*

Cue 6 — keep the reductions. /praməstə/, /ə'grɪdʒtə/, /'wɔːndmɪtə/, weak *that*. A summary delivered with full auxiliaries sounds read aloud.

🎧 **Record the headline and one attributed position.** Check the pause after the headline and the break between positions.

🏋️ TRAIN — تدرّب (REPORT THE MEETING)

A. Find the four things that matter. From the source dialogue above, list the four points somebody who missed the meeting genuinely needs. Then list three things safe to leave out.

B. Attribute it. Assign the right verb to each position:

1. Dina, on the client date.
2. Karim, on the estimate.
3. Omar, on the budget.
4. Omar, on signing today.
5. Karim, on funding the demo.

C. Decided or discussed? Sort these:

1. Karim sends the revised scope by tomorrow.
2. The delivery gets split in two.
3. Omar responds by Thursday.
4. The March date.
5. Legal gets copied in.

D. Strength check. Fix each report:

1. *Omar agreed to the split.*
2. *Omar agreed to reopen the budget.*
3. *Karim promised the demo would be ready.*

E. Summarise it. In pairs, deliver the full ninety-second summary using all six moves. Your partner's only job is to ask, at the end: *so what's actually been decided?* If they have to ask, move 4 was not clear enough.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Summarise a **real** discussion — a meeting, a call, a family decision — in about **ninety seconds**, using all six moves.

Requirements: at least **four** different reporting verbs across **three** patterns, an explicit **decided-versus-discussed** split, and **open items** at the end.

 **Record it.** Then ask yourself the test question: *could someone act on this without asking me anything?*

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a spoken summary of a real discussion.
- **After your next meeting, summarise it out loud in ninety seconds** before you do anything else. In English. It is the single highest-value habit in this unit.
- **Check one commitment.** Next time you report that someone agreed to something, ask yourself whether they agreed to the thing or agreed to look at it.

**REMEMBER — افكر**

- Six moves: **headline → positions → proposal → decided vs discussed → instructions → open items.**
- **Lead with the headline.** Your listener needs the subject before the detail.
- **Mark the decided/discussed split explicitly.** Without it, nobody knows what is now true.
- *Agreed to look at it* is not *agreed to it*. Report the **strength** of the commitment.
- **Selection is the skill.** Ninety seconds. Leave out anything nobody will act on.
- **End with open items and risks** — that is usually what your listener wanted.

**SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك**

- ☐ I opened with a one-sentence headline.
- ☐ Every position is attributed to a named person with an accurate verb.
- ☐ I said explicitly what was agreed and what was not.
- ☐ I reported weak commitments as weak.
- ☐ I ended with open items and any flagged risk.
- ☐ Someone could act on my summary without asking me anything.

Empire English 🏰 — a summary people can rely on is a career asset

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: REPORT A DISCUSSION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 8 · **Lesson 5** — **UNIT TASK** ⌚ ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit8-reported-speech-advanced.md](#) · **S3-U8-L05**

YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you produce a summary somebody could act on:

- ~**2 minutes** reporting a discussion
- **four or more** reporting verbs across **three or more** patterns
- an explicit **decided-versus-discussed** split
- accurate attribution, accurate commitment strength 🗣️

WARM-UP — سخن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. *suggested + -ing* · 2. *insisted + that* · 3. *promised + to* · 4. *warned + object + not to*
2. One **loaded** verb and what it claims about the person.
3. The difference between *agreed to it* and *agreed to look at it*.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

The source discussion — read it once:

LAYLA: I want to flag something before we sign off on the vendor. Their references are all from projects under half our size. **TAREQ:** We looked at that. Honestly, they're the only ones who came in under budget, so we didn't have much choice. **LAYLA:** I'm not saying don't use them. I'm saying we shouldn't give them the whole thing at once. **HANA:** What would you do instead? **LAYLA:** Give them phase one, review, then decide on phase two. **TAREQ:** That'll cost us. They quoted for the whole scope — splitting it means renegotiating, and they might walk. **HANA:** I'll take that risk over discovering in month six that they can't scale. **TAREQ:** Fine. But I'm not going back to them without a written mandate from you two. **HANA:** You'll have it tomorrow. Layla, can you write up the phase-one criteria? And don't share the split idea with the vendor until Tareq's spoken to them. **LAYLA:** Understood. **TAREQ:** One more thing — if they do walk, we're four months behind and I want that on record.

The model report — two minutes:

[HEADLINE] Short version: we're still using the vendor, but Hana's decided to split the contract rather than award the whole thing.

[POSITIONS] Layla pointed out that all the vendor's references are from much smaller projects. Tareq explained that they were the only bidder under budget, so the options had been limited. Layla was clear she wasn't objecting to the vendor itself — she suggested awarding phase one first and reviewing before committing to phase two.

[THE ARGUMENT] Tareq warned that splitting the scope would mean reopening the price, and that the vendor might walk away. Hana accepted that risk — she said she'd rather take it than find out in month six that they can't scale.

[DECIDED] So what's decided: we're splitting it. Hana has agreed to send Tareq a written mandate tomorrow, and she asked Layla to write up the phase-one criteria.

[NOT DECIDED] What isn't decided: the phase-two award, obviously, and the revised price — Tareq hasn't gone back to them yet.

[INSTRUCTION] Hana warned Layla not to mention the split to the vendor until Tareq has spoken to them.

[RISK ON RECORD] And Tareq asked for it on record that if the vendor withdraws, we're four months behind.

Study four things. **Nobody is misrepresented** — Tareq *explained*, he did not *admit*; Layla *pointed out* and *suggested*, she did not *complain*, and the report explicitly says she was not objecting to the vendor. The **decided/not-decided split is a separate move** with its own sentence. The **instruction and the warning are reported with the correct patterns** — *asked Layla to*, *warned Layla not to*. And the **risk is preserved**, because Tareq specifically asked for it.

THE UNIT-8 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a headline first	<i>Short version: we're splitting the contract.</i>
2	four or more reporting verbs	<i>pointed out · explained · suggested · warned · agreed · asked</i>
3	three or more patterns	<i>+ -ing · + that · + to · + obj + to</i>
4	an explicit decided / not decided split	<i>What's decided... What isn't...</i>
5	accurate commitment strength	<i>agreed to send ≠ agreed to look at</i>
6	fair attribution	<i>explained, not admitted, unless it was a concession</i>

Items 5 and 6 are the assessment. Range is easy to demonstrate and accuracy is what makes the summary worth anything. A learner who reports nine verbs and puts one commitment too strongly has produced a worse summary than a learner who used four and got them all right.



ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (REPORTING-FRAME RHYTHM)

Everyone — two stresses per report: the reporting verb and the action:

*She **POINT**ed out that the references were **SMALL**er.* · He **WARNED** us not to **SHARE** it.

Everyone — the frames reduce. /praməstə/, /ə'grɪdət/, /'wɔːndmɪtə/, /sə'dʒestɪd/, weak or absent *that*. A summary delivered with full auxiliaries sounds read aloud rather than reported.

Everyone — not stays strong. *warned Layla **NOT** to mention it.* A weak *not* reverses a warning in the listener's ear, and this is a summary — people will act on it.

Everyone — the -ed on the reporting verb carries the tense. /'pɔɪntɪd/, /ɪk'spleɪnd/, /sə'dʒestɪd/. Under two minutes of load these vanish first.

Everyone — commitment strength is carried by stress: *agreed to **LOOK** at it* is not agreement to the thing.

Everyone — a break between attributed positions, so nobody's view merges with the next person's.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker, one cue, one sentence, stop.



Record before the task: "Tareq warned that splitting the scope would mean reopening the price."

Check the -ed, the weak *that*, and the two stresses.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REPORT IT IN PAIRS)

Round 1 — select, don't transcribe. Two minutes alone. Write down only: the headline, the three or four positions worth reporting, what was decided, what was not, and the instruction or warning. **No full sentences.**

Round 2 — deliver it. In pairs, two minutes each. The listener ticks the six checklist items and notes any verb they think **overstates** what the source said.

Round 3 — the closing question. The listener asks exactly one thing: *so what's actually been decided?* If the speaker has to re-explain, item 4 was not clear enough. Then two clarifying questions:

Who's doing what by when? · Did anyone actually object? Was that a firm commitment or not? · What's the risk if it goes wrong?

Round 4 — the fairness pass. Swap one verb each of you would change, and say why. This is the most valuable ninety seconds in the lesson.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** reporting either the source discussion above or a real one from your own work, containing all six checklist items. Then answer **two clarifying questions**, unrehearsed.

 **Save this recording.** Unit 10 is professional communication — meetings, presentations, negotiations — and this summary is the skill that unit assumes you already have.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your two-minute report.
- Complete the **Unit-8 quiz** — choosing the precise reporting verb, verb + *-ing* / *that*, verb + *to* / object + *to*, and spotting pattern mismatches.
- **Summarise your next real meeting out loud in ninety seconds.** In English, before you do anything else. That habit is what this unit was for.
- Keep the three chunks alive: *suggested doing* · *promised to* · *warned me not to*.

REMEMBER — افكر

- The reporting verb is your **analysis of the speech act**. Choosing it is making a claim.
- Four patterns, decided by the verb: + *-ing* · + *that* · + *to* · + **obj** + *to*.
- Ask **whose action is it?** — that settles whether a person is required.
- ***not to***, before the verb. And ***not stays stressed***.
- **Mark decided against discussed explicitly**, or nobody knows what is true.
- ***Agreed to look at it*** is not ***agreed to it***. Accuracy beats range.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke for about two minutes, unscripted, in English.
- ☐ I used four or more reporting verbs across three or more patterns, each correctly structured.
- ☐ I said explicitly what was decided and what was not.
- ☐ I reported every commitment at its actual strength.
- ☐ I can justify each verb choice as fair to the person.
- ☐ My listener did not have to ask what had been decided.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 8 complete — a summary people can act on



STAGE 3 · UNIT 9

REGISTER & NUANCE

👑 UNIT 9 — REGISTER & NUANCE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: stop sounding like a textbook. Match how you speak to the room you are in, soften without going vague, and start collecting the word partnerships that make English sound natural.

The errors people notice about your English are no longer grammatical. They are about **fit**. Register mistakes are almost never experienced as language problems — they land as *he seems cold*, *she was quite blunt*, *he's trying too hard*. The judgement attaches to you rather than to your English, which is exactly why it is worth fixing on purpose.

And one myth gets dismantled here: formal is not better. Too formal is a real error with a social cost, and it is the one learners produce while believing they are being careful.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Formal or informal	four markers, one message, two versions — and consistency
L02	Diplomacy & softening	soft frame, hard content — requests, bad news, disagreement
L03	Collocations	<i>make a decision</i> , not <i>do a decision</i> — the biggest naturalness lever you have
L04	Reading the room	two dials , and the gear change when the stakes move
L05	Unit task 🎙️	one message, two registers — plus the judgement to say which you'd send

Grammar spine: register markers (word choice, contractions, phrasal against Latinate verbs, directness, passive, nominalisation) · softening and hedging devices · high-frequency collocations across four patterns · register selection and mid-interaction shifting. **Accent Lab:** register-appropriate prosody — **formal is the one place in Stage 3 where you reduce LESS** · the softening rise · hedges **unstressed** · understatement delivered flat and quiet · collocations as **single chunks with one stress** · warmth as pitch movement. **Mindset:** code-switching confidently. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- The ability to say one message two ways, and the judgement to know which the room needs.
- *I'm afraid...* — two words that let bad news be heard.

- A **collocation notebook**, which is the one habit from this stage that keeps paying after the course ends.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** formal ↔ informal conversion · choosing the diplomatic version · collocation matching · register-audience fit · spotting over-softening and over-formality.
- **Speaking task:** the L05 two-register performance plus the justification, scored on the B2 rubric with **appropriateness weighted above complexity**.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **register prosody** and **politeness intonation** (both named U12 clinic inputs), collocation errors logged precisely since they do not self-correct, and each learner's notebook habit.

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 10 — PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

meetings, presentations, negotiations and calls — where register, diplomacy and collocations stop being exercises and become the job.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · read the room, and sound like you belong in it

FORMAL OR INFORMAL — SAYING THE SAME THING TWO WAYS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1 range *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md](#) · **S3-U9-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say one message two ways — to a friend and to a client.
- Spot the four markers that make English formal or informal.
- Judge what a situation actually needs. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

By now your English is good enough that the errors people notice are no longer grammatical. They are about **fit**.

Consider a real situation. You need someone to send you a file. To a colleague you sit next to: *can you ping me that file when you get a sec?* To a client you have never met: *I'd be grateful if you could send the file over when you have a moment.* Both sentences are perfect English. Swap them, and you have two problems — the first sounds presumptuous to the client, and the second sounds oddly stiff and distant to the colleague, as though you were displeased with them.

That second failure is the one worth talking about, because it is the one learners produce and do not notice. There is a widespread assumption that formal English is more correct, safer, more impressive. It is none of those things. It is one register among several, appropriate in some rooms and wrong in others. A learner who writes *I would be most grateful for your assistance in this matter* to a teammate has not been polite; they have been strange, and the strangeness reads as coldness or as showing off. Being too formal is not a safe default — it is a mistake with a different flavour.

Here is why it goes unnoticed. Register errors are almost never experienced as language errors. Nobody thinks *his register is off*; they think *he seems a bit cold*, or *she was quite blunt*, or *he's trying too hard*. The judgement lands on you as a person rather than on your English, which is precisely why it is worth fixing deliberately. In your first language you calibrate this without thinking, from decades of exposure. In English you have to do it on purpose until it becomes automatic.

The good news is that the markers are few and learnable. English formality lives mostly in four places: **word choice** (*get* against *receive*), **contractions** (*I'd* against *I would*), **phrasal against single-word verbs** (*put off* against *postpone*), and **directness** (*send me the file* against *I'd be grateful if you could*). Change

those four and the same content moves register cleanly. You do not need a different vocabulary — you need a second version of a few hundred everyday choices.

One thing to be clear about before we start: **consistency matters more than any individual choice.** *I would be grateful if you could sort it out ASAP* mixes a formal frame with two informal items and sounds worse than either version done properly. Pick a register and stay in it.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّن (ONE IDEA, PLAINLY)

Say each in the simplest way you can:

1. Ask someone to send you a document.
2. Tell someone you cannot attend a meeting.
3. Ask for more time on something.

Now say number one again — as if to a client you have never met.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip — the same message, twice. Read both:

To a colleague, by message:

Hey — did you get a chance to look at the deck? No rush, but I need to send it out Thursday, so if you can have a quick look before then that'd be great. Also, they've pushed the client call to Friday, FYI.

To the client, by email:

Dear Ms Haddad,

I wanted to check whether you had received the presentation I sent last week. We are hoping to circulate the final version on Thursday, so any comments you are able to provide before then would be very much appreciated.

I should also mention that the client call has been moved to Friday.

Kind regards,

Same three pieces of content: *did you get it, I need comments by Thursday, the call has moved.* Now compare the choices:

	Colleague	Client
verb	<i>get</i>	<i>receive</i>
contraction	<i>they've, that'd</i>	<i>we are, you are</i>
phrasal verb	<i>look at, pushed to</i>	<i>provide comments, has been moved</i>
directness	<i>if you can have a quick look</i>	<i>any comments you are able to provide would be appreciated</i>
voice	active	<i>has been moved</i> — passive

Notice the last row. The formal version uses a **passive** to avoid naming who moved the call — Unit 6's grammar doing register work here.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (FOUR MARKERS)

1. WORD CHOICE

Informal	Formal
get	receive · obtain
kids	children
a lot of	a great deal of · considerable
but	however
so	therefore · consequently
ask for	request
need	require
show	demonstrate · indicate
find out	establish · determine
big / huge	significant · substantial

2. CONTRACTIONS

Informal: *I'd, we've, they're, don't, that'd* Formal: *I would, we have, they are, do not*

This is the fastest single marker. Contractions everywhere reads as casual; none at all reads as formal or, in speech, as slightly severe.

3. PHRASAL VERBS AGAINST SINGLE-WORD VERBS

Informal (phrasal)	Formal (Linate)
put off	postpone
bring up	raise
look into	investigate
find out	discover
go up	increase
set up	establish
deal with	address · handle
sort out	resolve

This is the one most learners have backwards. **Phrasal verbs are the informal option**, and they are the more natural one in speech. If you have been avoiding phrasal verbs because they feel difficult, you have been sounding more formal than you intended.

4. DIRECTNESS

Direct (informal)	Indirect (formal)
<i>Send me the file.</i>	<i>Could you send me the file?</i>
<i>Can you look at this?</i>	<i>I'd be grateful if you could look at this.</i>
<i>I can't come.</i>	<i>I'm afraid I won't be able to attend.</i>
<i>That's wrong.</i>	<i>I think there may be an error.</i>
<i>What do you want?</i>	<i>How can I help?</i>

And two more, in the formal direction: the **passive** (*the call has been moved*) and **nominalisation** — turning verbs into nouns (*we decided* → *the decision was taken*). Both remove people from sentences, which is much of what formality does.

CONSISTENCY IS THE RULE

✗ *I would be grateful if you could sort it out ASAP.* — formal frame, informal verb, informal abbreviation. ✓ *I would be grateful if you could resolve this as soon as possible.* ✓ *Any chance you could sort this out today?*

Both fixes are fine. The mixture is not.

FORMAL IS NOT BETTER

To a teammate: *I would be most grateful for your assistance in this matter.* — cold, or showing off. To a client: *Can you just ping me that?* — presumptuous.

The question is never *how formal should I be?* It is *what does this room need?*



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Informal	Formal
get	receive / obtain
put off	postpone
sort out	resolve
look into	investigate
ask for	request
I can't come	I'm afraid I won't be able to attend
Can you...?	I'd be grateful if you could...
No rush	at your convenience
Thanks a lot	Thank you for your assistance
a lot of	a considerable number of
FYI	for your information
Let me know	Please advise



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (REGISTER LIVES IN THE VOICE TOO)

Register is not only vocabulary. The **same sentence** shifts register through delivery.

Cue 1 — formal speech is crisper and less reduced. More full vowels, fewer squeezed auxiliaries, slightly slower:

Informal: /aɪd bi 'greɪt fəl/ — squeezed. Formal: /aɪ wəd bi 'greɪt fəl/ — each word given its weight.

This is the one place in Stage 3 where **not** reducing is the right choice. Everywhere else, squeeze.

Cue 2 — informal speech links and reduces heavily:

did you get a chance to → /dɪdʒə 'getə 'tʃænstə/ *have a quick look* → /hævə 'kwɪk 'lʊk/

Cue 3 — formal delivery has more even stress and clearer clause boundaries. Informal speech has bigger peaks and more collapsed valleys. Read both versions of the model aloud back to back and you will hear it immediately.

Cue 4 — warmth is carried by pitch movement, not by words. A formal sentence delivered flat sounds severe:

I'd be grateful if you could look at this. 📈📉 — warm, cooperative. Same sentence, monotone — a reprimand.

This is the bridge into L02: politeness is at least half prosody, and a grammatically polite sentence said flatly still sounds rude.

Cue 5 — do not over-articulate to sound formal. Speaking slowly and hitting every syllable does not read as educated; it reads as cold or as reading aloud. Formal English is crisper, not slower and heavier.

🎧 **Record one sentence twice** — once for a colleague, once for a client. Play them to a partner and ask which was which. If they cannot tell, the difference is only on paper.



TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Make it formal.

1. *Can you send me the numbers?*
2. *We put the meeting off till Tuesday.*
3. *I'll look into it and let you know.*
4. *Sorry, I can't come.*
5. *We got a lot of complaints about it.*

B. Make it informal.

1. *I would be grateful if you could provide an update.*
2. *The matter has been resolved.*
3. *Please advise at your earliest convenience.*
4. *I regret to inform you that I will be unable to attend.*

C. Fix the mixture.

Each mixes registers — choose one and make it consistent:

1. *I would be grateful if you could sort it out ASAP.*

2. Hey — *I regret to inform you that the deck isn't ready.*
3. Dear Ms Haddad, just wanted to check you got my email.

D. Which register? Say what each situation needs, and why:

1. Asking a colleague you sit next to for a file.
2. Emailing a client you have never met.
3. Replying to a complaint from a customer.
4. Messaging your manager about being ten minutes late.
5. Writing to a university admissions office.

E. Too formal. Each of these is wrong for the situation. Say why, and fix it:

1. To a teammate: *I would be most grateful for your assistance in this matter.*
2. To a friend: *I am writing to enquire whether you are available on Saturday.*

YOUR TURN — دورك

Take **one real message** you need to send. Say it twice — once informally, once formally. Then say **which one you will actually send, and why**.

Informal: "Hey, any chance you could look at the deck before Thursday? No rush otherwise." Formal: "I wanted to ask whether you might have time to review the presentation before Thursday. Any comments would be much appreciated." I'll send the informal one — she's on my team and we message all day. The formal one would sound like I was annoyed with her.



Record both versions and your reason. Check: could a listener tell them apart from your **voice** alone?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post one message in **both** registers.
- **Stop avoiding phrasal verbs.** They are the natural, informal option, and avoiding them has been making you sound more formal than you meant. Use three this week in casual conversation.
- Read one email you received in English and identify the four markers. Then ask whether the register matched the relationship.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Four markers: **word choice · contractions · phrasal against Latinate verbs · directness.**

- **Phrasal verbs are the INFORMAL option.** Avoiding them makes you sound stiff.
 - Formality also uses the **passive** and **nominalisation** — both remove people from sentences.
 - **Consistency beats any single choice.** A mixed-register message is worse than either version done properly.
 - **Formal is not better.** Too formal is a real error with a social cost.
 - The question is never *how formal?* — it is ***what does this room need?***
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I can name the four markers and give a pair for each.
 - ☐ I know phrasal verbs are the informal choice.
 - ☐ Both my versions were internally consistent.
 - ☐ A partner could tell them apart from my voice.
 - ☐ I can say which register a situation needs, and why.
 - ☐ I understand why over-formality is a mistake, not a safe default.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the question is not how formal, but what the room needs

DIPLOMACY & SOFTENING — POLITENESS UNDER PRESSURE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 *Built from:*
[curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md](#) · **S3-U9-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Ask for something without putting anyone on the spot.
- Deliver bad news so it can be heard.
- Disagree without a fight — and say no and mean it. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

English does something that surprises speakers of many other languages: it makes requests, criticism and disagreement **longer**. Where a direct translation would give you *send me the report*, English professional culture gives you *I was wondering if you could send me the report when you get a chance*. Four times the words for the same instruction.

That extra length is not padding and it is not weakness. It is doing a specific job: it leaves the other person **room to say no**. *Send me the report* assumes compliance. *I was wondering if you could...* frames it as a request that could in principle be declined — and because it could be declined, agreeing to it is a choice rather than an obedience. That is the mechanism, and once you see it, all the softening devices make sense as one strategy rather than a list of phrases.

Here is why it matters practically. Learners who have not built this sound blunt in English, and — this is the important part — **they do not sound blunt in their own language**. The bluntness is an artefact of translating direct structures into a language that expects indirect ones. Colleagues do not conclude *his English is developing*; they conclude *he's quite abrupt*, which is a judgement about character. The whole cost of missing this is paid in how you are perceived rather than in how your English is rated.

There is a resistance worth addressing head on. Softening can feel dishonest, or servile, or like a waste of words — *why not just say what I mean?* The answer is that you **are** saying what you mean; you are just also signalling that you are aware of the other person's position. Notice who uses this language most in any English-speaking workplace: it is not the junior people. It is the senior ones, because they are the ones for whom a badly-handled request has consequences. *I'm afraid we're going to have to push back on this* is not weaker than *no*. It is a refusal you cannot easily be angry about, which makes it more effective.

And the limit, which matters just as much. Softening must not remove the message. *I'm afraid there may possibly be a slight issue with some of the figures* has hedged the content out of existence — the recipient

does not know whether anything is wrong. Diplomacy is the **frame**, not the content: a softened sentence still contains the bad news, still names the problem, and still asks for the thing. *I'm afraid there's a problem with the figures — the totals in section three don't reconcile* is diplomatic **and** specific. That combination is the target.

Finally, and this is why half the lesson is pronunciation: all of this collapses if your voice does not cooperate. *I was wondering if you could possibly help* delivered flat and fast is a demand wearing polite clothes, and native listeners hear the voice over the words every time.

WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01)

Say each twice — once for a colleague, once for a client:

1. Ask for a file.
2. Say you cannot make a meeting.

Then say, as bluntly as you can: "*The figures are wrong.*" Notice how it feels to receive that.

WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. Three difficult jobs, all handled:

A: [REQUEST] Hi Nadia — I was wondering if you'd have time to look at the forecast this week? No pressure if not, I know you're buried. **B:** I can probably do Thursday. What's the deadline? **A:** Friday, ideally.

B: [BAD NEWS] Right. I'm afraid I won't be able to get to it properly before Friday, then. I could give you a quick sanity check tomorrow, but a real review would have to wait until next week. **A:** That's helpful, thanks. Actually — while you're here, can I ask about section three?

B: [DISAGREEMENT] Go on. Although I should say, I'm not sure I agree with the approach there. The growth assumption looks quite optimistic to me. **A:** You think it's too high? **B:** I do, yes. Fourteen percent would be the best year the company's ever had. I'd be inclined to model something lower as well, just so you've got both. **A: [PUSHING BACK]** The board asked for fourteen specifically. **B: [HOLDING THE POSITION]** I understand — and I'm not suggesting you drop it. I'd just want a second scenario next to it, so nobody's surprised later.

Study what B does. The bad news is **specific** — *not before Friday*, and here is what I **can** do. The disagreement is softened (*I'm not sure I agree, looks quite optimistic, I'd be inclined to*) and it still contains a hard fact: *fourteen percent would be the best year the company's ever had*. And when pushed, B **holds the position** while conceding the frame: *I understand — and I'm not suggesting you drop it*.

That is diplomacy doing its actual job. Nothing was softened away.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (THREE JOBS, ONE STRATEGY)

The strategy: leave the other person room. Every device below does that one thing.

1. REQUESTS — MAKE IT DECLINABLE

Device	Example
<i>I was wondering if...</i>	<i>I was wondering if you'd have time to look at this.</i>
<i>Would it be possible to...</i>	<i>Would it be possible to move the call?</i>
<i>Do you think you could...</i>	<i>Do you think you could send it today?</i>
<i>if you get a chance</i>	<i>...if you get a chance.</i>
<i>no pressure if not</i>	<i>...no pressure if not.</i>
<i>when you have a moment</i>	<i>...when you have a moment.</i>

Past forms feel softer. *I was wondering* is more tentative than *I wonder*; *I wanted to ask* softer than *I want to ask*. English uses past tense as distance.

2. BAD NEWS — I'M AFRAID, THEN BE SPECIFIC

Device	Example
<i>I'm afraid...</i>	<i>I'm afraid we won't make Friday.</i>
<i>Unfortunately...</i>	<i>Unfortunately the supplier has withdrawn.</i>
<i>It looks like we're going to have to...</i>	<i>...push the date back.</i>
<i>There's been a bit of a problem with...</i>	<i>...the delivery.</i>
then: what you CAN do	<i>I could give you a quick check tomorrow.</i>

I'm afraid is the single most useful phrase here. It signals bad news coming, so the listener braces, and it costs two words.

Always follow bad news with what you can offer. Bad news plus an alternative is a professional communication. Bad news alone is a problem handed over.

3. DISAGREEMENT — SOFTEN THE FRAME, KEEP THE SUBSTANCE

Device	Example
<i>I'm not sure I agree with...</i>	<i>I'm not sure I agree with the approach.</i>
<i>I see it slightly differently</i>	—
<i>I'd be inclined to...</i>	<i>I'd be inclined to model something lower.</i>
<i>That may be true, but...</i>	—
<i>I take your point, although...</i>	—
<i>Wouldn't it be better to...?</i>	<i>Wouldn't it be better to show both?</i>

Then hold it. When pushed, concede the frame and keep the position:

I understand — and I'm not suggesting you drop it. I'd just want a second scenario next to it.

THE UNIVERSAL SOFTENERS

hedges: *quite, slightly, a bit, rather, somewhat, fairly* **openers:** *to be honest · with respect · if I'm honest · I have to say* **minimisers:** *just, only, a little*

That's wrong. → That looks slightly off to me. That's too expensive. → That's a bit more than we were expecting.

British-influenced professional English uses understatement heavily: *not ideal* means bad; *a bit of a problem* can mean a serious one; *I'm not entirely convinced* means no. Learn to **hear** it as much as to produce it.

THE LIMIT — DO NOT SOFTEN AWAY THE MESSAGE

✗ *I'm afraid there may possibly be a slight issue with some of the figures.* — nothing has been communicated. ✓ *I'm afraid there's a problem with the figures — the totals in section three don't reconcile.*

Soft frame, hard content. That is the formula.

AND SAYING NO

I'm afraid I can't take that on at the moment. · I'd love to, but I honestly haven't got the capacity. That's not going to be possible, unfortunately.

Then **stop**. Over-explaining a refusal invites negotiation. One reason is enough.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
I was wondering if...	<i>I was wondering if you'd have time.</i>
Would it be possible to...?	<i>Would it be possible to move it?</i>
no pressure if not	<i>...no pressure if not.</i>
I'm afraid...	<i>I'm afraid we won't make Friday.</i>
unfortunately	<i>Unfortunately the supplier withdrew.</i>
what I can do is...	<i>What I can do is send a draft.</i>
I'm not sure I agree	<i>I'm not sure I agree with that.</i>
I'd be inclined to...	<i>I'd be inclined to wait.</i>
I take your point, although...	<i>I take your point, although...</i>
a bit / slightly / quite	<i>That's a bit more than we expected.</i>
not ideal	<i>It's not ideal, honestly.</i>
I'm not entirely convinced	<i>I'm not entirely convinced.</i>
to be honest	<i>To be honest, I'd rather not.</i>

🎤 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (HALF OF DIPLOMACY IS THE VOICE)

This is the most consequential Accent Lab in the unit. A polite sentence said flatly is rude.

Cue 1 — the softening rise. Requests and disagreements lift at the end, gently:

I was wondering if you'd have time to look at this. ↗

Deliver that with a hard fall and it becomes an instruction. The words did not change.

Cue 2 — slow down on the bad news. Speeding up through *I'm afraid* signals you want it over with, which reads as either guilt or indifference:

I'm afraid (small pause) we're not going to make Friday. ↘

Cue 3 — hedges are unstressed. *quite, a bit, slightly* should be light. Stress them and you have emphasised the criticism you were trying to soften:

✓ *That's a bit more than we were expecting.* ✗ *That's a **BIT** more than we were expecting.* — now it is sarcasm.

Cue 4 — warmth is pitch movement. English politeness needs your voice to **move**. A monotone polite sentence is heard as cold or insincere. Practise the same request twice — flat, then with movement — and hear the difference.

Cue 5 — the refusal falls and stops. *I'm afraid I can't take that on at the moment.* 📌 Then silence. A rising tail on a refusal invites negotiation; trailing off makes it sound negotiable.

Cue 6 — hold the position without hardening the voice. *I understand — and I'm not suggesting you drop it.* The words concede; the pitch stays warm; the position does not move. That combination is what senior people sound like.

🎧 **Record one request twice** — once flat, once with the softening rise. Play both to a partner and ask which one they would rather receive. Then do the same with a refusal.

🏋️ TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Soften the request.

1. *Send me the figures.*
2. *I need this by Thursday.*
3. *Can you cover my shift?*
4. *Move the meeting.*

B. Deliver the bad news — with *I'm afraid*, something specific, and what you **can** do:

1. The delivery will be a week late.
2. You cannot attend the client dinner.
3. The report will not be ready on Friday.
4. The price has gone up.

C. Disagree diplomatically — soft frame, hard content:

1. *That number is far too high.*
2. *That won't work.*
3. *You've misunderstood the brief.*

D. Fix the over-softening. Each has hedged the message away:

1. *I'm afraid there may possibly be a slight issue with some of the figures.*

2. *It might perhaps be somewhat difficult to potentially deliver by then.*

E. Say no, and hold it. In pairs. One asks; the other declines diplomatically. The asker then asks **again**. Hold the refusal without hardening your tone.

F. Hear the understatement. What do these actually mean?

1. *It's not ideal.* · 2. *I'm not entirely convinced.* · 3. *There's been a bit of a problem.*
2. *That's an interesting approach.* · 5. *With respect...*



YOUR TURN — دورك

Handle **all three jobs** in about a minute, about something real:

- a **request** that leaves room to decline
- **bad news**, specific, with what you can offer
- a **disagreement** with a soft frame and hard content

I was wondering if you'd have a chance to look at the draft this week — no pressure if you're stretched. I should say, I'm afraid I won't get you the full version before Friday; the data only arrived yesterday. What I can do is send you section one tomorrow so you can start. And on the growth figure — I'm not sure I agree with fourteen percent. It'd be the best year we've ever had. I'd be inclined to model a second scenario alongside it.



Record it. Then the real test: play it to a partner and ask *did that sound warm or cold?*



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a diplomatic version of a blunt message.
- **Use *I'm afraid once this week*** before real bad news. It is two words and it changes how the next sentence lands.
- **Practise the refusal.** Say no to one small thing, diplomatically, and do not over-explain. One reason, then stop.
- Listen for understatement in English at work. *Not ideal* is doing a lot of work.



REMEMBER — افكر

- The strategy is one thing: **leave the other person room to say no.**
- *I'm afraid* signals bad news in two words. Then **be specific**, then say what you **can** do.
- Disagreement: **soft frame, hard content.** Then **concede the frame and hold the position.**

- **Past forms are softer:** *I was wondering* beats *I wonder*.
 - **Do not soften away the message.** A hedged sentence with no content communicates nothing.
 - **Half of diplomacy is intonation.** A polite sentence said flat is rude. **Hedges stay unstressed.**
-

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ My request left the other person able to decline.
 - ☐ My bad news was specific and came with an alternative.
 - ☐ My disagreement kept a hard fact inside a soft frame.
 - ☐ I did not hedge the message out of existence.
 - ☐ My hedges were unstressed.
 - ☐ A partner said it sounded warm, not cold.
 - ☐ I held a refusal through a second ask without hardening my tone.
-

Empire English 🏰 — soft frame, hard content, and a voice that moves

COLLOCATIONS — THE WORDS THAT GO TOGETHER

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 · **Lesson 3** 🕒 ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md](#) · S3-U9-L03

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Say *make a decision*, not *do a decision*.
- Reach for the natural partner word instead of the correct-but-odd one.
- Start collecting these deliberately, for good. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

There is a category of English error that no rule will save you from and no listener will ever correct.

I did a mistake. We must do a decision. There was a strong rain. Every one of those is grammatically fine, completely comprehensible, and immediately identifiable as non-native. English says *make a mistake*, *make a decision*, *heavy rain* — and there is no reason. *Make* and *do* both mean roughly *perform*; rain is heavy rather than strong for no discoverable cause. These are **collocations**: words that happen to go together, learned as pairs, not derived from anything.

This matters more than it sounds, for two reasons.

The first is that collocations are the biggest single thing separating "good English" from "natural English" at your level. Your grammar is now largely sound. Your vocabulary is broad. What still marks your English is word **partnerships** — reaching for a word that is correct in meaning but not the one that belongs there. A learner who fixes fifty collocations sounds dramatically more native than a learner who learns fifty new words, because the fifty words were probably ones nobody uses.

The second reason is the difficult one: **nothing in a conversation will ever correct these**. If you make a grammar error, someone might rephrase you. If you say *do a decision*, the listener understands perfectly and moves on. The error is invisible to the conversation and completely visible to the listener. That means collocations do not improve by exposure alone — you have to collect them on purpose. This is one of the few places in language learning where deliberate note-taking genuinely beats immersion.

There is also a fluency benefit that is easy to miss. A collocation is stored and retrieved as **one unit**. When you say *make a decision* you are not building a phrase; you are producing a chunk you already own, which frees your attention for the rest of the sentence. Speakers who have hundreds of these sound faster and more fluent not because they think faster but because large parts of their sentences are prefabricated. That is what fluency actually is at this level, and it is buildable.

So the practical shape of this lesson is unusual. There is very little to understand and quite a lot to collect. The most important thing you will take from it is not the list below — it is the **habit** of noticing a word pair, writing it down as a pair, and using it three times this week.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (WHAT DO YOU ALREADY HAVE?)

Complete each with the verb English actually uses:

1. ____ a decision · 2. ____ a mistake · 3. ____ a break · 4. ____ progress
2. ____ an exam · 6. ____ attention · 7. ____ a risk · 8. ____ someone a favour

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — اسمع وشوف

Watch the clip, then read. The collocations are in bold:

A: How did the review go? **B:** Better than I expected. We've **made real progress** on the backlog, and I finally **took the opportunity** to **raise the resourcing issue**. **A:** How did that land? **B:** She **paid attention**, which was something. She **made it clear** she can't **do anything** about headcount this quarter, but she **took the point** about the workload. **A:** Better than nothing. **B:** I also **made a case** for moving the deadline. She said she'd **give it some thought** — which usually means no, but occasionally means yes. **A:** And the appraisal part? **B:** Fine. She **raised a couple of concerns** about the documentation, which is **a fair point**. I've been **cutting corners** there. **Heavy workload**, but that's not really an excuse. **A:** So you'll fix it? **B:** I'll **make a start** this week. **Do my best**, anyway.

Sixteen collocations in a short exchange. Now try replacing a few with words that mean the same thing:

*✗ We've **done real progress**. · ✗ She **gave attention**. · ✗ She **lifted a couple of concerns**. ✗ I've been **cutting angles**. · ✗ I'll **do a start**.*

Every substitution is comprehensible and wrong. That gap — comprehensible and wrong — is the whole category.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (PATTERNS, AND A LOT OF COLLECTING)

A collocation is a word partnership with no reason behind it. You store the pair, not the rule.

THE FOUR BIG VERBS

Verb	Takes	Examples
make	decisions, mistakes, progress, effort	<i>make a decision · make a mistake · make progress · make an effort · make a case · make a start · make it clear</i>
do	work, tasks, favours, vaguer things	<i>do the work · do your best · do someone a favour · do research · do damage</i>
take	opportunities, risks, time, actions	<i>take a break · take a risk · take the opportunity · take responsibility · take action · take the point</i>
give	attention, thought, advice, a chance	<i>give it some thought · give advice · give someone a chance · give a presentation</i>

make against do is the classic. Rough guide: *make* for creating and producing, *do* for performing and completing. It is a tendency, not a rule — *make a decision* but *do research*.

ADJECTIVE + NOUN

Natural	Not
<i>heavy rain · heavy traffic · heavy workload</i>	<i>strong rain</i>
<i>strong opinion · strong accent · strong argument</i>	<i>heavy opinion</i>
<i>deep concern · deep sleep</i>	<i>big concern</i> (weaker)
<i>serious problem · serious mistake</i>	<i>strong problem</i>
<i>fair point · fair amount</i>	<i>just point</i>
<i>close relationship · close call</i>	<i>near relationship</i>

Notice *heavy* and *strong* — near-synonyms that partner with completely different nouns.

ADVERB + ADJECTIVE

deeply concerned · highly unlikely · perfectly clear · absolutely essential · fairly straightforward utterly pointless · widely accepted · genuinely surprised

These are worth having because they are how English intensifies without repeating *very*. *Very unlikely* is fine; *highly unlikely* is what people say.

VERB + PREPOSITION

depend on · rely on · consist of · result in · lead to · deal with · insist on concentrate on · apologise for · succeed in · responsible for

Store the preposition **with** the verb. *Depend of* and *insist about* are the errors that persist longest, and there is nothing to reason from.

THE PROFESSIONAL SET — WORTH OWNING AS CHUNKS

raise a concern · raise an issue · make a case · take the point · give it some thought · bear in mind take on board · draw attention to · come to a decision · reach an agreement · meet a deadline · miss a deadline

raise is the professional verb learners most under-use. *Raise a concern* is what you do in a meeting; *say a problem* is not.

THE COLLECTION HABIT — THE ACTUAL TAKEAWAY

1. **Write pairs, never single words.** *Deadline* is nearly useless. *Meet a deadline / miss a deadline* is usable.
2. **Take them from real input** — what you read, hear and watch — not from lists.
3. **Use each one three times this week**, out loud. Three uses is roughly what it takes to own one.
4. **When you are unsure, search the pair**, not the word. If a pair returns almost nothing, it is not a collocation.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
make a decision	<i>We need to make a decision this week.</i>
make progress	<i>We've made real progress.</i>
make a case for	<i>I made a case for moving the deadline.</i>
make a start	<i>I'll make a start this week.</i>
take a risk	<i>They weren't willing to take a risk.</i>
take the point	<i>She took the point about the workload.</i>
take responsibility	<i>He took responsibility for it.</i>
give it some thought	<i>She said she'd give it some thought.</i>
pay attention	<i>Nobody was paying attention.</i>
raise a concern	<i>She raised a couple of concerns.</i>
meet a deadline	<i>We met the deadline, just.</i>
heavy workload	<i>It's been a heavy workload.</i>
a fair point	<i>That's a fair point.</i>
highly unlikely	<i>That's highly unlikely.</i>
bear in mind	<i>Bear in mind we're a person short.</i>
cut corners	<i>I've been cutting corners.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (ONE CHUNK, ONE STRESS)

Cue 1 — a collocation has a single stress pattern. Say it as one word, not two or three:

/meɪkə dɪ'sɪʒn/ — make a decision, with the stress on **-CI-**. /teɪkə 'breɪk/ · /peɪ ə'tenʃn/ · /meɪk 'pragres/

Storing them with their rhythm is what makes them come out whole under pressure. A collocation you assemble word by word is one you will assemble wrongly.

Cue 2 — the article vanishes. make a → /meɪkə/, take a → /teɪkə/, have a → /hævə/. Never a full /eɪ/.

Cue 3 — the adverb + adjective pairs have the stress on the ADJECTIVE:

deeply **conCERNED** · highly **unLIKEly** · perfectly **CLEAR** · absolutely **esSENTial**

Cue 4 — verb + preposition links, and the preposition is unstressed:

depend on → /dɪ'pendən/ · deal with → /diˈlwið/ · result in → /rɪ'zʌltɪn/

Cue 5 — chunks are what make speech sound fast. Speakers who sound fluent are not thinking faster; they are producing prefabricated units. Every collocation you own as a chunk is a piece of a sentence you no longer have to build.

 **Record five collocations** in full sentences. Listen for one thing: does each pair come out as **one** unit, or as separate words?

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. make, do, take or give?

1. ____ a decision · 2. ____ your best · 3. ____ a break · 4. ____ attention
2. ____ a risk · 6. ____ progress · 7. ____ someone a favour · 8. ____ it some thought
3. ____ responsibility · 10. ____ a mistake · 11. ____ research · 12. ____ a case for

B. Fix the collocation.

1. *I did a mistake in the report.*
2. *There was a strong rain yesterday.*
3. *She gave attention to the detail.*
4. *We must do a decision today.*
5. *He said a concern about the timeline.*
6. *It depends of the budget.*
7. *That's a big concern for me.*
8. *I want to do a start on it.*

C. Upgrade the phrasing. Replace each with a collocation:

1. *We are going forward well.* → We're **making good progress**.
2. *I want to say a problem.*
3. *She said she would think about it.*
4. *Please remember we are short-staffed.*
5. *That is very not likely.*

D. Adjective partners. *heavy, strong, deep or serious?*

1. ____ traffic · 2. ____ opinion · 3. ____ concern · 4. ____ mistake
 5. ____ workload · 6. ____ argument · 7. ____ sleep · 8. ____ accent

E. Self-source. Find **five** collocations from something you read or watched in English this week. Write them as **pairs**, and teach two of them to a partner.

 YOUR TURN — دورك

Talk for about **a minute** about your work or studies, using **at least five** collocations from this lesson.

We've made decent progress this quarter, although the workload's been heavy and I've been cutting corners on the documentation. My manager raised a concern about that, which is a fair point. I've made a case for bringing someone in, and she said she'd give it some thought — so I'm not holding my breath. We did meet the main deadline, just.

 **Record it.** Count your collocations. Then check: did each come out as **one chunk**?

 YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a short text using **five** target collocations.
- **Start a collocation notebook today.** Pairs only, sourced from real input. Five a week is plenty; five hundred a year is transformative.
- **Use three of this lesson's collocations out loud this week.** Three uses is roughly what it takes to own one.
- When you are unsure, **search the pair**, not the word. If it returns almost nothing, it is not English.

 REMEMBER — افكر

- A collocation is a **word partnership with no reason behind it**. Store the pair.
- **make** creates · **do** performs · **take** seizes · **give** offers. A tendency, not a rule.
- These errors are **comprehensible and wrong**, so **nothing in conversation will ever correct them**. Collect on purpose.
- **raise** is the professional verb you are under-using: *raise a concern, raise an issue*.
- Store the **preposition with the verb**: *depend on, result in, deal with*.
- **One chunk, one stress.** Prefabricated units are what fluency is actually made of.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I know which of *make*, *do*, *take* and *give* goes with the common nouns.
- ☐ I can fix *did a mistake*, *strong rain* and *depends of*.
- ☐ I used *raise a concern* correctly.
- ☐ I said each collocation as one chunk, not as separate words.
- ☐ I have started a notebook, with **pairs** in it.
- ☐ I sourced five collocations from real input this week.

Empire English 🏰 — the biggest naturalness lever you have, and nobody will ever correct it for you

READING THE ROOM — ADAPTING REGISTER TO THE SITUATION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 · **Lesson 4** 🕒 ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md](#) · **S3-U9-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Read a situation and pick the register it needs.
- **Change gear** mid-conversation when the stakes shift.
- Combine register, diplomacy and collocations without thinking about it. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

You now have the pieces: formal and informal markers, softening devices, natural collocations. This lesson is about the judgement that decides which to use, and judgement is the part nobody can give you a list for.

Start with a common mistake. Learners often assume register is set by the **topic** — serious subject, formal language. It is not. You can discuss a genuinely serious problem in completely casual English with someone you work closely with: *honestly, this is a mess and I don't know how we fix it*. And you can discuss something trivial in formal English with a stranger: *I wanted to check whether the parcel had been delivered*. The topic did not decide either one.

Two things decide register, and it is worth holding them separately:

The relationship. How well do you know this person, and what is the hierarchy between you? Close and equal allows casual. Distant or senior pushes formal. This dial moves slowly — it is roughly fixed for a given person, and it shifts over months.

The stakes. What happens if this goes wrong? Low stakes allow casual even with a stranger; high stakes push formal even with a friend. This dial moves **fast**, sometimes inside a single conversation.

That second dial is where the real skill lives, and it is what this lesson is for. Consider a conversation with a colleague you have known for years. You are talking about the weekend, someone's kids, a series you are both watching — comfortably informal. Then they mention that the client has threatened to walk. Everything about the language should change: you slow down, you soften, you become more careful and more specific, and the jokes stop. The relationship has not changed at all. The stakes have.

Missing that gear change is what makes someone seem tone-deaf, and it is one of the more damaging things you can do in a second language — not because it is rude but because it reads as **not understanding the situation**. Staying casual when the stakes rise looks like you have not grasped that they have risen. This is far more consequential than any grammatical error you are still making.

The reverse matters too, and learners do it more often. Staying formal when the stakes drop — continuing to say *I would be grateful if you could* to someone who has just started joking with you — reads as coldness, or as an inability to relax. English speakers move down the register scale as a signal of warmth, and not following them is noticed.

So the practical skill is: read the two dials, choose, and be ready to **change** when one of them moves. Native speakers do this continuously and unconsciously. You will do it consciously for a while, and then it becomes automatic.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (THE THREE TOOLS, FAST)

Thirty seconds each:

1. Say one thing **formally**, then the same thing **informally**.
2. Soften a request with a device from L02.
3. Use three **collocations** in one sentence about work.

Then: *who is the most formal person you speak English to, and the least? Say why.*



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. **One conversation, two register shifts.** Read along:

A: Morning. How was the weekend — did you get to the coast in the end? **B:** We did. Two hours of traffic each way, but worth it. Yours? **A:** Quiet. I mostly slept.

— *the gear change* —

B: Listen, before the stand-up — have you seen the email from Haddad? **A:** No. What's happened? **B:** They're saying that if the demo slips again they'll look at other suppliers. It's quite carefully worded but that's what it means. **A:** Right. Okay. That's... not ideal. **B:** No. I wanted to flag it to you before it comes up in the meeting, so you're not hearing it cold. **A:** I appreciate that. Do we know whether it's coming from her or from above her? **B:** I'd guess above. She's been reasonable throughout — I don't think this is her doing.

— *and back down* —

A: Okay. Let's talk properly after the stand-up. Coffee? **B:** God, yes.

Look at what happens across those three sections. The **relationship never changes** — they are colleagues who talk easily throughout. What changes is the **stakes**, and the language moves with them:

	Opening	Middle	Close
Sentence length	short, fragmentary	longer, more complete	short again
Softening	none needed	<i>quite carefully worded, not ideal, I'd guess</i>	none
Collocations	—	<i>flag it to you, coming from above her</i>	—
Speed	quick	slower	quick
Humour	present	absent	back

And notice the two smallest signals. "*Listen, before the stand-up*" opens the gear change — a single word warning the other person that the subject is about to become serious. And "*Coffee?*" closes it.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (TWO DIALS, AND THE GEAR CHANGE)

THE TWO DIALS

Dial	What it asks	Moves
Relationship	How close? What hierarchy?	slowly — roughly fixed per person
Stakes	What happens if this goes wrong?	fast — can shift mid-sentence

Topic does not set register. A serious subject with a close colleague can be entirely casual. A trivial subject with a stranger is formal. Read the dials, not the subject.

THE GRID

Close	fully casual — <i>can you ping me that?</i>	careful but warm — <i>listen, we've got a problem</i>
Distant	polite neutral — <i>could you send that over?</i>	fully formal — <i>I wanted to raise a concern regarding...</i>

The interesting box is **close + high stakes**, which is where most difficult professional conversations happen. It is not formal, and it is not casual either: it is **direct, slow, softened and specific**, with the warmth intact.

THE GEAR CHANGE

Signal it. One word or phrase is enough, and it prepares the other person:

Listen — · Actually, before we get into that — · Can I flag something? · On a more serious note — While I've got you — · Look, I need to tell you something.

Then change four things:

Move	Going up (stakes rise)	Going down (stakes fall)
pace	slow down	speed up
sentence length	longer, complete	short, fragmentary
softening	add it	drop it
humour	park it	bring it back

And close it. When the serious part is over, signal that too: *Anyway. · Right — coffee? · Let's pick it up after.* Without a closing signal the whole conversation stays heavy, and the other person does not know they are allowed to relax.

AUDIENCE CHECKLIST — FOUR QUESTIONS, TWO SECONDS

Who? How close, and what hierarchy? **What's at stake?** For them, not only for you. **Which channel?** Message, email, call, in person. Email is more formal than a call about the same thing. **What have they just done?** If they went casual, follow them. If they went formal, follow that too.

That last one is the most useful. **Follow the other person's register.** They are telling you what they need, and mirroring it is both easier and safer than deciding alone.

TWO FAILURES, BOTH REAL

Staying casual when stakes rise — reads as *not understanding the situation*. More damaging.
Staying formal when stakes fall — reads as *cold or unable to relax*. More common.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Open a gear change	<i>Listen — · Can I flag something? · Actually, before we get into that — · On a more serious note —</i>
Soften bad news at high stakes	<i>I wanted to flag it before it comes up. · It's quite carefully worded, but...</i>
Understate	<i>That's not ideal. · That's a bit of a problem. · It's not great.</i>
Hedge an attribution	<i>I'd guess it's coming from above her. · I don't think this is her doing.</i>
Acknowledge warmly	<i>I appreciate that. · Thanks for telling me. · Good to know.</i>
Close the serious part	<i>Anyway. · Right — let's pick it up after. · Coffee?</i>
Check the register	<i>Is this a call or an email conversation? · Do you want the short version?</i>
Mirror upward	<i>Of course — I'll put it in writing.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PROSODY CARRIES THE GEAR CHANGE)

Most of a register shift is heard before any of the words are processed.

Cue 1 — high stakes: slow down and reduce less. Fewer squeezed auxiliaries, more complete words, more space between phrases. This is the L01 point applied under pressure.

Cue 2 — low stakes: speed up, link everything, use fragments.

/dɪdʒə 'gettə ðə 'koust/ — did you get to the coast — one run.

Cue 3 — the signal word takes a pause after it. *Listen — (pause).* That pause is what makes the other person stop and attend. No pause and the warning does nothing.

Cue 4 — understatement is delivered flat and low. *That's not ideal* said with emphasis becomes sarcasm; said flat and quiet it carries real weight:

That's... not ideal. 📉 — quiet, slow.

Cue 5 — the close comes back up. *Right — coffee?* 📈 Brighter, faster, higher. That lift is the permission to relax, and learners who miss it leave the conversation heavy.

Cue 6 — warmth survives the seriousness. In the close + high stakes box, the pitch still needs to **move**. Flat delivery of a serious message reads as anger or blame, which is not what you meant.



Record three sentences — a casual opener, a high-stakes middle, a casual close. Play them to a partner and ask them to tell you where the register changed, without seeing the words.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Read the dials. For each, say where relationship and stakes sit, and what register you would use:

1. Asking a close colleague for a file you need in ten minutes.
2. Telling that same colleague the client has threatened to leave.
3. Emailing a supplier you have never met about a late delivery.
4. Messaging your manager that you will be fifteen minutes late.
5. Telling your manager you are resigning.
6. Replying to a customer complaint on behalf of your company.

B. Same message, three audiences. *The deadline has moved to Friday.* Say it to:

1. a teammate · 2. your manager · 3. the client

C. Signal the change. Add an opener and shift register:

1. *(casual chat) → the invoice hasn't been paid in three months*
2. *(casual chat) → I'm leaving the company*
3. *(casual chat) → there's a mistake in the figures you sent the board*

D. Follow the other person. Your partner opens in a register you must match — casual, neutral or formal. Reply in the same one. Three rounds, and they do not tell you which.

E. Fix the mismatch. Say what is wrong and correct it:

1. To a teammate you joke with daily: *I would be grateful if you could revert on this matter.*
2. To a client you have never met, about a serious delay: *Hey — bit of a mess with the delivery, sorry!*
3. In a conversation that has just turned to a lost account: *Anyway, did you see the match last night?*



YOUR TURN — دورك

Have a **one-minute conversation** that changes gear. Start casual, move to something high-stakes with a signal, handle it, then close and come back down.

Include: a **signal word**, at least one **softening device**, two **collocations**, and a **closing signal**.

"Morning — how was the drive? ... Listen, before the stand-up: have you seen Haddad's email? They're saying if the demo slips again they'll look elsewhere. It's carefully worded but that's what it means. I wanted to flag it before it comes up, so you're not hearing it cold. ... Anyway — let's talk properly after. Coffee?"



Record it. Then the test: could a partner hear where the register changed, from your **voice** alone?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post the same message adapted to **two** audiences.
- **Follow the other person's register** for a week. When someone goes casual with you, go casual back. It is the easiest and safest way to get this right, and it is what native speakers actually do.
- **Notice one gear change** in a real conversation this week — the moment the stakes rise. Watch what the other person does with pace and softening.



REMEMBER — افكر

- **Two dials: relationship** (slow) and **stakes** (fast). **Topic does not set register.**
- The hard box is **close + high stakes**: direct, slow, softened, specific — and still warm.
- **Signal the gear change.** *Listen* — plus a pause does the whole job.
- Going up: **slow down, lengthen, soften, park the humour.** Going down: reverse all four.
- **Close the serious part**, or the conversation stays heavy.
- **Follow the other person's register.** They are telling you what they need.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can name the two dials and say which moves faster.
- ☐ I know why a serious topic does not automatically mean formal language.
- ☐ I signalled my gear change with a word and a pause.
- ☐ I slowed down and softened when the stakes rose.
- ☐ I closed the serious part so we could relax again.
- ☐ A partner could hear the shift without reading the words.

Empire English 🏰 — read the room, change gear, and come back down again

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: SAME MESSAGE, TWO REGISTERS 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 9 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK ⌚ ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit9-register-and-nuance.md](#) · **S3-U9-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you prove you can code-switch:

- **one message, two registers** — about two minutes in total
- a **softening device** in each, and **collocations** throughout
- **prosody** that matches each register
- then explain **which one you'd actually send, and why** 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. A **formal/informal pair** — same idea, two ways.
2. A **softening device** for a request.
3. *I'm afraid...* plus specific bad news.
4. Three **collocations** in one sentence.
5. The **two dials** that set register, named.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

The message: a piece of work will be a week late, and the reason is partly the learner's own.

Version 1 — to a teammate, on chat:

Hey — bad news on the migration. I'm not going to make Friday. Partly the data came late, partly I underestimated how much cleanup there'd be. Realistically it's next Wednesday.

I know that's annoying with the demo. What I can do is get you the reporting tables by Friday so you're not blocked on that bit. Sorry — my bad on the estimate.

Version 2 — to the client, by email:

Dear Ms Haddad,

I'm afraid I need to let you know that the migration will not be complete by Friday as planned. The source data arrived later than expected, and on review the volume of cleanup required was greater than our original estimate allowed for.

We are now working to Wednesday the 14th. I appreciate this is not ideal given the demo, and I wanted to raise it with you now rather than closer to the date.

In the meantime, I can make the reporting tables available by Friday, which should allow the demo preparation to continue in parallel.

I apologise for the revised timeline, and I'm happy to discuss it on a call if that would be helpful.

Kind regards,

Same five pieces of content in both: **it's late · why · the new date · what I can offer · an apology.**

Now the comparison:

	Teammate	Client
contractions	<i>I'm, there'd, that's</i>	<i>I am mostly, some I'm</i>
verbs	<i>make Friday, get you, blocked</i>	<i>complete, allowed for, make available</i>
directness	<i>I'm not going to make Friday</i>	<i>I'm afraid I need to let you know that...</i>
apology	<i>my bad on the estimate</i>	<i>I apologise for the revised timeline</i>
ownership	<i>I underestimated</i>	<i>our original estimate — plural, softer</i>
collocations	<i>what I can do is</i>	<i>raise it with you, not ideal, in parallel</i>

Two things worth noticing. Both versions **own the mistake** — the formal one uses *our* rather than *my*, which is softer but not evasive. And both **offer something**: bad news plus an alternative, exactly as L02 required.



THE UNIT-9 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a consistently informal version	contractions, phrasal verbs, direct
2	a consistently formal version	full forms, Latinate verbs, indirect
3	a softening device in each	<i>I'm afraid... · what I can do is...</i>
4	three or more collocations	<i>raise it with you · not ideal · make a start</i>
5	prosody that matches each register	crisper and slower / faster and linked
6	an explanation of which you'd send, and why	<i>...because she's on my team and we message all day.</i>

Item 6 is the assessment. Items 1–5 are execution; item 6 is judgement, and judgement is what this unit was for.

Item 5 is what most learners miss. Two versions that differ only in vocabulary are half a performance. The voice has to change too.



ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (TWO VOICES)

Everyone — the two deliveries. This is the unit's signature target:

Informal: faster, heavily linked, reduced auxiliaries, fragments allowed. /aɪmnatgənə 'meɪk 'fraɪdi/

Formal: crisper, less reduced, slower, complete clauses. /aɪ wʊd laɪk tə ɪn'fɔrm ju/

Stage 3 has taught you to reduce everywhere. **Formal register is the one place where reducing less is correct** — but crisper, not slower and heavier. Over-articulating does not sound educated; it sounds like reading aloud.

Everyone — warmth is pitch movement. Both versions need it. A formal sentence delivered flat is severe; an informal one delivered flat is bored.

Everyone — hedges stay unstressed. *a bit, quite, slightly.* Stress them and you have emphasised the criticism you were softening.

Everyone — understatement is flat and quiet. *That's not ideal* — low, unhurried. Emphasis turns it into sarcasm.

Everyone — collocations are single chunks. /meɪkə 'start/, /reɪz ɪt wið ju/. Assembled word by word they sound constructed.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker, one cue, one sentence, stop.



Record one sentence in both registers. Play both to a partner **without** telling them which is which. If they cannot tell, work the prosody before recording the task.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE BOTH VERSIONS)

Round 1 — pick a real message and find its five parts. Two minutes on paper, bullets only: what the message is, the reason, the consequence or new date, what you can offer, and how you close it.

Round 2 — build the informal version. Deliver it to a partner as if to a teammate. They tick items 1, 3, 4 and 5.

Round 3 — build the formal version. Same content, to a client or senior stakeholder. Partner ticks the same items, plus **consistency** — no informal item leaking into the formal frame.

Round 4 — the blind test. Say one sentence from each version, in a random order. Your partner has to say which register it was, from the **voice**. Two out of two or work the prosody.

Round 5 — justify it. Say which you would actually send and give **two** reasons: relationship and stakes.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record about **two minutes** total:

1. The message, **informally**.
2. The same message, **formally**.
3. **Which you'd send, and why** — relationship and stakes.

 **Save this recording.** Unit 10 is professional communication — meetings, presentations, negotiations — and every one of those assumes you can pick a register and stay in it.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post both versions, plus your reason.
- Complete the **Unit-9 quiz** — formal/informal conversion, choosing the softened version, collocation matching, and register-audience fit.
- **Send the informal one when informal is right.** The habit of defaulting to formal because it feels safer is the thing to break this week.
- **Five collocations in the notebook.** From real input, as pairs. The habit is the deliverable.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Four markers: **word choice** · **contractions** · **phrasal against Latinate** · **directness**. Be **consistent**.
- **Soft frame, hard content.** Never soften the message away.
- Bad news needs *I'm afraid*, something **specific**, and what you **can** do.
- **Collocations are the biggest naturalness lever**, and nothing in conversation will correct them for you.
- **Two dials: relationship and stakes.** Topic does not set register.
- **Formal is not better.** The question is what the room needs.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ Both versions were internally consistent — nothing leaked across.
- ☐ Each version carried a softening device.
- ☐ I used three or more collocations, as chunks.
- ☐ A partner could tell my two versions apart from my voice alone.
- ☐ I said which I'd send and gave two reasons.
- ☐ My message survived the softening — the bad news is still in there.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 9 complete — code-switching, which is one of the clearest signs of an advanced speaker



STAGE 3 · UNIT 10

PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

🏰 UNIT 10 — PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: hold your own in a meeting, present so people can follow, negotiate without conceding for free, and run a call from opening to next steps. This is the **professional half of the flagship promise**.

Everything from Unit 9 stops being an exercise here. Register, softening, collocations — a meeting is where they get used or they were never learned.

The barrier in this unit is rarely language. It is permission and speed: believing you need a complete, correct sentence before you are entitled to speak. Meetings in English run on fragments, and the standard for entering one is far lower than learners think.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Meetings	contribute · interrupt · clarify — the four-second interruption formula
L02	Presentations	hook → roadmap → three points → summary → ask , and the two-beat pause
L03	Negotiating	<i>if you can..., we could...</i> — and never conceding for free
L04	Calls & follow-ups	the purpose sentence , and a voicemail that gets returned
L05	Unit task 🎧	a 3-minute presentation + Q&A, including one <i>I don't know</i>

Grammar spine: meeting, presentation, negotiation and call functions, integrating Stage-3 grammar — conditionals for bargaining, modal passives for rules, reported speech for summarising, U9 diplomacy throughout. **Accent Lab:** the **interruption lift-then-drop** · the **two-beat pause** at transitions · pause **after** the important thing · stress the content not the signpost · numbers **twice and slowly** · final consonants surviving phone compression · *fifteen* against *fifty* is **stress alone** · warm-and-immovable in negotiation · **dropping pitch for Q&A**. **Mindset:** English as a career multiplier. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A **three-minute presentation with Q&A** — a genuine professional artefact and a strong proof clip.
- **Building on that...** — the cheapest entry into any English conversation.

- *I don't know, I'll come back to you by Thursday* — the most professionally valuable sentence in the stage.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** meeting phrases (interrupting and clarifying) · presentation signposting · negotiation moves and the conditional trade · call structure and the voicemail formula.
- **Speaking task:** the L05 three-minute presentation plus Q&A, scored on the B2 rubric with **delivery and interaction weighted equally with content**.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **presentation delivery and emphasis, enunciation and number clarity** (both named U12 clinic inputs), plus a note of who still never interrupts.

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 11 — ABSTRACT TOPICS & DEBATE

frameworks for subjects you have no facts about, structured argument, defending a position under challenge, and moving from small talk to real conversation.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · your voice belongs in the room, and getting in is a formula

MEETINGS — CONTRIBUTE, INTERRUPT, CLARIFY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: Unit 9 (register & diplomacy) Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md` · **S3-U10-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Get into a meeting that is already moving.
- **Interrupt politely** — and be heard doing it.
- Ask for clarification without looking lost. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Here is a pattern that repeats in every multilingual workplace. A learner with genuinely strong English sits through a forty-minute meeting and says almost nothing. Afterwards, in one-to-one conversation, they have three good points about what was discussed. They understood everything. They simply never got in.

That is not a language problem, and it is worth being precise about what it actually is.

Partly it is **speed**. Meetings in English move fast, people overlap, and by the time you have assembled a sentence the topic has moved. The fix for that is having phrases ready that require no assembly — which is why the language in this lesson should be learned as chunks, exactly like the collocations in Unit 9.

But mostly it is **permission**. Many learners believe they need a complete, correct, well-formed contribution before they are entitled to speak. Native speakers do not operate that way at all. Listen to any meeting and you will hear half-formed contributions constantly: *can I just — sorry — on the timeline thing, is that fixed or...?* That is somebody thinking out loud, in fragments, and nobody minds. The standard for entering a meeting is far lower than you think.

The consequence of staying silent is not neutral, and this is why the lesson matters. In most professional cultures that run on English, **visibility in meetings is how contribution is measured**. If your good ideas arrive afterwards, in a message, they are attributed less and remembered less. Being quiet is read as having nothing to add — unfairly, but consistently. Learning to get into the conversation is worth more to your career than another twenty grammar points.

There are three specific skills, and they escalate:

Contributing when there is space. Easy, and the easiest form is **building on** what somebody else just said — *building on what Nadia said, I think...* Low risk, welcome to the speaker you are supporting, and it gets you into the conversation with the smallest possible commitment.

Interrupting when there is not space. This is the one learners avoid, and it is a learnable formula rather than an act of confidence: signal, name your reason, be brief. *Sorry, can I just come in on that? — just quickly* — and then say the thing.

Clarifying when you have not followed. This one is frightening and it should not be. Asking *sorry, when you say "scope", do you mean the deliverables or the timeline?* does not reveal weakness. It usually reveals that three other people did not understand either, and it is one of the most valuable things anyone says in a meeting.

One thing to be clear about: everything in Unit 9 applies here. The softening, the register, the collocations. A meeting is where that unit stops being an exercise.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE UNIT 9)

Thirty seconds each:

1. Soften a **request** with a device from U9-L02.
2. **Disagree** with soft frame and hard content.
3. Three **collocations** about work — *raise a concern, make a case, take the point*.

Then: *when did you last stay quiet in a meeting when you had something to say? Why?*

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the meeting clip, then read. The moves are marked:

CHAIR: ...so that's the timeline as it stands. Any thoughts before we move on?

[CONTRIBUTING] NADIA: I think the sequencing is right. My only worry is the review stage — two days feels thin. **[BUILDING ON] SAMI:** Building on that — if the review is only two days, the sign-off has to be immediate, and historically it never is. **[CHAIR MANAGING] CHAIR:** Fair. Omar, you've done this before — what's realistic? **OMAR:** Four days, honestly. Anything less and we're just pretending.

[POLITE INTERRUPTION] NADIA: Sorry, can I just come in on that? Four days pushes us past the client date, so we'd need to move something else. **[CHAIR ACCEPTING] CHAIR:** Good point. What would you move? **NADIA:** The second demo. It's internal — nobody outside would notice.

[CLARIFYING] SAMI: Just to clarify — when you say the second demo, do you mean the one on the 20th, or the dry run? **NADIA:** The dry run. **SAMI:** Right. Then I'd support that.

[DISAGREEING DIPLOMATICALLY] OMAR: I'm not sure I agree, actually. The dry run is the only place we catch integration problems. I'd rather lose a day of review than lose that. **[HANDING OVER]**

CHAIR: Okay — two views. Nadia, do you want to respond to that, and then we'll decide.

Study four things. Sami's **building on that** is the cheapest possible entry — it borrows Nadia's momentum. Nadia's interruption follows the **formula**: signal, reason, content, and it takes four seconds. Sami's clarification is **specific** — he names the two possibilities rather than saying *I don't understand*. And Omar disagrees using exactly U9-L02's soft frame with a hard fact inside it.

Nobody in that exchange spoke in complete, polished sentences. That is what a meeting sounds like.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THREE SKILLS, ESCALATING)

1. CONTRIBUTING

Move	Language
give a view	<i>I think... · My view is... · From where I'm sitting...</i>
build on (easiest)	<i>Building on that... · To add to what Nadia said... · Picking up on that...</i>
agree and extend	<i>Exactly — and the other thing is... · Yes, and...</i>
disagree (U9-L02)	<i>I'm not sure I agree, actually... · I see it slightly differently...</i>
flag a concern	<i>My only worry is... · The one thing I'd flag is...</i>
support someone	<i>I'd support that. · That's my read too.</i>

Building on is your entry route. It is the lowest-risk contribution available: someone else established the topic, you are adding rather than proposing, and the person you build on is on your side. Use it in your first three meetings and the rest becomes easier.

2. INTERRUPTING — A FOUR-SECOND FORMULA

signal → reason → be brief

Signal	Then
<i>Sorry, can I just come in on that?</i>	say it in one sentence
<i>Can I just add something quickly?</i>	one sentence
<i>Sorry to interrupt, but...</i>	the reason it can't wait
<i>Just on that point —</i>	shortest form; very common
<i>Before we move on —</i>	when the chair is closing the topic

Three rules:

Signal first. Never start with your content. The signal is what makes it an interruption rather than talking over someone. **Give a reason if you can.** ...*because that changes the date* justifies the interruption in four words. **Be brief.** An interruption buys you one point, not a speech. Make it, then hand back.

And hand back explicitly: *Sorry, go on.* · *That's all — carry on.* Returning the floor is what makes people happy to let you take it next time.

3. CLARIFYING — BE SPECIFIC, NOT LOST

✗ *Sorry, I don't understand.* — hands the problem over with no help. ✓ *Sorry, when you say "scope", do you mean the deliverables or the timeline?* — names the ambiguity.

Move	Language
check a term	<i>When you say X, do you mean...? · Sorry, X in what sense?</i>
check you followed	<i>Just to clarify — you're saying...? · So the plan is..., is that right?</i>
ask for more	<i>Could you expand on that? · Can you say a bit more about...?</i>
check a number	<i>Sorry, was that fourteen or forty?</i>
buy a moment	<i>Sorry, one second — let me make sure I've got that.</i>

Clarifying is high-status, not low-status. The person who asks *do you mean the deliverables or the timeline?* has just prevented a misunderstanding that would have surfaced in three weeks. Learners consistently believe the opposite.

CHAIRING MOVES — FOR THE STRETCH ROUTE

Omar, you've done this before — what's realistic? — inviting. *Okay, two views. Nadia, do you want to respond?* — managing. *So where we've landed is...* — summarising.

AND THE STANDARD IS LOWER THAN YOU THINK

Meetings run on fragments. *Can I just — sorry — on the timeline, is that fixed?* is a completely normal contribution. You do not need a finished sentence to be entitled to speak.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
Building on that...	<i>Building on that — the sign-off has to be immediate.</i>
My only worry is...	<i>My only worry is the review stage.</i>
Can I just come in on that?	<i>Sorry, can I just come in on that?</i>
Just on that point —	<i>Just on that point — it moves the date.</i>
Sorry to interrupt, but...	<i>Sorry to interrupt, but that changes the timeline.</i>
Just to clarify —	<i>Just to clarify — do you mean the 20th?</i>
When you say X, do you mean...?	<i>When you say scope, do you mean deliverables?</i>
Could you expand on that?	<i>Could you expand on that?</i>
I'd support that	<i>I'd support that.</i>
That's my read too	<i>That's my read too.</i>
Sorry, go on	<i>That's all — sorry, go on.</i>
Before we move on —	<i>Before we move on — one thing.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (INTERRUPTION INTONATION)

An interruption succeeds or fails on **how** it is delivered. The words are the easy part.

Cue 1 — the signal is faster, higher and louder than the surrounding speech. That is what makes it audible over someone who is still talking:

🔊 *Sorry, can I just come in on that?* — quick, lifted, slightly louder.

Delivered at normal volume and pitch, an interruption is simply not heard, and the learner concludes that interrupting does not work for them.

Cue 2 — then drop straight back down for the content. The lift gets you the floor; the drop makes you sound measured rather than agitated:

🔊 *Sorry, can I just come in?* 📉 *Four days pushes us past the client date.*

Cue 3 — just is the softener and it must stay unstressed. /dʒəst/, light and quick. Stress it and the interruption becomes impatient:

✓ *Can I /dʒəst/ come in on that? ✗ Can I **JUST** come in on that? — now you are annoyed.

Cue 4 — clarifying questions FALL. They are wh-questions, and a rise makes them sound disbelieving:

When you say *scope*, do you mean the deliverables? 🗣️

Cue 5 — stress the word you are querying:

When you say **SCOPE**, do you mean... — that is the word you did not follow, so it carries the weight.

Cue 6 — hand back with a fall and a stop. *That's all — sorry, go on.* 🗣️ Trailing off leaves the floor ambiguous and somebody will fill it.

🎧 **Record an interruption twice** — once flat, once with the lift-then-drop. Have a partner talk over you and try both. Only one of them works.

🏋️ TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Build on it. Your partner gives an opinion; you add to it using a building-on phrase. Four rounds, and you may not disagree.

B. The interruption formula. Your partner talks continuously about a topic. Interrupt **three times** using a different signal each time, with a reason, in one sentence. Then hand back.

C. Clarify specifically. Turn each vague confusion into a specific question:

1. *I don't understand what you mean by "the platform".*
2. *I didn't catch the number.*
3. *I'm not sure whether you mean this quarter or next.*
4. *I don't know which team you're talking about.*

D. Disagree, then support. Your partner states a view. Disagree using U9's soft frame with a hard fact — then, in the next round, support them explicitly.

E. Mini-meeting. Four learners, one chair, eight minutes. Topic: *should the team move to four days a week?* Each non-chair must **contribute**, **interrupt once**, and **clarify once**. The chair must **invite**, **manage two views**, and **summarise**.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Record about **a minute** contributing to a meeting on a topic you know. You must include:

- a **contribution** — ideally *building on* something
- a **polite interruption** with a signal and a reason
- a **specific clarifying question**
- one **hand-back**

Building on what Nadia said — my only worry is the review stage. Two days assumes sign-off is immediate, and it never is. ... Sorry, can I just come in on that? Four days pushes us past the client date, so we'd have to move something else. That's all — go on. ... Just to clarify, when you say the second demo, do you mean the one on the 20th or the dry run?

 **Record it.** Check: does your interruption **lift** and then **drop**?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** meeting phrases in use.
- **Interrupt once, in a real meeting, this week.** Signal, reason, one sentence, hand back. Once is enough to prove it works.
- **Use *building on that* in your next meeting.** It is the cheapest entry into any conversation in English.
- Ask one **specific** clarifying question instead of staying quiet. You will find you were not the only one.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Three skills, escalating: **contribute • interrupt • clarify.**
- ***Building on that*** is the **lowest-risk entry** in English. Use it.
- The interruption formula: **signal → reason → one sentence → hand back.**
- **Clarify specifically.** *When you say X, do you mean A or B? — not I don't understand.*
- **Clarifying is high-status.** You are usually preventing a problem for everyone.
- The signal **lifts**, the content **drops**, and **just stays unstressed.**
- **The standard is lower than you think.** Meetings run on fragments.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I contributed by building on someone else's point.
- ☐ My interruption had a signal, a reason and one sentence.
- ☐ My interruption lifted, then dropped — and it was actually heard.

- ☐ My clarifying question named the ambiguity.
 - ☐ I handed the floor back explicitly.
 - ☐ I know I don't need a finished sentence to be entitled to speak.
-

Empire English 🏰 — your voice belongs in the meeting, and getting in is a learnable formula

GIVING A SHORT PRESENTATION — STRUCTURE & SIGNPOSTING

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 · **Lesson 2** 🕒 ~45 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md](#) · **S3-U10-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Structure two minutes so an audience can follow without effort.
- **Signpost** — say where you are and where you are going.
- **Pause** on purpose, which is the whole of good delivery. 🎤

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

A presentation is the one professional speaking task where you get to decide everything in advance — the content, the order, the words, the emphasis. Nothing is spontaneous. That makes it the easiest professional task to be genuinely good at, and the one where preparation pays the highest return.

It also makes it the task where the difference between competent and impressive is almost entirely **delivery**. Two people can present identical content and one is followed easily while the other is not, and the difference is not vocabulary or accent. It is whether they signposted, and whether they paused.

Signposting first, because it is the cheaper win. Your audience is listening once, in real time, with no ability to re-read. They cannot see your structure. So you have to say it: *there are three things I want to cover, so that's the first point, moving on to the second, to sum up*. Those phrases feel almost insultingly obvious to say out loud, and they are the single largest determinant of whether an audience follows you. Without them a listener spends attention working out where they are instead of on what you are saying — and attention spent on navigation is attention not spent on your argument.

Pausing second, and it is the thing nobody does. Under pressure everyone speeds up and stops breathing, which is exactly backwards. A pause does three things at once: it gives your audience a moment to absorb what you just said, it makes the next thing sound important, and it makes you sound in control. Speaking slightly slower with real pauses is the single highest-return change available to any presenter in any language, and it costs nothing to learn.

There is a structural discipline that matters too, and it is a constraint rather than a taste: **three points**. Not five, not seven. An audience listening once can hold roughly three things. If you have seven points you do not have a presentation, you have a list, and your audience will remember two of them at random. Deciding which three is the thinking work, and it is where most of the value of preparing lies.

Finally, one habit to eliminate. Learners very often open by apologising — *sorry, my English isn't very good, I didn't have much time to prepare, this might not be very interesting*. Every one of those costs credibility before the content begins, and none of them helps. Your audience had no complaint until you supplied one. Start with your subject.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE CONNECTORS + MEETING PHRASES)

Fast round:

1. Three **sequencing** connectors: *firstly, moving on, finally*.
2. Two **contrast** connectors: *however, although*.
3. One **meeting** phrase from L01.

Then: *say three things you know about your job, in order, out loud, with the connectors*.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the two-minute model presentation, then read. Structure marked:

[HOOK] Last quarter we lost four clients. Three of them told us the same thing on the way out — they didn't know what was happening with their project.

[ROADMAP] So I want to cover three things: what the actual problem is, what I think we should do, and what it would cost.

[POINT 1] Firstly, the problem. It isn't quality — our delivery scores are the highest they've ever been. It's communication. Clients hear from us when something is finished, and in between they hear nothing. For a six-month project that means five months of silence.

[TRANSITION] So that's the problem. Moving on to what we should do.

[POINT 2] I'd propose a fortnightly update — one paragraph, sent whether or not there is news.

[EVIDENCE] We trialled this with two accounts last year and both renewed. **[HONESTY]** That's a small sample, so I wouldn't over-claim it.

[TRANSITION] Which brings me to the cost.

[POINT 3] About twenty minutes per project per fortnight. Across nine projects that's roughly three hours a month — less than we currently spend on recovery calls after something goes wrong.

[SUMMARY] To sum up: we're losing clients to silence, a fortnightly paragraph would fix most of it, and it costs about three hours a month.

[ASK] What I'd like is a decision to trial it for one quarter. **[CLOSE]** Happy to take questions.

Study five things. It **opens with a fact, not an apology**. The **roadmap** tells you the shape in one sentence. Each **transition** closes the old point before opening the new one — *so that's the problem, moving on to...*

The **summary repeats the three points**, which is what makes them stick. And it ends with a **specific ask**, not with *thank you for listening*.

Note also the honesty: *that's a small sample, so I wouldn't over-claim it*. Volunteering the weakness in your own evidence makes the rest more credible, and it is the U3-L04 hedging discipline applied under pressure.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE SHAPE, AND THE SIGNPOSTS)

THE SHAPE

Part	Job	Time in 2 min
Hook	one fact or question that makes it matter	10 s
Roadmap	<i>I want to cover three things...</i>	10 s
Point 1	claim + evidence	25 s
Point 2	claim + evidence	25 s
Point 3	claim + evidence	25 s
Summary	repeat the three points	15 s
Ask	what you want to happen	10 s

Three points. This is a memory constraint, not a preference. An audience listening once holds about three things. Deciding **which** three is the real preparation.

THE SIGNPOSTS

Job	Language
roadmap	<i>I want to cover three things... · I'll look at X, Y and Z.</i>
open a point	<i>Firstly... · The first thing is... · Let's start with...</i>
close a point	<i>So that's the problem. · That's the first point.</i>
transition	<i>Moving on to... · Which brings me to... · Turning to...</i>
add evidence	<i>We trialled this... · The figures show... · To give you an example...</i>
signal the end	<i>To sum up... · So, to bring it together... · In short...</i>
the ask	<i>What I'd like is... · What I'm proposing is... · My recommendation is...</i>
hand over	<i>Happy to take questions.</i>

Close the old point before opening the new one. *So that's the problem. Moving on to what we should do.* Two sentences, and your audience knows exactly where they are. Learners transition with a single *and then* and lose people.

THE HOOK — FOUR OPTIONS THAT WORK

a number: *Last quarter we lost four clients.* **a question:** *Why do clients leave when they're happy with the work?* **a contradiction:** *Our quality scores have never been higher. And we've never lost more clients.* **a short story:** *A client rang me last month to ask whether we were still working on his project.*

Never open with an apology. *Sorry, my English isn't great. I didn't have much time. This might be boring.* Your audience had no complaint until you gave them one.

THE CLOSE — AN ASK, NOT A THANK YOU

✗ *Thank you for listening.* — fine as a final courtesy, useless as a close. ✓ *What I'd like is a decision to trial it for one quarter.*

A presentation exists to make something happen. Name it.

AND VOLUNTEER YOUR OWN WEAKNESS

That's a small sample, so I wouldn't over-claim it. · I haven't costed the second option properly yet.

This is the U3-L04 discipline: naming the limit of your evidence makes the rest of it more believable, and it disarms the question somebody was about to ask.

🔪 YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Hook	<i>Last quarter we... · Why do...? · Our X has never been higher — and yet...</i>
Roadmap	<i>I want to cover three things: ... · I'll look at X, Y and Z.</i>
Open a point	<i>Firstly... · Let's start with... · The first thing is...</i>
Close a point	<i>So that's X. · That's the first point.</i>
Transition	<i>Moving on to... · Which brings me to... · Turning to...</i>
Evidence	<i>We trialled this... · To give you an example... · The figures show...</i>
Hedge honestly	<i>That's a small sample. · I wouldn't over-claim it.</i>
Summarise	<i>To sum up... · In short... · So: three things.</i>
Ask	<i>What I'd like is... · My recommendation is... · What I'm proposing is...</i>
Close	<i>Happy to take questions.</i>

🎤 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PAUSING AND EMPHASIS)

This is the highest-value Accent Lab in Stage 3. Six minutes, and it changes how learners sound permanently.

Cue 1 — pause AFTER the important thing, not before it. Learners pause to think, which lands the silence in the wrong place. Put it where the audience needs to absorb:

Last quarter we lost four clients. (pause) Three of them told us the same thing.

Cue 2 — pause at every transition. A full stop of silence, longer than feels comfortable:

So that's the problem. (pause — two beats) Moving on to what we should do.

Two beats feels enormous to the speaker and correct to the audience. That mismatch is why nobody does it.

Cue 3 — the roadmap gets three separate beats:

what the problem is (beat) what we should do (beat) and what it would cost.

Run them together and the audience gets none of the three.

Cue 4 — stress the content word, not the signpost. *Firstly* and *moving on* are navigation, not news:

✓ *Firstly, the **PROB**lem.* ✗ **FIRST**ly, the problem.

Cue 5 — numbers get their own space. *Four clients. Three hours a month.* Slow down slightly on any figure — it is what your audience will quote afterwards, and it is the easiest thing in a presentation to mishear.

Cue 6 — slow down overall, and breathe. Under pressure everyone accelerates. The fix is mechanical: **breathe at every transition.** You cannot rush a sentence you have just taken a breath for.

Cue 7 — the summary is delivered slower than the body, and each point falls:

We're losing clients to silence. ↘ A fortnightly paragraph would fix most of it. ↘ And it costs three hours a month. ↘

 **Record your first thirty seconds twice** — once at your natural pace, once with a deliberate two-beat pause at the transition and after the hook. Keep the second.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Choose three. Take a topic you know well and write down **seven** things you could say about it. Then cut to **three**. Say why you cut what you cut.

B. Write the hook. For your topic, produce all four kinds — a number, a question, a contradiction, a short story. Then pick one.

C. Transition pairs. Practise closing and opening in one move:

So that's the problem. Moving on to what we should do.

Do it for all three of your points, out loud.

D. Fix the openings. Each of these damages the speaker. Rewrite:

1. *Sorry, my English isn't very good, so please be patient.*
2. *I didn't really have time to prepare this properly.*
3. *Today I'm going to talk about communication with clients. (true, and no hook)*

E. Write the ask. Turn each vague ending into a specific one:

1. *So, that's what I think about it.*

2. *Thank you for listening.*
3. *I hope that was useful.*

F. Rehearse and time it. In pairs, deliver two minutes. Your partner times the **pauses at transitions** — anything under two beats does not count.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Deliver a **two-minute presentation** on a work or study topic. No slides, no reading.

Required: a **hook**, a **roadmap**, **three points** with evidence, closing-and-opening **transitions**, a **summary** that repeats the three, and a **specific ask**.

 **Record it.** Then listen back once with one question: **where did I pause?** If the answer is *nowhere* or *only to think*, record it again.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a two-minute presentation recording.
- **Pause where it feels too long.** For one week, whenever you finish an important sentence, count two beats before the next one. It will feel wrong and sound right.
- **Never open with an apology again.** Not in English, not in any language.
- Watch one talk in English and mark the signposts. You will hear the shape before you hear the content.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Hook → roadmap → three points → summary → ask.**
- **Three points.** It is a memory constraint, not a preference.
- **Close the old point before opening the new one.** *So that's X. Moving on to Y.*
- **End with an ask**, not a thank you. A presentation exists to make something happen.
- **Volunteer the weakness in your own evidence.** It makes the rest more credible.
- **Pause after the important thing**, two beats at every transition, and **breathe at the transitions.**
- **Never open with an apology.**

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I had exactly three points, and I can say what I cut.
- ☐ My hook was a fact, question, contradiction or story — not an apology.

- ☐ My roadmap named the three things in one sentence.
 - ☐ Every transition closed the old point before opening the new one.
 - ☐ My summary repeated the three points.
 - ☐ I ended with a specific ask.
 - ☐ I paused two beats at every transition, and I can hear them in the recording.
-

Empire English 🏰 — signpost so they can follow, pause so they can absorb

NEGOTIATING — PROPOSE, CONCEDE, BARGAIN

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 · **Lesson 3** ⌚ ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md](#) · **S3-U10-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Propose without demanding.
- **Trade** instead of conceding: *if you can..., we could...*
- Reach a compromise, and still be liked. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Negotiating is not something that only happens over contracts. You negotiate a deadline with a colleague, a scope with a client, a price with a supplier, a start date with an employer, a division of work with a team. It happens constantly and most of it is low-drama. What makes it feel intimidating in a second language is not the stakes — it is that you have fewer moves.

The move that changes everything is the **conditional trade**:

If you can give us until the 20th, we could include the extra reporting.

Look at what that sentence does. It gives something, asks for something, and links the two so that neither is a concession. Compare it with the two alternatives most learners have available. *We need until the 20th* is a demand, which invites a refusal. *Okay, we'll try to make the 14th* is a surrender, which costs you something for nothing. The conditional turns the same situation into an **exchange**, and exchanges get agreed.

This is why the grammar from Unit 4 matters here. You already own *if* + present + *will/could*. You have simply not been using it as a negotiating instrument, and it is the main one there is.

The second principle is a rule rather than a phrase, and it is the most useful thing in the lesson: **never concede without asking for something in return**. Not because you should be adversarial — because a unilateral concession teaches the other side that pushing works. If you drop the price because they asked, they will ask again. If you drop the price *in exchange for* a longer contract, you have made a deal and set a pattern where movement costs something. Even a small ask preserves that: *we could do that, if you can confirm by Friday*.

The third thing is about tone, and learners get it backwards. Being firm and being cold are unrelated. The most effective negotiators in English are **warm and immovable** at the same time: *I completely understand,*

and I'd love to help — but I can't get below eight thousand. Nothing in that sentence is aggressive and nothing in it moves. Learners often assume that holding a position requires hardening the voice, which turns a negotiation into a confrontation and makes agreement harder for everyone.

And finally, the part that gets forgotten: **confirm the agreement out loud**. Say back exactly what was agreed before the conversation ends. *So — the 20th, with the extra reporting, and you confirm by Friday.* Half the disputes that follow a negotiation come from two people leaving the room with different memories of it, and thirty seconds of spoken confirmation prevents most of them.



WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (RETRIEVE THE TWO INGREDIENTS)

Fast round:

1. A **first conditional**: *if you..., we'll...*
2. A **second conditional**: *if you..., we could...*
3. A **softening device** from U9-L02.
4. *I'm afraid...* plus specific bad news.

Then: *ask your partner for an extra week on something, without demanding it.*



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the negotiation clip, then read. The moves are marked:

A: [OPEN — POSITION] So the position is that we can't make the 14th. Realistically we need until the 20th. **B: [PUSH BACK]** The 14th is what we agreed, and it's in the client's diary.

A: [ACKNOWLEDGE, THEN HOLD] I know, and I'm not pretending that's not a problem. But if we ship on the 14th it'll be untested, and that's worse for both of us. **B: [CONDITIONAL PROBE]** What could you do by the 14th? **A: [PARTIAL OFFER]** A working demo — the core flow, not the reporting.

B: [CONDITIONAL TRADE] Alright. If you can get us a demo that covers the client's three main journeys by the 14th, we could take the full release on the 20th. **A: [ACCEPT, WITH A CONDITION]** That works — as long as we agree now that the reporting scope doesn't grow between the two dates. **B: [CONCEDE, WITH AN ASK]** Fine. And in exchange, I'd want the demo by end of play on the 12th so I can look at it before the client does. **A: [MEET IN THE MIDDLE]** The 13th. The 12th genuinely isn't possible. **B:** The 13th, morning. **A:** Done.

[CONFIRM] B: So — demo covering three journeys, 13th in the morning, full release the 20th, reporting scope frozen as it stands. I'll put that in writing this afternoon. **A:** Perfect.

Study four things. **Every concession is paired with an ask** — B gives the 20th but wants the demo early; A accepts but wants the scope frozen. The **conditional trade** does the structural work: *if you can..., we*

could... The **meet-in-the-middle** is one exchange, not a haggle. And the **confirmation at the end** restates everything in one sentence.

Note also that nobody is ever unpleasant. A says *I'm not pretending that's not a problem*, which concedes the frame while holding the position — exactly U9-L02's move.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (FIVE MOVES)

1. PROPOSE — NOT DEMAND

Demand	Proposal
<i>We need until the 20th.</i>	<i>Would you be open to the 20th?</i>
<i>You'll have to pay more.</i>	<i>How would you feel about a slightly higher rate?</i>
<i>Move the deadline.</i>	<i>How about we move it to the 20th?</i>

How about...? · Would you be open to...? · What if we...? · One option would be to...

2. PROBE — FIND OUT WHAT THEY ACTUALLY NEED

What could you do by the 14th? · What's the constraint on your side? What would you need to make that work? · Is the date the issue, or the scope?

Probing is the underused move. You often discover the other side's real constraint is not the one they stated, and that is where the deal is.

3. TRADE — THE CONDITIONAL, AND THE HEART OF THE LESSON

If you can + X, we could + Y.

If you can give us until the 20th, we could include the extra reporting. If you're able to confirm by Friday, we'd hold the price. We could do that, provided the scope doesn't change.

Also: *provided that..., as long as..., on the condition that..., assuming...*

Never concede alone:

✗ Okay, we'll do the 20th. ✓ We could do the 20th — if you can confirm the scope this week.

Even a tiny ask keeps the pattern. A free concession teaches the other side that pushing is free.

4. CONCEDE — GRACEFULLY, AND ONLY SO FAR

I take your point. · That's fair. · I can see why that matters. I'd be willing to... · We could probably live with... Let's meet in the middle. · Could we split the difference?

And hold the limit warmly:

I completely understand, and I'd love to help — but I can't get below eight thousand. That's genuinely not possible for us. What I can do is...

Warm and immovable. Firmness is not coldness, and every bad negotiation in a second language comes from confusing the two.

5. CONFIRM — OUT LOUD, BEFORE ANYONE LEAVES

So — demo on the 13th, full release the 20th, scope frozen. Have I got that right? Let me say that back to you... · I'll put that in writing this afternoon.

Thirty seconds, and it prevents most post-negotiation disputes.

AND THE POSITION/INTEREST DISTINCTION

Position: *we need the 20th.* **Interest:** *we need the release to be tested.*

Positions collide; interests often do not. When you are stuck, say the **interest** — *if we ship untested it's worse for both of us* — and a new option usually appears.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Propose	<i>How about...? · Would you be open to...? · What if we...? · One option would be...</i>
Probe	<i>What could you do by...? · What's the constraint? · What would you need?</i>
Trade	<i>If you can..., we could... · provided that... · as long as... · in exchange, I'd want...</i>
Acknowledge	<i>I take your point. · That's fair. · I can see why that matters.</i>
Concede partly	<i>I'd be willing to... · We could probably live with... · Let's meet in the middle.</i>
Hold the limit	<i>I'd love to help, but I can't go below... · That's genuinely not possible. What I can do is...</i>
State the interest	<i>The reason that matters to us is... · If we do X, it's worse for both of us.</i>
Confirm	<i>So — X, Y and Z. Have I got that right? · Let me say that back.</i>
Close	<i>Done. · That works. · I'll put it in writing.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PERSUASIVE BUT WARM)

Cue 1 — proposals rise gently. A proposal delivered with a hard fall is a demand:

How about the 20th? ↗ — an option. *How about the 20th.* ↘ — an instruction.

Cue 2 — the conditional trade has two halves and a pause between them:

If you can get us a demo by the 14th ↗ **(pause)** *we could take the full release on the 20th.* ↘

The rise on the condition and the fall on the offer is what makes it sound like a deal rather than two separate sentences.

Cue 3 — hold the limit with a WARM voice and a firm fall:

I'd love to help ↗ — *but I can't go below eight.* ↘

The rise carries the goodwill; the fall carries the limit. Do both. A flat delivery of the same sentence sounds like a refusal to engage.

Cue 4 — never harden your voice to be firm. This is the central point. Learners lower and flatten their voice to sound serious, which reads as hostility. The position holds because of what you say, not how heavily you say it.

Cue 5 — numbers get space and stress. *The **THIR**teenth.* Below **EIGHT** thousand. Numbers are what get misremembered, and in a negotiation that is expensive.

Cue 6 — the confirmation is slow and level, one item at a time:

Demo on the 13th **(beat)** full release the 20th **(beat)** scope frozen. 

 **Record the limit sentence twice** — once warm, once flat. Play both to a partner and ask which one they would keep negotiating with.

TRAIN — تَدْرِب (NEGOTIATE)

A. Turn demands into proposals.

1. *We need another week.*
2. *You'll have to lower the price.*
3. *Move the meeting to Thursday.*
4. *I want to work from home on Fridays.*

B. Build the trade. Complete each with a conditional:

1. *If you can confirm by Friday, ____.*
2. *We could include the training, ____.*
3. *____, we'd be able to hold the current price.*

C. Never concede alone. Add an ask to each concession:

1. *Okay, we'll do the 20th.*
2. *Fine, we can absorb the extra cost.*
3. *Alright, you can have the whole team on it.*

D. Hold the limit, warmly. Say each so it is friendly and immovable:

1. You cannot go below a certain price.
2. You cannot deliver before a certain date.
3. You cannot take on an extra project this quarter.

E. Find the interest. For each position, what is the interest underneath?

1. *We need the 20th.* · 2. *The price has to come down.* · 3. *I need to leave by four every day.*

F. Full negotiation. In pairs, eight minutes. One scenario each:

- a supplier wants a price rise; you have a fixed budget
- a colleague wants you to take on a project; you are at capacity
- a client wants a feature added at no extra cost
- you want a later start date on a new job

Each of you must **propose**, **probe**, **trade**, **concede once with an ask**, and **confirm** at the end.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Negotiate with a partner for about **ninety seconds**, then confirm the agreement.

You must include: a **proposal**, a **probe**, a **conditional trade**, one **concession with an ask**, one **limit held warmly**, and a **spoken confirmation**.

"Would you be open to the 20th? ... What could you actually use by the 14th? ... Alright — if you can take a demo covering the three main journeys on the 14th, we could deliver the full release on the 20th. ... I can do that, as long as the reporting scope stays as it is. ... I'd love to give you the 12th, honestly, but it isn't possible — the 13th is the earliest. ... So: demo on the 13th, release the 20th, scope frozen. Have I got that right?"

 **Record it.** Check: did every concession come with an ask, and did you confirm at the end?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post **three** negotiation phrases in use.
- **Never concede without asking for something.** Try it once this week on something small. *I can do that — could you confirm by Friday?*
- **Confirm out loud** at the end of your next agreement, even a casual one. Say it back and watch how often you were about to remember it differently.
- **Practise being warm and immovable.** Firmness is not coldness.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Five moves: **propose • probe • trade • concede • confirm.**
- The trade is the heart of it: *if you can..., we could...*
- **Never concede without asking for something.** A free concession teaches them that pushing is free.
- **Probe.** Their real constraint is often not the one they stated.
- **Warm and immovable.** Firmness is not coldness, and hardening your voice makes agreement harder.
- **Confirm out loud** before anyone leaves. Thirty seconds prevents most disputes.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I proposed rather than demanded.
 - ☐ I probed for their actual constraint.
 - ☐ I used a conditional trade.
 - ☐ Every concession I made came with an ask.
 - ☐ I held one limit warmly, without hardening my voice.
 - ☐ I confirmed the agreement out loud, item by item.
-

Empire English 🏰 — trade, don't concede; warm, and immovable

PROFESSIONAL CALLS & FOLLOW-UPS

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md](#) · **S3-U10-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to**:

- Run a professional call from opening to next steps.
- Leave a **thirty-second voicemail** that gets a callback.
- Say the purpose of your call in one sentence. 🎤

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Ask any advanced learner which English task they avoid and the answer is almost always the same: **the phone call**. Not meetings, not presentations, not writing. Calls.

The reason is worth understanding, because once you see it the fear becomes manageable. A call removes everything you normally rely on. There is no face, so you cannot see whether you have been understood. There is no gesture, no whiteboard, nothing written down. Audio quality is often poor. You cannot ask someone to repeat themselves indefinitely. And unlike a meeting, there is nowhere to hide — you cannot be quiet on a two-person call.

So the compensation has to come from two places, and both are trainable.

Structure. A professional call has a fixed five-part shape: open, purpose, discussion, next steps, close. Because the shape never varies, you can stop improvising the frame and spend all your attention on the content. Learners who dread calls are usually improvising the whole thing including the frame, which is exhausting and unnecessary.

The single most important part is the **purpose sentence** — one sentence, in the first fifteen seconds, saying why you are calling. *I'm calling about the invoice from March.* It orients the other person immediately and it stops the call drifting. Learners often open with pleasantries and arrive at the purpose two minutes in, by which point the other person has been guessing.

Enunciation. On a phone, consonant endings and numbers are the two things that get lost, and they are the two things that matter most. *Fifteen* and *fifty* are genuinely confusable, *can* and *can't* invert your meaning, and a dropped past-tense /t/ changes when something happened. This is where the whole stage's work on endings stops being an aesthetic matter and becomes functional.

Then there is **voicemail**, which deserves separate attention because it is uniquely unforgiving: thirty seconds, no feedback, no second attempt, and a bad one simply does not get returned. It has a four-part

formula — who, why, what you need, when you are available — and delivered in that order with the number said twice, it works. Delivered as a rambling apology, it does not.

Finally, the part that turns a call into progress: **agreeing next steps out loud**. *So I'll send the revised figures today, and you'll come back to me by Thursday*. This is Unit 8's confirmation habit applied to a call, and without it a call is a conversation that changes nothing.

WARM-UP — سَخِّن (RETRIEVE L01–L03)

Fast round:

1. A **polite interruption** from L01.
2. A **conditional trade** from L03.
3. A **specific** clarifying question.
4. Say these aloud clearly: *fifteen · fifty · thirteen · thirty · the 13th · the 30th*.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip — a call, then a voicemail.

The call:

A: [OPEN] Hi, is that Nadia? It's Karim from Meridian. **B: Hi Karim. A: [PURPOSE — one sentence]** I'm calling about the invoice from March — the one that's still showing as unpaid. **B: Right. Is now okay, or shall I call you back? I'm between meetings. A: [CHECK]** Now's fine if you've got five minutes. **B: Go ahead.**

A: [DISCUSSION] So it went out on the 3rd of March, for eight thousand four hundred. Our system says it hasn't been settled, but I wanted to check with you before it goes to a reminder. **B: [CLARIFY]** Sorry — eight thousand four hundred? I've got seven-nine in my notes. **A: Eight-four. Eight thousand, four hundred. There was a change order in February. B: Ah — that'll be it. The change order didn't come through to finance.**

A: [NEXT STEPS] Okay. So shall I resend the invoice with the change order attached? **B: Please. And copy me, not just the finance inbox. A: [CONFIRM]** Right — I'll resend it today with the change order, copying you directly. And you'll get it into this month's run? **B: I'll try. If it lands today, yes. A: [CLOSE]** Perfect. Thanks Nadia — I'll get that over within the hour. **B: Thanks Karim. Bye.**

The voicemail:

Hi Nadia, it's Karim from Meridian — Thursday, about eleven. I'm calling about the March invoice, which is still showing as unpaid on our side. I think there may be a change order missing from your

copy. Could you give me a call back when you get a chance? I'm on 0100 447 2318 — that's 0100 447 2318. I'm around all afternoon. Thanks.

Study the call first. The **purpose arrives in the second sentence**. Karim **checks whether it is a good time**. The number is repeated when queried — *eight-four, eight thousand four hundred* — and next steps are **confirmed out loud with who does what**.

Then the voicemail: **who · why · what I need · when I'm available**, and the number said **twice**. Thirty seconds, no apology, no rambling.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (FIVE PARTS, AND A VOICEMAIL FORMULA)

THE FIVE-PART CALL

#	Part	Language
1	Open	<i>Hi, is that X? It's Y from Z.</i>
2	Purpose — one sentence	<i>I'm calling about... · The reason I'm calling is...</i>
3	Check the timing	<i>Is now a good time? · Have you got five minutes?</i>
4	Discussion	clarify, propose, trade — L01–L03 language
5	Next steps + close	<i>So I'll..., and you'll... · Thanks — I'll get that over today.</i>

The purpose sentence is the most important thing in the call. One sentence, in the first fifteen seconds:

✓ *I'm calling about the invoice from March.* ✗ *Hi, how are you? ... how was your weekend? ... so, anyway, I wanted to ask about, er, there was an invoice...*

Always check the timing. Four words, and it prevents a whole category of bad calls:

Is now a good time? · Have you got five minutes? · Shall I call you back?

PHONE-SPECIFIC MOVES

Situation	Language
bad line	<i>Sorry, you're breaking up a bit. Could you say that again?</i>
didn't catch it	<i>Sorry, I missed that. · Could you repeat the last part?</i>
confirm a number	<i>Eight-four — eight thousand, four hundred.</i>
spell it	<i>That's R for Romeo, A for Alpha...</i>
buy a second	<i>Bear with me one second while I find it.</i>
wrong person	<i>Sorry, I think I need the finance team — could you put me through?</i>

Say numbers twice, in two forms. *Eight-four. Eight thousand, four hundred.* This is standard professional practice on a call, not a sign of weak English.

THE VOICEMAIL FORMULA — FOUR PARTS, THIRTY SECONDS

1. Who — *Hi Nadia, it's Karim from Meridian.* **2. Why** — *I'm calling about the March invoice.* **3. What you need** — *Could you give me a call back?* **4. When and how** — *I'm on 0100 447 2318 — that's 0100 447 2318. Around all afternoon.*

Rules: number **twice**, no apology, no rambling, under thirty seconds. And say the **day and time** you called — voicemails stack up and yours needs a place in the queue.

NEXT STEPS — WHO DOES WHAT, BY WHEN

So I'll resend it today, and you'll get it into this month's run.

Name **both** sides. *I'll look into it* is not a next step; *I'll come back to you by Thursday* is.

AND AFTER THE CALL

I'll follow up with an email so we've both got it in writing. Just to confirm what we agreed on the phone...

A call plus a two-line written confirmation is the professional standard, and it protects both of you.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

English	Example
It's X from Y	<i>It's Karim from Meridian.</i>
I'm calling about...	<i>I'm calling about the March invoice.</i>
Is now a good time?	<i>Is now a good time?</i>
Have you got five minutes?	<i>Have you got five minutes?</i>
you're breaking up	<i>Sorry, you're breaking up a bit.</i>
Could you repeat that?	<i>Sorry, could you repeat the last part?</i>
bear with me one second	<i>Bear with me one second.</i>
So I'll... and you'll...	<i>So I'll resend it, and you'll confirm.</i>
I'll follow up with an email	<i>I'll follow up with an email.</i>
Just to confirm...	<i>Just to confirm what we agreed...</i>
Could you put me through?	<i>Could you put me through to finance?</i>
I'll get that over within the hour	<i>I'll get that over within the hour.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PHONE-CLEAR DELIVERY)

On a call your voice is all there is. Four things carry disproportionate weight.

Cue 1 — numbers, said twice and slowly. The classic confusions:

fifteen /fɪf'tɪn/ — stress on the **second** syllable *fifty* /'fɪfti/ — stress on the **first**

Same for thirteen/thirty, fourteen/forty. **The stress is the only difference**, and on a phone it is easily lost. So disambiguate: *fifteen* — *one five*.

Cue 2 — final consonants survive. Phone compression eats the ends of words, and the ends of words are where English keeps its tense and its negation:

sent · *finished* · *can't* · *won't* · *eight*

can against can't is the one that matters most. On a bad line, drop the /t/ and you have said the opposite. When it is critical, say it a second way: *I can't* — *I'm not able to*.

Cue 3 — slow down by about ten percent. Not more; over-slow sounds patronising. A slight reduction in pace dramatically improves intelligibility on a compressed line.

Cue 4 — the purpose sentence gets its own beat. Pause before and after it:

*It's Karim from Meridian. **(beat)** I'm calling about the March invoice. **(beat)***

Cue 5 — the voicemail is slower than a call. Nobody can interrupt to ask you to repeat, so build the repetition in yourself. Say the phone number at dictation speed, twice, in groups.

Cue 6 — smile audibly on the opening. It sounds absurd and it is real: a raised, warm opening carries across a bad line and sets the tone for the whole call.

 **Record a voicemail.** Play it to a partner who writes down your **number** and your **request**. If either is wrong, record it again.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. The purpose sentence. One sentence for each reason for calling:

1. An invoice has not been paid.
2. You need to move a meeting.
3. A delivery is late.
4. You want to check whether a document arrived.

B. Numbers under pressure. Dictate to a partner, who writes them down. Then swap:

£8,400 · 15% · the 13th · 0100 447 2318 · 40 units · 14:50

C. Phone repair. What do you say when:

1. The line is bad.
2. You missed the last sentence.
3. You need a second to find something.
4. You need a different department.
5. You are not certain you heard a number right.

D. The voicemail. Record a thirty-second voicemail with all four parts. Your partner writes down your number and your request from one listen.

E. Full call role-play. In pairs, four minutes each. One scenario:

- chasing an unpaid invoice
- telling a client a delivery will be late
- rescheduling an important meeting
- following up on a job application

Each call must have all five parts, including **next steps naming both sides**.

F. Difficult caller (stretch). Your partner is annoyed, or will not get to the point. Stay warm, structure the call, reach next steps.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Record **two** things:

1. A **professional call** with a partner — about two minutes, all five parts, ending in next steps that name who does what by when.
2. A **thirty-second voicemail** — who, why, what you need, when you are available, number twice.



Check the voicemail with a listener. Can they write down your number and your request from one listen? That is the only test that matters.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a voicemail and a follow-up confirmation.
- **Say your purpose in the first fifteen seconds** of your next call. One sentence, before the pleasantries expand.
- **Say numbers twice.** *Eight-four — eight thousand four hundred.* It is professional practice, not weak English.
- **Follow up in writing** after your next call. Two lines. It protects both of you.

REMEMBER — افكر

- Five parts: **open · purpose · check the timing · discuss · next steps and close.**
- The **purpose sentence** in the first fifteen seconds. One sentence.
- ***Is now a good time?*** — four words that prevent a whole category of bad calls.
- **Voicemail:** who · why · what you need · when — number **twice**, under thirty seconds, no apology.
- **Next steps name both sides**, with a date. *I'll look into it* is not a next step.
- Numbers **twice and slowly**; **final consonants survive**; *fifteen* and *fifty* differ only by **stress**.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحح لنفسك

- ☐ My purpose sentence came in the first fifteen seconds.
 - ☐ I checked whether it was a good time.
 - ☐ I used at least one phone-repair phrase.
 - ☐ I said a number twice, in two forms.
 - ☐ My next steps named who does what by when.
 - ☐ A listener recovered my voicemail number and request from one listen.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the task everyone avoids, and it has a fixed shape

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: PRESENT + FIELD QUESTIONS



Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 10 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~45 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit10-professional-communication.md](#) · **S3-U10-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you deliver a real professional artefact:

- a **three-minute presentation** — hook, roadmap, three points, summary, ask
- **two or three questions** fielded, including one you cannot fully answer
- **pausing** and **emphasis** that make it easy to follow 🎧

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. A **polite interruption** with a signal and a reason.
2. Three **presentation signposts**.
3. A **conditional trade**.
4. A **purpose sentence** for a call.
5. *fifteen · fifty · thirteen · thirty* — said so a partner can write them down.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model presentation and Q&A. The presentation is the L02 shape at three minutes; the Q&A is the new part.

[PRESENTATION — abbreviated] Last quarter we lost four clients, and three of them said the same thing on the way out: they didn't know what was happening with their project. ... So I want to cover three things: the problem, what I'd do, and what it costs. ... **To sum up:** we're losing clients to silence, a fortnightly paragraph would fix most of it, and it costs about three hours a month. **What I'd like is a decision to trial it for one quarter.** Happy to take questions.

[Q1 — CLARIFICATION] *Who would actually write these updates?* **A:** The project lead each time — so it rotates. I'd rather it came from the person closest to the work than from me. **[CHECK]** Does that answer it, or did you mean who's accountable if it doesn't go out? *Both, really.* **A:** Then me, for the accountability.

[Q2 — CHALLENGE TO THE EVIDENCE] *You said two accounts renewed. Two isn't evidence of anything.* **A: [CONCEDE, THEN HOLD]** You're right that it isn't, on its own — I said at the time I wouldn't over-claim it. What I'd say is that it costs three hours a month to find out properly, and the downside of being wrong is small. That's why I'm asking for a trial rather than a rollout.

[Q3 — THE ONE HE CAN'T ANSWER] *What's the retention rate for clients who do get regular updates?* **A: [HONEST]** I don't know. I looked for that and couldn't find it broken down that way in our data.

[COMMIT] I can find out — give me until Thursday and I'll come back with it. **[REFRAME]** It wouldn't change what I'm proposing, but it would tell us how much to expect.

[CLOSE] CHAIR: Anything else? No? Thanks. **A:** Thanks — I'll send the one-pager round and the retention figure on Thursday.

Study the three answers. Q1 gets a direct answer plus a **check** — *does that answer it?* Q2 is a genuine attack on the evidence and he **concedes the point and holds the ask**, which is only possible because he hedged honestly in the presentation. Q3 he **does not know**, and the answer is the strongest of the three: *I don't know · I looked · I'll come back by Thursday · here's why it doesn't change the proposal.*

That last move is the whole lesson. *I don't know* is not a failure in Q&A. *I don't know* with a commitment and a date is a demonstration of competence.

🧩 THE UNIT-10 CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	hook + roadmap	<i>Last quarter we lost four clients... three things...</i>
2	three points , each with evidence	claim + number or example
3	transitions that close before opening	<i>So that's X. Moving on to Y.</i>
4	summary + a specific ask	<i>What I'd like is a decision to trial it.</i>
5	two or three questions fielded, one incl. <i>I don't know</i>	<i>I don't know — I'll come back by Thursday.</i>
6	audible pauses at transitions, and clear numbers	two beats, numbers slowed

FIELDING QUESTIONS — THE FOUR MOVES

Move	Language
Answer directly, then check	<i>...Does that answer it, or did you mean...?</i>
Concede and hold	<i>You're right that it isn't, on its own. What I'd say is...</i>
Don't know, commit, reframe	<i>I don't know. I can find out — by Thursday. It wouldn't change what I'm proposing.</i>
Buy a moment honestly	<i>That's a good question. Let me think for a second.</i>

Never bluff. An invented answer is the one thing in Q&A that damages you permanently, and the person asking usually knows more about their question than you do.



ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (PRESENTATION PROSODY)

Everyone — the two-beat pause at every transition. From L02, and it is the assessed delivery feature. It feels enormous to the speaker and correct to the audience; that mismatch is why nobody does it.

Everyone — pause AFTER the important thing, not before it while you think.

Everyone — numbers get space and stress. *Four clients. Three hours a month.* These are what the audience quotes back.

Everyone — stress the content, not the signpost. *Firstly, the **PROB**lem* — never *FIRST*ly.

Everyone — the summary is slower than the body, and each of the three points **falls**.

Everyone — in Q&A, drop your pitch and slow down. Presentation prosody is projected; Q&A prosody is conversational. Continuing to present at a question makes you sound defensive.

Everyone — the *I don't know* answer is delivered level and unhurried. Rushed, it sounds like embarrassment. Steady, it sounds like command.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker, one cue, one sentence, stop.



Record your first thirty seconds and your *I don't know* answer. Two things: are the pauses there, and does the *don't know* sound calm?



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (REHEARSE + PREPARE QUESTIONS)

Round 1 — plan and cut. Three minutes on paper. Write seven possible points, cut to **three**, and write your **ask** as a single sentence. No script.

Round 2 — deliver to a partner. Three minutes. Partner ticks items 1–4 and **times the pauses** at transitions.

Round 3 — question preparation. Each listener writes **three** questions: one **clarification**, one **challenge to the evidence**, and one the presenter **probably cannot answer**.

Round 4 — Q&A. Field all three. Use *I don't know* · *I can find out* · *by when* · *why it doesn't change the proposal* on the third.

Round 5 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver the weakest thirty seconds with the pauses corrected.

YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Deliver a **three-minute presentation** on a real work or study topic, then field **two or three questions** including at least one you cannot fully answer.

 **Save this recording. It is a professional artefact** — the closest thing in this stage to what the flagship benchmark will ask for, and with your consent one of the strongest proof clips the programme has. Consent is separate from the course, granular, and you can withdraw it later.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post the presentation and Q&A.
- Complete the **Unit-10 quiz** — meeting phrases (interrupt and clarify), presentation signposting, negotiation moves, and call structure.
- **Say *I don't know, I'll find out by X*** the next time you are asked something you cannot answer. In English, out loud, at work. It is the most professionally valuable sentence in this unit.
- **Use one meeting interruption and one purpose sentence** this week for real.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Hook → roadmap → three points → summary → ask.** Three is a memory constraint.
- **Close the old point before opening the new one**, and **pause two beats** at every transition.
- **End with an ask**, not a thank you.
- In Q&A: **answer and check · concede and hold · don't know, commit, reframe.**
- ***I don't know with a date is a demonstration of competence.*** Never bluff.
- **Drop your pitch for Q&A.** Projecting at a question sounds defensive.

SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I had exactly three points, each with evidence.
- ☐ Every transition closed the old point before opening the new one.
- ☐ I paused two beats at each transition, and I can hear them.
- ☐ I ended with a specific ask.
- ☐ I answered one question by conceding the point and holding my ask.
- ☐ I said *I don't know* with a commitment and a date, calmly.
- ☐ I did not bluff.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 10 complete — the professional half of the flagship promise



STAGE 3 · UNIT 11

ABSTRACT TOPICS & DEBATE

👑 UNIT 11 — ABSTRACT TOPICS & DEBATE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 of 12 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: talk for ninety seconds about something you have never thought about, build an argument somebody can follow, hold your position when it is challenged — and change your mind when you should.

This is the intellectual peak of the stage. Everything from Units 1–10 gets used here in service of thinking, and the next unit is the benchmark itself.

Two beliefs get dismantled. That you need an opinion in advance to have something to say — you need a **shape**, not a view. And that being challenged is an attack — it is **information**, and the strongest available response is sometimes *you've convinced me*.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Abstract topics	three frameworks that generate content on any subject, on demand
L02	Structured argument	claim → evidence → example → conclusion , made audible
L03	Defending & conceding	concede specifically, then hold — and stay calm doing it
L04	Small talk → deep talk	the transition , and the return trip nobody teaches
L05	Unit task 🎤	a 4–5 minute debate — the closest thing yet to the flagship

Grammar spine: thinking frameworks (pros and cons, causes and effects, short against long term) · argument structure with signposting · concession and rebuttal language · conversational transition moves — all integrating Stage-3 grammar, U5 hedging and U9 diplomacy. **Accent Lab:** the **framework marker buys the pause, the pause buys the content** · **contrastive stress on every comparison**, both halves · the concession **falls** and the hold **rises** · *but* and *although* **unstressed** · under challenge: **slow down, drop pitch, breathe** · the transition drops, the **return lifts**. **Mindset:** thinking and arguing in English. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- **Three frameworks** that let you speak for ninety seconds on any topic without preparation.

- *That's a fair point about X — and what I'd say is...* — the move that lets you concede without collapsing.
- A **four-minute unscripted debate**, which is the clearest evidence of what you can now do.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (FORMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** matching topic frameworks · ordering an argument (claim → evidence → example → conclusion) · choosing a concede-then-defend response · small-to-deep transitions.
- **Speaking task:** the L05 four-to-five-minute debate, scored on the B2 rubric with **Coherence and Interaction weighted above Accuracy**.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — **argument coherence**, **persuasive stress** and **composure under challenge** (all named U12 clinic inputs), plus a note of anyone who collapses or stonewalls.

NEXT CAMPAIGN → UNIT 12 — PUTTING IT TOGETHER (B2 FLAGSHIP) ★

consolidation, a personalised accent clinic, a full-length mock, and the **B2 benchmark**: a 20–30 minute conversation on everyday and professional topics, plus the graduation sample that closes the proof timeline.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · you don't need an opinion in advance; you need a shape to think in

HANDLING ABSTRACT TOPICS — FRAMEWORKS INSTEAD OF PANIC

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 · **Lesson 1** 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: B1/B2 opinions
Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md` · **S3-U11-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Talk for ninety seconds about a topic you have never thought about.
- Use **three reusable frameworks** that generate content on demand.
- Say *I don't know much about it, but...* and then be interesting. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Here is the moment this lesson exists for. Somebody asks you, in English, what you think about remote work, or artificial intelligence, or the education system, or whether cities are getting worse. You have thirty seconds of general opinion and then nothing. The conversation stalls, and you conclude your English is not good enough for real discussion.

Your English is fine. What you are missing is **structure to generate content**.

Watch what a fluent speaker actually does when asked something they have not thought about. They do not retrieve a prepared view — they apply a shape. *Well, there are obviously advantages and disadvantages. The advantage is X. The problem is Y. In the short term I'd say Z, but longer term I'm less sure.* That is ninety seconds of coherent speech, and none of it required prior knowledge or an opinion held in advance. It required a **framework** and the willingness to think out loud.

This matters because the Unit-12 benchmark is a twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation on everyday and professional topics. Nobody can prepare for that by memorising positions. What carries you through it is a small number of shapes you can apply to anything, plus enough topic vocabulary to fill them. Learners who freeze on abstract subjects do not fail because of grammar; they fail because they have nowhere to put their thoughts.

The second thing to unlearn is the belief that you must be **informed** to have something to say. You do not. *I don't know much about the details, but my instinct would be...* is how educated speakers routinely open, and it is honest rather than evasive. Compare it with silence, or with a confident claim you cannot support. Naming the limits of your knowledge and then reasoning within them is exactly what Unit 5's hedging taught, and it applies here directly.

There is a fluency mechanism worth understanding too. A framework buys you **time while sounding deliberate**. *There are two ways of looking at this* takes three seconds to say and gives you three seconds to think about what the two ways are. *On the one hand...* commits you to a first point and simultaneously reminds you that a second one is coming. The structure is doing cognitive work, not just organisational work — which is why it reduces panic rather than merely tidying speech.

Finally, vocabulary. Abstract discussion needs a modest set of topic words and collocations — *the root cause, in the long run, a trade-off, the underlying issue* — and these are worth learning as chunks in the Unit-9 sense. Fifteen of them will carry you across almost any abstract topic, because the frameworks are general and the vocabulary of framing is shared.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE OPINION STRUCTURE)

Thirty seconds each:

1. An opinion **with a reason** — U9's discipline.
2. A **hedged** prediction — *may well, probably won't*.
3. Two **connectors of contrast** — *however, although*.

Then: *what do you think about remote work?* Talk for thirty seconds. Notice where you run out.



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. Somebody is asked about a topic they have clearly not prepared:

INTERVIEWER: Do you think universities will still exist in their current form in twenty years?

SPEAKER: [ADMIT THE LIMIT] I don't know enough about the sector to be confident, but I'd guess not entirely. **[FRAMEWORK — SHORT / LONG TERM]** In the short term I think very little changes — institutions are slow and degrees are still the currency employers use. In the longer run I'd be surprised if the three-year residential model survived in the same shape.

[FRAMEWORK — CAUSES] The pressure is coming from two directions really. Cost, obviously — students are taking on debt for something whose value is less certain than it was. And the fact that a lot of the teaching can be done remotely at a fraction of the price, which the pandemic proved fairly conclusively.

[COUNTER-CONSIDERATION] Having said that, what universities actually sell isn't only teaching. It's the network, the signal to employers, and three years of being around people your own age. None of that is easy to replicate online, and I think that's underrated in these conversations.

[NUANCE — THE REAL DISTINCTION] So my honest answer is that the **teaching** will change enormously and the **institution** probably won't. The lectures move online, the degree keeps its value, and the buildings stay.

[HEDGE] Although I could be completely wrong — I'd have said the same about offices in 2019.

Look at what carried that. Two frameworks — **short term against long term**, and **causes** — plus a **counter-consideration** and a **distinction**. No specialist knowledge, one admitted limit at the start and one at the end, and roughly ninety seconds of genuinely interesting speech.

The strongest move is the distinction: *the teaching will change and the institution won't*. Separating two things that the question ran together is what makes an answer sound thoughtful rather than merely long.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (THREE FRAMEWORKS, AND HOW TO ENTER)

THE THREE FRAMEWORKS — LEARN THESE, AND NOTHING ELSE

1. Pros and cons

There are obvious advantages and equally obvious problems. The advantage is... The problem is... On balance I'd say...

2. Causes and effects

The pressure is coming from two directions. First... Second... And the effect of that is... I'd say the root cause is... which then leads to...

3. Short term against long term

In the short term, very little changes... In the longer run, I'd expect...

Any of the three works on any topic. That is the whole point — they are content-free shapes, so you never have to choose the right one, only a usable one.

TWO MORE MOVES THAT MAKE A FRAMEWORK SOUND LIKE THINKING

The counter-consideration. After your first side, deliberately argue against yourself:

Having said that... · The counter-argument would be... · Although in fairness...

The distinction. Separate two things the question ran together. This is the strongest single move in abstract discussion:

*I think the **teaching** will change and the **institution** won't. It depends whether we mean X or Y — those*

are quite different questions.

HOW TO OPEN WHEN YOU KNOW NOTHING

I don't know enough about it to be confident, but my instinct would be... I've not thought about it properly, but off the top of my head... I only know this second-hand, but...

This is not cheating. It is how educated speakers routinely open, and it buys you both honesty and thinking time. Compare it with silence or with a claim you cannot defend.

FRAMING VOCABULARY — FIFTEEN CHUNKS THAT CARRY ANY TOPIC

Chunk	Use
<i>the root cause</i>	the underlying reason
<i>the underlying issue</i>	what's really going on
<i>a trade-off</i>	you gain one thing, lose another
<i>in the long run</i>	over time
<i>on balance</i>	weighing it up
<i>the counter-argument</i>	the other side
<i>that's underrated / overstated</i>	correcting emphasis
<i>it comes down to</i>	the crux
<i>there's a tension between</i>	two things pulling apart
<i>a knock-on effect</i>	a consequence of a consequence
<i>broadly speaking</i>	in general
<i>to some extent</i>	partly
<i>the wider point is</i>	zooming out
<i>what's often missed is</i>	adding something new
<i>that's a separate question</i>	refusing a conflation

Learn these as **chunks**, in the Unit-9 sense. They are the connective tissue of abstract discussion and they are shared across every topic.

AND KEEP HEDGING

Everything from U3-L04 and U5 applies. An unhedged claim about an abstract topic is the easiest thing in the world to attack, which is L03's lesson.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Admit the limit	<i>I don't know enough to be confident, but... · Off the top of my head... · I only know this second-hand.</i>
Pros and cons	<i>There are advantages and problems. · On balance... · The trade-off is...</i>
Causes	<i>The pressure is coming from two directions. · The root cause is... · Which leads to...</i>
Time frames	<i>In the short term... · In the longer run... · Eventually...</i>
Counter-consideration	<i>Having said that... · The counter-argument would be... · Although in fairness...</i>
Distinction	<i>I'd separate two things here. · That's a separate question. · It depends whether we mean X or Y.</i>
Correct the emphasis	<i>That's underrated. · I think that's overstated.</i>
Zoom out	<i>The wider point is... · What's often missed is...</i>
Hedge the whole thing	<i>Although I could be completely wrong. · I'd have said the same about X in 2019.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (PHRASING A LONG UNSCRIPTED TURN)

A ninety-second unscripted turn fails on **breathing and grouping** long before it fails on grammar.

Cue 1 — the framework marker gets its own group, then a pause. That pause is where you think:

*In the short term **(pause)** I think very little changes. Having said that **(pause)** what universities sell isn't only teaching.*

This is the mechanism: the marker buys you the pause, and the pause buys you the content. It is completely invisible to the listener and it feels like control rather than hesitation.

Cue 2 — one idea per thought group. Break at the joins, not at random:

The pressure is coming from two directions // cost, obviously // and the fact that a lot of the teaching can be done remotely.

Cue 3 — contrastive stress on the distinction. Both halves get pushed, or the distinction disappears:

*The **TEACH**ing will change and the **IN**stitution won't.*

Cue 4 — the counter-consideration steps DOWN in pitch, then comes back up. Same parenthesis shape as a non-defining clause in U7:

Having said that ↘ — it's also the network and the signal — ↗ so I'd be cautious.

Cue 5 — the hedge at the end falls and slows. *Although I could be completely wrong.* Rushed, it sounds like a disclaimer nobody means.

Cue 6 — slow down when you are thinking, do not speed up. Under pressure the instinct is to accelerate and fill. Slowing slightly reads as deliberation; accelerating reads as panic, and the words are the same.

 **Record ninety seconds** on any abstract topic. Then listen for one thing: are your pauses **at the framework markers**, or scattered mid-clause?

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. One topic, three frameworks. Take *remote work* and talk for thirty seconds using each framework in turn — pros and cons, causes and effects, short against long term.

B. Find the distinction. Each question conflates two things. Separate them:

1. *Is social media bad for us?*
2. *Should university be free?*
3. *Is AI going to take our jobs?*
4. *Are cities getting worse?*

C. Argue against yourself. State a view, then produce a genuine counter-consideration:

1. Remote work is better for most people.
2. Public transport should be free.
3. Children should learn a second language early.

D. Open with nothing. Your partner names a topic you know nothing about. Open with an **admitted limit** and then apply a framework for thirty seconds. Four rounds, and you may not refuse a topic.

E. Chunk practice. Use five of the framing chunks in five sentences about any topic:

the root cause · a trade-off · on balance · that's underrated · that's a separate question

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak for about **ninety seconds** on an abstract topic. Use **one framework**, one **counter-consideration**, one **distinction**, and a **hedge** at the end.

I don't know much about the education system beyond my own experience, but I'd guess the problem isn't really quality. In the short term what's changing is delivery — everything's online now and that's cheaper for everyone. In the longer run I think the qualification loses value faster than the teaching does, which is the opposite of what people worry about. Having said that, employers are conservative, and they'll keep asking for degrees long after they stop meaning much. So I'd separate two things: whether the teaching improves, which I think it will, and whether the certificate keeps its value, which I doubt. Although I could easily be wrong about the second one.

 **Record it.** Check: did you pause **at** your framework markers, or scatter your pauses?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a framework-based take on a topic.
- **Own three frameworks by name.** Pros and cons, causes and effects, short against long term. Say them out loud until they arrive without searching.
- **Say *I don't know much about it, but...*** once this week and then talk anyway. It is legitimate, and it is the opposite of freezing.
- **Five framing chunks into your notebook**, as pairs.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Three frameworks: pros and cons · causes and effects · short against long term.** Any of them works on anything.
- The **framework marker buys you the pause, and the pause buys you the content.**
- The **distinction** is the strongest move: *the teaching will change, the institution won't.*
- **Argue against yourself** once — *having said that...* — and you sound like you have thought about it.
- *I don't know enough to be confident, but...* is how educated speakers open. It is not cheating.
- **Slow down when you think.** Accelerating reads as panic; the words are identical.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I can name three frameworks without looking.
- ☐ I applied one to a topic I had not prepared.
- ☐ I produced a genuine counter-consideration against my own view.

- ☐ I found a distinction the question had run together.
 - ☐ My pauses landed on framework markers.
 - ☐ I hedged the whole thing at the end.
-

Empire English 🏰 — you don't need an opinion in advance; you need a shape to think in

BUILDING A STRUCTURED ARGUMENT

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 · **Lesson 2** ⌚ ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01 *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md](#) · **S3-U11-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Build **claim** → **evidence** → **example** → **conclusion** without thinking about it.
- Make the structure **audible**, so your listener can follow it.
- Argue a position you do not actually hold. 🎤

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Unit 5 taught you to reason from evidence to a conclusion. This lesson is the same machinery pointed at a **position you want somebody to accept**, and the difference is that now the structure has to be **heard**.

That distinction matters more than it sounds. Consider two speakers with identical reasoning. The first says: *Remote work suits most people better, productivity data from the last few years supports that, our own team shipped more in 2021 than any year before or since, so I think the default should be remote.* The second says the same four things and signposts them: *My main point is that remote work suits most people better. The evidence for that is the productivity data from the last few years. To give you a concrete example, our own team shipped more in 2021 than in any year before or since. So my conclusion is that the default should be remote.*

Same content. The second is more persuasive, and it is not because it is more sophisticated — it is because the listener can **see the shape**. They know when a claim is being made, when evidence is arriving, and when you have finished. A listener who has to work out your structure has less attention available for your argument.

The four parts are not arbitrary and each one does a distinct job. The **claim** is what you want accepted. The **evidence** is why it should be. The **example** makes it real. The **conclusion** tells the listener what to do with it.

Of those, the **example** is the one learners drop, and it is the one that persuades. Abstract claims supported by abstract evidence convince almost nobody: *remote work is better because people are more productive at home* is two generalisations leaning on each other. One concrete instance — a team, a number, a year — does more work than three additional reasons, because it is the thing your listener will remember and repeat. If you have a specific example, use it. If you do not, your argument is weaker than you think.

There is one more habit worth building, and it is the bridge into the next lesson: **argue a position you disagree with**. It sounds like a debating-club exercise and it is genuinely useful for two reasons. It separates the skill of building an argument from the accident of holding an opinion — which means you can construct one on demand rather than only when you happen to care. And it forces you to understand the other side properly, which is exactly what you need when somebody challenges you in L03. You cannot defend a position well without knowing what the strongest attack on it is.

WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE L01)

Thirty seconds each:

1. Name a **framework** and apply it to any topic.
2. Produce a **counter-consideration** — *having said that...*
3. Find a **distinction** in this question: *is technology making us lonelier?*

Then: *state one opinion you hold about your industry, and give a reason.*

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. A tight ninety-second argument, signposted:

[CLAIM] My main point is that we should stop hiring for specific tools and hire for judgement instead.

[EVIDENCE 1] The reason is that tools change faster than people do. Anyone we hired three years ago for a particular platform is now working on something else entirely — the platform lasted eighteen months.

[EXAMPLE — CONCRETE] To give you a specific example: we turned down a candidate in 2022 because she hadn't used our reporting stack. We replaced that entire stack the following spring. So the thing we screened her out for stopped existing about nine months later.

[EVIDENCE 2] And the second reason is that the tool is the easy part. Teaching somebody a new system takes a few weeks. Teaching them to work out what a client actually needs takes years, if it can be taught at all.

[COUNTER + REBUTTAL] Now, the obvious objection is that you can't interview for judgement — it's vague. And that's partly fair. But we already do it for senior roles and nobody complains it's unmeasurable there. We just stop doing it when we hire junior people, which is when it matters most.

[CONCLUSION + ASK] So my conclusion is that we should drop the tool requirements from junior job specs entirely and replace them with a work sample. That's what I'd like us to try for the next two hires.

Study the shape. **Two** pieces of evidence, not five. One **concrete example** with a date and an outcome. The **objection is raised and answered** by the speaker rather than left for someone else. And it ends with a **specific ask**, exactly as U10-L02 required.

The example is the part that does the persuading. *We turned down a candidate for a skill that stopped existing nine months later* is a story, and it will be repeated in the room after the speaker sits down.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (FOUR PARTS, MADE AUDIBLE)

Part	Job	Signpost
Claim	what you want accepted	<i>My main point is... · What I'd argue is...</i>
Evidence	why it should be	<i>The reason is... · The evidence for that is...</i>
Example	make it real	<i>To give you a specific example... · Concretely...</i>
Conclusion	what to do with it	<i>So my conclusion is... · Which is why I'd...</i>

Say the signposts out loud. They feel obvious to the speaker and they are the reason the listener can follow. This is the same principle as presentation signposting in U10-L02: your audience is listening once, in real time, and cannot see your structure unless you say it.

Two pieces of evidence, not five. An argument with five reasons is weaker than one with two, because your listener cannot hold five and will remember the weakest. Choose your two strongest and drop the rest — the discipline is the same as the three-point rule for presentations.

The example is not optional. A claim plus abstract evidence is two generalisations leaning on each other:

✗ *Remote work is better because people are more productive at home.* ✓ *...and concretely, our team shipped more in 2021 than in any year before or since.*

A good example has a **specific**: a number, a date, a name, an outcome. *We turned down a candidate in 2022* beats *sometimes companies reject good people*.

Raise the objection yourself. From U5-L04, and it is even more valuable here:

Now, the obvious objection is that... And that's partly fair. But...

Three things happen. You demonstrate that you have considered the other side, you disarm the attack before it comes, and you invite correction if your rebuttal is weak.

End with an ask, not a summary. An argument exists to change something:

✗ So that's my view on hiring. ✓ So I'd like us to drop the tool requirements for the next two hires.

And be honest about your weakest link. *That's partly fair* is not a retreat; it is what makes the rest credible. Same principle as U3-L04's calibration and U10-L02's *I wouldn't over-claim it*.

🗡️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Claim	<i>My main point is... · What I'd argue is... · My position is...</i>
Evidence	<i>The reason is... · The evidence for that is... · That's borne out by...</i>
Second reason	<i>And the second reason is... · There's also the fact that...</i>
Example	<i>To give you a specific example... · Concretely... · A case in point is...</i>
Raise the objection	<i>Now, the obvious objection is... · The counter-argument would be...</i>
Rebut	<i>And that's partly fair. But... · Which is true, except that...</i>
Concede a limit	<i>I wouldn't over-claim that. · That's the weakest part of my case.</i>
Conclusion	<i>So my conclusion is... · Which is why I'd... · What follows from that is...</i>
Ask	<i>What I'd like us to do is... · So I'd propose...</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (EMPHASIS FOR PERSUASION)

Cue 1 — stress the claim's key word, and stress it again in the conclusion. The repetition is what makes an argument land:

*My main point is that we should hire for **JUDGE**ment, not for tools.* *...So my conclusion is that we drop the tool requirements and hire for **JUDGE**ment.*

Cue 2 — contrastive stress carries every comparison. Both halves get pushed, or the contrast vanishes:

*The **TOOL** is the easy part. The **JUDGE**ment is the hard part.* *Teaching a system takes **WEEKS**. Teaching judgement takes **YEARS**.*

This is the single most persuasive prosodic device in English and learners systematically under-use it.

Cue 3 — the example slows down. Your concrete instance is the part you want remembered, so give it space:

We turned down a candidate **(beat)** in twenty twenty-two **(beat)** because she hadn't used our reporting stack.

Cue 4 — the signposts are unstressed. My main point is, the reason is, to give you an example are navigation:

✓ *My main point is that we should hire for **JUDGE**ment.* ✗ My **MAIN POINT** is that...

Cue 5 — the objection steps down, the rebuttal comes back up:

Now the obvious objection is that you can't interview for judgement ↘ — and that's partly fair ↘ — **but** we already do it for senior roles. ↗

Cue 6 — the conclusion falls hard and stops. Do not trail off. A conclusion that fades sounds like you no longer believe it.

 **Record your claim and your conclusion.** Check that the same word is stressed in both, and that the conclusion **falls and stops**.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Build all four parts. Take one of these and produce claim, evidence, example, conclusion:

1. Meetings should have a default length of fifteen minutes.
2. Every job advert should state the salary.
3. Children should learn statistics instead of trigonometry.
4. Remote work should be the default for office jobs.

B. Supply the example. Each argument has a claim and evidence and no example. Invent a concrete one with a specific:

1. We should invest in training, because turnover is expensive.
2. Public transport should be free, because it reduces congestion.
3. We should test earlier, because late bugs cost more.

C. Cut to two. Here are five reasons for a position. Choose the **two** strongest and say why you dropped the rest:

Remote work: (1) less commuting, (2) wider hiring pool, (3) lower office costs, (4) people prefer it, (5) fewer interruptions.

D. Raise your own objection. For your argument in A, state the strongest attack on it, then rebut it — conceding the fair part.

E. Argue the opposite. Take a position you genuinely disagree with and build all four parts for it. Two minutes' preparation, then deliver it convincingly.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Argue a position for about **ninety seconds**. Required: a **claim**, **two** pieces of evidence, one **concrete example** with a specific in it, an **objection you raise and rebut**, and a **conclusion with an ask**.

 **Record it.** Two checks: is your example concrete enough to be repeated by someone else, and does the same word carry the stress in your claim and your conclusion?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a structured argument on a debatable topic.
- **Put an example in every argument this week.** With a number, a date or a name in it. It is the cheapest upgrade available to your persuasiveness.
- **Raise your own objection** once, out loud, in a real discussion. Watch how differently the reply comes back.
- **Argue one position you disagree with**, for practice. It is uncomfortable and it is the best preparation for being challenged.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Claim → evidence → example → conclusion**, and **say the signposts out loud**.
- **Two pieces of evidence, not five.** Your listener cannot hold five.
- **The example is what persuades.** Give it a number, a date or a name.
- **Raise the objection yourself**, concede the fair part, then hold the position.
- **End with an ask.** An argument exists to change something.
- **Contrastive stress on every comparison** — both halves, or the contrast disappears.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ All four parts were present and signposted out loud.

- ☐ I used two pieces of evidence, not five.
 - ☐ My example had a specific in it — a number, date or name.
 - ☐ I raised the strongest objection myself and conceded the fair part.
 - ☐ My conclusion ended in an ask, and it fell and stopped.
 - ☐ I stressed both halves of every contrast.
-

Empire English 🏰 — the reasoning is half of it; making the shape audible is the other half

DEFENDING & CONCEDED UNDER CHALLENGE

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 · **Lesson 3** ⌚ ~40 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L02 *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md](#) · **S3-U11-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- **Concede a fair point and still hold your position** — in one move.
- Stay calm when somebody disagrees with you in English.
- Change your mind when you should, and say so. 🎤

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Everything you built in L02 gets tested here, and how you handle being challenged says more about you than the argument did.

There are two ways this goes wrong and learners divide fairly evenly between them.

The first is **collapse**. Somebody pushes back and the learner immediately abandons the position: *oh, yes, you're right, I hadn't thought of that*. Sometimes that is genuine and admirable. Usually it is a reflex, driven by the effort of speaking a second language under pressure and by a sense that disagreement is uncomfortable. The cost is that your positions stop meaning anything — if you fold at the first objection, nobody has any reason to take your initial claim seriously.

The second is **stonewalling**. The learner repeats the original claim, slightly louder, with no acknowledgement of what was just said. This is what people do when they have no language for partial agreement, and it reads as either not listening or not understanding. It also makes the other person repeat themselves, which escalates.

The move that avoids both is a single unit: **concede then hold**.

That's a fair point about the sample size — and it's the weakest part of my case. What I'd say is that it costs three hours a month to find out properly, so the downside of testing it is small.

Look at what happens there. The objection is acknowledged **specifically** — not vaguely, but by name. Something is genuinely given up. And then the position is restated, usually reframed rather than repeated. Nobody had to be wrong, and the discussion moved forward.

That is not a rhetorical trick; it is how educated disagreement works in English. And it has a practical benefit beyond the debate: conceding the fair part makes your remaining position **more** credible, not less.

A speaker who has just demonstrated they can distinguish a good objection from a bad one is a speaker whose judgement you trust on the rest.

Then there is the part that is not language at all. **Staying calm.** When somebody challenges you in a language you are still building, your body reacts — you speed up, your pitch rises, your sentences shorten, and you sound defensive even if you feel fine. Listeners hear that as anger or as weakness, and neither is what you meant. The fix is physical rather than linguistic: slow down, breathe, drop your pitch. Deliberately. The words matter less than most learners think.

Finally, the honest case. Sometimes the objection is simply **right**. Then say so properly: *actually, that changes my view — I hadn't accounted for that*. Changing your mind in public is not a defeat; it is the strongest signal of intellectual seriousness available, and it costs one sentence. The Unit-12 benchmark will push you specifically to see whether you can do it.

WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE L02)

Fast round:

1. State a **claim** with **one** piece of evidence.
2. Add a **concrete example** with a specific in it.
3. Raise the **strongest objection** to your own claim.

Then: have your partner attack your claim once. Notice what your voice does.

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. The same position is challenged three times, differently:

SPEAKER: So my position is that we should drop the tool requirements from junior job specs and use a work sample instead.

[CHALLENGE 1 — the evidence] *You're basing that on one candidate from 2022.* **[CONCEDE SPECIFICALLY, THEN HOLD]** That's fair — one example isn't evidence, and I said at the time it's the weakest part of my case. What I'd say is that the cost of trying it is two hires. If it doesn't work we've lost very little.

[CHALLENGE 2 — the practicality] *Work samples take hours to review. Nobody has that time.*

[CONCEDE PARTLY, THEN REFRAME] They do take time, yes — although less than the interviews they'd replace. And the current process isn't free either; we spent six weeks on the last junior hire and she left in four months. I'd rather spend the hours earlier.

[CHALLENGE 3 — the objection that lands] *Work samples exclude people who are already working full time. They haven't got a spare afternoon.* **[GENUINELY CHANGE POSITION]** ...That's a good point, and I hadn't thought about it properly. That would systematically favour people who aren't

currently employed, which is the opposite of what I want. So I'd revise it — a shorter sample, paid, or done live in the interview rather than at home. The principle stands but the mechanism doesn't.

So you're dropping the work sample? **[CLARIFY WHAT SURVIVED]** No — I'm dropping the *take-home* version. Hire for judgement, not for tools; that part I'd still argue for.

Study the three responses. The first **concedes specifically** and holds by reframing the stakes. The second **concedes partly** and turns the objection around — *the current process isn't free either*. The third is the important one: the objection **lands**, and the speaker changes the mechanism while keeping the principle, then **names exactly what survived**.

That last move — separating the principle from the mechanism — is what lets you change your mind without abandoning everything.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (CONCEDE THEN HOLD)

THE CORE MOVE — ONE UNIT, NEVER TWO

acknowledge the specific point → give something up → restate, reframed

That's a fair point about the sample size (specific) — and it's the weakest part of my case (give) .
What I'd say is that the cost of finding out is small (reframe) .

Acknowledge specifically, not vaguely. *That's a fair point* alone is a filler. *That's a fair point about the sample size* proves you were listening, and it is the difference between a real concession and a polite noise.

THE THREE RESPONSES, AND WHEN TO USE EACH

Response	When	Language
Concede and hold	the objection is fair but not fatal	<i>That's fair — and yet... · I take your point, but...</i>
Concede and reframe	the objection is fair and changes the emphasis	<i>They do, yes — although less than... · That's true, except that...</i>
Concede and revise	the objection lands	<i>That's a good point. I'd revise that to...</i>

TURNING THE OBJECTION AROUND

Often the objection applies to the alternative as well, and saying so is powerful:

They do take time — but so does the current process. We spent six weeks on the last hire and she left in four months.

This is not deflection if it is true. It reframes a cost as a comparison, which is usually what it is.

SEPARATE THE PRINCIPLE FROM THE MECHANISM

The move that lets you change your mind without collapsing:

The principle stands but the mechanism doesn't. I'd keep the aim and change how we do it.

Then **name what survived**, or your listener will assume you abandoned everything:

I'm dropping the take-home version. Hire for judgement, not tools — that part I'd still argue for.

AND SAY IT WHEN YOU ARE WRONG

That's a good point, and I hadn't thought about it properly. Actually, that changes my view. You've convinced me on that part.

This is not a defeat. It is the strongest available signal that you are arguing to get somewhere rather than to win, and it costs one sentence.

THE TWO FAILURE MODES

Collapse: *Oh, you're right, forget what I said.* — your positions stop meaning anything.

Stonewalling: repeating the claim, louder, with no acknowledgement. — reads as not listening.

Both come from treating a challenge as an **attack** rather than as **information**. It is usually information.

BUYING A MOMENT, HONESTLY

That's a good question — let me think for a second. · Hm. Say that again? · I want to answer that properly.

Silence while you think is fine. Filling it with words you do not mean is not.

YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Acknowledge specifically	<i>That's a fair point about X. · You're right that Y.</i>
Concede and hold	<i>...and yet · ...but I'd still argue · What I'd say is...</i>
Concede and reframe	<i>They do, yes — although... · That's true, except that...</i>
Turn it around	<i>But so does the alternative. · The current approach isn't free either.</i>
Concede and revise	<i>That's a good point. I'd revise that to... · Let me change that.</i>
Separate principle from mechanism	<i>The principle stands but the mechanism doesn't. · I'd keep the aim, change the method.</i>
Name what survived	<i>I'm dropping X. Y I'd still argue for.</i>
Change your mind	<i>Actually, that changes my view. · You've convinced me on that part.</i>
Buy a moment	<i>Let me think for a second. · I want to answer that properly.</i>
Name the weakest link	<i>That's the weakest part of my case.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (CALM AND FIRM, NOT DEFENSIVE)

This Accent Lab is about a **physical** response, not a set of phrases. When you are challenged, your body does four things and all four make you sound worse.

Cue 1 — slow down. The instinct is to speed up. Deliberately halve your pace on the first sentence of your response:

That's... a fair point about the sample size.

Cue 2 — drop your pitch. Challenge raises it. Push it back down consciously. A response delivered at a higher pitch than your original claim sounds rattled regardless of its content.

Cue 3 — breathe before you answer. One breath. It costs a second, it prevents the acceleration, and it reads as consideration rather than hesitation.

Cue 4 — do not raise your volume. Volume reads as anger. The position holds because of what you say.

Cue 5 — the concession falls, the hold rises slightly:

That's fair — and it's the weakest part of my case . What I'd say is that the cost of finding out is small.

That pattern — down for the concession, up for the reframe — is what makes it sound like reasoning rather than retreat.

Cue 6 — *but* and *although* are unstressed. Stressing the pivot word turns a reframe into a rebuttal:

✓ *That's true, /bəʔ/ so is the alternative. ✗ That's true, **BUT** so is the alternative. — now you are arguing.

Cue 7 — changing your mind is delivered level and unhurried. *Actually, that changes my view.* Rushed, it sounds grudging. Steady, it sounds like intellectual seriousness.

 **Have a partner challenge you and record your response.** Listen for one thing: is your pitch **higher** than in your original claim? If it is, do it again with a breath first.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Acknowledge specifically. Turn each vague acknowledgement into a specific one:

1. *That's a fair point.*
2. *You're right.*
3. *Good point.*

B. Concede and hold. Your partner challenges; respond with the three-part move. Four rounds on one position.

C. Turn it around. For each objection, show it applies to the alternative too:

1. *Work samples take hours to review.*
2. *Remote work makes collaboration harder.*
3. *Free public transport would be expensive.*

D. Principle or mechanism? For each, decide what you would keep and what you would change:

1. *Your training plan is good but nobody has three days free.*
2. *Fortnightly updates are a nice idea but the project leads won't write them.*
3. *Hiring for judgement is right but you can't assess it in an interview.*

E. When it lands. Your partner gives you an objection you genuinely cannot answer. Say so properly: acknowledge, revise, and **name what survives**.

F. Rapid-fire (stretch). Three challenges in a row, no pause between them. Stay calm, respond to each, do not collapse and do not repeat yourself.

YOUR TURN — دورك

State a position, then have your partner challenge it **twice**. Respond to each in about thirty seconds.

Required: one **concede and hold** with a **specific** acknowledgement, one response that either **turns the objection around** or **revises** the position, and — if the second challenge lands — a clear statement of **what survived**.

— "You're basing that on one example." "That's fair — one case isn't evidence, and it's the weakest part of my argument. What I'd say is that the cost of testing it is two hires, so being wrong is cheap." —
 "Work samples exclude people with full-time jobs." "That's a good point and I hadn't thought it through. It would favour people who aren't working, which is the opposite of the aim. So I'd revise the mechanism — do it live in the interview, not at home. The principle I'd still argue for."



Record it. Check the one thing that matters: is your **pitch** higher than in your original claim?

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a concede-then-defend response to a counter-argument.
- **Acknowledge specifically.** For a week, never say *that's a fair point* without naming the point. It takes four extra words and it changes how you are heard.
- **Breathe before answering a challenge.** One breath. It is the whole Accent Lab.
- **Change your mind once, out loud, in a real discussion.** *Actually, that changes my view.* Notice that it costs you nothing.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Concede then hold is one move:** acknowledge specifically, give something up, restate reframed.
- **Name the point.** *That's a fair point about the sample size* — not just *that's a fair point*.
- **Turn it around** when the objection applies to the alternative too.
- **Separate principle from mechanism,** then **name what survived.**
- **Changing your mind is the strongest move available.** It costs one sentence.
- **Slow down, drop your pitch, breathe.** Challenge is information, not attack.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I acknowledged the specific point, not vaguely.
- ☐ I gave something up and still held a position.
- ☐ I turned one objection around, or revised precisely.

- ☐ When I revised, I named what survived.
 - ☐ My pitch did not rise when I was challenged.
 - ☐ I neither collapsed nor repeated myself.
-

Empire English 🏰 — a challenge is information; the strongest answer is sometimes "you've convinced me"

SMALL TALK → DEEP TALK

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 · **Lesson 4** ⌚ ~35 min · 📺 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 *Built from:* [curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md](#) · **S3-U11-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Do two minutes of small talk that is not painful.
- **Steer** into something substantial without it feeling abrupt.
- Come **back down** and close gracefully. 🗣️

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Real conversations have a shape, and it is almost always the same one: light at the start, substantial in the middle, light again at the end. Learners are usually trained for the middle and left to improvise the edges — which is why so many capable speakers find the first two minutes of a conversation the hardest part.

Start with the small talk, because it is misunderstood. Learners often dislike it and try to skip it: *why spend two minutes on the weather when we both know why we're here?* The answer is that small talk is not about the weather. It is an **entry protocol**. It establishes that the two of you can talk comfortably, that neither is in a hurry or a bad mood, and that the conversation is safe. Skipping it and opening with your real subject reads as brusque in almost every English-speaking culture, and it makes the substantial part harder because you have not established the comfort it needs.

It also has a practical function: it gives you material. Half the deep conversations you will have started as small talk about something specific — a trip, a busy week, somebody's move — and then went somewhere. Which brings us to the move this lesson is about.

The transition. Learners stall here because they treat it as a social skill they either have or do not. It is neither — it is four phrases and a change in your voice:

Speaking of which... — pivot on something just said. *That reminds me...* — pivot on an association. *Actually, while we're on that...* — pivot with permission. *On a more serious note...* — explicit gear change.

The best of these is *speaking of which*, because it uses **their** material. If someone mentions they have been travelling for work, *speaking of which* — *do you think all this travel is actually necessary any more?* has moved from small talk to a real topic in one sentence, and it feels natural because it grew out of what they said rather than arriving from nowhere.

Then there is the part nobody teaches: **the return trip**. A conversation that goes deep and stops there feels unfinished, and the other person is left in a heavier register than they entered. Coming back down — *anyway, I should let you get on, right, coffee?* — is what makes the whole thing feel complete. This is the same closing signal as U9-L04's gear change, and its absence is noticeable.

Finally, why this specific skill matters now. The Unit-12 benchmark is a twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation covering **everyday and professional** topics. That is not two separate conversations — it is one that moves. Assessors are watching for whether you can be comfortable at both levels and, more importantly, whether you can get from one to the other without a visible seam. That is what this lesson trains.

WARM-UP — سَخْن (RETRIEVE SMALL TALK)

Two minutes in pairs, and the rule is that neither of you may mention work:

Weekend · travel · weather that actually matters · something you watched · food · how busy things are.

Then notice: what did your partner say that you could have turned into a real topic?

WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the clip. One conversation, and it travels:

[SMALL TALK] A: How was Istanbul? **B:** Good. Exhausting. Three days, five meetings, and I saw approximately none of the city. **A:** Classic. **B:** I got about forty minutes by the water on the last morning, which I'm counting as a holiday.

[TRANSITION — speaking of which] A: Speaking of which — do you think all that travel is actually necessary any more? Genuinely asking. We spent two years proving it wasn't.

[DEEP TALK — FRAMEWORK] B: That's a good question. Honestly, about half of it isn't. The meetings that needed to be in person were the two where we were negotiating something — you can read a room in a way you can't on a call. The other three could have been emails. **A:** So why did they happen? **B:** Partly habit. Partly, I think, because being flown somewhere signals that you matter. Which is an expensive way to make somebody feel important. **[COUNTER-CONSIDERATION] A:** Although there's the informal side too, isn't there — the dinner, the corridor conversation. That's where you find out what people actually think. **[CONCEDE AND HOLD] B:** That's fair, and it's the strongest argument for it. What I'd say is you could get that from one trip a quarter instead of one a month. The principle's right; the frequency isn't.

[RETURN TRIP] A: Fair. Anyway — did you at least eat well? **B:** Spectacularly. That part I did commit to. **A:** Good. Right, I should let you get on.

Study the arc. Small talk for four exchanges, a **pivot on B's own material** (*speaking of which*), four exchanges of genuine substance including a framework, a counter-consideration and a concede-then-hold — then a **deliberate return** with *anyway* and a close.

Notice the pivot is a **question**, not a statement. *Do you think all that travel is necessary?* invites them in. A statement — *I think business travel is mostly pointless* — announces a topic rather than opening one.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (UP, AND BACK DOWN)

THE ARC

small talk (2 min) → transition → deep talk → return → close

SMALL TALK THAT WORKS

Safe and productive topics: travel, weekend, how busy, something watched or read, food, a shared event. **Avoid:** money, politics, health, family problems — until the relationship allows them.

Three techniques that stop it being painful:

Technique	Example
ask a follow-up, not a new question	<i>Exhausting how? · Did you get any time at all?</i>
give something back	<i>Classic. I did the same thing in Berlin last year.</i>
be slightly specific	<i>Forty minutes by the water beats it was nice</i>

One specific detail is worth ten pleasantries, because it gives the other person something to grab.

THE TRANSITION — FOUR MOVES

Move	Use	Example
<i>Speaking of which...</i>	pivot on their material — best	<i>Speaking of which — is all that travel necessary?</i>
<i>That reminds me...</i>	pivot on an association	<i>That reminds me — did you see the policy change?</i>
<i>Actually, while we're on that...</i>	pivot with permission	<i>Actually, while we're on that...</i>
<i>On a more serious note...</i>	explicit gear change	<i>On a more serious note — how are you finding the new structure?</i>

Three rules:

Use their material. *Speaking of which* grows out of what they said, so it never feels abrupt. **Make it a question, not a statement.** A question invites; a statement announces. **Signal it.** The phrase plus a small pause is what tells them the level is changing.

DEEP TALK — YOU ALREADY HAVE THIS

L01's frameworks, L02's structure, L03's concede-and-hold. Nothing new; this is where they get used in an actual conversation rather than a monologue.

But keep it conversational. A deep topic is not a speech — hand it back frequently: *what do you think?, is that your experience too?, am I being unfair?*

THE RETURN TRIP — DO NOT SKIP IT

Move	Example
mark the end of the deep part	<i>Anyway. · Right. · Fair enough.</i>
go back to something light	<i>Did you at least eat well?</i>
close	<i>I should let you get on. · Good to see you. · Let's pick it up properly next week.</i>

Without the return, the other person is left in a heavier register than they arrived in, and the conversation feels abandoned rather than finished.

AND READ WHETHER THEY WANT TO GO DEEP

Not every conversation should. If they give you short answers, stay light — that is information, not rudeness. Push once, gently; if it does not open, let it be.

✂ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Job	Language
Small-talk opener	<i>How was...? · How's the week been? · Did you get away at all?</i>
Follow up	<i>Exhausting how? · Did you get any time at all? · Whereabouts?</i>
Give something back	<i>Classic. · Same thing happened to me in... · I know that feeling.</i>
Pivot on their material	<i>Speaking of which... · Which actually makes me wonder...</i>
Pivot on association	<i>That reminds me... · Funnily enough...</i>
Pivot with permission	<i>Actually, while we're on that... · Can I ask you something about that?</i>
Explicit gear change	<i>On a more serious note... · Genuinely asking...</i>
Hand it back	<i>What do you think? · Is that your experience? · Am I being unfair?</i>
Mark the return	<i>Anyway. · Right. · Fair enough.</i>
Close	<i>I should let you get on. · Good to see you. · Let's pick it up next week.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (THE LEVEL CHANGE IS AUDIBLE)

Cue 1 — small talk is fast, linked and high-energy. Fragments, heavy reduction, more pitch movement:

/haʊwəz ɪ'stænbəl/ — how was Istanbul — one run.

Cue 2 — the transition phrase gets a pause after it, and your pitch drops slightly:

Speaking of which ↴ (pause) — do you think all that travel is necessary?

That pause and drop is the audible gear change. Without it, the deep question arrives at small-talk speed and sounds like another pleasantry.

Cue 3 — deep talk is slower, with longer thought groups and more complete clauses. You are reasoning now, so give yourself the space. This is the U9-L04 stakes dial applied to topic depth.

Cue 4 — the framework markers keep their pauses. *In the short term (pause)* — from L01, and they are still buying you thinking time.

Cue 5 — the return lifts. *Anyway ↗* — brighter, faster, higher. That lift is the permission to relax, and it must be audible or the conversation stays heavy.

Cue 6 — hand-backs rise. *What do you think? ↗* A falling *what do you think* sounds like a challenge rather than an invitation.



Record three moments — a small-talk exchange, the transition, and the return. Play them to a partner and ask where the level changed. They should be able to say, without the words.



TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Small talk with follow-ups. Two minutes in pairs. Rule: every response must contain a **follow-up question** and **one specific detail**. No new topics.

B. Find the pivot. For each small-talk line, produce a *speaking of which* transition into a real topic:

1. *I've been in the car about four hours a day this week.*
2. *We watched three episodes and gave up.*
3. *My daughter's just started at the new school.*
4. *I've barely been in the office all month.*

C. Question, not statement. Turn each announced topic into an inviting question:

1. *I think business travel is mostly pointless.*
2. *The education system is broken.*
3. *Remote work has damaged junior training.*

D. The return trip. Your partner has just finished a serious point. Mark the end, go light, and close. Three rounds.

E. Read the signal. Your partner responds to your pivot either with engagement or with a short, closed answer. If it is closed, stay light. Three rounds, and they choose without telling you.

F. The full arc. Three minutes: two minutes of small talk, a transition, ninety seconds of substance with a framework and a hand-back, then the return and a close.



YOUR TURN — دورك

Have a **three-minute conversation** with a partner that travels the whole arc.

Required: **small talk** with a follow-up and a specific detail, a **transition** using their material as a question, **substance** with one framework and one hand-back, and a **return** with a close.

"How was Istanbul?" ... "Three days, five meetings, forty minutes by the water." ... "Speaking of which — do you think all that travel's still necessary? Genuinely asking." ... "About half of it isn't. The two negotiations needed a room; the rest were emails. Partly habit, partly because being flown somewhere"

signals you matter. What's your read?" ... "Anyway — did you eat well at least?" ... "Right, I'll let you get on."



Record it. Check: can a listener hear **where** the level changed, and **where** it came back down?



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a small → deep transition example.
- **Use speaking of which once this week** to move a real conversation somewhere more interesting. Pivot on **their** material.
- **Give one specific detail** in your next small talk instead of a pleasantry. *Forty minutes by the water, not it was nice.*
- **Come back down at the end.** *Anyway* — and then something light. Notice how much better the conversation feels finished.



REMEMBER — افكر

- The arc: **small talk → transition → deep talk → return → close.**
- **Small talk is an entry protocol**, not filler. One specific detail beats ten pleasantries.
- *Speaking of which* is the best pivot because it uses **their** material.
- **Make the pivot a question.** A statement announces; a question invites.
- **The transition has a pause and a pitch drop.** The **return lifts.**
- **Do not skip the return trip**, or you leave them in a heavier register than they arrived in.
- **Read whether they want to go deep.** A short answer is information.



SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ My small talk had a follow-up question and a specific detail.
- ☐ I pivoted using something my partner had said.
- ☐ My pivot was a question, not a statement.
- ☐ There was an audible pause and pitch drop at the transition.
- ☐ I handed the topic back at least once.
- ☐ I marked the return and closed properly.

Empire English 🏰 — real conversations move between levels, and the seams are learnable

UNIT SPEAKING TASK: DEBATE A PROFESSIONAL TOPIC 🎤

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 11 · **Lesson 5** — UNIT TASK 🕒 ~45 min · 📞 Recorded + live (assessment-style) ·
Prerequisite: L01–L04 Built from: [curriculum/stage3/unit11-abstract-topics-debate.md](#) · **S3-U11-L05**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (UNIT TASK)

Today you debate properly, for four to five minutes:

- a **framework** to open, then a **structured argument**
- **concede and hold** under challenge, at least twice
- **nuance** — a distinction, a hedge, a limit named
- and you stay **in English**, calmly, throughout 🎤

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL)

Thirty seconds each:

1. Name a **framework** and apply it.
2. **Claim** → **evidence** → **example** in three sentences.
3. **Concede specifically**, then hold.
4. A **distinction**: *those are two different questions...*
5. A **transition** from small talk into substance.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model debate. Two speakers, one topic, roughly four minutes. The moves are marked:

TOPIC: *Should companies be required to publish salary ranges in job adverts?*

A: [FRAMEWORK + CLAIM] I'd look at this in terms of who it helps and who it costs. My position is that it should be required, mainly because the current system transfers information away from the people with the least of it. **[EVIDENCE]** Candidates negotiate against a number they cannot see. Companies know the range; the applicant doesn't. **[EXAMPLE]** I've been in a hiring process where two people accepted offers eleven thousand apart for the same job title, the same month. That gap wasn't performance. It was who felt able to ask. **[CONCLUSION]** So publishing the range removes an advantage that isn't earned.

B: [CONCEDE, THEN COUNTER] I don't disagree with the aim — that eleven thousand gap is indefensible. **[COUNTER-CLAIM]** But I'd argue mandatory publication solves it badly. **[EVIDENCE]**

Companies respond by publishing ranges so wide they mean nothing — thirty to seventy — which is compliance without transparency. **[EXAMPLE]** That is what happened in the markets where it came in first.

A: [CONCEDE SPECIFICALLY, THEN HOLD] That's a fair point and it's the strongest objection. Wide ranges are a real dodge. What I'd say is that a bad range is still more information than no range — you learn something from *thirty to seventy* even if it's mostly that they haven't decided. **[TURN IT AROUND]** And the alternative isn't a precise number; it's silence.

B: [DISTINCTION] I think we're arguing about two different things. Whether ranges *should* be public — I agree. Whether **mandating** it produces useful ranges — that I doubt. **[REFRAME]** I'd rather it were a norm than a rule.

A: [CONCEDE AND REVISE] That's a better version of my position than mine was, honestly. **[NAME WHAT SURVIVED]** I'd keep the requirement but attach a rule about range width — no more than twenty percent. Principle the same, mechanism tightened.

B: [HEDGE + LIMIT] That might work. I'd want to see whether it survives contact with lawyers, which most rules of that kind don't. I'd also say neither of us actually knows what happens to hiring volume, and that's the number that would decide it.

A: [CLOSE WITH NUANCE] Agreed. So where I'd land is: publish, with a width limit, and check what it does to applications before extending it.

Study four things. Both speakers **concede specifically** before countering. B's **distinction** — *should be public against mandating it* — is the highest-quality move in the exchange and it moves the debate forward rather than round in circles. A **revises** and names what survived. And both **name a limit on their own knowledge** at the end, which is what makes it a discussion rather than a contest.

Nobody won. That is what a good B2 debate looks like.

THE UNIT-II CHECKLIST — طقم النجاة

#	Must contain	Example
1	a framework to open	<i>I'd look at who it helps and who it costs.</i>
2	claim → evidence → example	with a specific in the example
3	concede specifically, then hold — twice	<i>That's fair, and it's the strongest objection. What I'd say is...</i>
4	one distinction	<i>We're arguing about two different things.</i>
5	nuance — a hedge or a named limit	<i>Neither of us knows what it does to hiring volume.</i>
6	stay in English , calmly, for 4–5 minutes	no switching, no rise in pitch under challenge

Item 3 twice, not once. One concession can be luck. Two is a habit.

Item 4 is the highest-quality move available. A distinction moves a debate forward; without one, debates circle.



ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (PERSUASIVE STRESS, CALM DEFENCE)

Everyone — contrastive stress on every comparison. Both halves, or the contrast disappears:

That gap wasn't **PERformance. It was who felt able to **ASK**.* A bad range is still more information than **NO** range.*

This is the most persuasive prosodic device in English and it is systematically under-used.

Everyone — the same key word stressed in your claim and your conclusion. Repetition is what makes a position land.

Everyone — under challenge: slow down, drop your pitch, breathe. From L03, and it is assessed. A response delivered at a higher pitch than the original claim sounds rattled whatever it says.

Everyone — the concession falls, the hold rises:

That's a fair point 📉 — and it's the strongest objection 📉. What I'd say is that a bad range is still more information. 📈

Everyone — but and although stay unstressed. Stressing the pivot turns a reframe into a fight.

Everyone — the distinction needs double stress and a pause:

*Whether ranges **SHOULD** be public (**pause**) *— and whether **MAN**dating it works* — are two different questions.*

Everyone — the hedge at the end slows and falls. *Neither of us actually knows* delivered quickly sounds like a disclaimer.

Then your own residual target. One sound from the tracker, one cue, one sentence, stop.



Record your claim, then your response to one challenge. Compare the pitch. If the response is higher, breathe and record it again.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (DEBATE, THEN SWAP)

Round 1 — prepare, five bullets. Two minutes. Your framework, your claim, two pieces of evidence, one concrete example with a specific, and the strongest objection you can imagine against yourself. **No sentences.**

Round 2 — debate, assigned positions. Four minutes in pairs. You must **concede specifically at least twice** and you may not repeat a point.

Round 3 — swap sides. Same topic, opposite position, one minute's preparation. Argue it properly.

Round 4 — find the distinction. Together, identify the two questions you were actually arguing about. Say them out loud separately.

Round 5 — one polish pass. Swap one thing that worked and one to fix. Re-deliver your weakest thirty seconds with the pitch corrected.

Topics:

- Should companies publish salary ranges in job adverts?
- Should university be free at the point of use?
- Is remote work damaging the training of junior staff?
- Should employers be allowed to monitor productivity software?
- Is it reasonable to expect people to answer messages outside working hours?



YOUR TURN — التسجيل (THE TASK)

Record a **four-to-five-minute debate** with a partner, containing all six checklist items.



Save this recording. This is the closest thing in Stage 3 to the flagship benchmark, and with your consent it is strong proof material — a four-minute unscripted debate is the clearest possible evidence of what you can now do. Consent stays separate from the course, granular, and you can withdraw it later.



YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post your debate recording.
- Complete the **Unit-11 quiz** — matching topic frameworks, ordering an argument, choosing a concede-then-defend response, and small-to-deep transitions.
- **Have one real disagreement in English this week** and concede one point specifically. Notice that the conversation gets better rather than worse.

- **Find the distinction** next time a discussion goes in circles. Usually you are arguing about two questions at once.

🧠 REMEMBER — افكر

- **Framework first**, then **claim → evidence → example → conclusion**.
- **Concede specifically** — name the point — then **hold or revise**.
- **The distinction is the strongest move**: two questions wearing one coat.
- **Name a limit on your own knowledge**. It makes everything else credible.
- **Contrastive stress on every comparison**, both halves.
- **Under challenge: slow down, drop your pitch, breathe**. A challenge is information.
- **Nobody has to win**. A good debate ends with a better position than either side started with.

✅ SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I opened with a framework and built a full argument.
- ☐ My example had a specific in it.
- ☐ I conceded specifically **twice**, and held or revised each time.
- ☐ I found a distinction the topic had been running together.
- ☐ I named something neither of us knew.
- ☐ My pitch did not rise when I was challenged.
- ☐ I stayed in English for the full four to five minutes.

Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Unit 11 complete — thinking and arguing in English, which is the intellectual core of B2



STAGE 3 · UNIT 12

PUTTING IT TOGETHER (B2 FLAGSHIP GRADUATION)

👑 UNIT 12 — PUTTING IT TOGETHER ★ (B2 FLAGSHIP GRADUATION)

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · **Unit 12 of 12** Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` (unit map + lessons)

THE CAMPAIGN — حملة الوحدة

Your mission: hold a natural **20–30 minute conversation** in English — everyday, professional and abstract — clearly and confidently, meeting a **defined minimum in all five rubric dimensions**. Then record the graduation sample that closes the proof timeline.

This is the flagship. Every lesson in this programme was engineered backwards from the benchmark in L05. Nothing new gets taught in this unit; everything gets made **available under pressure**.

Two things get settled here. That knowing a structure and reaching for it while you are thinking about something else are **different skills** — the first four lessons close that gap. And that the goal was always **clear, confident, neutral American**, never "native" — an honest standard you can actually meet, and meet today.

THE LESSONS — دروس الوحدة

#	Lesson	You'll be able to...
L01	Big review 1	four or more structures across time in one turn — and name your three residuals
L02	Big review 2	passive, relatives, reported speech + a register switch you can hear
L03	Accent & fluency clinic	your six targets , one-second cues, and the self-monitoring routine you keep
L04	Full mock, 20–30 min	the exact benchmark format , one week early, at full length
L05	B2 benchmark + graduation sample 🎓★	the flagship conversation, the determination, the fifth point on the timeline

Grammar spine: integrated retrieval of the full Stage-3 range — perfect aspect, past perfect narrative, advanced futures, third and mixed conditionals, modals of deduction (L01) · advanced passive, causative, relative clauses, reporting-verb patterns, register and collocation (L02) · all of it in spontaneous use (L04, L05). **Accent Lab:** naturalness across long turns · the reduction trio /ɪfaɪd · aɪdɐv · aɪdbi/ · the **comma pause** that nobody can hear as punctuation · register in **prosody**, not vocabulary · personalised **rung-1-**

to-rung-4 drilling · **one-second cues** and monitoring **one feature at a time**. **Mindset:** graduation — learner → **confident user**. Self-monitoring is what outlives the course. **Arabic support: 0%** — full immersion.

THE PRIZE — جائزة الوحدة

- A recorded **20–30 minute B2 conversation**, scored on five dimensions — the promise of this programme, evidenced.
- A **self-monitoring routine** that works with no coach in the room: choose one · cue it · repair, never restart · log one.
- The **five-point timeline** — Day-1 → Stage-0 → A2 → B1 → **B2** — same prompt, same person, four months apart.

END-OF-UNIT CHECK — تقييم آخر الوحدة (STAGE-3 FLAGSHIP SUMMATIVE)

- **Quiz:** the full Stage-3 range — perfect aspect, past perfect narrative, advanced futures, third and mixed conditionals, deduction, advanced passive and causative, relative clauses, reported-speech patterns, register and collocation — recognition plus short production.
- **Speaking task:** the **20–30 minute B2 benchmark conversation**, scored on all five dimensions (Fluency · Accuracy · Range/Coherence · Interaction · Pronunciation) with a **defined minimum in every dimension**, plus the standard-prompt **graduation sample** as a separate recording.
- **Feeds:** the Cohort Tracker — the **B2 graduation determination** with quoted evidence, the graduation-clip link and consent tier, any accommodation used, residuals for optional Stage 4, and the completed proof timeline (Day-1 → Stage-0 → A2 → B1 → **B2**).

NEXT CAMPAIGN → YOUR CHOICE 🎓

The flagship promise is delivered. Nothing further is required of you.

- **Stage 4 — Advanced / Exam (C1 + IELTS/TOEFL):** near-native range and nuance, idiomatic and academic language, prosodic polish, optional certification. Take it for a concrete reason — a university place, a visa band, a role that needs academic writing. C1 polish is an aspirational ceiling, never guaranteed.
- **Community and maintenance:** keep speaking, keep the routine from L03. This is not the lesser path. English that is used stays; English that is stored decays, at every level.

*Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 · Confident rank · **B2 GRADUATION** · from studying English to living in it*

BIG REVIEW 1: TENSES, CONDITIONALS & DEDUCTION

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 12 · **Lesson 1** — RETRIEVAL 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: Units 1–5 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` · **S3-U12-L01**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Move across **four or more** Stage-3 structures in one two-minute turn.
- Name your own **top three residual errors** — from evidence.
- Hear that you now command the whole time system. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

This is the beginning of the last unit of the stage, and its job is not to teach you anything. It is to make what you already know **available under pressure**.

There is a real difference between knowing a structure and being able to reach for it while thinking about something else. You can almost certainly build a mixed conditional correctly if someone asks you to. The question the benchmark asks is different: can you produce one **in the middle of an argument**, when your attention is on the point you are making rather than on the grammar? That is what four weeks of separate units cannot test and what this one does.

The mechanism for getting there is **retrieval**, and it is worth understanding why it feels unpleasant. Being asked to produce something from memory, at speed, without support, is harder than reviewing it — and that difficulty is precisely what makes it work. Re-reading a rule feels productive and changes very little. Struggling to produce the form under mild time pressure is what moves it into the part of your memory that speech draws on. So if the next forty minutes feel harder than the original lessons did, that is the design.

The second purpose of this lesson is diagnostic, and it is the one that matters most for what follows. By the end you should be able to name your **top three residual errors** — not vaguely, but specifically: *I drop the 'd in mixed conditionals, I use 'must' for negative certainty, I lose the -ed on participles at speed*. Those three become the content of your clinic in L03. A learner who arrives at the clinic with three specific, evidenced targets gets a personalised session. A learner who arrives saying *my grammar is not perfect* gets a generic one.

Finally, this is worth noticing for its own sake: **you now command the whole English time system**. Every tense exists in your speech. Present perfect and perfect continuous, the four past tenses, the advanced futures, the unreal past, the unreal past bleeding into the present. There is no time you cannot express.

Stage 4 adds nuance and register, not new time. If you began this programme unable to talk about yesterday, that is worth sitting with for a moment before we get back to work.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL, NO SUPPORT)

Twenty seconds each. Fast, and do not stop to correct yourself:

1. Something you've **been doing** lately, with a shaded duration.
2. Something that had **already happened** before your day started.
3. What you'll **have finished** by a date, and what you'll **be doing** at a moment.
4. *If I'd ____, I would have ____.*
5. *If I'd ____, I'd be ____ **now**.*
6. A deduction about the **present**, and one about the **past**, each with evidence.



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Watch the model. One turn, roughly ninety seconds, ranging across the whole grammar:

[PERFECT CONTINUOUS] I've been trying to change career for about two years now — on and off, properly since last spring. **[PERFECT SIMPLE]** I've had four interviews and no offers, which tells you something.

[PAST PERFECT] The first one I went into completely unprepared. I hadn't looked at their accounts, I hadn't spoken to anybody who worked there, and **[PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS]** I'd been telling myself for weeks that experience would carry it. **[THIRD CONDITIONAL]** If I'd done two hours of research I'd probably have got through to the second round.

[MIXED CONDITIONAL] And honestly, if I'd started this properly in 2023, I'd be somewhere else by now — that's the part I find irritating.

[PAST DEDUCTION] The second interview I think I misread completely. They must have decided before I walked in; the whole thing lasted nineteen minutes. **[PRESENT DEDUCTION]** Either that, or they can't have had budget approval, which would explain why nobody could answer anything about the start date.

[FUTURE PERFECT] By the end of this year I'll have applied to about thirty places, which is more than I've done in the whole of the rest of my life. **[FUTURE CONTINUOUS]** And this time next spring I'll either be doing something different or I'll have made peace with staying.

[HEDGED] Although I've been wrong about my own timeline every single time so far, so I wouldn't put money on it.

Count them: perfect continuous, perfect simple, past perfect, past perfect continuous, third conditional, mixed conditional, past and present deduction, future perfect, future continuous — **ten structures in**

ninety seconds, and none of them announced. Every one arrived because the story needed it.

That is the target: **range in service of content**, not range on display.



DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE RESIDUAL-ERROR LIST)

You are not learning these again. You are checking which ones still slip. Go through the list honestly.

TENSES

Structure	The error that persists
present perfect continuous	<i>I'm working here since March</i> — present tense for duration
continuous vs simple perfect	a quantity in the continuous: <i>I've been writing three emails</i>
past perfect	over-use — marking every past verb instead of the earlier one
past perfect continuous	dropping the /d/ : <i>she been working</i>
future perfect	no by boundary — usually means you wanted a different tense
future continuous	using it for a decision : <i>I'll be getting it</i>

CONDITIONALS

Structure	The error
third conditional	double would have : <i>if I'd have known</i>
third conditional	would of — it is always have
mixed conditional	matching the tenses instead of mixing them
mixed conditional	no present time word in the result: <i>now, still, by now</i>
<i>wish</i>	<i>wish</i> + past simple where the regret is about the past

DEDUCTION

Structure	The error
negative certainty	mustn't instead of can't — present and past
past deduction	a past simple after the modal: <i>must have went</i>
all deduction	no evidence attached — a deduction with no clue is an assertion

THE THREE REDUCTIONS THAT MUST SURVIVE

/aɪdəv/ — *I'd have* · /aɪdbi/ — *I'd be* · /mʌstəv/ — *must have*

These three are one consonant apart from each other and they carry three different time frames. If they collapse under speed, your listener loses the sequence.

NOW NAME YOUR THREE

Write down the **three** from these tables that you actually still get wrong, with an example of your own error. Be specific. *My conditionals are weak* is not usable. *I drop the 'd in mixed conditionals so they sound like third conditionals* is a target.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Structure	Language
perfect continuous	<i>I've been trying to... on and off, properly since...</i>
perfect simple + quantity	<i>I've had four interviews and no offers.</i>
past perfect	<i>I hadn't looked at... I hadn't spoken to...</i>
past perfect continuous	<i>I'd been telling myself for weeks that...</i>
third conditional	<i>If I'd done two hours of research, I'd probably have...</i>
mixed conditional	<i>If I'd started in 2023, I'd be somewhere else by now.</i>
past deduction	<i>They must have decided before I walked in.</i>
present deduction	<i>They can't have had budget approval.</i>
future perfect	<i>By the end of the year I'll have applied to about thirty.</i>
future continuous	<i>This time next spring I'll either be doing something different...</i>
hedge	<i>I've been wrong about my own timeline every time, so I wouldn't put money on it.</i>



ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (NATURALNESS ACROSS A LONG TURN)

Cue 1 — the three near-identical openings. Say the trio five times, in order:

/ɪfaɪd/ ... (condition) · /aɪdəv/ ... (past result) · /aɪdbi/ ... (present result)

One consonant apart, three time frames. This is the single most consequential sound distinction in Stage 3.

*Cue 2 — /mɒstəv/ *against* /wʊdəv/. * Deduction against conditional. Confusing them inverts the meaning of a sentence.

Cue 3 — participle endings survive. *finished, applied, decided, approved.* In a ninety-second turn these disappear first, and they are the tense.

Cue 4 — breathe at the joins, not mid-clause. A long turn fails on breathing before it fails on grammar. One idea per thought group.

Cue 5 — the hedge at the end falls and slows. Rushed, it sounds like a disclaimer you do not mean.

 **Record ninety seconds**, then compare it with your **U1-L05 baseline** — the *what I've been working on* talk from the first week of this stage. Same speaker, twelve weeks apart. That comparison is the point of the recording.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Four structures, one turn. Take a prompt and produce at least four Stage-3 structures naturally:

1. A decision you are still thinking about.
2. Something that went wrong at work and why.
3. How you got to the job or course you are in now.
4. Something you have been trying to change for a long time.

B. Fix the residuals. Each contains one of the persistent errors:

1. *I'm working here since March.*
2. *If I'd have known, I'd have come.*
3. *He mustn't have got the email.*
4. *If I'd taken that job, I would have been in Dubai now.*
5. *I've been writing three reports this week.*
6. *She been working all night.*
7. *By next year I'll have finished. (what's missing?)*
8. *It must have went wrong somewhere.*

C. The reduction trio. Say each sentence three times, faster each time, keeping all three auxiliaries distinct:

If I'd known, I'd have called — and I'd be there now.

D. Deduction with evidence. Make three deductions about a real situation, one present and two past, each with its clue attached.

E. Self-correct live. Speak for one minute on any topic. When you notice a slip, **repair the phrase and continue** — do not restart. Your partner counts your repairs.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak for about **two minutes** on one of the prompts, ranging across **four or more** Stage-3 structures. Do not announce them; let the content require them.

Then, in one sentence each, name your **three residual targets** for the clinic.

 **Record it, and keep it next to your U1-L05 baseline.** Listen to both once, in order.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a wide-ranging two-minute talk.
- **Write your three residual targets down and bring them to L03.** Specific, with your own example of the error. This is what makes your clinic yours.
- **Listen to your U1-L05 recording.** Once, all the way through. You have earned that comparison.
- Keep the trio alive: /ɪfaɪd/ · /aɪdɐv/ · /aɪdbi/.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Retrieval, not review.** The difficulty is what makes it work.
- The persistent errors: *I'm working since* · **double would have** · **mustn't** for negative certainty · a **quantity** in the continuous · **no present time word** in a mixed conditional.
- **Deductions need evidence.** Without a clue it is an assertion.
- /ɪfaɪd/ · /aɪdɐv/ · /aɪdbi/ — one consonant apart, three time frames.
- **Range in service of content**, never on display.
- **You now command the whole time system.** Stage 4 adds nuance, not new time.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I used four or more Stage-3 structures in one turn, without announcing them.
- ☐ I can name my three residual errors specifically, with my own examples.
- ☐ I fixed all eight items in Train B.
- ☐ My three reductions stayed distinct at speed.
- ☐ Every deduction I made had its evidence attached.
- ☐ I repaired one slip without restarting.
- ☐ I listened to my Unit-1 baseline.

Empire English 🏰 — knowing a structure and reaching for it under pressure are different skills

BIG REVIEW 2: PASSIVE, RELATIVES, REPORTED SPEECH & REGISTER

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 12 · **Lesson 2** — RETRIEVAL 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: Units 6–9 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` · **S3-U12-L02**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Combine **three or more** of passive, relatives and reported speech in one natural turn.
- Say the same thing in **two registers** and choose correctly between them.
- Name your **top three residual errors** from this half of the stage. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

L01 reviewed the structures that let you place events in time. This lesson reviews the four that decide whether people believe you.

That is not a motivational phrase; it is a fairly literal description of what these structures do. The advanced passive lets you talk about a process without inventing an agent you do not actually know — *the file was approved on Tuesday* commits you to less than *someone approved the file on Tuesday*, and the difference matters when you are describing a system you only partly understand. Relative clauses let you specify exactly which thing you mean, so a listener is never guessing between two candidates. Reported speech lets you carry someone else's words accurately, including the part where you signal whether they *insisted*, *suggested*, *admitted* or merely *mentioned* it. And register control lets you deliver all of that at the right temperature for the room.

Put together, they are the difference between a speaker who is understood and a speaker who is trusted. Anyone at B1 can make a listener understand what happened. The specific new capability of B2 is that a listener can **act on your account of it** — because it is precise about who did what, which thing you meant, who claimed it, and how confident you are. That is why these structures dominate professional English and why the benchmark conversation moves into professional territory in its second half.

Register deserves a separate warning, because it is the dimension learners most often walk into the benchmark unprepared for. There is a very common and very costly pattern: a learner who has worked hard on accuracy runs the entire twenty-five minutes in a single register — usually a stiff, careful, semi-formal one — and is surprised to score below their expectation. Nothing they said was wrong. The problem is that a conversation which moves from a weekend story to a disagreement with a manager to an abstract question about technology, without any change in how it is said, reads as someone reciting

rather than someone talking. The fix is not more vocabulary. It is deciding, deliberately, to be looser in the everyday section and tighter in the professional one, and letting your voice do it as well as your words.

Then there is the reverse failure, which is subtler and worth naming because good students fall into it: over-formality as a safety behaviour. Structures like *it is widely believed that* and *the individual to whom I reported* are correct, impressive, and completely wrong in a conversation about your cousin's wedding. Choosing the plain version is not a retreat from your level — using a structure where it does not belong is the actual error, and it is the one that most reliably makes a strong speaker sound like they learned English from documents. Precision means the *right* form, not the heaviest available one.



WARM-UP — سَخْن (RAPID RETRIEVAL, NO SUPPORT)

Twenty seconds each. Fast, no correcting yourself:

1. Something at your work or in your city that **must be done** by a deadline.
2. Something that **should have been checked** and was not.
3. A place you know, with a **non-defining** clause added — commas and all.
4. A person, using a **reduced** relative clause.
5. Something a colleague said, using a reporting verb that is **not said**.
6. One sentence you would say to a close friend, then the **same message** to a director.



WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج

Two versions of one story. Same speaker, same events, two rooms.

Version A — to a friend, over coffee:

[**ACTIVE, LOOSE**] So they've completely reorganised our department, and nobody told us until it was already done. [**REDUCED RELATIVE**] The guy running it now is somebody I've literally never met. [**REPORTING VERB**] My manager swore she didn't know either, which — honestly? I don't buy it. [**WHICH FOR A WHOLE IDEA**] She'd been in meetings about it for a month, which kind of gives it away. [**INFORMAL COLLOCATION**] Anyway, I'm just keeping my head down until it settles.

Version B — to a senior director, in a review:

[**REPORTING PASSIVE**] It's my understanding that the restructure was signed off in late March. [**PASSIVE, AGENTLESS**] The team wasn't formally notified until it had been implemented, [**MODAL PASSIVE**] and I think that could have been handled rather differently. [**NON-DEFINING RELATIVE**] Our new lead, whom I haven't yet had the chance to meet, inherited a team that had had no warning. [**HEDGED REPORTING VERB**] My manager has indicated that she wasn't consulted either,

[DIPLOMATIC] although I'd be cautious about drawing conclusions from that. **[FORMAL COLLOCATION]** My priority now is making sure the handover doesn't lose momentum.

The facts are identical. Every substantive claim in B appears in A. What changed:

Feature	Version A	Version B
voice	active, agent named	passive where the agent is unknown or impolitic
relatives	reduced, no commas	full, commas, <i>whom</i> , <i>which</i> for a whole idea
reporting	<i>swore, I don't buy it</i>	<i>has indicated, it's my understanding that</i>
stance	stated flat	hedged — <i>I'd be cautious about</i>
collocation	<i>keeping my head down</i>	<i>lose momentum</i>
what it protects	the friendship	the speaker's credibility

Notice what B does **not** do: it does not become vague. It is more careful about attribution, not less specific about facts. That is the target.

🧩 DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE RESIDUAL-ERROR LIST)

You are not learning these again. Read each line and decide honestly whether it still catches you.

THE PASSIVE

Structure	The error that persists
passive in any tense	wrong be for the tense: <i>it is been done, it was being done</i> for a finished action
passive	the participle slips to a past simple: <i>it was took, it was wrote</i>
agentless passive	adding a by phrase that carries no information: <i>by someone, by people</i>
modal passive	dropping be : <i>it must done</i>
perfect modal passive	one auxiliary too few: <i>should have checked</i> for <i>should have been checked</i>
reporting passive	a finite clause after <i>is thought</i> : <i>he is thought that he left</i>
causative	have conjugated but the object order lost: <i>I had cut my hair</i> vs <i>I had my hair cut</i>
causative	get where the tone needs have , or the reverse

RELATIVE CLAUSES

Structure	The error
defining	doubled subject: <i>the man who he called me</i>
defining	that where the clause is non-defining — <i>that</i> never takes commas
non-defining	no commas , which silently changes the meaning
reduced	keeping who is / which was where it should vanish
reduced passive	wrong participle: <i>the report writing by</i> for <i>written by</i>
preposition + <i>which</i>	stranding it in formal register: <i>the meeting which I spoke about</i> where <i>about which</i> is wanted
<i>whom</i>	using it as a subject : <i>the colleague whom called</i>
<i>which</i> for a whole idea	using what : <i>he arrived late, what annoyed everyone</i>

REPORTED SPEECH

Structure	The error
reporting verbs	everything is said — the range collapses and stance disappears
verb + <i>-ing</i>	<i>he suggested to go</i> for <i>he suggested going</i>
verb + <i>that</i>	<i>he insisted me to stay</i> for <i>he insisted that I stay</i>
verb + object + <i>to</i>	dropping the object: <i>she reminded to send it</i>
<i>deny / admit</i>	<i>he denied to take it</i> for <i>he denied taking it</i>
backshift	over-applying it to something still true
reported questions	keeping the question word order : <i>he asked what did I want</i>

REGISTER

Area	The error
register	one register for everything — the costliest error on the benchmark
register	over-formality as a safety behaviour, in a casual moment
register	formal words, informal prosody — or the reverse
softening	a hedge stacked on a hedge until the point disappears
collocation	a correct word in the wrong partnership: <i>make a research, do a mistake</i>
collocation	translating a partnership from Arabic word by word

THE FOUR SOUNDS THAT CARRY THE MEANING

/bɪn/ in *has been done* · /stəv bɪn/ in *must have been* · /hu:m/ not /hu:/ · the **comma pause** before a non-defining clause

The last one is not punctuation. In speech, that tiny pause is the only thing distinguishing *my brother who lives in Cairo* (I have several) from *my brother, who lives in Cairo* (I have one). Nobody can hear your commas. They can hear your pauses.

NOW NAME YOUR THREE

Write the **three** from these tables that you still actually get wrong, each with your own example of the error. *My passive is weak* is not usable. *I say "should have checked" when I mean "should have been checked"* is a target.

✂️ YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك

Structure	Language
passive, agentless	<i>The team wasn't formally notified until it had been implemented.</i>
modal passive	<i>That could have been handled rather differently.</i>
reporting passive	<i>It's my understanding that the restructure was signed off in March.</i>
causative	<i>We had the whole system audited before launch.</i>
non-defining relative	<i>Our new lead, whom I haven't yet met, inherited a team with no warning.</i>
reduced relative	<i>The guy running it now is somebody I've never met.</i>
which for a whole idea	<i>She'd been in meetings about it for a month, which gives it away.</i>
reporting verb + stance	<i>My manager has indicated that she wasn't consulted.</i>
reporting verb, informal	<i>My manager swore she didn't know either.</i>
diplomatic hedge	<i>I'd be cautious about drawing conclusions from that.</i>
formal collocation	<i>My priority is making sure the handover doesn't lose momentum.</i>
informal collocation	<i>I'm keeping my head down until it settles.</i>

🎧 ACCENT LAB — معمل النطق (REGISTER-APPROPRIATE PROSODY)

Cue 1 — the comma pause. Say both, and make the difference audible:

My brother who lives in Cairo is an engineer. (one of several — no pause) *My brother, who lives in Cairo, is an engineer.* (my only brother — two small pauses)

Cue 2 — the passive auxiliary stack. /stəv bɪn/: *it must have been approved, it should have been checked, it can't have been sent.* Three words compressed into two syllables that still have to be there.

Cue 3 — register lives in prosody, not only in words. Say *I don't think that's going to work* twice: once flat and final, once with a rise on *think* and a softened ending. Same words, two completely different meetings.

Cue 4 — formal register is slower and flatter, not louder. Learners raise volume when they mean to raise formality. Widen your pauses instead.

 **Record both versions of your own story** — friend, then director. Play them back to back. If the two sound the same, the register switch happened only on paper.

TRAIN — تَدْرِبْ

A. Same story, two registers. Take one real event from the last month. Tell it to a friend, then to a senior person. Keep every fact identical; change voice, relatives, reporting verbs and prosody.

B. Fix the residuals. Each has one error from the tables:

1. *The report was wrote by the finance team.*
2. *It must done before Friday.*
3. *The file should have checked before it went out.*
4. *He is thought that he left the company in March.*
5. *The colleague whom called me yesterday was very helpful.*
6. *My sister that lives in Dubai is visiting. (she is my only sister)*
7. *The report writing by the consultants arrived late.*
8. *He suggested to postpone the launch.*
9. *She insisted me to stay until the end.*
10. *He asked me what did I want.*
11. *He denied to take the documents.*
12. *I need to make a research about it.*

C. Reporting-verb precision. Report the same sentence — *"Fine, I'll do it, but I'm not happy"* — four ways, using four different reporting verbs, so the listener gets four different impressions of the speaker.

D. The comma pause out loud. Your partner writes the commas they hear:

1. *The engineers, who had been warned twice, ignored it.*
2. *The engineers who had been warned twice ignored it.*
3. *My manager, who joined last year, disagreed.*

E. Register repair. Your partner says a sentence in the wrong register for the situation they name. You repair it in one move, out loud, without commenting on the error.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak for about **two minutes** on one prompt, using **three or more** of the advanced structures, and switch register at least once — naming the switch as you make it (*if I were saying this to my director...*).

A process or system at your work that is not working, and what should have been done differently. A person who changed something about how you work. A disagreement you had, reported accurately, including what each side actually claimed. A decision that was made above you and how it was communicated.

Then name your **three residual targets** for the clinic, one sentence each.

 **Record it.** Keep it beside your L01 recording — L01 was your range in time, this is your range in precision.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a two-minute talk using three or more advanced structures with one register switch.
- **Write your three residual targets down and bring them to L03**, with your own example of each error. Together with L01's three, these six are the entire content of your clinic.
- Record your story **twice** — friend and director — and listen to both.
- Keep the pause alive: *my brother who lives in Cairo* against *my brother, who lives in Cairo*.

REMEMBER — افكر

- These four structures are what make an account **reliable**, not merely understandable.
- **One register for everything** is the costliest habit on the benchmark — and **over-formality** is the version that catches good students.
- **Nobody can hear your commas. They can hear your pauses.**
- *should have been checked* — the missing *been* is the most common advanced-passive slip in the corpus.
- Choose the reporting verb for its **stance**, not to avoid repeating *said*.
- Register lives in **prosody**, not only in vocabulary. Slower and flatter, never louder.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I used three or more advanced structures in one turn without announcing them.
- ☐ I switched register once, and the change was audible in my voice.
- ☐ I fixed all twelve items in Train B.
- ☐ My partner wrote the commas I intended in Train D.
- ☐ I can name my three residual errors from this half of the stage, with my own examples.
- ☐ I reported one sentence four ways and the stance changed each time.
- ☐ I brought six specific targets — three from L01, three from here — to the clinic.

Empire English 🏰 — being understood is B1; being relied on is B2

ACCENT & FLUENCY CLINIC: NATURALNESS AND SELF-MONITORING

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 12 · **Lesson 3** — CLINIC 🕒 ~40 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: all Stage-3 units Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` · **S3-U12-L03**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Work your **top three residual features** with a cue you can use alone.
- **Catch and repair** your own slips mid-sentence, without stopping.
- Hear the distance between your **Day-1 recording** and today. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

Every other lesson in this stage handed you something new. This one hands you back the six targets you wrote down yourself in L01 and L02, and asks you to do something about three of them.

That is a deliberate shift, and it is the last important thing the Accent Lab has to teach you. For twelve weeks, someone else has decided which feature you were working on. After the benchmark, nobody will. If your ability to keep improving depends on a coach naming the problem, then it stops when the course stops — and the honest measure of this programme is not how you sound on graduation day but whether you are still getting better six months later. That capability has a name: **self-monitoring**. It is a real, trainable skill, and it is the actual subject of this lesson.

Self-monitoring is not the same as being anxious about your English. Anxiety monitors everything at once, which is why it produces hesitant speech and catches almost nothing. Trained self-monitoring listens for **one named feature at a time**, in the background, while your attention stays on what you are saying — and when it catches something, it repairs the phrase and keeps going. That last part matters more than it sounds. Repairing without restarting is scored as competent interaction on the benchmark rubric; restarting the whole sentence is scored as disfluency. The same underlying error, noticed the same way, lands in two different places depending only on how you handle it.

Then there is what "better" means here, and you deserve a straight answer rather than a flattering one. The target of this programme is **clear, confident, neutral American English**: a listener follows you without effort, your stress and rhythm carry your meaning rather than fighting it, and your accent does not stand between you and what you are trying to say. That is the standard, it is genuinely demanding, and it is what the Pronunciation dimension of the rubric measures. Sounding *indistinguishable from someone born in Ohio* is not the standard, has never been promised to you, and is not required for any professional or academic purpose you have. Some learners drift close to it, most do not, and it has no

bearing on whether you graduate. Anyone who sells you the other promise is selling you something they cannot deliver.

One more thing about comparison, because it decides whether this lesson helps you or damages you. Today you compare your voice to **one** thing: your own earlier recordings. Not to the person next to you, whose starting point, first language and available practice hours you do not know. Not to the model audio, which is a reference for a feature rather than a score to reach. Your Day-1 sample is the only fair comparison in existence, because it is the only one where every variable except the work you have done is held constant. Play it today. Most learners have not heard it in three months, and it is usually the most persuasive evidence they will ever encounter that this worked.

WARM-UP — سَخِّنْ (STATE YOUR TARGETS)

Out loud, in English, each learner names their **top three** — from the L01 and L02 lists and the tracker.

A target is usable when it is this specific:

"I drop the 'd in mixed conditionals, so they come out sounding like third conditionals." "I say 'should have checked' when I mean 'should have been checked' — the 'been' disappears." "I run every sentence at the same pitch, so nothing I say sounds emphasised." "My thought groups are too long. I run out of breath and then break in the wrong place."

A target is not usable when it sounds like this:

"My pronunciation isn't good." · "I need to be more fluent." · "My grammar has mistakes."

If yours is in the second group, your coach will help you turn it into the first group in one question. That conversion **is** the first exercise.

WATCH & LISTEN — اِصْغِ (PERCEIVE BEFORE YOU PRODUCE)

For each of your three features, hear it before you attempt it. Your coach models three things in order:

1. the feature done **naturally**, inside a full sentence
2. the feature done **the way you do it**, so you can hear your own version from outside
3. the two **back to back**, until you can tell them apart with your eyes closed

That order is not decorative. You cannot reliably produce a contrast you cannot yet hear, and the second step — hearing your own version modelled back — is the one that usually produces the moment of recognition. It can feel uncomfortable. It is also the fastest part of the process.

For **prosodic** targets, perception works differently. Listen for the shape rather than the sound:

- **Thought groups:** where does the speaker break, and where do they refuse to break?
- **Contrast stress:** which single word is carrying the weight of the sentence?
- **Final fall:** does the sentence land, or drift?

🧩 DECODE IT — الطريقة (CUE CARDS + THE ROUTINE)

YOUR CUE CARD

Each of your three features gets a cue short enough to run in one second, silently, before you speak. Not an explanation — a trigger. Examples of the form it takes:

Feature	Cue
the 'd' in mixed conditionals	/ɑɪd bi/ — one syllable, keep the d
<i>should have been</i>	<i>stack all three: /ʃʊd əv bi n/</i>
flat delivery	<i>one word carries the sentence — pick it</i>
over-long thought groups	<i>breathe at the comma you would write</i>
/θ/ under speed	<i>tongue forward, then release</i>
lost participle endings	<i>land the -ed</i>

If your cue takes longer than a second to run, it is not a cue yet. Shorten it.

THE SELF-MONITORING ROUTINE — FOUR STEPS

This is the part you keep for life:

1. **Choose one.** Before you speak, pick **one** feature to listen for. One. Monitoring three at once monitors nothing.
2. **Cue it.** Run the one-second cue. Then stop thinking about it consciously.
3. **Catch and repair.** When you hear the slip, fix the **phrase** and continue. — *should have been checked, sorry — should have been checked before it went out.* Never restart the sentence.
4. **Log one.** Afterwards, note the single most frequent slip. That is tomorrow's chosen one.

Step 3 is the whole rubric distinction: repair reads as control, restart reads as breakdown.

Step 1 is the one learners resist, because monitoring one feature feels like neglecting the other two. It is not neglect — it is rotation. Three features monitored one at a time across three days beats three features monitored simultaneously for zero minutes, which is what actually happens when you try.

🔧 YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك (THE REPAIR LANGUAGE)

You need phrases that fix a slip without drawing attention to it. These are the ones that sound like control rather than apology — short, mid-phrase, and immediately back to the point:

Function	Language
plain repair	— <i>should have been checked, rather</i> —
repair with a marker	<i>sorry, been checked</i> —
rephrase forward	<i>or rather, what I mean is...</i>
self-flag and continue	— <i>I keep doing that</i> —
buy a beat, honestly	<i>let me put that another way.</i>
hold the floor while you think	<i>that's a good question, actually — give me a second.</i>

Two rules about all of these. **Say them at normal volume and normal speed** — a repair whispered apologetically costs you more than the original slip. And **use no more than one or two in a two-minute turn**; a speaker who repairs constantly reads as unsure, not as careful. What you are aiming for is the repair that a listener barely registers.

And the phrases to retire, permanently: *sorry, my English is not good · I don't know how to say · excuse my mistake*. They are apologies for existing in a second language, they invite a listener to lower their expectations, and on the benchmark they cost you Interaction marks that the slip itself never would have.

🎤 ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (TARGETED DRILLS → CONNECTED SPEECH)

Each of your three features climbs the same four rungs. Do not skip a rung; the point is that the feature survives the climb, and most features fail on rung three rather than rung one.

rung 1 — the feature alone (sound, or a two-word prosodic shape) **rung 2 — inside one short phrase** **rung 3 — inside a full sentence, at speaking speed** **rung 4 — inside ninety seconds of connected speech, unscripted**

Segmental targets work through minimal pairs at rung 1, then straight into rungs 2–4. Anyone can do rung 1 correctly; nobody gets credit for it. A feature you produce perfectly in isolation and lose in a sentence is a feature you do not yet have.

Prosodic targets work differently:

- **Thought groups.** Take a long sentence. Mark where you would breathe. Say it. Your partner raises a hand at every break they hear. If the hands come up mid-clause, the group is too long.

- **Contrast stress.** *I didn't say **she** took it.* Move the stress to five different words and give the five different meanings. This drill alone often unlocks flat delivery.
- **Final fall.** End ten statements with a genuine fall. Rising statements make a competent speaker sound uncertain.
- **Naturalness.** Read a sentence in a monotone, then again as though telling it to a friend. Name the difference out loud. Then keep the second version.

Record-and-compare, in the session: record rung 4 for your top feature, then play your **U1-L05 baseline** from the first week of this stage. Same speaker, twelve weeks. Not the person beside you. Not the model.

 **Keep this rung-4 recording.** It is your before-clip for the graduation comparison in L05, two lessons away.

TRAIN — تدرّب

A. Self-flagging read-aloud. Read a prepared paragraph containing all three of your features. Raise a hand **the moment you hear yourself slip** — not afterwards. Your partner marks the slips they heard. Compare lists: the gap between what you caught and what they caught is your monitoring accuracy, and it is the number that should be improving.

B. Repair without restarting. Your partner reads sentences seeded with errors. You repair each one **mid-phrase**, aloud, and continue. Then do it with your own speech.

C. Contrast-stress ladder. *I never said she borrowed my car.* Six words, six stress placements, six meanings. Say each and state the meaning it creates.

D. Thought-group surgery. Take one over-long sentence from your own L02 recording. Re-say it with breaks that let a listener follow. Notice that the grammar did not change.

E. One-minute rotation. Speak for a minute monitoring feature 1 only. Again, feature 2. Again, feature 3. Notice how much easier one is than three — that is the argument for rotation, felt rather than explained.

YOUR TURN — دورك

Speak **spontaneously for two minutes** on any topic, monitoring your **single** top feature.

The rules:

- Repair slips **in the phrase** and keep going. Never restart the sentence.
- Meaning comes first. A monitored sentence that says nothing is worse than an unmonitored sentence that says something.
- At the end, say how many slips you caught and how many your partner heard.

 **Record it.** Then play, in this order: **Day-1 → Stage-0 → A2 → B1 → today.** Listen all the way through. This is the last stop before the benchmark, and this arc is what it is measuring.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- Post a **record-and-compare**: your top feature at rung 4 today, beside an earlier clip of the same feature. Say in one line what changed.
- Carry your **cue card** into L04 and L05. One-second cues, three features.
- Run the **rotation** daily until the benchmark: one feature, one minute, one logged slip.
- Listen to your **Day-1 recording** once, all the way through. You have earned it.

REMEMBER — افكر

- **Self-monitoring is the skill that outlives the course.** Everything else here has a coach attached; this does not.
- **One feature at a time.** Monitoring three monitors none. Rotate.
- **Repair the phrase, never restart the sentence.** Same slip, two different scores.
- A feature you produce in isolation and lose in a sentence is **not yet yours** — rung 4 or it does not count.
- **Nobody can hear your grammar in a monotone.** Contrast stress carries meaning.
- The target is **clear, confident, neutral American.** Not native. That was never the promise, and you do not need it.
- Compare yourself to **your own Day-1 recording** and to nothing else.

SELF-CHECK — صحّ لنفسك

- ☐ I named three specific residual features, each with my own example.
- ☐ I have a one-second cue for each of the three, in my own words.
- ☐ I can state the four steps of the routine from memory.
- ☐ My top feature survived to rung 4 — ninety seconds of unscripted speech.
- ☐ I repaired at least one slip mid-phrase without restarting.
- ☐ I know my caught-versus-heard gap from Train A.
- ☐ I listened to my Day-1 recording and my Unit-1 baseline.
- ☐ I can say honestly what the target is: clear, confident, natural — not native.

Empire English 🏰 — the coach names the problem for twelve weeks so that afterwards you can

FULL B2 MOCK CONVERSATION — 20–30 MINUTES



Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 12 · **Lesson 4** — FULL MOCK 🕒 ~45 min · 📞 Recorded + live · Prerequisite: L01–L03 Built from: `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` · **S3-U12-L04**

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك

By the end, **you'll be able to:**

- Hold a natural **20–30 minute** conversation in English, everyday through professional to abstract.
- Narrate, argue, speculate, report and hedge — **spontaneously**, without a script.
- Score your own performance against the **five rubric dimensions** from evidence. 🎧

👑 WHY THIS MATTERS — ليه ده مهم

This is the thing the whole programme was engineered backwards from.

Not the grammar, not the accent work, not the sixty lessons — those are the means. The promise at the centre of Empire English is one specific, testable capability: **a natural twenty-to-thirty-minute conversation in English, on everyday and professional topics, clearly and confidently.** Everything you have done since your first lesson exists to make today possible. Next week, the identical event is your graduation benchmark. Today it is a rehearsal with no consequences.

Which raises the fair question of why we would spend a full forty-five-minute lesson rehearsing something you are about to do for real. The answer is that the benchmark measures your English, and it can only do that if nothing else in the room is unfamiliar. If the length is unfamiliar, you pace yourself wrong and run out of energy at minute eighteen. If the three-part arc is unfamiliar, you spend the professional section wondering when it changes again. If the rubric is unfamiliar, you optimise for the wrong thing — usually zero errors, which is not what any of the five dimensions actually reward. Every one of those is a way of scoring below your real level, and every one of them is removed by doing this once, at full length, a week early. After today, the only variable left is your English. That is the entire design.

Twenty-five minutes is also longer than you think, and the specific failure it produces is worth naming in advance. It is not grammatical collapse — it is **energy**. Learners who start at full intensity, monitoring every feature, choosing every word carefully, are noticeably tired by minute fifteen and their accuracy falls off a cliff after that, which reads on the recording as a level they do not have. A twenty-five-minute conversation is paced like a conversation, not like a performance: you settle, you let some sentences be ordinary, you let your partner talk, you use the thinking-time phrases you have. You will find out today what your own pacing does, which is information you cannot get from a two-minute task.

There is one more thing this format asks of you that shorter tasks never have, and it is the reason the benchmark is a conversation rather than a monologue. You have to be **interested in the other person**. Interaction is a scored dimension in its own right: asking a real question, picking up something the other person said three minutes ago, conceding the fair part of their objection and holding the rest. A learner who delivers twenty-five minutes of excellent monologue and never genuinely responds does not meet the B2 standard, and should not — because the standard is a conversation, and a conversation has two people in it. If you notice one thing today, notice how much of the time you spend listening.

🔄 WARM-UP — سَخْن (LIGHT SMALL TALK, ENGLISH ONLY)

No grammar. No targets. Just warm the voice and the mind up in English, the way a real conversation starts:

What did you do this weekend? · What's the weather doing? · Have you eaten? · Anything good on this week? · How's the traffic been?

Two minutes of genuine small talk, then two minutes on your best moment of the last week. The point is to be **already speaking English** when the twenty-five minutes begins — a conversation that starts cold spends its first three minutes warming up, and on benchmark day those are three scored minutes.

💡 WATCH & LISTEN — النموذج (THE SHAPE OF THE 25 MINUTES)

Before you begin, know the arc. It moves in three connected phases, and it moves **outwards** — from your life, to your work, to ideas:

Phase	~Time	Territory	What is being evidenced
1 — Everyday	~7 min	your week, your history, a story, a plan	fluency, narrative range, natural tense use
2 — Professional	~10 min	your work or field, a process, a disagreement, a report	precision, passive/relative/reported, register control
3 — Abstract	~8 min	an opinion, a speculation, a hypothetical, a nuance	argument, hedging, deduction, conditionals

Two things about the transitions. They are **not announced** by the assessor as topic changes — they arrive as questions that happen to be broader than the last one. And the register is expected to move with them: looser in phase 1, tighter in phase 2, and thoughtful rather than formal in phase 3. That movement is Range, and L02 warned you about the learner who runs all three phases identically.

A model transition, so you recognise it when it happens:

Assessor: ...so it sounds like that project took over your whole autumn. How does your team usually decide what to take on?

That is the door from phase 1 into phase 2, and it looks exactly like the previous question. A strong candidate walks through it and changes gear. A weaker one answers it as more small talk.

DECODE IT — القاعدة (THE FIVE DIMENSIONS AND THE DEFINED MINIMUM)

You are scored on five dimensions. Read this properly, because most learners prepare for a rubric that does not exist — they prepare to make no mistakes. That is not what any of the five measure, and there is no dimension called *accuracy alone*.

Dimension	What it actually asks	Strong at B2
Fluency	Can you keep going at a natural pace over 25 minutes?	pauses are for thinking, not for searching; no collapse late on
Accuracy	Is the grammar in control at speaking speed ?	slips happen and get repaired; the structure survives complexity
Range / Coherence	Do you command variety, and does it hold together?	tense, structure and register all move; arguments are signposted
Interaction	Are you in a conversation, or performing?	real questions, real responses, genuine engagement with objections
Pronunciation	Can a listener follow you without effort?	clear, natural prosody, thought groups; not "native"

THE DEFINED MINIMUM

The B2 determination requires the threshold **in every dimension**, not on average. This is the part that most changes how people prepare. Brilliant fluency does not compensate for a Pronunciation score below the minimum. Flawless accuracy does not rescue an Interaction score earned by monologuing for twenty-five minutes. The exact bands live in `curriculum/05-assessment-suite.md`, and your coach will read you the card — the principle you need today is: **your weakest dimension is your result**.

Which makes the practical instruction obvious. Find out today which dimension is your weakest, and spend the next seven days there. Not on the one you enjoy improving.

WHAT IS EXPLICITLY NOT PENALISED

This list is short, true, and worth trusting:

- **Asking for repetition or clarification.** *Sorry, could you say that again?* is scored **as** Interaction.
- **Taking thinking time**, if you take it out loud. *That's an interesting question — let me think for a second.*
- **Repairing a sentence** mid-phrase. Control, not error. (Restarting the whole sentence is the version that costs you.)
- **Saying you do not know.** *Honestly, I've never thought about that* is a real answer, and what you do next is scored.
- **Having an accent.** Never a criterion. Not at any band, in any dimension.

WHAT ACTUALLY COSTS MARKS

- **Silence** where a thinking-time phrase would have worked.
- **One register for all twenty-five minutes** — the Range error L02 named.
- **Monologuing.** No questions, no uptake, no engagement. Interaction is scored, and it cannot be inferred.
- **Late collapse** from pacing at performance intensity instead of conversation intensity.
- **Apologising for your English.** It lowers the listener's expectation and costs Interaction. Nothing is gained.



YOUR ARSENAL — ذخيرتك (THE STRATEGIES, NOT A SCRIPT)

Do not memorise content. Memorise **moves** — these are what carry a long conversation:

Move	Language
buy thinking time	<i>That's a good question — let me think about it for a second.</i>
narrow a huge question	<i>I'll answer that from the work side, if that's alright.</i>
signpost an argument	<i>There are two things going on here. The first is...</i>
concede, then hold	<i>You're right that it's expensive — I still think it's cheaper than the alternative.</i>
hedge honestly	<i>I'd be cautious about saying that, but my impression is...</i>
attribute a claim	<i>My manager has indicated that... — although I haven't seen it myself.</i>
speculate with evidence	<i>It must have been decided earlier; nobody could answer about the start date.</i>
an unreal alternative	<i>If we'd started in March, we'd be finished by now.</i>
shift register deliberately	<i>If I were saying this to my director, I'd put it as...</i>
ask a genuine question	<i>Does it work the same way in your field?</i>
pick up an earlier thread	<i>Can I come back to what you said about deadlines?</i>
repair, mid-phrase	<i>— should have been checked, rather —</i>
close a long answer	<i>So, broadly, that's where I've landed on it.</i>

The last three are the ones learners forget and the ones that most visibly separate a conversation from a recital.



ACCENT LAB — عيادة النطق (90–60 SECOND TOP-ONE TUNE-UP)

One feature. Your **single** highest-impact target from the L03 clinic. Not three.

cue → one phrase → one sentence → **stop**

Then put the card face down. During the conversation you monitor **one** feature, in the background, while your attention stays on the person in front of you. That is exactly the routine you built in L03, and this is what it was for.



The whole conversation is recorded. You will use it twice: once for self-assessment tonight, and once next week to compare against the benchmark itself.



TRAIN — البروفة الكاملة (THE FULL 20–30 MINUTE CONVERSATION)

This is the lesson. Twenty-five minutes, recorded, in three phases. Your coach follows the prompt bank; these are the kinds of question each phase opens with.

PHASE 1 — EVERYDAY (~7 MIN)

Tell me about your week — what's actually taken up your time? · How did you end up in the work you do? · Tell me about something that went unexpectedly well or unexpectedly badly recently. · What are you planning for the next few months?

Let the tenses arrive naturally: perfect continuous for what has been going on, narrative past for the story, advanced futures for the plans. Do not force them. Do not announce them.

PHASE 2 — PROFESSIONAL (~10 MIN)

Walk me through how something actually gets done where you work. · Tell me about a process that isn't working, and what should have been done differently. · Tell me about a disagreement you had at work — what did each side actually claim? · How was a decision made above you communicated to your team? · If a new colleague joined tomorrow, what would you warn them about?

This is where the passive, relative clauses, reported speech and register live. **This is the phase where your register should tighten** — and where at least one push-back is coming.

PHASE 3 — ABSTRACT (~8 MIN)

Has technology made us worse at something? · Should companies be able to monitor how their staff work? · Is it better to be respected or liked at work? · What's something most people in your field believe that you think is wrong? · If you could change one thing about how education works, what would it be?

Argument, hedging, deduction, conditionals. You are not required to have a settled view — thinking out loud is a scored B2 skill. *I can see both sides, and here's what makes it difficult* is a strong answer, not an evasion.

THE RULES OF THE ROOM

- **English only**, all twenty-five minutes.
- **Pace it like a conversation**, not a performance. Let sentences be ordinary sometimes.
- **Ask questions**. At least three genuine ones across the twenty-five minutes.
- **When you slip, repair and continue**. Never restart.
- **Expect push-back twice**. Concede what is fair; hold what is not.
- **Do not apologise for your English**. Not once.

YOUR TURN — دورك (SELF-ASSESSMENT FROM EVIDENCE)

Score yourself on all five dimensions — **from the recording**, not from memory. Memory of your own performance is unreliable in both directions, which is why the recording exists.

For each dimension write one line of evidence and a number:

Dimension	Your evidence — quote yourself	Band
Fluency	<i>e.g. "steady until ~min 18, then noticeably slower"</i>	
Accuracy	<i>e.g. "three slips on 'been' in passives; repaired one"</i>	
Range / Coherence	<i>e.g. "good tense range; register never changed in phase 2"</i>	
Interaction	<i>e.g. "asked one question in 25 min; conceded the deadline point well"</i>	
Pronunciation	<i>e.g. "clear; thought groups too long when arguing"</i>	

Then answer the only question that matters this week:

Which is my weakest dimension, and what will I do about it in the next seven days?

Because of the defined minimum, that dimension **is** your result. Work there.

YOUR ORDERS — مهمتك

- **Self-assess with the rubric card** against your recording, all five dimensions, evidence quoted.
- **Name your weakest dimension** and do one thing about it every day for seven days. One dimension, not five.
- If it was **Interaction**: practise asking three real questions in every English conversation this week.
- If it was **Range**: practise the two-register version of one story a day.
- If it was **Fluency**: two ten-minute unscripted talks, not two-minute ones. Length is a separate skill.
- If it was **Pronunciation**: your top-one cue at rung 4, daily.
- If it was **Accuracy**: your six residual targets from L01 and L02, out loud, in sentences.
- **Sleep before L05**. It is a conversation, and tired conversation is the single most avoidable way to score low.

REMEMBER — افكر

- This is **the exact benchmark format**. After today the only unfamiliar thing left on benchmark day is nothing.
- **Your weakest dimension is your result**. The minimum is defined in every dimension, not on average.

- **Pace it like a conversation.** Late collapse from performance intensity is the classic twenty-five-minute failure.
- **Interaction is scored and cannot be inferred.** Ask real questions. Listen to the answers.
- Asking for repetition, thinking out loud, repairing mid-phrase and saying *I don't know* all cost **nothing**.
- **Never apologise for your English.** It lowers expectations and gains you nothing.
- **Register moves with the phases** — looser, tighter, thoughtful. One register for twenty-five minutes is a Range error.

✓ SELF-CHECK — صحّح لنفسك

- ☐ I spoke English for the full 20–30 minutes, without switching.
- ☐ I got through all three phases: everyday, professional, abstract.
- ☐ I asked at least three genuine questions.
- ☐ My register changed audibly between phase 1 and phase 2.
- ☐ I handled two push-backs — conceding what was fair, holding what was not.
- ☐ I repaired my slips mid-phrase and never restarted a sentence.
- ☐ My pace at minute twenty was close to my pace at minute five.
- ☐ I did not apologise for my English once.
- ☐ I scored all five dimensions from the recording, with quoted evidence.
- ☐ I know my weakest dimension and exactly what I am doing about it this week.

Empire English 🏰 — one week from now this is your graduation; today it costs you nothing

B2 FLAGSHIP BENCHMARK + GRADUATION "AFTER" SAMPLE 🎓★

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · Unit 12 · **Lesson 5** — *STAGE FINALE · FLAGSHIP GRADUATION* 🕒 ~50 min · 📺 Live recorded assessment, English-only · Prerequisite: L01–L04 *Built from:* `curriculum/stage3/unit12-putting-it-together.md` · *S3-U12-L05*

🎯 YOUR CONQUEST — هدفك (FLAGSHIP GRADUATION)

Today you will:

- complete the **Stage-3 summative quiz**
- hold the **B2 benchmark conversation** — 20–30 minutes, everyday → professional → abstract
- record the **graduation "after" sample** on the standard prompt
- receive an evidence-based **B2 graduation determination**, and choose your next path 🎧

1 SETTLE

One breath. You ran this exact format, at this exact length, last week.

This is a celebration and a piece of evidence — not a filter. A result describes what you did today and what comes next. It does not describe your intelligence, your effort, or your worth. Nobody in this room is hoping you fall short.

Three permissions that are real, and that people forget under pressure:

- If your mind empties in the first minute, **say so in English** and ask for the question again. That is scored as interaction, not lost.
- If you need a second to think, **take it out loud**. *That's a good question — let me think.*
- If a sentence goes wrong, **repair the phrase and carry on**. Do not restart it.

And one thing to know before you begin: whatever the number says at the end, you are about to hold a twenty-five-minute conversation in English. Two years ago — for some of you, four months ago — that sentence was not available to you.

2 THE STAGE-3 SUMMATIVE QUIZ

Complete it independently. It samples recognition and short production across the whole stage:

- the full perfect aspect: present perfect, perfect continuous, and the perfect-versus-past choice

- past perfect and past perfect continuous in narrative sequence
- advanced futures: future perfect, future continuous, *be about to*, *be due to*
- third and mixed conditionals, and *wish / if only* for regret
- modals of deduction, present and past, with evidence attached
- the advanced passive: every tense, modal and perfect passives, the reporting passive, the causative
- relative clauses: defining and non-defining, reduced, preposition + *which / whom*, *which* for a whole idea
- reported speech: the reporting-verb range and its patterns, backshift, reported questions
- register, diplomatic softening, and collocation

3 BENCHMARK SETUP

The conversation runs **20–30 minutes**, in the three phases you rehearsed in L04:

1. **Everyday** (~7 min) — your week, how you got here, a story, your plans.
2. **Professional** (~10 min) — how something gets done, a process that is failing, a disagreement reported accurately, a decision made above you.
3. **Abstract** (~8 min) — an opinion held and defended, a speculation, a hypothetical, a nuance.

You are scored on five dimensions — **Fluency · Accuracy · Range/Coherence · Interaction · Pronunciation** — and the B2 determination requires the **defined minimum in every one of them**, not on average.

What that means in the room: do not spend twenty-five minutes protecting your Accuracy. **Ask real questions** (Interaction cannot be inferred). **Let your register move** with the phases (that is Range). **Pace it like a conversation** so that minute twenty-two sounds like minute five. You know all of this; you found out last week which of the five is yours to watch.

4 ACCENT TUNE-UP

One feature. Your single highest-impact target from the L03 clinic.

cue → one phrase → one sentence → **stop**

Then the card goes face down. During the conversation you monitor that one feature in the background while your attention stays on the person in front of you. Meaning and responsiveness first; clarity follows from the cue you have already built.

5 THE B2 BENCHMARK CONVERSATION ★

20–30 minutes. English only. Recorded and scored. This is the flagship.

PHASE 1 — EVERYDAY

Your week and what actually took up your time; how you ended up in the work or study you do; something that went unexpectedly well or badly; what you are planning next. Let the tenses arrive because the story needs them.

PHASE 2 — PROFESSIONAL

How something really gets done where you work; a process that is not working and what should have been done differently; a disagreement, reported accurately, with what each side actually claimed; how a decision made above you was communicated. This is where precision lives — passive, relatives, reported speech — and where your register should tighten.

PHASE 3 — ABSTRACT

An opinion you hold, defended under challenge; something most people in your field believe that you think is wrong; what you would change if you could; a hypothetical taken seriously. Thinking out loud is a B2 skill, not an evasion. *I can see both sides, and here is what makes it difficult* is a strong answer.

ACROSS ALL THREE

You will be **challenged at least twice**. Concede the part that is fair and hold the part that is not — that is the single clearest evidence of B2 interaction there is. Ask your own questions. Pick up something said earlier. Repair without restarting. Do not apologise for your English, not once.

6 THE GRADUATION "AFTER" SAMPLE 🎬

A **separate recording**, and nothing in it is scored.

Record the standard prompt under the before/after protocol's comparable conditions — same prompt, same phone or microphone position, same quiet room, unread and unrehearsed:

"Tell me about yourself, your family, and your typical day."

Then the B2 flagship extension:

"Talk about your work or your studies, and discuss a topic you care about."

Speak naturally. Do not memorise and do not read. This is the same prompt you answered on your very first day, and that is the entire point: it is the only recording in existence where every variable except the

work you have done is held constant. It will sit beside your Day-1, Stage-0, A2 and B1 samples as the fifth and headline point on the timeline.

7 RESULT, EVIDENCE AND THE B2 DETERMINATION

Your coach gives you, in this order:

1. the **rubric evidence** across all five dimensions, quoted from what you actually said
2. the **B2 graduation determination** against the defined minimum in every dimension
3. **two specific wins**, quoted — things you did today that you could not do in Unit 1
4. one **language or interaction target** to carry forward
5. one **residual pronunciation target** from the tracker

Evidence comes before the label, always. If one dimension sits below the minimum, that is a named, dated piece of work with a rescheduled component attached — not a verdict about you, and not a reason to discard the twenty-five minutes you just did. Most of a strong performance is still a strong performance.

8 CELEBRATE, CONSENT, AND WHAT COMES NEXT

COMPLETION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Summative quiz score **and** production responses saved.
- ☐ B2 benchmark conversation recorded and scored on all five dimensions, with quoted, timestamped evidence.
- ☐ Standard graduation prompt recorded as a **separate file** under protocol conditions.
- ☐ **B2 graduation determination** and evidence notes entered in the Cohort Tracker.
- ☐ Consent tier, storage link and any publication restriction recorded — and re-confirmed today.
- ☐ Any residual structures and pronunciation features flagged for optional Stage 4.
- ☐ Learner has received the result, the two wins, and their next path.
- ☐ Any accommodation used (topic notes, shorter end of the range) recorded beside the result.

THE TIMELINE

Where consent permits, sit with the learner and play the five points in order:

Day-1 → Stage-0 → A2 → B1 → B2

Same prompt. Same person. Five recordings. This is the proof the whole programme exists to produce, and it belongs to the learner before it belongs to anyone else. It is evidence of development, not permission to publish.

YOUR NEXT CAMPAIGN — AND IT IS A CHOICE

You have delivered the flagship promise. There is no further level you are required to reach. Two honest paths:

- **Stage 4 — Advanced / Exam (C1 + IELTS/TOEFL).** Near-native range and nuance, idiomatic and academic language, prosodic polish, and an optional certification track. Take this if you have a concrete reason: a university place, a visa band, a role that needs academic writing. C1 polish is an aspirational ceiling and it is never guaranteed.
- **Community and maintenance.** Keep using English every week, keep the self-monitoring routine, keep speaking. This is not the lesser option. English that is used stays; English that is stored decays, at any level.

Either way, take the routine from L03 with you. It is the only part of this course that works without a coach in the room.



REMEMBER — افكر

- You began this programme unable to talk about yesterday. You just held a **twenty-five-minute conversation** about ideas, in English, without a script.
- **B2 means reliable, not flawless.** Slips repaired mid-phrase are evidence of control.
- Conceding the fair part of a challenge and holding the rest is the clearest thing a confident speaker does.
- The target was always **clear, confident, natural** — never native. You did not need native, and you never will.
- Your recordings are proof of your progress; **your consent controls what may be done with them**, today and later.
- **Self-monitoring is what you keep.** It is the difference between finishing a course and continuing to improve.
- Five points on the timeline. Stage 4 is optional. Using English for the rest of your life is not.



EMPIRE SIGN-OFF

Confident → B2 GRADUATION, when the evidence meets the standard in every dimension.

You did not collect grammar. You built enough control to tell the story, make the argument, report what was said, speculate about what happened, disagree without giving ground, and change how you sound depending on who is listening — for twenty-five unbroken minutes, in English, with nobody feeding you lines.

That was the promise. Keep the recording. Let the evidence speak. Then go and use it. 🏰

*Empire English 🏰 · Stage 3 — Confident · **B2 GRADUATION** · the flagship promise, delivered on evidence*



STAGE 3

GLOSSARY

STAGE 3 — GLOSSARY

Empire English · Stage 3 — **Confident** (B2) · **487 entries** Generated from the **Your Arsenal** tables of all 60 Stage-3 lessons by `tools/audit/generate-stage-glossary.mjs --stage 3` — do not edit by hand.

Your whole Stage-3 arsenal, in the order you met it — and in English only, like the stage itself. There is no translation column here because there was none in the lessons.

Every word here is taught somewhere in the book, and the lesson it comes from is named, so you can go back to the explanation rather than memorising a list out of context.

CONTENTS

- **Unit 1 — Perfect Aspect Mastery** · 42 entries
- **Unit 2 — Past Perfect & Narrative Mastery** · 35 entries
- **Unit 3 — Future Forms (Advanced)** · 40 entries
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- **Unit 11 — Abstract Topics & Debate** · 38 entries
- **Unit 12 — Putting It Together (B2) ★** · 42 entries

UNIT 1 — PERFECT ASPECT MASTERY

Lesson	English	Example
L01	I've been working on...	<i>I've been working on the report.</i>
L01	I've been meaning to...	<i>I've been meaning to call you.</i>
L01	I've been trying to...	<i>I've been trying to fix it.</i>
L01	lately / recently	<i>What have you been doing lately?</i>
L01	all week / all day	<i>I've been travelling all week.</i>
L01	It's been taking...	<i>It's been taking forever.</i>
L01	barely	<i>I've barely slept.</i>
L01	I've been looking for...	<i>I've been looking for a flat.</i>
L01	ever since	<i>She's been studying ever since.</i>
L01	make progress	<i>I've been making good progress.</i>
L02	so far	<i>I've painted two rooms so far.</i>
L02	up to now	<i>Up to now I've read half.</i>
L02	I've almost finished	<i>I've almost finished it.</i>
L02	I've managed to...	<i>I've managed to fix two of them.</i>
L02	I haven't got round to it	<i>I've been meaning to — I haven't got round to it.</i>
L02	It's been going on for...	<i>It's been going on for weeks.</i>
L02	I've made a start	<i>I've made a start, at least.</i>
L02	how far have you got?	<i>How far have you got with it?</i>
L02	in progress	<i>It's still in progress.</i>
L02	a fair bit	<i>I've done a fair bit.</i>
L03	ever since	<i>Ever since I was a teenager.</i>
L03	for ages	<i>I've been doing this for ages.</i>
L03	for a while	<i>I've been thinking about it for a while.</i>
L03	on and off	<i>On and off for about five years.</i>
L03	just over / just under	<i>Just over a year.</i>
L03	nearly / almost	<i>Nearly six years now.</i>
L03	a couple of years	<i>A couple of years, maybe more.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L03	properly, only for...	<i>Properly, only for two years.</i>
L03	I couldn't tell you	<i>Ages — I couldn't tell you.</i>
L03	all that time	<i>Have you been there all that time?</i>
L04	I've been working on...	<i>I've been working on a new system.</i>
L04	making progress	<i>We've been making steady progress.</i>
L04	so far	<i>So far I've finished the design.</i>
L04	about two thirds done	<i>It's about two thirds done.</i>
L04	it's been giving me trouble	<i>The payment side has been giving me trouble.</i>
L04	going round in circles	<i>I've been going round in circles with it.</i>
L04	taking longer than expected	<i>It's been taking longer than expected.</i>
L04	the next step is...	<i>The next step is user testing.</i>
L04	I'm going to...	<i>I'm going to test it next month.</i>
L04	if that goes well	<i>If that goes well, we'll launch.</i>
L04	the hardest part has been...	<i>The hardest part has been scope.</i>
L04	I've cut / dropped...	<i>I've cut about half the features.</i>

UNIT 2 — PAST PERFECT & NARRATIVE MASTERY

Lesson	English	Example
L01	by the time	<i>By the time I got there, they'd left.</i>
L01	already	<i>They'd already started.</i>
L01	I'd never ... before	<i>I'd never flown before.</i>
L01	it turned out that...	<i>It turned out he'd resigned.</i>
L01	it had taken...	<i>It had taken three weeks.</i>
L01	by then	<i>By then I'd made up my mind.</i>
L01	I realised (that) I'd...	<i>I realised I'd forgotten it.</i>
L01	I hadn't expected...	<i>I hadn't expected that at all.</i>
L01	the day before	<i>I'd accepted it the day before.</i>
L01	in the end	<i>It was fine in the end.</i>
L02	because I'd been...	<i>I was tired because I'd been travelling.</i>
L02	all night / all day	<i>She'd been working all night.</i>
L02	since Thursday	<i>He'd been on it since Thursday.</i>
L02	for two weeks	<i>They'd been waiting for two weeks.</i>
L02	that's why...	<i>That's why she was so upset.</i>
L02	it explained why...	<i>It explained why he'd looked worried.</i>
L02	the whole time	<i>He'd been changing it the whole time.</i>
L02	I'd been meaning to...	<i>I'd been meaning to call her.</i>
L02	out of breath	<i>He was out of breath.</i>
L02	wrecked / exhausted	<i>She was completely wrecked.</i>
L03	<i>This was back when... · At the time I was... · It was the middle of...</i>	Set the scene
L03	<i>Anyway... · So... · The next thing I knew... · A couple of days later...</i>	Move forward
L03	<i>I should say... · To explain... · A bit of background... · This was after...</i>	Step back

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>It turned out that... · What I didn't know was... · As it happened...</i>	Reveal
L03	<i>...because I'd been... · By then I'd... · Which explained why...</i>	Give the cause
L03	<i>In the end... · The upshot was... · And that's when I realised...</i>	Reach the point
L03	<i>Looking back... · I've never forgotten... · It taught me that...</i>	Reflect
L04	<i>On the surface... · The immediate cause was... · Officially...</i>	Surface cause
L04	<i>But that's not really the reason. · That was a symptom. · The underlying issue was...</i>	Go deeper
L04	<i>We'd been ... since ... · By then we'd already ... · Nobody had been ...</i>	Reach back
L04	<i>It turned out that... · What we didn't know was... · As it happened...</i>	Reveal
L04	<i>The real cause wasn't X, it was Y. · The actual problem was that we'd...</i>	Name the real cause
L04	<i>...which meant that... · and that was because... · so by the time...</i>	Chain it
L04	<i>My best guess is... · I still don't fully know why... · Nobody ever explained it.</i>	Concede uncertainty
L04	<i>Looking back... · If we'd known earlier... · That's what makes it frustrating.</i>	Judge with hindsight

UNIT 3 — FUTURE FORMS (ADVANCED)

Lesson	English	Example
L01	this time next week	<i>This time next week I'll be flying.</i>
L01	at eight tomorrow	<i>At eight tomorrow I'll be travelling.</i>
L01	Will you be using...?	<i>Will you be using the room?</i>
L01	Will you be joining us?	<i>Will you be joining us later?</i>
L01	Will you be needing...?	<i>Will you be needing anything else?</i>
L01	I'll be in meetings	<i>I'll be in meetings all afternoon.</i>
L01	by then	<i>I'll be finishing up by then.</i>
L01	I won't be around	<i>I won't be around on Friday.</i>
L01	all next month	<i>I'll be travelling all next month.</i>
L01	when you arrive	<i>When you arrive I'll be waiting.</i>
L02	by the end of the year	<i>By the end of the year I'll have moved.</i>
L02	by then	<i>By then we'll have decided.</i>
L02	by the time you arrive	<i>By the time you arrive I'll have finished.</i>
L02	in three years	<i>In three years I'll have qualified.</i>
L02	I'll have finished	<i>I'll have finished it by Friday.</i>
L02	we'll have completed	<i>We'll have completed testing.</i>
L02	I won't have...	<i>I won't have finished by then.</i>
L02	I'll have been ... for	<i>I'll have been studying for six years.</i>
L02	hopefully	<i>Hopefully I'll have started by then.</i>
L02	that's the plan	<i>...and that's the plan.</i>
L03	<i>I'm meeting... · I'm having lunch with... · We're using... · I'm on a call at...</i>	Diary entry
L03	<i>I'm going to try to... · I'm planning to... · I'm hoping to...</i>	Intention
L03	<i>It'll be... · That probably won't... · I imagine it'll...</i>	Prediction
L03	<i>Actually, I'll... · You know what, I'll... · I'll just...</i>	Instant decision
L03	<i>I'll be ... all afternoon · This time next week I'll be...</i>	In progress later

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>By Friday we'll have... · By then I'll have...</i>	Completed by then
L03	<i>What does your Thursday look like? · Have you got anything on?</i>	Ask about the diary
L03	<i>...though nothing's confirmed yet. · ...in theory.</i>	Flag the unfixed
L04	bound to	<i>Prices are bound to rise.</i>
L04	likely to	<i>It's likely to slow down.</i>
L04	may well	<i>It may well change.</i>
L04	the chances are	<i>The chances are it'll slip.</i>
L04	I'd imagine	<i>I'd imagine so, yes.</i>
L04	it could go either way	<i>Honestly, it could go either way.</i>
L04	probably won't	<i>It probably won't move.</i>
L04	I'd be surprised if...	<i>I'd be surprised if it did.</i>
L04	unlikely to	<i>It's unlikely to recover fully.</i>
L04	I can't see it happening	<i>I can't see it happening.</i>
L04	I wouldn't put money on it	<i>I wouldn't put money on it.</i>
L04	mainly because...	<i>...mainly because of the supply issue.</i>

UNIT 4 — THIRD & MIXED CONDITIONALS

Lesson	English	Example
L01	If I'd known...	<i>If I'd known, I'd have called.</i>
L01	I would have...	<i>I would have gone with you.</i>
L01	I could have...	<i>I could have helped.</i>
L01	I might have...	<i>You might have caught it.</i>
L01	I wouldn't have...	<i>I wouldn't have said that.</i>
L01	if it hadn't been for...	<i>If it hadn't been for her, we'd have failed.</i>
L01	otherwise	<i>I didn't know — otherwise I'd have come.</i>
L01	as it turned out	<i>As it turned out, it didn't matter.</i>
L01	in hindsight	<i>In hindsight, I'd have done it differently.</i>
L01	I'd never have...	<i>I'd never have met her otherwise.</i>
L02	<i>If I'd only... · In hindsight I'd have... · I wish I'd... · That's on me.</i>	Regret
L02	<i>So from now on I'm... · Which is why I now... · Lesson learned.</i>	Regret → lesson
L02	<i>You could have... · It would have helped to... · We might have... · I suppose we could have...</i>	Soften a criticism
L02	<i>...to be fair. · It's not only you. · In their defence...</i>	Add fairness
L02	<i>Would it have...? · Might we have...? · Would that have changed anything?</i>	Hypothesise
L02	<i>Honestly, probably not. · It might not have made any difference.</i>	Concede the hypothesis
L02	<i>Either way... · As it turned out... · There's no point going over it.</i>	Close it down
L03	I'd be ... now	<i>I'd be a doctor now.</i>
L03	I wouldn't be ...	<i>I wouldn't be here.</i>
L03	by now	<i>My English would be better by now.</i>
L03	I wouldn't have this...	<i>I wouldn't have this job.</i>
L03	I'd still be...	<i>I'd still be living there.</i>
L03	looking back	<i>Looking back, I'd be somewhere else.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L03	that's why I'm...	<i>That's why I'm here.</i>
L03	if it hadn't been for...	<i>If it hadn't been for her, I wouldn't be doing this.</i>
L03	I wouldn't know...	<i>I wouldn't know any of you.</i>
L03	it shaped...	<i>That decision shaped everything.</i>
L04	I wish I'd...	<i>I wish I'd applied.</i>
L04	I wish I hadn't...	<i>I wish I hadn't sent it.</i>
L04	If only I'd...	<i>If only I'd listened.</i>
L04	that's the real one	<i>I wish I'd learned English — that's the real one.</i>
L04	at least	<i>I wish I'd applied, at least.</i>
L04	looking back	<i>Looking back, I wish I'd waited.</i>
L04	I don't regret...	<i>I don't regret leaving, actually.</i>
L04	what it costs	<i>I know exactly what it costs.</i>
L04	lesson learned	<i>Lesson learned, honestly.</i>
L04	that's why I now...	<i>That's why I don't put things off now.</i>

UNIT 5 — MODALS OF DEDUCTION & SPECULATION

Lesson	English	Example
L01	he must be...	<i>He must be in a meeting.</i>
L01	it might be...	<i>It might be broken.</i>
L01	it could be...	<i>It could be the connection.</i>
L01	that can't be right	<i>That can't be right.</i>
L01	she can't be...	<i>She can't be ignoring you.</i>
L01	judging by...	<i>Judging by the queue, it must be good.</i>
L01	given that...	<i>Given that the lights are off...</i>
L01	that would explain...	<i>That would explain the delay.</i>
L01	the only explanation is...	<i>The only explanation is that he forgot.</i>
L01	there must be a reason	<i>There must be a reason for it.</i>
L02	it must have...	<i>It must have rained.</i>
L02	she might have...	<i>She might have forgotten.</i>
L02	they could have...	<i>They could have missed it.</i>
L02	he can't have...	<i>He can't have known.</i>
L02	that would explain...	<i>That would explain the delay.</i>
L02	something must have...	<i>Something must have gone wrong.</i>
L02	I must have...	<i>I must have sent the wrong one.</i>
L02	that seems unlikely	<i>All four of them? That seems unlikely.</i>
L02	although...	<i>Although I got my own copy.</i>
L02	that's exactly what...	<i>That's exactly what I've done.</i>
L03	<i>It looks like... · Judging by... · Going by the fact that...</i>	Read visible evidence
L03	<i>It seems... · I get the impression... · There's something a bit off about...</i>	Offer an impression
L03	<i>Presumably... · The obvious explanation is... · Which suggests...</i>	Draw the obvious inference
L03	<i>In which case... · If that's right, then... · Which would mean...</i>	Chain a consequence

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>Or it could just be... · Then again... · Unless...</i>	Offer an alternative
L03	<i>Was he? Then it can't be... · Actually, in that case...</i>	Revise
L03	<i>I'm guessing, to be fair. · I could be completely wrong. · Don't quote me.</i>	Retreat
L03	<i>He's been ... all week · She was fine with ... this morning</i>	Keep it about behaviour
L04	<i>Given that... · The fact that... · We know that... · Going by...</i>	Set out evidence
L04	<i>This suggests... · That points to... · Which implies...</i>	Soft inference
L04	<i>Which would mean... · In which case... · If that's right, then...</i>	Consequence
L04	<i>It could be... · One possibility is... · Unless it's...</i>	Raise alternative
L04	<i>But that wouldn't explain... · Except that... · That doesn't account for...</i>	Rule it out
L04	<i>So my conclusion is... · Therefore... · On balance, I'd say...</i>	Conclude
L04	<i>...though it doesn't prove it. · We'd need to check. · If I'm right, we'd expect...</i>	Stay honest
L04	<i>Given all that, I'd... · My recommendation would be...</i>	Recommend

UNIT 6 — THE PASSIVE (ADVANCED)

Lesson	English	Example
L01	is being + participle	<i>The floor is being fitted.</i>
L01	has been + participle	<i>The desks have been ordered.</i>
L01	will be confirmed	<i>The date will be confirmed.</i>
L01	nothing's been decided	<i>Nothing's been decided yet.</i>
L01	it's been sold	<i>The building's been sold.</i>
L01	we weren't told	<i>We weren't told until afterwards.</i>
L01	is checked every...	<i>The system is checked nightly.</i>
L01	once ... is signed off	<i>Once the fit-out is signed off...</i>
L01	is due to be...	<i>It's due to be replaced.</i>
L01	it's still being...	<i>It's still being reviewed.</i>
L02	must be submitted	<i>Forms must be submitted by Friday.</i>
L02	has to be approved	<i>It has to be approved by a director.</i>
L02	should be checked	<i>It should be checked first.</i>
L02	can be done online	<i>Payment can be made online.</i>
L02	can't be changed	<i>It can't be changed once submitted.</i>
L02	needs to be signed	<i>This needs to be signed.</i>
L02	doesn't have to be...	<i>It doesn't have to be in English.</i>
L02	should have been...	<i>That should have been flagged.</i>
L02	it shouldn't have been left	<i>It shouldn't have been left that long.</i>
L02	that's not on you	<i>And it should have been. That's not on you.</i>
L03	it is believed that...	<i>It is believed that rates will hold.</i>
L03	it is said that...	<i>It is said that he's leaving.</i>
L03	it is widely thought...	<i>It is widely thought to be safe.</i>
L03	he is understood to...	<i>He is understood to have resigned.</i>
L03	it has been reported...	<i>It has been reported that two others may follow.</i>
L03	it is expected to...	<i>The bridge is expected to reopen in March.</i>
L03	it is estimated that...	<i>It is estimated that repairs will cost 40 million.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L03	it is alleged that...	<i>It is alleged that funds were misused.</i>
L03	it's supposed to be...	<i>It's supposed to be excellent.</i>
L03	although nothing has been confirmed	<i>...although nothing has been confirmed.</i>
L04	I had my hair cut	<i>I had my hair cut yesterday.</i>
L04	I got it fixed	<i>I got the laptop fixed.</i>
L04	I'm having it done	<i>I'm having the brakes done next month.</i>
L04	I need to get... done	<i>I need to get my passport renewed.</i>
L04	I'll get it looked at	<i>I'll get it looked at.</i>
L04	we've had ... painted	<i>We've had the kitchen painted.</i>
L04	serviced	<i>I had the car serviced.</i>
L04	replaced	<i>We're getting the windows replaced.</i>
L04	translated	<i>I had the documents translated.</i>
L04	I had my phone stolen	<i>He had his bag stolen at the airport.</i>
L04	reviewed by a lawyer	<i>We had it reviewed by a lawyer.</i>

UNIT 7 — RELATIVE CLAUSES (ADVANCED)

Lesson	English	Example
L01	..., who joined in March, ...	<i>Layla, who joined in March, is doing it.</i>
L01	..., which was already tight, ...	<i>The deadline, which was already tight, has moved.</i>
L01	..., whose ...	<i>My neighbour, whose car was stolen, is furious.</i>
L01	..., where I grew up, ...	<i>Alexandria, where I grew up, has changed.</i>
L01	..., when everything closed, ...	<i>2020, when everything closed, was strange.</i>
L01	which is why...	<i>She worked there, which is why they asked for her.</i>
L01	who I actually quite like	<i>Their director, who I actually quite like, changed it.</i>
L01	..., none of which...	<i>Three emails, none of which were answered.</i>
L01	..., most of whom...	<i>Twelve people, most of whom left early.</i>
L02	the one who...	<i>The candidate who had experience was stronger.</i>
L02	..., who happens to...	<i>My sister, who happens to live in Dubai, is a doctor.</i>
L02	the ones that...	<i>The files that were corrupted are gone.</i>
L02	all of whom	<i>The designers, all of whom were consulted, hated it.</i>
L02	some of whom	<i>Twelve people, some of whom left early.</i>
L02	which means...	<i>..., which means we start again.</i>
L02	specifically	<i>Do you mean specifically the Dubai one?</i>
L02	as opposed to	<i>The Dubai one, as opposed to the others.</i>
L02	just to be clear	<i>Just to be clear — I have one sister.</i>
L03	the woman talking to...	<i>The woman talking to Ali is my manager.</i>
L03	the man standing by...	<i>The man standing by the window.</i>
L03	the report written last year	<i>The report written last year was shorter.</i>
L03	the changes agreed at...	<i>The changes agreed at that meeting.</i>
L03	anyone wanting to...	<i>Anyone wanting to comment has until Friday.</i>
L03	people living abroad	<i>People living abroad pay more.</i>
L03	the seats reserved for...	<i>The seats reserved for guests.</i>
L03	brought in to...	<i>The consultant brought in to review it.</i>
L03	the figures used in...	<i>The figures used in the forecast.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L03	commissioned by...	<i>The report commissioned by the board.</i>
L04	the person I spoke to	<i>The woman I spoke to was helpful.</i>
L04	the department she works in	<i>The department she works in handles it.</i>
L04	to whom / in which (formal)	<i>The officer with whom I spoke.</i>
L04	..., which meant...	<i>..., which meant we had to restart.</i>
L04	..., which is why...	<i>..., which is why I'm not doing it by email.</i>
L04	..., which was something	<i>They apologised, which was something.</i>
L04	..., which nobody expected	<i>He called back, which nobody ever does.</i>
L04	..., all of which...	<i>Three emails, all of which were ignored.</i>
L04	..., none of which...	<i>Four options, none of which worked.</i>
L04	at which point...	<i>The supplier withdrew, at which point it collapsed.</i>
L04	as a result of which	<i>..., as a result of which it was rejected.</i>

UNIT 8 — REPORTED SPEECH (ADVANCED)

Lesson	English	Example
L01	he admitted...	<i>He admitted the timeline was unrealistic.</i>
L01	she denied...	<i>She denied saying that.</i>
L01	he suggested...	<i>He suggested splitting it in two.</i>
L01	she recommended...	<i>She recommended waiting.</i>
L01	they objected	<i>Finance objected.</i>
L01	he insisted...	<i>He insisted the budget was closed.</i>
L01	she offered to...	<i>She offered to cover it.</i>
L01	they refused to...	<i>They refused to sign.</i>
L01	he promised to...	<i>He promised to look at it.</i>
L01	she reminded us that...	<i>She reminded us the deadline is next week.</i>
L01	he warned us not to...	<i>He warned us not to assume.</i>
L01	she claimed...	<i>She claimed she'd sent it.</i>
L01	he pointed out that...	<i>He pointed out that the data was old.</i>
L02	suggested + -ing	<i>She suggested taking a break.</i>
L02	recommended + -ing	<i>He recommended waiting.</i>
L02	denied + -ing	<i>They denied approving it.</i>
L02	admitted + -ing	<i>She admitted making a mistake.</i>
L02	mentioned + -ing	<i>He mentioned having raised it before.</i>
L02	suggested that we...	<i>She suggested that we ask the client.</i>
L02	admitted that...	<i>He admitted that the estimate was optimistic.</i>
L02	insisted that...	<i>They insisted the budget was closed.</i>
L02	claimed that...	<i>She claimed she'd sent it.</i>
L02	pointed out that...	<i>He pointed out that the data was old.</i>
L02	which is not quite true	<i>...which is not quite true.</i>
L03	he offered to...	<i>He offered to help.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L03	she promised to...	<i>She promised to send it today.</i>
L03	they refused to...	<i>They refused to change the price.</i>
L03	we agreed to...	<i>We agreed to extend.</i>
L03	she advised us to...	<i>She advised us to wait.</i>
L03	he warned me not to...	<i>He warned me not to reply yet.</i>
L03	she reminded me to...	<i>She reminded me to copy legal in.</i>
L03	he asked me to...	<i>He asked me to check clause nine.</i>
L03	they encouraged us to...	<i>They encouraged us to apply.</i>
L03	she threatened to...	<i>She threatened to escalate it.</i>
L03	he persuaded them to...	<i>He persuaded them to reconsider.</i>
L04	<i>Short version... · The main thing is... · In one sentence...</i>	Headline
L04	<i>X pointed out that... · Y admitted... · Z insisted...</i>	Attribute
L04	<i>X suggested ... -ing · Y offered to... · Z agreed to...</i>	Proposal
L04	<i>What was actually agreed was... · The one firm outcome is...</i>	Mark a decision
L04	<i>Nothing was decided on... · That's still a proposal. · Nobody committed to...</i>	Mark a non-decision
L04	<i>agreed to look at it · said he'd consider it · promised to come back on it</i>	Weak commitment
L04	<i>X asked Y to... · X warned Y not to...</i>	Instructions
L04	<i>Two open questions... · Still outstanding...</i>	Open items
L04	<i>X warned that if ..., he'd... · The risk flagged was...</i>	Risk
L04	<i>I'm not sure whether that was firm. · I'd check with X.</i>	Flag uncertainty

UNIT 9 — REGISTER & NUANCE

Lesson	English	Example
L01	get	formal: receive / obtain
L01	put off	formal: postpone
L01	sort out	formal: resolve
L01	look into	formal: investigate
L01	ask for	formal: request
L01	I can't come	formal: I'm afraid I won't be able to attend
L01	Can you...?	formal: I'd be grateful if you could...
L01	No rush	formal: at your convenience
L01	Thanks a lot	formal: Thank you for your assistance
L01	a lot of	formal: a considerable number of
L01	FYI	formal: for your information
L01	Let me know	formal: Please advise
L02	I was wondering if...	<i>I was wondering if you'd have time.</i>
L02	Would it be possible to...?	<i>Would it be possible to move it?</i>
L02	no pressure if not	<i>...no pressure if not.</i>
L02	I'm afraid...	<i>I'm afraid we won't make Friday.</i>
L02	unfortunately	<i>Unfortunately the supplier withdrew.</i>
L02	what I can do is...	<i>What I can do is send a draft.</i>
L02	I'm not sure I agree	<i>I'm not sure I agree with that.</i>
L02	I'd be inclined to...	<i>I'd be inclined to wait.</i>
L02	I take your point, although...	<i>I take your point, although...</i>
L02	a bit / slightly / quite	<i>That's a bit more than we expected.</i>

Lesson	English	Example
L02	not ideal	<i>It's not ideal, honestly.</i>
L02	I'm not entirely convinced	<i>I'm not entirely convinced.</i>
L02	to be honest	<i>To be honest, I'd rather not.</i>
L03	make a decision	<i>We need to make a decision this week.</i>
L03	make progress	<i>We've made real progress.</i>
L03	make a case for	<i>I made a case for moving the deadline.</i>
L03	make a start	<i>I'll make a start this week.</i>
L03	take a risk	<i>They weren't willing to take a risk.</i>
L03	take the point	<i>She took the point about the workload.</i>
L03	take responsibility	<i>He took responsibility for it.</i>
L03	give it some thought	<i>She said she'd give it some thought.</i>
L03	pay attention	<i>Nobody was paying attention.</i>
L03	raise a concern	<i>She raised a couple of concerns.</i>
L03	meet a deadline	<i>We met the deadline, just.</i>
L03	heavy workload	<i>It's been a heavy workload.</i>
L03	a fair point	<i>That's a fair point.</i>
L03	highly unlikely	<i>That's highly unlikely.</i>
L03	bear in mind	<i>Bear in mind we're a person short.</i>
L03	cut corners	<i>I've been cutting corners.</i>
L04	<i>Listen — · Can I flag something? · Actually, before we get into that — · On a more serious note —</i>	Open a gear change
L04	<i>I wanted to flag it before it comes up. · It's quite carefully worded, but...</i>	Soften bad news at high stakes
L04	<i>That's not ideal. · That's a bit of a problem. · It's not great.</i>	Understate
L04	<i>I'd guess it's coming from above her. · I don't think this is her doing.</i>	Hedge an attribution

Lesson	English	Example
L04	<i>I appreciate that. · Thanks for telling me. · Good to know.</i>	Acknowledge warmly
L04	<i>Anyway. · Right — let's pick it up after. · Coffee?</i>	Close the serious part
L04	<i>Is this a call or an email conversation? · Do you want the short version?</i>	Check the register
L04	<i>Of course — I'll put it in writing.</i>	Mirror upward

UNIT 10 — PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

Lesson	English	Example
L01	Building on that...	<i>Building on that — the sign-off has to be immediate.</i>
L01	My only worry is...	<i>My only worry is the review stage.</i>
L01	Can I just come in on that?	<i>Sorry, can I just come in on that?</i>
L01	Just on that point —	<i>Just on that point — it moves the date.</i>
L01	Sorry to interrupt, but...	<i>Sorry to interrupt, but that changes the timeline.</i>
L01	Just to clarify —	<i>Just to clarify — do you mean the 20th?</i>
L01	When you say X, do you mean...?	<i>When you say scope, do you mean deliverables?</i>
L01	Could you expand on that?	<i>Could you expand on that?</i>
L01	I'd support that	<i>I'd support that.</i>
L01	That's my read too	<i>That's my read too.</i>
L01	Sorry, go on	<i>That's all — sorry, go on.</i>
L01	Before we move on —	<i>Before we move on — one thing.</i>
L02	<i>Last quarter we... · Why do...? · Our X has never been higher — and yet...</i>	Hook
L02	<i>I want to cover three things: ... · I'll look at X, Y and Z.</i>	Roadmap
L02	<i>Firstly... · Let's start with... · The first thing is...</i>	Open a point
L02	<i>So that's X. · That's the first point.</i>	Close a point
L02	<i>Moving on to... · Which brings me to... · Turning to...</i>	Transition
L02	<i>We trialled this... · To give you an example... · The figures show...</i>	Evidence
L02	<i>That's a small sample. · I wouldn't over-claim it.</i>	Hedge honestly
L02	<i>To sum up... · In short... · So: three things.</i>	Summarise
L02	<i>What I'd like is... · My recommendation is... · What I'm proposing is...</i>	Ask
L02	<i>Happy to take questions.</i>	Close

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>How about...? · Would you be open to...? · What if we...? · One option would be...</i>	Propose
L03	<i>What could you do by...? · What's the constraint? · What would you need?</i>	Probe
L03	<i>If you can..., we could... · provided that... · as long as... · in exchange, I'd want...</i>	Trade
L03	<i>I take your point. · That's fair. · I can see why that matters.</i>	Acknowledge
L03	<i>I'd be willing to... · We could probably live with... · Let's meet in the middle.</i>	Concede partly
L03	<i>I'd love to help, but I can't go below... · That's genuinely not possible. What I can do is...</i>	Hold the limit
L03	<i>The reason that matters to us is... · If we do X, it's worse for both of us.</i>	State the interest
L03	<i>So — X, Y and Z. Have I got that right? · Let me say that back.</i>	Confirm
L03	<i>Done. · That works. · I'll put it in writing.</i>	Close
L04	It's X from Y	<i>It's Karim from Meridian.</i>
L04	I'm calling about...	<i>I'm calling about the March invoice.</i>
L04	Is now a good time?	<i>Is now a good time?</i>
L04	Have you got five minutes?	<i>Have you got five minutes?</i>
L04	you're breaking up	<i>Sorry, you're breaking up a bit.</i>
L04	Could you repeat that?	<i>Sorry, could you repeat the last part?</i>
L04	bear with me one second	<i>Bear with me one second.</i>
L04	So I'll... and you'll...	<i>So I'll resend it, and you'll confirm.</i>
L04	I'll follow up with an email	<i>I'll follow up with an email.</i>
L04	Just to confirm...	<i>Just to confirm what we agreed...</i>
L04	Could you put me through?	<i>Could you put me through to finance?</i>
L04	I'll get that over within the hour	<i>I'll get that over within the hour.</i>

UNIT 11 — ABSTRACT TOPICS & DEBATE

Lesson	English	Example
L01	<i>I don't know enough to be confident, but... · Off the top of my head... · I only know this second-hand.</i>	Admit the limit
L01	<i>There are advantages and problems. · On balance... · The trade-off is...</i>	Pros and cons
L01	<i>The pressure is coming from two directions. · The root cause is... · Which leads to...</i>	Causes
L01	<i>In the short term... · In the longer run... · Eventually...</i>	Time frames
L01	<i>Having said that... · The counter-argument would be... · Although in fairness...</i>	Counter-consideration
L01	<i>I'd separate two things here. · That's a separate question. · It depends whether we mean X or Y.</i>	Distinction
L01	<i>That's underrated. · I think that's overstated.</i>	Correct the emphasis
L01	<i>The wider point is... · What's often missed is...</i>	Zoom out
L01	<i>Although I could be completely wrong. · I'd have said the same about X in 2019.</i>	Hedge the whole thing
L02	<i>My main point is... · What I'd argue is... · My position is...</i>	Claim
L02	<i>The reason is... · The evidence for that is... · That's borne out by...</i>	Evidence
L02	<i>And the second reason is... · There's also the fact that...</i>	Second reason
L02	<i>To give you a specific example... · Concretely... · A case in point is...</i>	Example
L02	<i>Now, the obvious objection is... · The counter-argument would be...</i>	Raise the objection
L02	<i>And that's partly fair. But... · Which is true, except that...</i>	Rebut
L02	<i>I wouldn't over-claim that. · That's the weakest part of my case.</i>	Concede a limit
L02	<i>So my conclusion is... · Which is why I'd... · What follows from that is...</i>	Conclusion
L02	<i>What I'd like us to do is... · So I'd propose...</i>	Ask
L03	<i>That's a fair point about X. · You're right that Y.</i>	Acknowledge specifically
L03	<i>...and yet · ...but I'd still argue · What I'd say is...</i>	Concede and hold
L03	<i>They do, yes — although... · That's true, except that...</i>	Concede and reframe
L03	<i>But so does the alternative. · The current approach isn't free either.</i>	Turn it around
L03	<i>That's a good point. I'd revise that to... · Let me change that.</i>	Concede and revise

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>The principle stands but the mechanism doesn't. · I'd keep the aim, change the method.</i>	Separate principle from mechanism
L03	<i>I'm dropping X. Y I'd still argue for.</i>	Name what survived
L03	<i>Actually, that changes my view. · You've convinced me on that part.</i>	Change your mind
L03	<i>Let me think for a second. · I want to answer that properly.</i>	Buy a moment
L03	<i>That's the weakest part of my case.</i>	Name the weakest link
L04	<i>How was...? · How's the week been? · Did you get away at all?</i>	Small-talk opener
L04	<i>Exhausting how? · Did you get any time at all? · Whereabouts?</i>	Follow up
L04	<i>Classic. · Same thing happened to me in... · I know that feeling.</i>	Give something back
L04	<i>Speaking of which... · Which actually makes me wonder...</i>	Pivot on their material
L04	<i>That reminds me... · Funnily enough...</i>	Pivot on association
L04	<i>Actually, while we're on that... · Can I ask you something about that?</i>	Pivot with permission
L04	<i>On a more serious note... · Genuinely asking...</i>	Explicit gear change
L04	<i>What do you think? · Is that your experience? · Am I being unfair?</i>	Hand it back
L04	<i>Anyway. · Right. · Fair enough.</i>	Mark the return
L04	<i>I should let you get on. · Good to see you. · Let's pick it up next week.</i>	Close

UNIT 12 — PUTTING IT TOGETHER (B2) ★

Lesson	English	Example
L01	<i>I've been trying to... on and off, properly since...</i>	perfect continuous
L01	<i>I've had four interviews and no offers.</i>	perfect simple + quantity
L01	<i>I hadn't looked at... I hadn't spoken to...</i>	past perfect
L01	<i>I'd been telling myself for weeks that...</i>	past perfect continuous
L01	<i>If I'd done two hours of research, I'd probably have...</i>	third conditional
L01	<i>If I'd started in 2023, I'd be somewhere else by now.</i>	mixed conditional
L01	<i>They must have decided before I walked in.</i>	past deduction
L01	<i>They can't have had budget approval.</i>	present deduction
L01	<i>By the end of the year I'll have applied to about thirty.</i>	future perfect
L01	<i>This time next spring I'll either be doing something different...</i>	future continuous
L01	<i>I've been wrong about my own timeline every time, so I wouldn't put money on it.</i>	hedge
L02	<i>The team wasn't formally notified until it had been implemented.</i>	passive, agentless
L02	<i>That could have been handled rather differently.</i>	modal passive
L02	<i>It's my understanding that the restructure was signed off in March.</i>	reporting passive
L02	<i>We had the whole system audited before launch.</i>	causative
L02	<i>Our new lead, whom I haven't yet met, inherited a team with no warning.</i>	non-defining relative
L02	<i>The guy running it now is somebody I've never met.</i>	reduced relative
L02	<i>She'd been in meetings about it for a month, which gives it away.</i>	which for a whole idea
L02	<i>My manager has indicated that she wasn't consulted.</i>	reporting verb + stance
L02	<i>My manager swore she didn't know either.</i>	reporting verb, informal
L02	<i>I'd be cautious about drawing conclusions from that.</i>	diplomatic hedge
L02	<i>My priority is making sure the handover doesn't lose momentum.</i>	formal collocation
L02	<i>I'm keeping my head down until it settles.</i>	informal collocation
L03	<i>— should have been checked, rather —</i>	plain repair
L03	<i>sorry, been checked —</i>	repair with a marker
L03	<i>or rather, what I mean is...</i>	rephrase forward

Lesson	English	Example
L03	<i>— I keep doing that —</i>	self-flag and continue
L03	<i>let me put that another way.</i>	buy a beat, honestly
L03	<i>that's a good question, actually — give me a second.</i>	hold the floor while you think
L04	<i>That's a good question — let me think about it for a second.</i>	buy thinking time
L04	<i>I'll answer that from the work side, if that's alright.</i>	narrow a huge question
L04	<i>There are two things going on here. The first is...</i>	signpost an argument
L04	<i>You're right that it's expensive — I still think it's cheaper than the alternative.</i>	concede, then hold
L04	<i>I'd be cautious about saying that, but my impression is...</i>	hedge honestly
L04	<i>My manager has indicated that... — although I haven't seen it myself.</i>	attribute a claim
L04	<i>It must have been decided earlier; nobody could answer about the start date.</i>	speculate with evidence
L04	<i>If we'd started in March, we'd be finished by now.</i>	an unreal alternative
L04	<i>If I were saying this to my director, I'd put it as...</i>	shift register deliberately
L04	<i>Does it work the same way in your field?</i>	ask a genuine question
L04	<i>Can I come back to what you said about deadlines?</i>	pick up an earlier thread
L04	<i>— should have been checked, rather —</i>	repair, mid-phrase
L04	<i>So, broadly, that's where I've landed on it.</i>	close a long answer

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